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*For Vic, always*

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*The fact that something is far-fetched is no reason why it should not be true; it cannot be as far-fetched as the fact that something exists.*

CELIA GREEN

*OceanofPDF.com*

# I

## THE RIDGE

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# 1

1. *A lost, lonely season unmoored. My mind erring  
– Returning to half-empty halls  
Of unending silence; enclosing, ensnaring –  
Now torrid remembrance enthrals.*
2. *All trauma's exiles, demented, therein  
All unto night's torments exposed.  
Delusions roam; eerie qualms underpin –  
Every spurious theory supposed.*

‘SO, WHAT ARE YOU going to do all summer?’ said Marcus idly, through half a sandwich. ‘I mean, you can’t very well stay here in this shithole, can you?’

‘Of course not,’ I said. ‘But, you know. Having no plan is also, like, a *great* plan. World’s my oyster. I can go anywhere, do anything.’

‘Right.’ Marcus seemed unconvinced by this; he made the word last two whole seconds. His mouth was still full. ‘Well, I suppose that’s technically correct.’ Amethyst gazed airily through the window, at the uninspiring bulk of the opposite wing of The Ridge, identical twin of the one we were in, and blew smoke dismissively from her nostrils.

‘I thought you were going to stay with relatives? Some aunt or something?’

Had I said this? It seemed likely I might have done, at some point, probably to change the subject. Either way, it wasn’t true. ‘I don’t want to be a burden to anyone. Plus, this way I’m very much my own person. I can do what I like. Go where I like.’

Marcus looked puzzled, as if reviewing a bill filled with items he hadn't ordered. 'Wait. Are you saying you've made no plans *whatsoever*? For the *entire summer*?' And this statement was both horrible and unthinkable, and wholly and precisely correct, but I didn't want to discuss it. Any of it. Instead, I shrugged and smiled as if this complete lack of forward thinking were no big deal.

'Not yet. Like I say, it's very liberating, in one sense. I mean, ha, *terrifying* in another, but also, y'know, ultimately *very liberating*.'

Amethyst chewed her lip doubtfully. 'Really?'

'Definitely!' My voice brimmed with confidence. 'People say *if you want to make God laugh, make a plan*, but my dad always maintained if you *really* want to make the old fucker slap his thigh, make no plans at all. See where you end up!'

To underline my complete confidence in the age-old, tried-and-tested method of having absolutely no plan at all, I grinned, until my face hurt.

---

Term had been over for half an hour. The Ridge, in that moment, still held a full complement of students, and so the usual noises still prevailed; slamming doors, scuffling feet, laughter and occasional shouting, music from radios and stack stereos, the drone of indie bands, the saccharine rush of dance music. Marcus and Amethyst were sitting in my room, as they were both already in the process of packing up their rooms. We were also listening to music; I had attempted to introduce them to Sonic Youth, but that had not gone well, so we were listening to a Jazz-Funk compilation and sharing the last third of a bottle of white wine.

I had met Marcus last September, before term started, when we'd both arrived early at The Ridge. There were only the two of us at first, and we got on well. But then, when everyone else arrived, and there had been drinks in the bar for the new residents, I saw for the first time how Marcus behaved in a social situation. Amidst a roomful of extremely self-conscious and shy eighteen-year-olds, fresh out of small towns all over Britain,

Marcus was bracingly different. He made everything into a big, boyish joke, called everyone *chum* and genuinely didn't care whether people liked him or not, which of course meant most people did. By the end of that first night, he was friends, it seemed, with everyone, and I made it my mission to let people believe that this loud, confident, easy-going young man was a close friend, that our friendship might go back years, rather than just two days. And most assumed precisely that, meaning I was spared a large portion of the burden of having to introduce myself to other people.

Amethyst had arrived a few days later, as close to the start of lectures as possible. Her scent arrived before she did – a thick, almost sickly perfume that pervaded the corridor, rolling out ahead of her like a red carpet; an astringent odour that insisted, almost angrily, that the wearer was an adult, a being of complexity and sophistication. This impression was only strengthened when I saw her. She did not resemble any nineteen-year-old I knew, certainly not any student. Her clothes seemed strangely middle-aged, as if her dress sense had skipped a couple of decades: roll-neck sweaters, thick cork heels, pleated trousers and large gold earrings that spoke of an exacting glamour painstakingly derived from the correct magazines. It turned out that she was not only on the wrong corridor that first day, she was also in the wrong hall – she was supposed to be at Hatfield, which was ten minutes away. I offered to walk over there with her and carry her bags, and from that moment – for better or worse – there was a connection between us. At the end of Freshers' Week, we had gone to some kind of mixer for Humanities students, and ended up drunkenly sleeping together, and although this situation had not recurred since then, I imagined – hoped – that it eventually would. Until then, we had simply remained as friends, but friends who – to me, at least – shared a history, and possibly a future.

Looking at both Marcus and Amethyst now, in my room, I was suddenly acutely conscious that this was the last time I would see either of them in their current form. They were going away, to have *experiences*. Amethyst had already talked at length about her summer, which she saw as nothing less than a dazzling opportunity for an almost-three-month holiday. She was going to spend the first couple of days in London, where she had a few



parties to attend with her two best friends from school. Then, she and these friends were off to South East Asia, possibly ending their trip with a week in Australia. And why not? Her parents would write a cheque for a large amount of money they wouldn't even notice they'd spent. Why wouldn't her summer be anything other than a fantastic adventure?

Similarly, Marcus had plans. He was going back to London, too, where his family lived, and then he was off to stay with a cousin in Florida, where the plan was to teach American kids to take penalties at what he called *some godawful soccer camp* somewhere outside of Tampa. These specifics, however, were irrelevant; they were both going somewhere I couldn't imagine, somewhere where the beaches were white sand, the sky blue enough to make your eyes sting, somewhere where the sun shone, always. From my perspective, they might as well have been going to one of Saturn's moons, the far future, the deep past.

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'You must have some kind of plan, though?' said Marcus. Thus far, I had been careful to avoid the subject of summer, or, when pressed, to bat it away. And it *was* odd to have no plan; I could see that now. Most of the other students had vague plans – summer jobs organized by relatives, weekends at festivals, trips abroad. But even vague plans were better than no plans at all.

'Not sure yet,' I said breezily, trying to turn a negative into a positive. 'As I say, world's my oyster really.' I could have stopped there, but something – the painful sense that I was always, no matter how hard I tried, lagging behind them – made me carry on talking.

'I've been thinking about going up to, um, Scotland?' I heard myself say. 'To work on a fishing boat?'

It was strange to hear myself say this. I had not planned to say this.

'Wow,' said Marcus, unsure how seriously to take this. 'You've... got friends up there?'

‘No,’ I said, my mouth suddenly dry. ‘But, you know. They’re always looking for people!’

There was baffled silence. I realized they were both looking at me intently. The worst possible outcome: they were genuinely curious. Again, I felt compelled to talk. To keep digging.

‘I mean, I was just gonna turn up? They always need people to work on the, um, the trawlers.’

No-one said anything. I experienced a brief, hot panic that *trawlers* might not be the correct word. Worse, when the silence continued, I heard my own voice say, as an unnecessary addendum to my previous unnecessary statements, ‘I saw a programme about it on telly.’ This last statement, at least, was true, and was the genesis of the whole strand of thought in my mind, but the words sounded desperate – pleading, almost. In the following seconds, I swore I could hear my own face redden, a fizzing sound like fat on a griddle.

Amethyst looked distressed, as if something in her body had started to ache. Marcus gazed intently out of the window. From somewhere, there was the drone of a lawnmower; the clean, eternally optimistic scent of freshly mowed grass spicing the air. They were already cleaning The Ridge up for summer.

‘Don’t you need a lot of experience to do something like that? It’s very dangerous,’ said Amethyst eventually. She sounded both puzzled and disappointed. She lit another menthol cigarette. I smoked infrequently, usually after meals and at the beginning and end of the day, but Amethyst smoked constantly. Whenever she came to my room, I had to air the place out afterwards. She never asked if she could smoke. She just did; flicking an efficient little flame from a slender lighter that I didn’t doubt was real gold.

‘Yeah, but... you can pick it up on the job.’ I just wanted this conversation to be over now. I looked to Marcus for help, but he was still gazing out of the window.

‘Also,’ said Amethyst, putting her lighter back inside her handbag and zipping it up, ‘don’t you have to be really strong to work on a fishing boat?’

‘Again,’ I said, irrevocably entangled in the flypaper of this ludicrous fiction, ‘I can shape up on the job.’

‘*Right.*’ She smiled and raised her eyebrows. ‘Well. It’ll be interesting to see what you look like in September.’ She stretched, arching her back like a cat. I knew from experience this meant that, truth or lie, whatever I was saying had ceased to interest her. She reached for the bottle of wine and splashed the last of it into her glass. The Jazz-Funk compilation was still playing at a low volume, the Brand New Heavies or Galliano or someone. I couldn’t actually tell the tracks apart; I found this kind of music irritating. I suddenly realized I’d only bought this album because Amethyst had mentioned in passing that she liked it.

‘When do you think you’ll be back in the country?’ I asked casually, trying to make it sound as if the answer was of very little concern to me.

‘September.’ Amethyst flicked her hair back. ‘As close to term time as bloody possible!’

‘Well, why don’t we meet up?’ This was a plan I had considered raising for a long time, and was now straining hard to pass off as something I’d only just thought of. In that respect, it was the precise inverse of the conversation I’d just endured, only just as awkward.

‘When we get back?’ said Marcus.

‘Yeah,’ I said, ‘I mean, I *suppose*, the three of us, sure. But I was thinking more of just—’

‘We could go out!’ said Amethyst, smiling. ‘A night on the town. We could all meet up in London and go out!’

‘Well, I mean, we *could*—’ I began.

‘That’s a great idea!’ said Marcus. ‘I know a few places around Green Park we can go to. We could start at my dad’s club. I mean, everyone there’s about a billion years old, but the drinks are cheap.’

‘There’s a new club I want to check out in Piccadilly,’ said Amethyst. ‘It was set up by two DJs from Chicago. Someone said they saw *Lenny Kravitz* in there!’ This was clearly big news to Amethyst. She gave us a couple of seconds to absorb this world-changing information.

‘Wow,’ I said flatly.

‘Yes,’ said Amethyst, enchanted with her own idea of what our night out would be like. ‘It’ll be fun!’

‘When will you be back?’ I asked again, as casually as I could, directing the question at Amethyst. Despite my best efforts, the words were shot through with a thread of pure desperation.

Neither of them appeared to have heard me. And so, I decided to affect indifference, about this, about the whole crushing matter of them leaving, about my failure to engage with the immediate future and my need to lie about it, almost a reflex now; my need to lie about everything.

And the needlings of Marcus and the indifference of Amethyst were, ultimately, small and trifling cruelties compared to the deeds of The Annihilator, and the events of the Last Day.

## 2

3. *Under night's urging, that treacherous evening,  
Reason and base lies engineered:  
Mad and deluded, erring; perceiving  
In tedium, infinite fears.*
4. *Under lone exile, desire: even now,  
This house entices, surprises  
Until naught remains; I see easily how  
An unquiet night terrorizes.*

I SLEPT BADLY. My night was full of half-dreams, broken scenarios in which I was always close to humiliation, abandonment and utter defeat; I woke feeling as if I'd fallen down a flight of stairs. To cheer myself, I dragged a chair over to the window and sat watching, with a cup of instant coffee and a cigarette, as the rooms at The Ridge began to empty.

At first, I'll admit, it was funny to me, seeing everyone leave. From three floors up, I watched, delighted, as they packed up – along with their Anglepoise lamps and stereo systems – their lurid, noisy university personas. The people they had tried out being, wearing like costume, for the past year.

And so, there went Nick Tanner, captain of the university rugby team, climbing sombrely into the black Saab that belonged to his dad, who, it transpired, was some kind of clergyman. Nick's expression was a mask of shock; he looked for all the world like he'd been arrested. I half-expected his stern-faced father to push him down by the top of his head into the back

seat. And there went Fay, shy to the point of fainting when sober, but if given more than one drink would reliably make an exhibition of herself. Fay's mousy parents approached their daughter cautiously across the tarmac, as if she were being freed from a hostage situation, descending on her in a tearful embrace. And there went Nikki, or Nicola Molyneux as she'd now have to resume being, who had foamy-looking white dreadlocks and a nose stud and described herself as a New Age anarcho-collectivist, usually when nobody prompted her to do so. Her librarian-sensible and painfully embarrassed-looking mum came to collect her in a tiny blue Mini Cooper, which the pair of them packed up in a silence so strained I could feel the crackle of it from fifty yards away.

The amusement began to pall, however, when people who were more than simply the background scenery of my life at The Ridge also started to disappear. Phil – probably my best friend here after Marcus – an amiable ginger-haired young man who never swore, always shared cigarettes and played fragmentary Metallica songs on his acoustic guitar, was the first on my corridor to go, knocking on my door to wish me a good summer. I watched sadly as his bemused dad – looking uncannily like an older version of Phil – arrived as though through a time warp to rescue his younger self. Angela, who lived directly across from me, was next to vanish, meaning the corridor would never again vibrate to the shockwaves of her constant manufactured dramas, ranging from the terror of upcoming exams to breaking up with her on-off boyfriend, a singularly dull Classics student called Andrew.

It was easy, during term time, to sneer, yet now, it was plain to see that all of this was colour, was context, was life. It was infinitely precious, all of it: youth and folly and energy, the envy of the whole dead world, now itself dying, ossifying into the stale shorthand of nostalgia, a simplification of itself from which it would never recover. This rich combination of things – people, time, place, circumstance – would never repeat, never happen again, and its priceless complexities would be smoothed away by time, its heady and unique flavour condensed by memory into a series of images bland as flashcards; a dance, a laugh, a kiss, a song, stripped of all vitality.

And every hour, the corridor I lived on, and the hall of residence that surrounded it, grew quieter; the building around me seemingly growing larger and more imposing as its population dwindled. *It's like they're all dying*, I thought, as I shut the window. Succumbing, each one, to a disease that would take them, and leave me, cursed and alone, with the one person whose company I wasn't sure I could endure.

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After lunch, Marcus and Amethyst left together in Marcus's car. This made sense, as they both lived in West London; Marcus in Ealing, Amethyst in Notting Hill. Neither of them had very much stuff, so their belongings all fitted into Marcus's battered blue Volvo. I persuaded him to take a couple of boxes of my things too, partly because it reduced my luggage here solely to things I could carry, which I felt might be handy, and partly because I wanted a hook, some sort of obligation, in Marcus's life. Even someone as allergic to short-term planning as I knew that beyond the immediate problem of summer lay the larger problem of next year's living arrangements, and I half-hoped that Marcus and I might get a house together, maybe with Phil. Leaving Marcus in possession of my music system was therefore a tactical move. It meant that when he came back, one of the first people he would have to see would be me.

I helped them load the car. Every cardboard box I carried was a step closer to being alone, and having to face whatever happened next, so of course I dawdled. When the car was finally packed, I realized I was staring at Amethyst, as if I were a faithful dog, she my indifferent owner.

'I suppose this is it,' I said, more sadly than I intended. In response, she smiled a restrained, political smile.

'See you, Alex.'

'Take care out there,' I said. 'Let me know when there's an address I can write to you.'

She looked excessively grave and serious. '*I shall.*' I got the impression that Marcus was grinning, but when I looked, he turned away.

‘Goodbye then,’ I said. What did I want to happen? In that moment, I wanted her to embrace me, to kiss me, to make it clear that she would miss me. I wanted to matter to her. In the end, of course, she simply gave me a perfunctory hug and a kiss on the cheek, before detaching herself from me with the air of someone having fulfilled some grim but necessary duty. And, ultimately, wasn’t it better this way? This way, I could maintain the agonizing fiction that we were drifting towards being a couple, that the endless summer apart was just one more bump in a road that led to a beautiful inevitability. I could survive on that delusion all summer. Before I could say anything further, Marcus’s hand clapped firmly onto me, gripping me so tightly I thought his fingers and thumb might meet somewhere in the meat of my shoulder.

‘See you on the other side of summer!’ he said, playfully mock-punching me. And then, he turned away, opened the driver side door of the Volvo and swung himself inside.

As he did so, he muttered, almost imperceptibly, from the corner of his mouth, ‘*Good luck on the trawler.*’

For a split second I perceived his grinning face as something diseased – a ripe spot about to burst. I looked away, just as a smirking Amethyst, already in the passenger seat, put an elbow playfully in Marcus’s ribs. Then, Marcus parped his horn twice as the car accelerated up the driveway, and Amethyst’s pale, delicate arm appeared from the passenger window and gave a regal wave.

And they were gone.

---

I went back up to my room, intending to look out of the window, down onto my fellow students, for a while, but the fun had soured. Plus, I was just watching strangers now, people I didn’t know, and never would. A thin young man with bleached hair and a vintage leather jacket with band names carefully painted onto it was arguing in a petulant voice with both parents about something he deemed of vital consequence. This argument continued



into the car, meaning that the young man's distracted dad almost drove into another car, triggering shouts and beeps and sheepish apologies. Some distance away, a tall young woman with long, vibrant red hair, wearing a pale green dress, turned away from this scene as if offended by it, meaning I would never see her face. Someone's mum carried a ballgown wrapped in plastic in their outstretched arms, as tenderly as if it were a child pulled from an earthquake.

I left the window, and lay on my bed for a long time, long enough for the squares of fading amber reflected from the windows of the opposite wing of The Ridge to travel most of the way across the walls of my room. I didn't move, save to breathe.

People descended the stairs at the end of the corridor. Everything sounded louder now, hollow, booming, clattering. I became aware that, while everyone else was descending, I was climbing upwards, doggedly, against the crowd. Upwards, upwards, until the staircase became impossibly baroque and wide and grand, yet somehow also narrow, claustrophobic, filled with items and objects, and I was almost to the top, and something long forgotten that I knew was there, a puzzle that I might finally, this time, resolve. And then a step was missing, and I fell forever, jerking awake with a shivering start, fully clothed.

My room had grown chilly; the window was still open, but the temperature had plummeted. Outside, it was evening, night strengthening in shifting shades of blue and grey, giving way to darkness.

Something on my desk caught my eye, white to the point of luminescence in the failing daylight.

One of Amethyst's menthol cigarette filters, kissed with crimson lipstick, sat in the green glass ashtray I had liberated from the nearest pub specifically so she could smoke in my room.

I stared at the cigarette butt for a long time, suddenly aware that this moment, however small, was one of profound choice.

It was very easy to foresee a moment when I might, my judgement eaten away by loneliness, make of it a relic, another thing that reminded me of beautiful, unobtainable Amethyst, soon to be on the other side of the

world. I could see myself putting this cigarette butt in a matchbox, putting the matchbox on a shelf. Taking this treasure out at night, like a medieval priest with a fragment of saintly bone. *Her lips touched this*. Putting it to my own lips, imagining a kiss. The object representing not just a person, but an era, now gone forever. And this would be madness.

I picked the cigarette butt up as if it were something dangerous but currently inert, like a stunned hornet. Before sentiment could intervene, I threw it out of the window.

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### 3

5. *Each day enduring that endless routine,  
Numbed in those years so received.  
Uttered in nightmare, eternity's dream;  
An unholy becoming achieved.*
6. *Dreadful exigency, losing one's nerve,  
Gethsemane. Death's abrogation.  
Yet salvation's impulse now something inverts:  
Let endless night come. Elation!*

ON MONDAY MORNING, I awoke to find I was the only person left on my corridor.

The cleaners arrived, three cheery, chatty local women in their fifties, whose loud laughter announced their presence long before they were visible. They fell silent when they saw me, sitting at the kitchen table chewing cereal; they seemed baffled as to why anybody would choose to linger in this place. The three of them bustled around me, moving with a clear and defined purpose that I, lacking any purpose whatsoever, found both tiring and vaguely shaming. After ten minutes in the kitchen, trying to make coffee and bumping into one or other of the three women at every turn, I couldn't stand it any longer and left.

I wanted to go for a walk, but the weather had soured alongside my mood. June – which had begun with sunny days, boozy picnics on the lawns and drunkenly innovative celebrations of exam results – was ending in the

static wash of constant rain, too heavy to make going outside a practical proposition.

That didn't matter, however. There was enough of the vast emptiness of The Ridge to explore.

---

Without students, The Ridge's role was not immediately obvious. The place could just as easily have been a boarding school or a mental hospital. The rows of lifeless rooms were depressing, though I was obscurely cheered to note that the bile-yellow linoleum floor tiles of my corridor had been inflicted on the entire building. From a tall, grand window at the end of the wing I didn't live on, I paused to look out at the main entrance, where the words *SOMMERIDGE HALL* ran across the top of the porch, in Antiqua Double. Over the years, whatever held those words to the pediment had degraded, the letters had sagged out of line, and the psychological effect of reading the building's name now was akin to the feeling of watching a lunchtime drinker trying to appear sober and dignified in a busy office.

While the dorms had become merely sad, the communal areas had become downright unsettling. The main corridors were now lit by single bulbs set into wire baskets, like the emergency lighting on a stricken submarine, enhancing the impression that some unspecified catastrophe had occurred. The refectory, once so loud with the clatter of cutlery and the barrage of excited chatter that you could barely hear someone across the table talk at normal volume, now sat cavernous and echoing. The hall bar, where so many drunken nights had played out, was saddest of all – closed steel shutters and clean, empty ashtrays, the stale smell of the aged carpet slowly curing in the still, grey air. The shadows seemed to have multiplied, to replace the people who had left, gathering in corners, lurking under staircases. The slightest noise would make the emptiness mutter.

Of course – having no choice – I had stayed at The Ridge over the Easter holidays, and before that, bits of Christmas, but this was different. On those occasions, other students had stayed behind too, and there was a

sense that the place would be back to normal again in a couple of weeks. Now, it was being reset, waiting for a new cast of characters, the previous year's intake having cleared the stage. Standing in the empty lobby, before a mass of pigeonholes half-filled with letters that had arrived too late ever to be read, I was hit with an overwhelming sense of being in utterly the wrong place.

When I returned to my corridor, the cleaners had left, the small communal kitchen smelled of bleach, and all the rooms bar mine had been left open, with doors ajar, as if ransacked. I opened the door to my room – with its posters and timetables of lectures and flyers for club nights, now officially a time capsule of a bygone age – and flopped down onto the bed.

---

That night, when I leaned out of the window and counted the other lights still burning in The Ridge, there was only one, a solitary light shining from the ground floor, cutting into the fading daylight, making a slab of watery yellow on the lawn outside.

Two people left, then. In a building designed to house hundreds.

So there was me, and – who was the other person?

---

On the Monday of the second week, the rain stopped, and the sun, unseen for days, broke through, making everything sparkle. Inspired by this change in the weather, I decided to take decisive action to improve my situation.

I would make the forty-five-minute round trip to the nearest corner shop, to buy more cigarettes.

In my pigeonhole in the front lobby, I found a brown A5 envelope. No stamp, just my name punched crisply into the brown paper by an electric typewriter: a letter from the university. The sunshine gave me confidence, and – in a decidedly uncharacteristic show of meeting a situation head-on – I tore open the envelope as I shoved the front doors of the building open, and read its contents as I walked.

Nothing in the letter came as a surprise. It reminded me – with the steely politeness of English officialdom – of the period by which all students should have left their university-owned student residence and sought alternative accommodation, going on to apologize profusely for the university's carelessness in not reminding me sooner of this fact. The letter was practically mortified, therefore, to have to point out that I would definitely have to leave at the first opportunity, and that I had currently accrued one week's worth of extra accommodation fees, payable to the university governing body as soon as possible.

The letter's author, a jagged sawtooth line of blue ink above the words *STUDENT HOUSING OFFICER*, sincerely hoped I would understand.

I understood, but not in the way I imagined I was supposed to. I screwed the letter up and threw it away.

---

And so, although events were taking shape around me whether I participated in them or not, I still found myself quietly calm. I was strangely unmoved by the threat of imminent eviction, or even the accommodation fees I absolutely couldn't afford. I had no idea why I was so calm, but didn't want to investigate this perspective in case, in doing so, I dismantled it. I bought my cigarettes and smoked two on the way back to The Ridge, in a mood that was almost triumphant.

One way or another, I mused, things were coming to a head.

The sunlight clotted over with cloud at about 2 p.m., and the day resolved into a warm, wet, grey. I drew the curtains. As much as I tried not to, I thought of Amethyst. What was she doing right now? Was she still in London, or had she already flown abroad? Already lounging on a beach in some country I would never visit, this place and me the very last things on her mind? I imagined her trading thick handfuls of absurd-looking paper currency to jaded locals in exchange for drugs. A beach party at dusk; everyone in swimsuits, everyone high, minds filled with thrilling and utterly inconsequential chemical revelation. And I saw – very clearly, as if she

were in front of me – Amethyst herself. She was wearing a dazzling white bikini, large bug-eyed Jackie O sunglasses. She was smiling, in a way that she had smiled at me perhaps twice in our entire acquaintance, a smile of genuine warmth, and if I embraced her, I knew, her hair would smell of salt, of the sea. The sunlight that fell on her flat stomach, on her breasts, her hips, her cheekbones, was as white and pure and alien as the light of a distant star. This vision pulled on a cord that wound itself very tightly around my reasons to be alive, and contemplation of it sucked the breath from me as surely as if I'd been punched in the gut.

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The question of who the other resident might be was answered later that night, when, leaning out of the window for a final night-time cigarette, I saw the Pale Strange Boy.

As I watched him cross the lawn, returning to his room, I realized I had observed him many times before, throughout the year, without really seeing him. This situation was made possible by the fact that even though he was obviously shy, he was also very distinctive-looking. His hair was white and waxy, like sheep's wool, and his skin appeared to be the same colour as his hair, as if he were made of the same materials throughout. You'd have almost said he was an albino until you saw his eyes, which were a striking mineral blue.

I watched him, hardly daring to move, as if I were observing something wild that could easily be spooked. He was carrying two heavy-looking plastic shopping bags, walking silently and carefully across the gravel path, like someone trying not to wake a light sleeper. As he did so, he looked nervously all about him, even glancing up at my window. My lights were off; I had finished my cigarette and had dropped it out of the window before I had seen him, and so I was certain he couldn't see me, but I still held my breath for a second.

He turned away, approached the main entrance, paused to find his keys.

The front door of The Ridge slammed shut behind him, harsh and final in the damp night air.

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Again, the next day, I considered the idea that it would be prudent to make a plan, some sort of survival strategy for the next few days and beyond. But once again, I found the future paralysing in its immensity, insufferable with its constant demands, its desire to be at all times catered to and created. It was annoying, a pest; I almost felt it was beneath me. A wounded, arrogant voice pulsed through my head sometimes, and it did so then: *I lived through catastrophe*, it said, *and I saw The Annihilator. As a result, my perspective is entirely different – not only to what it was before, but also to everyone else's. Why should I bother with these trifling matters? For enduring the things I lived through, I should either be celebrated, or left alone.* With no small effort, I ignored the voice. Instead, I went into town and, as an act of defiance, used a chunk of my remaining savings to buy a bottle of very good wine.

Returning to The Ridge, I found another official-looking brown envelope in my pigeonhole. I took it up to my room, and burned it in the ashtray, before pouring myself a glass of excellent Merlot.

I realized I was waiting for something; a sign. Some catalyst that would spur me into action. Such a thing, whatever form it might take, could not, nor could ever be, the letters from the university, or my own dwindling funds, or even the food – scavenged from other people's cupboards and the freezer before the cleaners arrived – running out. It would, I felt, be something unambiguous, something I couldn't ignore. A sign.

I wondered, almost idly, what shape such a thing might take.

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Over the next three days, I saw the Pale Strange Boy more and more, coming and going, always nervous and awkward, largely nocturnal, his waxy paleness accentuating the impression that he was something not quite



formed, something larval. He gave off, even at the distance from which I observed him, an impression of fearful furtiveness. I wondered who he was, what he was studying. Classics, I guessed, or Philosophy; something you'd have to rectify later with the inevitable law conversion course. Or maybe he even studied English, like me, lurking at the back of the lecture hall to minimize the chances of being asked for an opinion, and that's where I'd seen him before? I couldn't remember.

I thought of saying hello, given that events had conspired to put us in the same boat. Had it been practically anyone else I was sharing the abandoned hulk of The Ridge with, I would have made some kind of friendly overture, or at least introduced myself. And it would have been in my best interests to do so, to find out what his situation was; how things stood with him and the university, what his plans were, how he was coping, what the hell he was going to do next.

But I didn't approach him, without articulating to myself precisely why. I suspected it would feel unwholesome, like putting your hand in cobwebs.

## 4

7. Storms orchestrate rumbling rain overhead,  
Weep over everything. Rust.  
Flow, live, old water, in night's *grey* undeath.  
Narcotic, his eyeless eyes dust.
8. Eerie does night end. At the horizon,  
Dawn's rays: emerald, amethyst.  
Righteous eyes must perceive this. Your dubious reason,  
Evil's arcane *motives* suppressed.

IT WAS THREE DAYS LATER, just before dawn, when I heard the scream.

At first, it seemed inseparable from the state of sleep, an overspill from a nightmare; one single bright burst of noise, of scalding realization, that sounded briefly and then stopped. It echoed around my skull, around the vast cube of space enclosed by the empty arms of the building, and was gone, to the point where I began to question whether I'd heard it at all. However, as full wakefulness came, there was no doubting that I had heard it, and no question as to where it had come from.

I opened the window as wide as it would go.

The Pale Strange Boy's room, the light always on, looked quiet and still.

Should I do something, call someone? The Pale Strange Boy, whoever he was, sounded as if he were in real distress. There had been something animal in the scream, simultaneously free from human restraint but trapped by circumstance.

And then all at once the front doors of the building cracked open with a sound like a gunshot, and there he was, lit by the sickly yellow glow of the entrance hall.

His waxy white hair looked even more artificial by this light, his pale face virtually fluorescing. He wore pyjama bottoms, but no shirt: I could see his narrow chest rise and fall rapidly, as he gulped down air, like a rabbit hunted to ground.

I was sure I couldn't be seen, but nonetheless, I dared not move.

He walked a few paces forward, staring into the empty lawn, the row of trees beyond. He raised an arm and pointed, accusingly, into the shadows under the cypress trees. He pointed and lunged, jabbing his finger, his mouth agape. His sightless eyes widened.

Hardly breathing, I looked over to where his gaze was fixed.

There was nothing there.

His arm dropped to his side. He staggered forward two more steps, as if in a passion of doubt, and seemed to realize at the same time I did that his feet were bare. They were, like the rest of him, very white, shining under the dawn light like bone. Cautiously, he advanced across the asphalt driveway, like a wading bird at low tide, each foot placed carefully, tentatively, in front of the other. All the while, he didn't take his eyes from the row of cypress trees.

What was the thing you did with sleepwalkers? You woke them up? Or was that the very thing you shouldn't do? In that moment, I couldn't remember.

Slowly, he wrenched his gaze away from the trees. He turned in his own time, like a rusty clock mechanism in the shape of a human being, emerging stiffly on the hour to strike a bell. Then he stopped, and, in one smooth movement, turned and looked upwards.

Directly at me.

Time itself elongated. The blood in my body felt like something corrosive; I thought that he might point again, might scream again – only with words, this time, terrible words, some awful, final judgement on me and my character, my life story, seen in its entirety by a pitiless god,

something I would never, ever recover from. But then, he simply turned to face the doors again, setting each footstep down carefully. His hand plunged twice for the door handle, gripping it at the third attempt.

And then he was gone, and the courtyard was empty.

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The ground seemed a thousand miles below me, a black chasm.

I became aware that I was shaking. I was about to light another cigarette when I realized there was already a freshly lit one between my fingers, somehow. I breathed the smoke in gratefully, as if it were clean mountain air, and listened as my heartbeat went from a gallop to a canter to a trot, and slowly – slowly – returned to normal.

This place – The Ridge – had changed, or maybe had simply reverted to what it had always been. Belatedly, I saw that it was merely a piece of scenery that reflected whatever mood was projected onto it. Life – noisy joyful existence, carefree term-time fun and youthful energy – had fled from it, and it had responded to this absence with spite, becoming something else, something strange. Only the insane could live here now; rising barefoot to greet the dawn, screaming at the trees.

They were welcome to it.

I shut my window and, with daylight purpling the sky, closed the curtains. At some point I must have gone back to sleep, but not before I finally, finally, made a decision, and set my alarm.

---

A few hours later, I got up, showered and dressed, and went to do what I should have done weeks ago.

I called the Student Welfare Office from the brown payphone in the lobby of The Ridge. It was time to come clean, collapse the waveform, turn the many dire possibilities of my immediate future into one single dire outcome. I needed to know my options: I needed guidance. The secretary, in a voice both sweet-natured and cheerful, informed me that my timing was

appalling, as the Student Welfare Office was closed until Thursday, three days away, for staff training, but if I came in at ten that morning, I should be able to see the Welfare Officer in person. I nodded contritely, as if the woman could see me through the telephone, and wrote the details of this appointment down on the back of a bus ticket.

Three days away. Three more nights, at the very least, stuck here at The Ridge, with a man who screamed at the trees.

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That night, however, as darkness fell and I leaned out of my window to smoke, the rain coming down hard and heavy, I saw no other lights anywhere in the building.

Even the Pale Strange Boy, it seemed, had finally left. Now, I was entirely alone in The Ridge.

My initial sense of relief was replaced by a greater, unanticipated sense of unease.

It occurred to me that I might be the only human being for a mile in every direction. It was unlikely anyone would be out in the nearby suburban parkland in this kind of weather; even the hardest or maddest of joggers or dog-walkers wouldn't venture out in this downpour.

Previously, I had felt isolated at The Ridge, but now, I felt like the last surviving member of the human race. Every single door of every single room stood open, and every single room was empty. The echoing rain made the place seem even more like the abandoned hulk of a great ship, adrift in the night, driven by the mindless tide, bows washed in spray; pilotless, rudderless, *The Flying Dutchman*. The clouds dissolved, and the moonlight gave the world and its contents a uniform texture, as if all were composed of the same indefinable substance, grey as lunar soil, hard as marble. In that moment, it became difficult to believe there ever was anyone else alive, anywhere; as if space and time had crumbled, decayed, and there would only ever be this, now.

## 5

9. Because life is suffering, sanity-rending;  
Its poor end not in numinous glow.  
Instead narrowing *to* oblivion ne'erending;  
Our trite heaven is not granted, now.
10. Ever, strange sickness: grinding relentlessly;  
Our woes incarnate nothing great.  
In night's *numb* inkiness, giddily, heedlessly,  
True misery accumulates.

FINALLY, THURSDAY CAME. I showered, dressed in my most respectable clothes, caught a bus into town and made my way to the Student Welfare Office. For once, the sun shone.

The office was housed in a grand Victorian family house of considerable size, partitioned up into offices, near the Humanities faculties. The largest office of this complex, situated on the first floor, was the lair of a tiny, fearsome, caustic woman called Daena McCullough. Daena McCullough's role, as far as I understood it, was to make sure nobody fraudulently received financial help, or genuinely received financial help, or received any help, of any kind whatsoever, from the university. She was excellent at her job. I had been to see her once before, when a grant cheque had not materialized on time, and I needed cash to cover the days until it appeared. The encounter had been an ordeal: I had left with nothing apart from an indefinable feeling of guilt for having the temerity to bother her. I had come here today to – what? To beg her to ignore the fact I was still living on

university property? To kick me out? Again, I just wanted to know what my options were.

On my last visit to see Daena McCullough, the waiting room outside her office had been full. Students freaking out due to exam stress, or seeking advice about emergency contraception, or simply just enduring a good old-fashioned nervous breakdown. Today, however, after I'd clomped my way up the stairs to the first floor, I found the waiting room empty apart from the receptionist. I sat fidgeting for five minutes, already feeling that same obscure sense of shame familiar from my last visit, as if I were awaiting treatment for a sexually transmitted disease. I worked out things I was going to say, in the sure knowledge that I would forget them the second Daena McCullough set eyes on me.

The receptionist called my name; superfluously, as I was the only person there. I stood up so fast my vision blurred, and stumbled into Daena's office.

---

She sat behind a desk, comparing one set of paperwork with another. She didn't look up when I came in, merely pointed to the empty chair on the other side of her desk with a red pen. I never saw her when she wasn't sitting in her chair, but from what I could see she was a small woman in her early fifties with caramel-coloured hair, styled into something tall and defiantly at least twenty years out of fashion. Despite the warmth of the day, she wore a brightly coloured sweater with a knitted pattern of Scottie dogs; her fingers were adorned with a variety of rings set with large, garish stones. After a couple of seconds of silence, I realized she wasn't going to prompt me to speak, and so I began to talk, explaining what I could of my predicament. All the time I spoke, she didn't look up, or desist from writing notes with her red pen.

'You're not unique, you know,' she said, apparently speaking to the document in her hand. 'There's a few of you who preferred to stay here

over the summer.’ The red pen went through another line of text, deleting it from existence.

‘I didn’t.’

‘Didn’t *what*?’ There was already frost in her voice.

‘Didn’t *prefer* to. I didn’t want to stay here. But there’s nowhere else I can currently go.’

‘*Really*?’ The red pen deleted another line of text. She still hadn’t looked at me.

‘I have to stay here,’ I said. ‘I have no choice.’

‘*Really*,’ she said, again. ‘No choice? You’re nineteen years old, Mr Lane. All you have is choice. Trust me. Endless choice.’

‘I don’t,’ I said. ‘Have a choice, I mean. There’s literally nowhere else I can go.’

‘Hmmm.’ She tapped her upper lip with the pen. Her gaze was still firmly fixed on the documents in front of her. ‘I mean, you could always just go home? Everyone else manages to.’

‘I can’t.’

Finally, she looked at me over the top of her glasses.

‘Why ever not?’ Her tone was artificially cordial, the prelude to unleashing a black torrent of scorn. But, for the first and only time in my dealings with Daena McCullough, I was ahead of her.

‘It’ll probably just be quicker if you look in my file.’

She peered hard at me, scanning me for impertinence. When she could detect none, she scooted her chair the short distance to an olive-green filing cabinet. A few seconds of casual flipping with her pink acrylic fingernails produced a cardboard folder. She scooted back to her desk and opened the file.

After a minute or so of silent reading, during which she rolled her tongue round her teeth as if counting them, she reached the relevant information. The Last Day. The Day of The Annihilator.

This discovery was unmistakeable. She froze, and, slowly, her mouth hung open involuntarily as she read, giving her a vaguely simian look. A minute passed. Two minutes. Three. Eventually, she closed the file



carefully, as if the details needed to be shut away, lest they contaminate other files, other life stories. She took her glasses off. They were on a cord, and sat on the bosom of her brightly coloured Scottie Dog jumper as she put her elbows on the armrests of her chair. She was, I realized, assessing me properly, for the first time.

‘No other relatives you can stay with?’ she said at last, in a quiet, almost kind, voice.

I shook my head. She put her glasses back on, but by now she was looking through me, not at me, and thinking. I didn’t interrupt her; I had played my only card.

‘Okay,’ she said. ‘Here’s what I can do. You’re not the first student to have... *extenuating circumstances*. You’re not even the first one to have come to me this week, though you have left it rather later than I would have liked for me to do anything about it. So here’s what I can do. You’re up at... The Ridge? Yes?’ She spoke the name as if the place were a maximum security prison.

‘Yes.’

‘Well, every summer each hall of residence is hired out for conferences or whatnot. Including The Ridge, I’m afraid. So you can’t stay there. In two weeks’ time the place will be swarming with Mormons.’

‘Okay.’ I had no regrets about this at all. After the last three weeks, I felt that if I never saw The Ridge again, I’d be happy.

‘There are of course various other university-owned properties, houses and so forth’ – she gave a little pause before dashing my hopes – ‘but they’re all currently occupied.’

‘Oh.’ Was she toying with me, I wondered? Dragging me forcibly through a tour of my own stupidity, in order that I might learn an improving lesson? She reached for a folder in a wire in-tray.

‘However, it would appear... you’re in luck.’

She opened the folder. ‘Six miles north of The Ridge, in the countryside, the university is looking to acquire a large, empty property called Marshlands, and all adjoining properties, with a view to turning them into a seventh hall of residence.

‘Marshlands is a former private hospital. It’s been empty for a long time, but there were some... issues with the estate. The plan is to entirely renovate the place over the next two years or so, but in order for *that* to happen, the university has to finalize the sale of the place, and in order for *that* to happen, the surveyors have to make a proper assessment. And in order for *that* to happen, the place has to be entirely cleared out, and all contents removed.

‘So, in an attempt to be magnanimous to people like yourself, who’ve elected – or ended up – spending the summer here, and also to save money, the university has thrown this task open to the student body. There’s a team of supervised students who’ve signed on to clear it up. They started this week, I believe.’

‘I... didn’t hear about this?’

‘There were posters about it all over the Student Union.’

I almost never went to the Student Union building. Amethyst disliked it, so that had more or less made the decision for me.

‘Anyway, as well as being accommodated in a dormitory on-site, the team up there are being paid three hundred pounds a week, which the university has deemed fair for the work.’

‘*Bloody hell,*’ I said, before I could stop myself. I needn’t have worried, however; my swearing didn’t even slow her down.

‘*Bloody hell indeed,* Mr Lane. And as you can imagine, on such attractive terms, all of the available positions were filled ages ago by eager students.’

‘Oh. Okay.’ *Then why the fuck—*

‘*However,*’ she said, shutting the folder, ‘I had a phone call late yesterday afternoon. One of the students helping with the clean-up has dropped out. Family emergency, apparently.’

‘So they... have a free place?’

‘Yeeees,’ said Daena McCullough slowly, as if talking to someone heavily medicated. ‘For as long as they have work that needs doing, anyway.’

‘So... I can stay there? And be paid?’ It had been so long since I had felt joy, or enjoyed any kind of good fortune, that I felt breathless.

‘It would appear so. Your timing, Mr Lane, is excellent. I will place a call to Jilly Cowie, the project leader up there, immediately. And Mr Lane?’

She peered at me over her glasses. If I’d considered her previous stares withering, they were as nothing compared to this one.

*‘I’m sticking my neck out for you here, so don’t make me regret this.’*

‘Of course. I mean, of course *not*.’ I was reeling. What had I expected, realistically, from this interview? A rap on the knuckles for staying at The Ridge without informing the university, a bill – payable whenever possible – for the weeks I’d already lingered? And me begging Daena McCullough – not figuratively – for another week at The Ridge, so I could find a dismal single room in town and a summer job to match.

And now, suddenly, everything felt luminous.

‘Thank you,’ I said, standing up. I held my hand out for Daena McCullough to shake. I have no idea why I did this. She stared at my outstretched hand with cold bafflement until I retracted my arm, mechanically, over the table. In my mind’s eye I saw my hand shrivel and drop off, onto the floor, to join the desiccated husks of other well-meaning hands there, going back many years.

‘I imagine there are forms to fill in?’ I said quietly.

‘Oh yes,’ said Daena McCullough, visibly and genuinely brightening for the first, and only, time in our acquaintance. ‘A *lot* of forms.’

---

Two hours later, I sat in a pub near the Student Welfare Office, sipping a celebratory second pint of Guinness, stunned by my good fortune. Calls had been placed, forms filled in, and Daena had informed me that the team at the hospital would be expecting me up there on Monday afternoon. Everything had – with no effort on my part – *entirely worked out*, and now not only had I somewhere to live and a job, I also had a purpose and a plan, possibly for the entire summer. And I would be paid, and paid well. If I

stayed for the next eight weeks or so, up until term started, I could walk away with just under two thousand pounds, once my debts to the university were paid. I could put down a deposit on a house for next term, maybe even have a little left over. Who cared that it didn't mean I would get away anywhere? I could make up a more exciting summer when I finally saw Amethyst again.

*Or, I thought, I could just work for six weeks and fly out to see her, wherever she is.*

The alcohol, on an empty stomach, made me euphoric, and so I simply sat, adrenalized and exhilarated by my undeserved good fortune. I headed back to The Ridge two pints later, still luxuriating in the lack of pressure, the absence of guilt for my very existence. My key, scraping four-pints-drunk around the lock, sounded loud in the empty courtyard.



My bare feet pattered down the concrete stairwell, onto the ground floor and into the lobby.

There was the reception area, with its wall of pigeonholes. There were the oil paintings of notable benefactors, hung high enough to deter all but the most determined pranksters, grotesque and monstrous, grimacing out from murky silence. I drifted noiselessly through the empty refectory, chairs tipped against tables, the room pungent with disinfectant.

I had known all along where I was heading. At the east side of the ground floor, I walked along another hallway lined with open doors. The rooms beyond had not been cleared yet. In the first one, a box of cornflakes and a can of kidney beans sat on the desk; on the second one, some scattered postcards were stuck to a corkboard, reproductions of works by Cranach and Bruegel. The third room was still decorated with fluorescent Day-Glo flyers for rave nights at various clubs: Utopia, Elysium, Eden, Xanadu.

None of this was what I was looking for. Advancing, step by cold step, I halted by the fourth door on the right, and knew at once that this was it.

## The room of the Pale Strange Boy.

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The door stood half-open. The room smelled of stale washing, a faint chemical whiff of deodorant. In the middle of the floor was a cardboard box, which had once held fabric softener but now contained empty vodka bottles.

On the desk, however, was some kind of book or journal; large and old, leather-bound, not the kind of thing one would deliberately leave behind. A red volume.

I was about to open it when something made me glance out of the window, into the dark, still courtyard, and upwards, to my room.

Within the rectangle of shadow contained by my window, something twitched, turned.

A pale face floated out of the abyssal blackness of the room like the face of a submerged corpse, and grinned down at me.

---

The bang of the chair hitting the floor was loud: I did not recall standing up. But I was lying down, surely? And then briefly, I was both, caught in a superposition, trapped here, in the dead building, and I was dead too. Maybe I was haunting myself. Maybe there was never anyone else here, and if there were, maybe they were here years ago. Amethyst and Marcus, everyone else who lived here, maybe they were all long dead. Three weeks ago. A hundred years ago. A hundred thousand. I thought I recognized this horrible predicament from somewhere, and that sense of recurrence made me panic even more until I realized I had kicked the chair over.

I was in my own bed, in my room. I had not wandered the cloistered expanse of The Ridge at all, just explored the model of it in my mind. I wondered if I had heard a scream or produced one, or whether I was just remembering the Pale Strange Boy and his night terrors of the previous – when was it? Time seemed not to be working any more. It was two in the

morning. I was in bed. I had not gone anywhere. I had kicked the chair over. The chair was on the floor.

I snapped my bedside light on, but the dread at the core of the dream endured, present in everything, saturating my perception. I lay still, and only when my left forearm began to ache did I realize how tightly I was gripping it with my right hand. Time slowed, became meaningless, as sleep began to take me. *Three weeks. A hundred years. A hundred thousand.*

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# II

## MARSHLANDS

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## 6

11. Regions immortal supposed hitherto,  
Gilded ruin of *this* Earth, sparkling quartz;  
Utopia, Elysium, Eden, Xanadu.  
To realms empty, mad eyes sight awards.
12. Stranger. Reclusive, elusive, strange, pale:  
In time's *empty* tragedy held.  
Ever, his own unhappy shout exhales –  
In no sense atones. Now expelled.

NEXT MONDAY, on my last ever morning at The Ridge, I rose early.

I had expected to sleep in, to luxuriate in the feeling of having somewhere to go and something to do, but instead I found I was just keen to leave. I ate breakfast, then packed my things, which did not take long. As Marcus had left with my stereo, and all my tapes and CDs, the contents of my room fitted into one green canvas bag and a rucksack I'd bought a while ago from the Army & Navy Store. The minicab I'd booked to take me to the address that Daena McCullough had given me turned up at 3 p.m.; I got in, and, entirely without ceremony, the car pulled off, and we left. I thought I might watch The Ridge drop away behind me, melting away to nothing, as if I were in a film, and the moment narratively significant, but in the end I didn't bother. I just wanted to be somewhere else.

After a mile of steadily thinning suburbs, urbanity gave way to trees and hedgerows, and I realized that I had been so elated at the prospect of leaving The Ridge that I hadn't given any thought whatsoever to where I



was actually going. I should have asked Daena McCullough dozens of questions, but I was too used to the habit of not being concerned about my immediate future, and too enamoured with the idea that I had landed squarely on my feet, to think about that at the time. The possibility occurred, far too late, that I might be heading out of the frying pan and directly into the fire, but there was nothing I could do about that now. Nevertheless, having nothing else to focus on, this dread grew and grew, and in the back seat of the cab I began to persuade myself into a silent state of panic at what I might have signed up for, three hundred pounds per week or no. Where was I even going? Daena McCullough had said it was a hospital, was that right? Even that felt like something I might have made up. I looked again at the card she'd given me with the address on it.

I read the word *Marshlands*, and a shadow fell across the page.

I looked up to see a pair of enormous stone gateposts, looming in front of the car, topped with stone orbs. From these monoliths sagged two rusted wrought-iron gates, twelve feet high, once dignified, now bent and exhausted. A hand-painted hardboard sign attached to the right-hand gate with cable ties said *PRIVATE PROPERTY – KEEP OUT*.

And then we were on a small private road, approaching what appeared to be almost a small hamlet, a group of stone buildings huddled together under a vast, dreary sky.

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The cluster of dwellings were all two, three and, in the case of the main building, four storeys high, made of some drab local stone, now speckled with yellow lichen. This main building looked, at first sight, like a school: the kind of place where a single stern headmistress held sway over terrified staff and pupils, or where a cultish order of Victorian social reformers might have sought to manifest some highly specific Utopia. Extending diagonally outward from the right side of the main building, like a ramshackle prosthetic limb, was a 1970s one-storey wing of indeterminate function; seventy years younger than the rest of the complex, it was already falling

apart. Two large three-storey blocks loomed behind the main building, with some kind of kitchen block a little way off; even further away sat the tiniest possible version of a chapel, suitable only for private prayer, now boarded up and padlocked. All of this was surrounded by meadows, not recently mowed, but clearly maintained to some degree.

We swung to a halt in front of the main building. The cab driver handed me my bags wordlessly, as if I had besmirched the family name and now must join the Foreign Legion. In return, I tipped him all the change I had in the world, which he still managed to stare at derisively, as if it were an insult.

The drone of the cab's engine faded as it shrank towards the distant gates and I was immediately conscious of being alone again, in a vaster, wider solitude than the one I had just left. What would I do if this were the wrong place? I didn't have the money to get a cab back into town. If the address was incorrect, or Daena McCullough had deliberately given me the wrong address to amuse herself, then every five minutes of the journey here would be a mile to walk back, laden with luggage.

Part of me acknowledged that this might somehow be what I deserved.

What was this place? I picked up my bags and approached the building. Underneath its small stone portico, one of the enormous front doors had been wedged open with a folded-up newspaper. From within, I could hear the sound of a distant radio, 4 Non Blondes wailing 'What's going on?' I peered into the dark hallway.

'Hello?' My voice, underused these last few weeks, sounded entirely foreign to me. I stepped inside, cautious as a cat in this unfamiliar environment. The bright grey day made me momentarily blind, and the dark interior took a couple of seconds to resolve into a large, high-ceilinged reception room: I saw a high, grand desk, a wall of pigeonholes for mail, all empty, a floor of red and blue patterned tiles.

There was, momentarily, the disquieting sense I had left The Ridge only to end up in a smaller version of it.

Postcard-sized framed paintings hung on the wood-panelled wall. Most of them were landscapes, but there was the odd portrait or still life. The

closest painting showed a vista of patchwork fields, bordered by meandering hedgerows, a neat whitewashed cottage in the foreground. From the chimney, smoke rose in a zigzag of painstakingly exact right angles.

There was a quality about the technique, something that hinted at immense restraint, of intense, agonized concentration in each tiny brushstroke. This quality was present, though manifested differently, in the next painting, and the next, and the next.

And then I knew what I was looking at, and where I was.

This place had indeed been some kind of hospital. These pictures had been painted by the residents, or – to put it another way – the patients.

*Or to put it yet another way, by the insane.*

Of course. There had to be a catch, and here it was. The place was an abandoned asylum, for those too disturbed to be allowed near society. I was so pleased with myself for escaping The Ridge that I hadn't considered where I was escaping to, and the answer was this: I was going to spend the next two months in a mental asylum, a place where the echoes of maltreatment and misery saturated the very brickwork of the building. I had signed up to spend the twentieth summer of my life in a place haunted by the indelible screams of the deranged, the mad, a distant generation of long-dead lunatics.

*Out of the frying pan.*

I realized that, for the first time in weeks, I was laughing.

'Hello?' said a voice.

# 7

13. These old rooms – my *Eden* – now threatened, exposed,  
Drear solitude's ode unconcealed.  
God's heeding, tireless, noting each woe;  
Our frail feeble evils revealed.

14. I needed guidance, some true orientation,  
I needed veracious insight.  
Tortured experience, *cursed* revelation  
Underpins Eden's lying twilight.

'THE FIRST THING you have to realize,' said Jilly Cowie from behind her desk, 'is that this place is *not* a lunatic asylum. And it never was! I really can't stress that enough. The university is very keen to quash any misunderstanding on that point, lest the place get a... *name* it doesn't deserve. They don't want any student population based out here to think... I mean, they'll have enough to contend with, being this far out, relying on a shuttle-bus to get to even the most basic amenities without...'

She paused to inhale. 'I'm just saying. It would be unfair in the extreme to say that Marshlands was *ever* an asylum. It was always a *refuge for the distressed*.'

Jilly Cowie had introduced herself to me five minutes ago, with an enormous grin and a confident, trustworthy handshake. She looked, to the nearest decimal point, exactly as I would expect someone with the name *Jilly Cowie* to look, being in the region of thirty-five years old, with a mousy bob, and large tortoiseshell-framed glasses adorning a face that was

ruddy-cheeked, with a toothy, frequent smile. She wore a blue tracksuit top and a pleated plaid skirt, like a games teacher; maybe she had just found school PE kit comfortable and had decided, at an unconscious level, to spend the rest of her life wearing it. She was also only just five feet tall; on the short walk to her office, I had towered over her. 'I'm running the show here,' she had laughed, '*for my sins!*' and I had managed a laugh in return. Most of the laughter was relief: I was just pleased to have found the right place.

The office Jilly led me to was tiny; this struck me as odd in a large, empty building, where space was presumably not a problem, and she could, in theory, have any size room she liked. The walls were already covered with timetables and fixtures for dozens of various university sports clubs and activities; everything about Jilly Cowie left me in no doubt that she ran them all. The cramped conditions inside her office were exacerbated by the fact that jammed diagonally across the small space was a ten-speed racing bike, wedged next to us as we sat either side of Jilly's desk. The bike's front end, adorned with curved handlebars and complicated brakes that made it look like the head of some tropical mollusc, seemed to be eavesdropping on our conversation. I noted with no surprise whatsoever that Jilly Cowie's tiny sloping desk was an old 1950s school desk, with the runner at the top for pencils and a hole for the inkwell. It seemed entirely appropriate.

'Anyway, look!' she said, clapping her hands as if to recapture my attention. 'Great to meet you. You're the new Rex!'

I stared at her in confusion. 'I'm sorry?'

'You're the replacement for Rex, the French student who had to drop out. When I say "French student", I don't mean "Student who was studying French" of course, I mean "Student who was French", because he was, he was French, from France. But he was actually studying Economics.' Jilly paused, as if to get her bearings. 'Anyway, his father died suddenly, poor boy, so he had to return to the family home in Bordeaux. Which, fair enough, if *I* were him and I was faced with the choice between a summer in Bordeaux and being... *here*, I know which I'd have chosen! No offence!' Jilly Cowie was the kind of person who Jilly Cowie herself would describe

as *talking nineteen to the dozen*. She snorted with a bark of sudden, alarming laughter as she flipped open a folder. ‘And it’s... Adam, yes?’

‘I’m— No. Alex.’

‘Right. Of course.’ She picked up another folder. ‘Alex. Sorry, what day is it again?’

‘Monday.’

She frowned at the calendar as if it weren’t to be trusted. ‘Very hard to keep track of time out here!’ she laughed. ‘*Ve-ry* hard. Ah! Here you are. Alex Lane!’

‘That’s me.’

She read my folder for a few seconds, pupils flicking back and forth like someone on a moving train trying to read the name of a passing station. Her indifferent reaction to the information inside told me that Daena McCullough had redacted certain details, for which I was thankful. Jilly Cowie looked up at me and smiled with all her might.

‘Well then, Alex. Welcome to Marshlands! Let me show you around!’ She got up and bustled past me in the cramped office. ‘Bring your bags! Wow, is that all you’ve got?’



Jilly Cowie strode purposefully ahead of me as we wandered down a dark ground floor corridor, punctuated along its length by double doors. This gave way to a large, low-ceilinged ward, its metal beds dismantled, the brass bedsteads stacked tidily in corners or tipped against walls.

All the walls, without exception, were painted an institutional green.

‘Wow,’ I said.

‘Yes,’ said Jilly. ‘These are the rooms we’ve already cleared out, just to give you some idea of how fast we’ve been working. We’re on a very strict timetable, if we’re to get everything done in time for the survey at the end of summer. I like to keep a tight ship!’ I had no doubt this was true.

‘This place was built in 1910,’ said Jilly briskly, as she locked the doors. ‘So society’s attitude to the mentally unwell – although not perfect – was

very much less barbaric than it *had* been. Also, the place operated under the influence of the patrons, the Flayne family, who were basically secular late-Victorian humanists, if they were anything, so, no electric shocks, no constant sedation, very little in the way of restraints or straitjacketing. It was all very *modern*!

‘A sanatorium for people suffering acute mental distress was something of a curio at first,’ she continued, propping open one half of a double door, ‘and the place was not well attended. Then came 1914, of course, and the place was *packed* for decades after. A huge success!’ She smiled, momentarily pleased by this happy ending for World War I, before bustling us upwards into a stairwell with large, broad steps.

‘Is this place safe?’ I asked, as we climbed past a particularly ominous crack in the concrete. ‘I mean, structurally?’

‘Oh yes,’ said Jilly. ‘*Absolutely*. I mean, some of the cracks and stuff might *look* bad, but it’s passed a site inspection. Trust me, they don’t build ‘em like this any more!’ She patted one of the nearby walls affectionately; when it didn’t immediately collapse, she smiled triumphantly, as if to say *see?*

‘And are we clearing out all of these buildings?’ I asked, looking out of the window to the boarded-up chapel.

‘Good Lord, no,’ said Jilly. ‘We’re only doing this building at the moment. The others have all been emptied by contractors.’

We reached the first floor landing. Jilly propped open another door, and we emerged into a shorter, better-maintained corridor, with no damp and no cracks at all, warmer than the other corridors and wards we’d traversed, and unmistakably inhabited. I could hear the slow pulse of ambient music, possibly The Orb, something soft and slow and gradual, the aural equivalent of a Salvador Dalí watch melting, and there was a faint smell of coffee and tobacco.

‘Hello!’ said Jilly Cowie. ‘Avon calling! Anyone home?’ When it became obvious no-one could hear her, she trilled, ‘*Helllllooooo?*’ in a voice that could shatter marble.

Halfway up a nearby door jamb, a young man's head appeared, sliding into view as if it were descending a ramp; it took me a couple of seconds to realize that the owner of the head must be leaning backwards on the rear two legs of an unseen chair. He had a mass of shoulder-length sandy-coloured hair growing into a sandy-coloured beard, and sandy-coloured eyebrows that met above thick glasses through which large brown eyes squinted. He looked immediately displeased to see Jilly Cowie, but upon seeing me, his beard magically grew bright white teeth, set in a mischievous grin. He must have tilted forward again on his chair, as he abruptly vanished, to emerge two seconds later in the corridor. He was tall and large, and wore a shabby brown jersey, even shabbier green corduroy trousers, and, as he approached us, I saw his feet were in flip flops. His welcoming grin got wider as he came nearer.

'Ah! Fresh blood! Nice to see a new face here, I'm getting very bored with the others.'

'Alex, this is Clive. Clive, this is Alex,' said Jilly. 'He's Rex's replacement.'

'Hi,' I said. 'I just hope I can, y'know, fill Rex's *chaussures*.'

'Hahaha!' Clive's laugh was an unrestrained boom. 'A proper joke!' He grabbed my hand and shook it vigorously. 'Don't worry, literally anyone would be an improvement on Rex, the humourless bastard.'

'Now, now,' said Jilly Cowie, in an indulgent-mum-dealing-with-naughty-child voice. Her smile became strained. 'That's not very pleasant, is it? Clive here is a postgrad. He's second in command, after me.' Clive said nothing, simply smiled a strained smile and raised his bushy blond eyebrows to confirm that *yes, this is my current lot in life. Subordinate to Jilly Cowie*.

'The rooms up here were all for staff,' said Jilly. 'And as such they're much more comfortable than the wards. And much more private! So you'll have your own room, and most of them even have a small bathroom attached. The kitchen, however, is communal. Just on the left there.'

'Yeah,' said Clive. 'Right next to my room. So don't cook any fish in there, or I'll fucking kill you.' He said this in a perfect deadpan, which



made me smile. I liked Clive. It would have been hard not to.

Jilly soldiered on through a rictus grin, as if she hadn't heard him. 'The boys' rooms are on the left, girls on the right.'

'How many of us are there?'

'Seven at the moment, but there's someone else due to turn up tonight. Or tomorrow. I mean, if she even *does* turn up. Maybe she's found something better to do.'

Clive picked at something on his jersey. 'Difficult though that is to imagine.'

'So there'll be eight of you all together. We'll be putting all of you as near as possible to each other, and to me, in order to keep things organized. I do like things organized!' Jilly collapsed into snorts of laughter as if *liking things organized* was as scandalous a vice as a human being could obtain. Clive smiled tightly, as if trying to endure the pain of a stubbed toe without crying out.

'My quarters are downstairs,' Jilly went on. 'There's a phone down there for emergencies. It's the only working phone on the premises. I'll give you the number later so you can share it with your next of kin. Use it sparingly, though, I'm not an answering service.' For a fleeting second, I detected a hardness in her voice, beyond all of her schoolmarm-ish enthusiasm, but it was gone in an instant. She clapped her hands together again, concluding my introduction to the place. 'Okay! I'll leave you to it. Clive can show you your room and where everything is. And tomorrow, when you're all settled in, we'll put you to work!' Jilly Cowie pushed open the double doors and made her way out into the corridor, heading back downstairs.

Clive stared after her, watching her leave.

'Thank fuck,' he said, as the double doors slammed closed behind her. 'I was just putting together a truly colossal joint, if you fancy it?'

I looked at my watch. It was not quite 4.30.

'Maybe... later?'

'Really?' Clive turned back into his room, and slumped down into an orange plastic chair. Removing a newspaper that had been hastily thrown

over his desk, he revealed an elaborate three-skinned joint in the final stages of construction. ‘Wow. I thought you were *cool*.’ He picked up the joint and resumed rolling it, his thick fingers surprisingly dexterous, and grinned up at me. ‘Anyway, welcome to the nuthouse. I see you’ve already met Silly Cowie, for which I can only apologize.’ His tongue flashed out from his thick beard to lick the rolling papers.

‘Ah, she seems alright,’ I said. ‘Unless... everyone else here is like her?’

Clive appeared to stretch the completed joint into existence between his fingertips, like a magician pulling a wand out of thin air. ‘No, thank God.’ He stuck the finished product in his mouth, struck a match. ‘Most of the others are normal. Or, you know. As normal as you can expect from a bunch of people who’ve chosen to spend their summer doing... *this*.’ He inhaled, and immediately seemed to relax, tipping his chair back again to blow a plume of grey-brown smoke into the air.

‘God, that’s better. Come on, I’ll show you to your quarters.’

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The room was larger than the one I’d had at The Ridge, and undoubtedly grander. The walls were painted white, with the boarded-up remnant of a tall fireplace set into one corner. The bed was, unsurprisingly, another former hospital bed, with great gleaming brass steads and a mattress that, on sitting down, I discovered to be granite-hard. Apart from a small bedside table, a desk and chair, there was no other furniture. A door led off to a tiny, cupboard-like bathroom, tiled in pale yellow: poking my head inside, I saw a toilet, a sink and a half-sized bath I would be unable to lie down in.

‘There you go,’ said Clive. ‘One of the nicer rooms, I’d say. We’ve even managed to get rid of Rex’s unwashed Gallic reek.’

‘Great,’ I said. ‘Now it only reeks of pot.’

Clive exhaled through a smile, thickening the haze around him. ‘Don’t worry, it’s on the house. When you’re all unpacked, I’ll show you where the washing machines and stuff are.’

I nodded, only half listening. Looking east from the window, I could see, just beyond the meadows of Marshlands, a high stone wall, enclosing what appeared to be very dense woods.

Emerging from the treetops were the attic storey and chimneys of a large, imposing Victorian house.

Even from this distance I could see that it was intensely detailed, with every fussiness that the final flowering of Victorian Gothic could manifest. Time had darkened the brickwork and the decorative elements, and what once had surely looked almost twee when the building was new now looked overwrought, leaving the impression of a thing manically asserting its own grandiosity to the dozen or so acres of empty unkempt woodland that surrounded it. All of the windows I could see – arched, surrounded by ecclesiastical-looking masonry and tilework – seemed to be boarded up. The overall impression was of a mad aristocrat, fallen from grace, imprisoned in her own desperate and decaying magnificence, Miss Havisham in stone and brick and tile.

Clive joined me as I stared out of the window.

‘What’s *that*?’

Clive smirked.

‘Haunted house,’ he said. ‘*Duh.*’

## 8

15. Your ease now shattered, here reality's ordering  
Unravels, dismantling each date.  
Grey routine ends, erupting, *distorting*:  
Rote existence I now vacate.
16. Ever near, tragedy expunges, destroys,  
A silent sojourn in distress.  
Unshackle our unclean souls. Let *your* voice  
Express inexpressible loss!

AFTER I HAD UNPACKED, in no great hurry, I ambled to the kitchen. Clive was in there, preparing a vast quantity of cheese on toast on a grill tray. He smiled as I came in.

'Worcestershire Sauce? On cheese on toast?' I sniffed. 'How very exotic.'

'What can I say? I'm very much the *bon viveur*.' He belched, then finished shaking the bottle of sauce onto the cheese and, slamming the tray under the grill, ignited it. The grill roared like a blowtorch.

I remembered that I had a practical question. 'So, how do we get... y'know. Food?'

'Oh yeah.' Clive paused to take off his enormous brown jumper, revealing a faded Led Zeppelin T-shirt over a large beer gut. 'I'm supposed to be showing you the ropes, aren't I?'

'You are.'

'Okay. How much do you know about what's happening here?'

‘We’re cleaning this place out, right?’

‘Cor-rect.’ He bent down to light a cigarette from one of the rings of the gas cooker; when it was lit he took a series of short, deep drags to make sure it stayed lit, then turned the gas off. The seamlessness of his movements indicated he’d done this many times. ‘I’m sure Cowie made it seem like more of a project than it is. We’re clearing all the crap out of this main building, so that the surveyors can make a detailed assessment of the place, and how best to convert it, and the buildings around it, into a hall of residence.’

‘What’s the work like?’

‘Why?’ he said, smiling. ‘Afraid of hard work?’

I smiled back. ‘Terrified.’

‘Well, rest assured. Most of the big stuff, furniture and the like, was taken away and auctioned off a couple of months back, so cleaning out the wards didn’t take very long at all. In fact – between you and me – I’m worried we’re gonna be finished soon.’

This was a worry for me too. ‘How much work do you think is left?’

Clive pulled out the grill, inspected the melting rate of his cheese on toast, found it unsatisfactory and slammed it back in. ‘Hard to say. A week? Two?’

Clive must have seen my downcast face, as he suddenly appeared almost concerned. ‘I mean, don’t worry. This whole gig is a primo doss. I intend to keep it afloat as long as possible, so relax.’

He removed the grill again, and, with dancing fingertips, whipped the slices of bubbling toast onto a plate, before unceremoniously flopping down into one of two tatty leather armchairs. He remembered he had a cigarette on the go and carefully rolled it out in an ashtray on the chair’s armrest.

‘What else?’ he said, through a mouthful of cheese. ‘Oh yeah, I have to give you a safety induction thing, but it’s incredibly boring and it’s all common sense, like, *don’t lick any mains cables* and *don’t jump out of a fourth floor window* and so on, and it takes, like, an entire fucking hour. So if Cowie asks’ – he paused to slurp up a string of melted cheese – ‘just say you’ve done it.’ I shrugged, to indicate this was fine by me. Clive continued

talking, mouth still full. 'As far as living here goes, we're still finding our feet, but last week we all put twenty, thirty quid in for food and booze, and we started a rota for who goes to get it, either in my car or Malcolm's. Any special items, you'll have to request and pay for yourself. That seems the best way of doing it. Mind you' – he paused again to chew and swallow a wad of cheese on toast – 'last week we made the mistake of going during rush hour, so we decided to try and confine future trips to the supermarket to Monday afternoons, when it's less crowded.'

'So that means that someone's doing one now?'

'Oh shit, yeah. Malcolm and Adam today. I hope they remember my lighter flints. Never mind, you can chuck in twenty quid right now, just to make sure you don't starve.' He held out a hand.

I fished my wallet out of my hip pocket and handed over two ten pound notes – the last available cash I had in the entire world – as if it were nothing. Clive immediately pocketed it.

'And when do we get paid?'

'Every Monday,' he said. 'Cowie issues cheques, and then on Wednesday, she runs into town and sticks 'em all into the relevant banks.' And after that, I reflected, it would take five to seven working days for the cheque to clear. I would not have any money here for a while.

'What else?' Clive licked his fingers. 'Oh yeah, washing machines are in that little room over there.' He gestured towards a door leading from the kitchen into what had once been some kind of pantry. 'There's three of 'em, but it does get pretty messy here, so get in early. Cowie expects you to keep your room and bathroom clean, but since it's all gonna either be refitted or demolished, it's very hard to see why.' Something occurred to him. 'Oh, and although we each have a bathroom, there's only one shower, handily situated at the end of the laundry room, alongside the washing machines. There's only a limited amount of hot water, so at the end of any given day, competition for that is pretty fierce. Oh, and on that subject, ask Cowie for a boiler suit and gloves, for the work. Trust me, you'll need them, this place is absolutely filthy. Dust masks are in the locker in the corridor. I'll also stick you down on the housework rota. Any questions?'

‘Yeah,’ I said. ‘Can you lend me twenty quid to see me through the next fortnight?’

Clive smiled again, and shook his head in mock outrage at the audacity of it all, but he still handed the notes back.

‘What are the others like?’

Clive gestured towards the doorway. From the corridor beyond, I could hear voices echoing round the stairwell.

‘Ask ’em yourself.’

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Three people – two young women and a young man – clattered through the double doors, all clad in filthy blue boiler suits. Their faces were partially coated in grey-brown dust, with round clean spots where dust masks had been. They had been deep in animated conversation, but fell silent when they saw me. The nearest – a tall, thin woman with curtains of long, black hair, straight as if drawn with a ruler, framing a pale face – smiled at me in guarded greeting. Her eyes were blue, her expression one of permanent bemusement at the world around her. When she spoke, her voice was unexpectedly deep.

‘New guy!’ she said. ‘Here to join the fun?’

‘And what fun it looks,’ I said. ‘I’m Alex.’

‘Ruth,’ said the woman. Behind her, a tall, handsome man was already loosening his boiler suit to the waist, shedding it like a skin. He had short dreadlocks, piled on his scalp, and a goatee beard.

‘Leo.’ He shook my hand.

Behind Leo a short, slightly stern-looking woman, with shoulder-length blonde hair, regarded me with disappointment. ‘I thought we were getting a girl?’ she said, as if someone had returned from the pet shop with a dog when she’d wanted a cat. Her voice was loud and immediately grating.

‘She’s arriving next week,’ said Ruth. ‘Isn’t she? Clive?’ Clive said one indecipherable syllable through a mouthful of cheese on toast.

‘Hello,’ I said, smiling diplomatically at the stern blonde woman. ‘I’m Alex.’

‘Helen.’ She seemed to both scowl and smile as she shook my hand. ‘Pleased to meet you.’

‘How many of us are there again?’ I hoped this was it. Too many of us meant the work would proceed faster: the work proceeding faster meant that this would all end sooner. Having found this job, I was very keen to string it out as long as possible.

‘Just us,’ said Leo, ‘and Adam and Malcolm, who went off into town to do the shop.’

‘Seven of us,’ I said.

‘Hey!’ said Helen. ‘Wait a second. Now that we’re all here, and seeing as it’s supplies day, why don’t we welcome the new arrival by all eating together tonight?’

‘That’s actually a good idea,’ said Ruth.

‘First one she’s had,’ muttered Clive.

‘*Pardon?*’ said Helen. Clive smiled cheerily at her for a second then turned away.

---

We pushed two of the kitchen tables together and covered them with a slightly malodorous tablecloth someone found in a cupboard, and sourced seven different chairs from various rooms. Ten minutes later, the table was set, and despite the mismatched cutlery, and an ancient red stain in the centre of the tablecloth, it looked almost respectable, almost inviting. Helen had even picked some of the wildflowers that battled the weeds in the flowerbeds in front of Marshlands, putting them in a tall blue porcelain vase with a chipped rim. Nobody had an idea what to cook in sufficient quantity to feed seven people, so it was decided that an enormous spaghetti bolognese would be assembled, as soon as the foragers returned from their excursion to the supermarket. Ruth, Helen and Leo drifted off to have showers, returning to the kitchen as absurdly clean as they had been



absurdly filthy. Ruth returned in a long black dress, with black and white striped stockings and a pendant that was just a hexagonal bar of polished obsidian.

Helen had been last to shower, and joined us at the table, her blonde hair freshly blow-dried. 'Haven't we started cooking yet? I'm starving.'

'We're still waiting for the others to get back,' said Ruth. 'Can't cook if there's nothing to cook with.'

Clive's feet slapped in their flip flops as he approached. His eyes were even more bloodshot than when I'd seen him this morning. He sank down in the chair next to me.

'Good God,' I said. 'Doesn't Jilly Cowie object to you smoking dope all the time?'

Clive waved his hand. 'One of the good things about Silly – perhaps the only good thing – is her complete naïvety. I told her they were herbal cigarettes, and she hasn't asked since.'

'Impressive.'

'Or stupid,' he said. 'Either way. It's all working out for Clive.' He looked up at the sound of the double doors on the outer landing opening. 'And *what* time do you call this?'

At the doorway, a thin, very handsome young man with excellent cheekbones, dressed in a bomber jacket, skinny jeans and Doc Martens, was struggling to hold four plastic bags filled with shopping in each hand. His hair was styled into a neat 1950s-style flat-top; his T-shirt was almost fluorescent white. He looked impossibly well groomed for someone who lived in this place, where nothing was clean.

'Sorry,' he said. 'We couldn't decide whether to put it all on a horse or just to go to Sainsbury's, so in the end we flipped a coin.' He plonked the shopping bags on the floor, rubbed his hands and smiled at me; predictably, his teeth were perfect.

'You must be the new guy. Hello, new guy.' He shook my hand.

'Hello, shopping guy,' I said. 'I'm Alex.'

'Malcolm,' said the beautiful man.

'Where's Adam?' said Ruth.

‘Bringing up the rest of it. Ah, here he is.’

Despite carrying as much shopping as Malcolm, he moved silently; when he looked up at me the jolt of recognition was strong enough for me to inhale sharply.

‘*Hello,*’ he said, in a quiet, bland voice. The word was smeared round a smile that was at once both supercilious and guilty.

*Adam.* It was odd to think of the Pale Strange Boy having a name.

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## 9

17. It now gloats, erupting, a clamouring hateful,  
Sinful prayers, invites to evil.  
In trembling silence, night embraces, *fateful*  
And rejoices in our upheaval.

18. Sweet solace offered, unparalleled luck!  
Every voice echo! Rejoice, now!  
Exotic *expedients* doth fate undertake!  
Luck, this our refuge endow.

‘Hello,’ I said.

I stuck my hand out, and he shook it; his hand, to my complete lack of surprise, was both clammy and cold. The mineral-blue eyes stared at me, unblinking.

‘Don’t I know you?’ he said.

‘Very likely,’ I said, hoping he wouldn’t detect the relief on my face when I withdrew my hand. ‘Until recently, we were the very last people left in The Ridge.’

He peered at me knowingly, as if I were attempting a very unsophisticated confidence trick. ‘I don’t think so. I was alone there, I thought?’

‘No, I was there too. I’m sure I saw you.’

‘No.’ He shook his head. ‘That’s not it. I know you from somewhere else. I’m sure of it.’

I smiled good-naturedly. ‘I don’t think so!’

His blue eyes remained fixed on me as he shrugged. 'It'll come to me.' Turning away, he held up two of the shopping bags for everyone to see. 'So – we have vodka, gin... six bottles of Rioja, because it was on offer...' His soft voice was almost a hiss. 'Should see us through the evening!' This had the rhythm and pattern of a joke, but there was no humour in his voice.

'Blimey,' said Ruth. 'You did remember to get food, right?' Adam looked at her as if he didn't understand the question, but nodded all the same.

'Let's get cracking then!' said Helen briskly. 'Did you get red or white onions? Is there garlic too? Where's the mince?'

The others grudgingly began to unpack the shopping, all except Clive, who lit a cigarette, and Adam, the Pale Strange Boy, who rose at 4 a.m. to scream at the trees. Instead, one of his clammy white hands reached out to claim a chair. Once sat, he was unmoving, in a posture that suggested he'd been thrown there, like an oversized ventriloquist's dummy. After a couple of seconds, however, he twisted the top off a bottle of vodka and poured himself a large glass.



Regardless of how it ended, dinner started well.

Everyone introduced themselves; I heard where everyone was from and what course they were doing. Leo was doing Archaeology, and his eyes grew wide with enthusiasm when he talked about it. Clive was entangled in an interminable Maths PhD, and Helen was studying French. Adam, the Pale Strange Boy, mostly shrugged or gave his supercilious smile when questions were asked, but I eventually established that he was also studying Maths. Malcolm and Ruth were studying Philosophy. After we'd eaten, and half-empty bowls of spaghetti bolognese littered the table, Clive and I smoked, while Helen made an exasperated show of opening the windows, before melodramatically leaving the room entirely, 'until the smoke cleared'. The summer evening air that drifted in was cool and pleasant.

Ruth's large blue eyes regarded me with curiosity. 'So why are you here?'

Leo laughed. 'Is that the first question they ask you when you study Philosophy?'

'Hilarious,' she deadpanned. 'What I mean is, why is he here? Wasting a perfectly good summer cleaning out a disgusting old building?'

'I don't know,' I said. 'Why are *you* here?'

Ruth smiled. Her reason for not going home for the summer, she said, was Surrey. She said if I was from Surrey too, I'd understand. Nothing made her more depressed, she said, than the prospect of a summer in the suburb she'd worked her whole life to leave. 'It would be like dying,' she said, in a voice completely free of melodrama, stating a fact. As such, her desperation to avoid this fate had meant that she was the first person to discover the scheme, and the first person to sign up to it. She'd notified Malcolm, who had also signed up.

Malcolm's reason for not wanting to go home was that his parents either knew he was gay and didn't approve, or *didn't* know he was gay, and he just wasn't ready, he said, to have that conversation. He'd broached the subject once with his mother, who he'd judged to be the more sympathetic of the two, but when he'd dropped the mildest of hints as to his sexuality, she had, according to him, 'started Hoovering with such aggression she almost stripped the floorboards'. He hadn't even bothered bringing it up with his dad.

'Weirdly late to be having this kind of crisis, I felt,' said Malcolm. 'But I guess acceptance is still an issue.'

'I feel bad for you,' said Clive. 'An oppressed minority, battling an unfeeling environment that can't, or won't, understand.'

Malcolm smiled, clearly finding this refreshing. 'Thanks, man.'

'I wasn't talking to you,' said Clive. 'I was talking to Ruth. I was very moved by her poignant story of being the only Goth in Suburbia.' Ruth smiled; Malcolm laughed and flicked a strand of cold spaghetti at Clive with a fork.

‘Anyway, isn’t it a bit late, historically speaking, to even *be* a Goth?’ Clive asked, picking the spaghetti off his jumper.

‘Goth never dies!’ said Ruth brightly, then hissed, ‘*You cannot kill what does not live!*’ She turned to me. ‘Why *are* you here, Alex?’

‘Same as you really,’ I said, lying with ease. ‘I just can’t face going home. I mean, I, um, had another job, but it fell through.’ I changed the subject. ‘What about you, Leo? Why are you here?’

‘I’m raising the cash to go off and do some research.’ Leo removed his sweater, which took his glasses off with it. ‘I want to get a book together by the time we graduate.’ He rummaged in the inside-out sweater for his lost glasses.

‘Wow.’ This seemed to me to be a superhuman level of dedication and forward-planning. Part of the appeal of studying English Literature was, for me, the balancing act; the sheer improvisational challenge of applying theories you weren’t sure about, from critics you had barely heard of, to books you hadn’t read. It was a strange and novel concept to see someone considering their degree as an opening to an actual career.

‘So, doing Archaeology, you’re saving up to go – where? Rome? Crete?’

Leo gently shook his head. He located his lost glasses, put them back on. ‘Britain.’

I pulled an exaggerated ‘confused’ face. ‘Mate, I’ve got news for you. You can go to Britain any time you like. In fact—’ I looked about me as if sharing a secret. ‘You’re already here.’

‘He’s got you there,’ said Malcolm.

‘Yes, thanks, that fact hasn’t passed me by. But I need to fund a full year-long research trip, taking in all the major Neolithic sites in the UK. Stonehenge, obviously. Avebury. Castlerigg. But some of the more obscure ones too.’

‘Why those sites?’

‘Have you ever been to any of them?’

‘I haven’t.’

‘Well then. It sounds like a cliché, but you have to see them, in person. Touch the stones, feel the earth, breathe the air. Then you’d understand.’

My first instinct was to say something sarcastic, but I saw that Leo was being genuine. There was no arrogance in his words; they sounded more like an invitation, to join him, come along and see something wonderful, and appreciate it as he did. Leo seemed to read this realization in my expression and smiled benignly. ‘You can’t understand those sites until you go and visit them, spend time there, see them at dusk, dawn, during different seasons. See the stones covered in snow, or sparkling in the midsummer sun. See them as they were meant to be seen.’

‘He gets high at them, is what he means,’ muttered Clive.

Leo looked annoyed. ‘Broadly speaking, as part of my research, I find it helpful to imbibe *equivalent ethnobotanical stimulants* to those that would have been available to the people who built those monuments.’

‘Failing that,’ said Clive, ‘he just does any old shit he has to hand. Pot. Glue. Butane.’ Leo ignored him.

‘Wow,’ said Ruth. She gazed at him with her large blue eyes, apparently reassessing him somewhat. ‘I can see why you’d rather save up for that than stay with your parents.’

‘Yeah,’ said Leo. ‘Anyway, there’s only Mum, and she’s about as skint as I am. She lives in a council flat in town.’

‘You’re... local?’

‘Uh-huh,’ said Leo. ‘Born and raised.’

‘Well, I won’t be sticking around in the UK after this,’ I said. ‘Maybe I’ll go on holiday at the end of summer.’ And then, when no-one said anything, ‘South East Asia, probably. I have a friend out there.’

I flushed a little after saying this, suddenly hearing myself again say I was *going to work on a trawler*. The two lies were equal and opposite, both as absurd as each other. There was little chance I would earn enough to travel that far here, as things stood. And beyond that practical concern lay another certainty I wasn’t prepared to think about quite yet: that if I *did* turn up on the other side of the world – unannounced, out of the blue – and I *did* manage to find Amethyst, hailing her as she sunbathed topless on some

white sand beach, there was no way that she would react with anything other than horror. I could picture her clearly, sitting up on a sun lounger, mouth hanging open as she peeled off her sunglasses in disbelief.

‘What about you, Clive?’ I asked, changing the subject. ‘Why are you here?’

Clive smiled. ‘Job’s cushy. Money’s good. I’m senior supervisor too, so I also get fifty quid a week more than you lot.’

‘I beg your pardon?’ said Helen, returning to the room. ‘You get *what*?’

‘He’s joking,’ said Malcolm hurriedly.

‘What about you, Helen?’ I asked, presumably for the same reason that Malcolm had interjected. ‘Why are you here all summer?’

Helen shrugged. ‘Well, my parents are much older than most people’s. They had me very late. I’m an only child.’

‘No shit,’ muttered Clive. Helen glared at him, but carried on.

‘They’re on a cruise. Round the world. The Caribbean. Florida, those sort of places.’

‘Without you?’ I said, before I could think better of it.

‘Yes,’ said Helen. ‘They said that it would be very boring for me, trapped on a ship with a lot of old people. They’re very considerate like that.’

‘Yes,’ I said. ‘Very... considerate. What about... you?’ I couldn’t yet bring myself to call the Pale Strange Boy *Adam*. It felt wrong somehow.

He smiled his sickly smile, as if at some private joke, but this time there was an almost panicked look in his eyes, as if the stakes of the conversation were far higher for him than anyone else.

‘*I can’t go home*,’ he said. And something about the way he said it, some deep, almost desperate, resonance he gave to those four words, meant that no-one pursued the matter any further.



A block of ice cream was produced from the freezer, and some strawberries from the fridge, which we divided into several bowls. Clive did not help



prepare anything, just watched from behind a small fortification of empty beer cans he'd been building throughout the meal. After we'd eaten dessert, he cracked open another can and lit another cigarette, to Helen's clear annoyance. She fanned her hands theatrically, and looked over at the already-open windows, perhaps to see if they could be opened any wider. Clive, his face chimp-like with concentration, blew smoke rings.

Helen talked about how she was considering switching her course, to study Theology. She began to talk about how she might like to seek a career in the Church, when Clive, drunk, a good minute behind everyone else, seemed to finally hear her.

'Theology. Wow.'

'You don't approve?' Helen replied.

'It's always good to do an autopsy on a dead thing, I suppose. So you can learn how it died.'

'Whoah!' laughed Ruth. 'That's quite the statement.'

'What?' said Clive. 'You're the Goth! You should be on my side here.'

'Christianity is far from dead, thank you very much,' said Helen, in a calm, yet brittle, voice. 'It's the largest religion in the world.'

'Doesn't make it real,' said Clive breezily.

'I'm a Christian,' said Helen.

'*Of course* you are.'

'*Clive.*' Malcolm's tone was one of admonishment.

'Ah, here we go,' sighed Leo. 'Someone's drunk.'

'No, it's fine,' said Helen. 'As soon as people learn you have a faith, the first thing they want to do is attack it. It seems to be what people do.'

'I'm not attacking it,' said Clive. He was slurring slightly now. 'I'm merely trying to help you see sense, i.e., that it's all bullshit.'

'That is extraordinarily condescending,' said Helen. 'You're trying to make me see *your* sense. Which isn't the same as mine.'

'Fundamentally, I'm a rationalist,' said Clive airily. He teased a cigarette out of the packet in front of him. 'Science is provable, because it's based on observable fact. The results are demonstrable to everyone. Science is democratic like that.'

‘The glory of God’s creation is apparent everywhere too,’ said Helen, smiling. ‘*He’s* democratic like that. He has—’

Clive talked across her, settling into his role, learned at some debating society, of a blowhard, who, if he shouted loud enough, was always right. ‘If you’re going to say *God is love*, then you’re wrong, I’m sorry.’

‘I didn’t—’

‘If there *is* a God,’ he said, struggling to connect the end of his cigarette with the flame from his lighter, ‘you can’t truly understand him unless you understand his monsters. The monsters he manufactures in such prodigious numbers you’d think they were going out of style. Leeches, flies, parasitic wasps. And of course, people.’

‘Wait, he made people in his image, right? But who’s to say what he means by that?’ My voice was loud. ‘Maybe to him leeches *are* people. Which means God himself is just a colossal leech.’ I had had too much to drink as well. And whereas Clive had become belligerent and argumentative, I had become euphoric and silly. I was surrounded by people, and conversation, and it was exhilarating. Three weeks of solitude, with the prospect of many more, I could now see, had been more difficult to endure than I had admitted to myself at the time. And now I was free, in another chain of events entirely. I barely cared that the conversation was crashing into a mountainside. ‘Or maybe he’s a wasp?’

‘That’s a blasphemous idea,’ said Helen. ‘I’d rather you didn’t talk like that.’

‘Blasphemy, fuck’s sake.’ Clive downed the last of his can of beer, reached for another. ‘Are we still in the Middle Ages? What nonsense.’

‘Call me cynical,’ said Ruth, ‘but I don’t think the “Does God Exist?” question is going to be resolved tonight.’

‘Belief isn’t nonsense,’ said Helen, not hearing her. ‘Not *ever*.’

‘Oh, but we’re still gonna persist, are we? Excellent,’ muttered Ruth. From the corner of my eye, I could see Adam’s white face staring at us, listening, assessing.

‘Enough,’ said Malcolm. ‘Clive, stop giving Helen a hard time.’

‘I’m not giving her a hard time!’ said Clive. ‘I’m simply trying to make her understand that the entire ontological foundation of her life is utter bollocks.’ He smiled innocently.

Helen’s chair scraped across the linoleum tiles as she stood up. ‘I’m going to bed,’ she said. In that moment, I was struck by how dignified she looked, especially compared to Clive, who was, in that same moment, staring cross-eyed at the cigarette he kept failing to light.

‘Oh, Helen, don’t take it personally,’ said Leo. ‘Clive’s a twat, *obviously*, but he is at least a twat to everyone.’ Clive, still trying to light his cigarette, gave a distracted thumbs up.

‘I don’t,’ said Helen. ‘But it’s obvious that nothing will be gained from continuing this discussion.’

‘That’s right, *run*,’ sang Clive, in a high, gleeful voice, to his cigarette. ‘*Run! From the truth!*’

Helen didn’t reply. As she left the table, however, she picked up a glass jug half-filled with water. Marching at a stately pace round the table, she emptied it over Clive’s head.

Everyone cheered drunkenly. Helen smiled down at Clive in triumph; Clive spat out the waterlogged cigarette which dangled from his soaking beard, and stared at her with murderous fury.

‘*Ah, you silly cunt.*’

He said this casually, almost guilelessly, as if stating a simple truth about Helen, about who she ultimately was, something you’d have to factor in if you had to deal with her. The effect on Helen, however, was instant and dramatic. Her eyes and mouth seemed to open as wide as possible, and her sudden, involuntary intake of breath was loud. I realized it was perfectly plausible she’d never heard anyone say that word out loud before, let alone been called it. She issued a slow moan of horror and ran from the room. After a second, Ruth stood up.

‘Nice work, Clive,’ she said. ‘Well done.’ With an air of resigned pragmatism, she went after Helen.

‘Yeah,’ said Leo. ‘Nice work. You’ve made someone hate you within a week of meeting them, which must be a new record, even for you.’

‘Ah, fuck it,’ said Clive, pulling a fresh cigarette from the box. ‘It saves time.’

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# 10

19. At last, my soul, every vain ease repealed,  
Lonely and sorrowful, torn,  
Is now granted asylum, sanctuary, shield –  
*Undone*, my enlightenment dawns.

20. (*The ritual awakens, gains in capacity  
Years, eons, ages, repeating.  
Now in night's glory, now occult rhapsody,  
Our unholy ritual, waiting.*)

LEO TOOK CLIVE OUTSIDE immediately after; whether to sober him up or tell him off, I couldn't tell. Either way, it was very clear that this was the end of the evening. Ruth came back from checking on Helen, and then she and Malcolm both turned in after helping clear the dishes from the table. Consulting the weekly rota, I was annoyed to find that not only had my name already been added, but it was also my turn to wash up, which hardly seemed fair. As I began to fill the sink with water, I noticed that Adam still sat at the table, unmoving. I sensed he was staring at me, but when I turned round, he was looking away, deep in thought. After five minutes of scrubbing at various plates and pans, I turned to discover that he, too, had left.

Further scrutiny of the duty roster informed me that it was also my turn to empty the bins, at which point I began to suspect that the piss was being taken. Not wishing to upset anyone on my first day, however, I removed the black bin liner, knotted it up and carried it downstairs. It took me about five

minutes to find the large metal bins, in a dingy brick-built recess at the rear of the building. The quiet was profound out there, deeper, even, than the silence surrounding The Ridge, where you could still discern the faint grind of distant traffic. Here, there was nothing, just a thrilling stillness, occasionally punctuated by the rustle or call of something nocturnal.

This silence meant it was easy, on my walk back inside, to hear subdued voices, chatting in a dark corner near where the battered 1970s wing projected. Clive and Leo, laughing, deep in conversation. As I approached them, any mystery about what they were doing was dispelled by the chokingly sweet smell, thick as pollen, I detected from ten yards away.

‘Gentlemen,’ I said, holding out my hand. It had been a long day.

‘There you go,’ said Clive, through a mouthful of smoke, handing me the joint.

‘Good that you’re punishing Clive by giving him a massive spliff,’ I said to Leo, as I inhaled. ‘Important to maintain discipline.’

‘Ah, it straightens him out,’ said Leo.

‘That’s right!’ said Clive. ‘Couple of tokes and I’m back to my usual razor-sharp self.’

‘That wasn’t very nice,’ I said, ‘what you did to Helen.’

Clive smiled, waved his hand. ‘What did I do, exactly?’

‘You know. Made fun of her. Mocked her beliefs. She’s clearly quite fragile as a person.’

‘Fragile people break into sharp shards,’ said Clive mysteriously. ‘Anyway, fuck it, I’m doing her a favour in the long run. *I* should be the one complaining. She did throw a jug of water over me.’

‘Literally the first wash you’ve had all week,’ said Leo.

‘*She destroyed a cigarette,*’ said Clive gravely. ‘Those things are like gold dust out here. I might request a court martial.’

The joint was strong. All at once, I felt the cannabis hit my system in a wave, announcing its presence in a sudden widening, galloping, racing tide, accelerating my thoughts, like a river reaching the sea, a dam bursting, faster than I could process. I found myself fighting the rise of something that demolished, deconstructed, rewrote as it came, something that would

be exhilarating if ridden out, but could easily blossom into something terrifying. I passed the joint to Clive.

‘I must say,’ I said, attempting to make normal conversation through a last exhalation of thick, oily smoke, and the sudden and precipitous rearrangement of all my faculties. ‘It will be interesting spending my first night here.’ The words already felt starchy, artificial, scripted, something someone else would say.

Clive turned to me. His large, ruddy face held a sudden confusion.

‘What do you mean, *first night*?’

‘I mean...’ I found myself unable to break the statement down into simpler terms. ‘... *my first night here*. You guys have already been here for what, a week or so, right?’

‘What on earth are you talking about?’ said Clive, almost hoarse with puzzlement.

My brain flinched with a surge of panic, the vertiginous rollercoaster rise and dip of being far too high, far too quickly. I felt as if I had run up a flight of stairs at speed, only to notice, too late, that there were no more steps, just a sheer drop.

‘*What?*’ I managed.

‘*We’ve been here for years,*’ said Clive.

I stared at him. His watery eyes were sincere, concerned.

‘What... what are you talking about?’

Clive shuddered in disbelief, raising his hands. When he looked at me, his gaze was filled with pity.

‘Alex, mate, we’ve been in this asylum for years. *We’re the patients.*’

My thoughts were a fanfare now, my mind leaking out of my head in fungal tendrils, finding panic in everything. I turned to Leo. Leo looked pained, embarrassed for me, sad that I couldn’t remember. That I had forgotten.

That we had always been here.

And I felt as if I were falling, from a great height, into a canyon perhaps, too deep to see the bottom, with nothing to do but keep on falling.

‘You don’t remember?’ Clive looked troubled, disturbed. I found I had no answer. My mouth was dry.

‘We’ve all been in this hospital for years. We all suffered some kind of trauma, then we all fantasized we were students or something, but that was *ages* ago. Now, we spend our time deluding ourselves that we’re cleaning the place up. Anything to make the truth bearable. Because the truth is, and always has been—’

He began to smirk, and then laugh. In seconds, he was doubled up, helpless.

‘You *twat!*’ I said. I found I was laughing now too. ‘You utter fucking *twat!*’

Clive hooted delightedly. ‘You were starting to wonder, though, weren’t you? I could see it in your eyes! “*Shit! Have I always been here? Ooh, have I? Am I going mad? Or is this just exceptionally good gear?*”’

I couldn’t seem to stop laughing now. Laughter born of relief, flooding my body and mind. ‘*You absolute fucking twat!*’ I turned to Leo. ‘Is he always like this?’

‘Fraid so,’ said Leo, taking the forgotten joint from Clive’s hand. ‘Anyway, Clive, it’s not an asylum, Cowie will be furious if you describe it that way. It was a *refuge for the traumatized*, remember?’

‘LOONY BIN!’ blared Clive, gleefully, at the top of his voice.

‘Alright, smart arse,’ I said. ‘If we *are* the patients, what are we all here for?’

‘Well now,’ said Clive, immediately warming to the topic. ‘Firstly, and most obviously, Leo here did too many drugs and burned himself out at one of his Neolithic burial doodahs. Alas, he took one trip too many. Drifted off into space, sadly. Nowadays he just hangs around the docks, servicing sailors for loose change and raving about Stonehenge.’

‘Thanks, man,’ said Leo, raising his beer can in a toast. Clive bowed slightly.

I smiled. ‘What about Helen?’

‘Oh, now *Helen*,’ said Clive, barely able to keep himself from spluttering. ‘That buttoned-down Bible-bashing bint is secretly a deranged



nymphomaniac. All she craves is cock.'

Leo and I could hardly breathe now for laughing. Clive, very much enjoying himself by this point, carried on. 'Ruth is of course at the other end of the spectrum, an insatiable lesbian, something I discovered on our first night here when I made certain advances—'

'Oh yeah!' smirked Leo. 'She completely shot you down, didn't she?' Clive ignored him.

'—and although we're all supposed to look kindly on that sort of thing now, she's still extremely depraved and lustful in her appetites. And obviously a satanist.'

Leo smiled into his beer can. 'That's one way of processing rejection, I suppose.'

Clive either affected not to hear him or genuinely didn't, turning instead to me. 'And *you*, Alex. You're clearly a straight-up pervert. You have that look about you. You'll do it with anything. Horses. Chickens. Small-gauge diesel locomotives. You wake up and you don't know where you are. All you can recall is that somehow, somewhere, *something's* been fucked.'

'Up yours,' I said, through my laughter.

'Malcolm, obviously, is a narcissistic onanist. Which in practical terms means he just wanks in front of a mirror.'

I shrugged. 'To be fair, if I looked like him, I probably would too.'

'What about you, then, dickhead?' said Leo.

'Ah, a sad story!' said Clive. 'I think I'm a reincarnation of Casanova, the world's greatest lover. Sad thing is, reality has betrayed me, and I really *am* Casanova, as many, many, *many* satisfied women will tell you.'

'You are *such* a tool!' Leo and I were bent double again.

'What about Adam?' I asked.

Clive snorted. 'I would have thought that was obvious.'

'Go on.'

'Adam's a murderer.'

For some reason, the laughter ceased abruptly after that.

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At about 1 a.m. our tiny illicit party broke up. We were all aware we'd have to be at work by nine the next day. I went to my small cold bathroom to brush my teeth; something about having smoked a joint made the toothpaste burn in my mouth. I was still pleasantly stoned. The building, the main part of the Marshlands complex, had a good feeling about it, I decided, a calm pulse that reverberated, stately and slow. A place of peace. I was still delighted at how completely I had, as Dad used to say, before that terrible Last Day, *fallen arse backwards into clover*.

I went to the kitchen for a glass of water. When I got to my door, there was a note taped to it. I didn't know what Clive's handwriting looked like, but I guessed this was it.

*Oh yes, we are the loonies, in the loony bin we dwell!  
We like it here there's food and beer and sometimes wine as well!  
But the ten foot wall surrounding all begs me to reason thus:  
Is that wall to keep us from the world, or keep the world from us?!*

I smiled, tore the note down and threw it in the bin.

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# 11

21. Of ruined lives *doomed*, despite each craven  
Entreaty issued to fate.  
Unerringly led unto noisome evasion,  
Rapture rattling its nacreous gate.
22. Labyrinth, yew *maze*, artful dead ends.  
Built upon tragedy foreseen.  
On ruination – everything depends  
On obliterating my dream.

MY HEAD WAS FILLED with brown fog the next morning, and the day was fuzzy, as if it needed tuning, but after half an hour and a heavily sugared coffee, reality returned to factory settings. I was very aware that today was my first day of work, and some weird species of anticipation or even diligence meant that I was up before anyone else. I sat in the kitchen smoking, as the others drifted in. Everyone bar Helen was hung-over; everyone was quiet, everyone looked slightly drawn. Clive, in particular, looked like he'd been exhumed. Unsurprisingly, Helen turned out to be one of those people who are resoundingly awake first thing in the morning: she opened windows and fanned her hands theatrically whenever anyone smoked, she asked a lot of questions, she also sang. She seemed determined to torment Clive, who winced every time she spoke. She did not apologize for emptying a jug of water over his head.

Jilly Cowie appeared at nine o'clock on the nail and leaned against one of the desks which had formed our dining table. She carried a clipboard.

‘Settle down you lot!’ she said, although no-one was talking. ‘Right! Great that you’re all keen to get going. We’re two days behind schedule, so can’t afford to waste time. With that in mind, where are our two new recruits?’

‘One,’ said Ruth. ‘Only Alex turned up.’

‘Oh.’ Jilly Cowie consulted her clipboard. ‘No sign of the other one yet? The girl?’

Leo shook his head. ‘Nope.’

‘Hmm.’ Jilly looked perturbed. ‘Perhaps she isn’t coming after all. I shall check. In the meantime, Clive, has Alex had his site safety induction?’

‘Absolutely,’ said Clive, with total conviction. I shot him a wry look, which Jilly didn’t notice.

‘Excellent!’ she said. ‘I’ve brought you a boiler suit and gloves, Alex, and a new box of dust masks for everyone, for the worst bits. And today – apologies, Alex – is one of the worst remaining bits. It’s the auditorium, at the rear of this building. I’ve had an initial recce and it seems pretty straightforward, no nasty surprises.’

‘What did they need an auditorium for?’ I asked. Clive widened his eyes as if to say *why on earth would you encourage her to say any more than she needs to?* I ignored him.

‘Ah,’ said Jilly. ‘When the hospital was built, the auditorium was a communal gathering place, with regular meetings for patients and staff alike – a bit like school assembly!’ These words seemed to make her almost wistful. ‘Christmas and Easter services and other seasonal celebrations would have been held there, as well as any dramatic performances. It has a stage and piano and— Look, it’s probably best I just show you, hmm?’



A few minutes later, all of us, wearing boiler suits and gloves, stood at a set of large wooden doors, waiting for Jilly Cowie to select the correct key from a comically large bunch. After two or three attempts, the padlock clicked, and Jilly pulled the double doors open.

The auditorium was about the size of a small church, with dark wood-panelled walls rising to meet the beams of a vaulted ceiling. Tall windows lined the walls, three each side. The floor was filthy, the dust having lain undisturbed long enough to form tidal-looking dunes across a desert of parquet the colour of honey, where rows of chairs had once been arranged. Directly opposite us was a modest-sized stage, reached by staircases at either side. This was empty save for a lectern and, to the left of that, a tired-looking grand piano. The rear of the stage was swathed in a tattered gold curtain, which sagged from its runners.

‘Wow.’ Ruth sniffed. ‘It smells of Bible.’

‘You could totally have an illegal rave in here,’ said Malcolm. ‘Get a sound system in. Fluorescent paint all over the walls, tenner a ticket, bosh. In fact, I’m surprised nobody has.’

‘It’s depressing,’ said Helen.

‘Oh, I don’t know,’ I said. ‘It’s quite affecting, in its way.’ Once, I considered, this space had been the focus of all life here at Marshlands. VE Day would have been marked here, the staff telling the patients, with joy, the unthinkable news that the war in Europe was over. The coronation of Queen Elizabeth, also, would have been celebrated here, and twenty-five years later, the Silver Jubilee, the place filled with bunting and home-made cakes. Looking at the stage, I found myself wondering which plays had been put on here over the years, and what those productions might have looked like. Dressing up the disturbed and traumatized in colourful costumes and greasepaint seemed a particularly bizarre thing to do, but I would have loved to have seen it.

‘There’s not much for us to do in here, surely?’ said Leo. ‘I mean, I take it we’re not shifting that piano anywhere. Beyond that, it’s mostly sweeping up?’

‘Ah,’ said Jilly. ‘You haven’t seen what’s waiting in the wings. So to speak!’

Jilly clattered up the stairs to the stage, with us following dutifully behind her. ‘Exit stage right!’ she trilled inevitably, as she ducked off-stage. Clive sighed, perhaps involuntarily, but was the first to follow her in.

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Jilly led us through the empty backstage area to an anteroom, a roughly triangular wedge of partition walls.

This forgotten chamber was completely filled with cardboard boxes, wooden crates, lever arch files, and dozens upon dozens of brown leather ledgers, all stacked in precarious piles to just over head height.

‘What’s this?’ I asked.

‘Admin,’ said Jilly Cowie, almost fearfully. ‘The accumulated paperwork of almost eighty years of operation here at Marshlands. So – we need to clean and sweep the hall outside, make sure it’s spotless. Then, we need to bring everything out from this room, into the auditorium, see what we have. Be warned, it’ll be filthy work, and it’ll take a while.’

‘Great!’ I was all for anything that made this exercise as time-consuming as possible.

Jilly Cowie smiled her toothy smile. ‘So – brooms, mops, buckets – you know where to find all of those. Once you’ve cleaned the floor, the work lends itself to setting up a proper little production line! You never know, it might even be fun! So, chop chop!’

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Slowly, we got to work.

Jilly left us, telling us she’d be back in a couple of hours to see how we were getting on, and to bring lunch. Ruth led Malcolm and me to the supply cupboard, and the three of us returned with a handcart laden with cleaning equipment.

The first hour was spent sweeping and mopping the hall floor, and slowly the auditorium started to look almost beautiful. The parquet was in pristine condition; restored to a square sea of gleaming amber checks, it shone almost proudly. Maybe, if the university did go through with its plan to turn Marshlands into a hall of residence, this space would become a small canteen or refectory. The plasterwork would be repaired; the stage

dismantled, the panelling pulled out or painted, the whole place made less severe, less imposing.

With the auditorium cleaned, we turned our attention to the small triangular chamber, and began to remove the boxes and folders of paperwork, back and forth, in a chain of fetch-and-carry that made me dizzy with repetition. Malcolm and Helen, at the head of this production line in the triangular room itself, uncovered, alongside the official records, a few miscellaneous objects that had clearly been there for years. A hat stand, a chipped avocado-green light fitting, a broken lamp. There were numerous books, too – about fifty or so titles, all non-fiction, all of them apparently selected to be as dry and unenticing as possible. A book about electrical circuits. A book about heraldry. An inexplicable copy of *Who's Who*, ten years out of date. All of it was picked up, carried, set down, picked up, carried, set down, over and over, until it found its way to Ruth, and the parquet floor.

Two hours of this took us to lunch. By that time I was numb from walking the same short distance again and again, turning to pick up, bending to put down. I was almost relieved when one of the boxes I was carrying across the stage burst open, spilling its contents all over the floor.

‘God’s telling us to stop working!’ said Clive.

‘I thought you didn’t believe in God,’ said Helen immediately, as if she’d been waiting hours for Clive to say something like this.

‘I do when he does stuff in my favour,’ said Clive. ‘Let’s call that lunch.’

‘I’ll catch you up.’ The others were already leaving; I’m not sure they heard me.

Alone on the empty stage, I scrabbled on my hands and knees to pick up the box’s contents. This done, I was just about to leave, when I saw a faded red cord hanging to one side of the stage, attached somewhere far above.

Pulling it made the threadbare gold curtains shuffle arthritically along their runners, and there – as I had hoped – was the scenery for whatever the final-ever production staged here had been. Some sort of drawing room, the false walls papered with real wallpaper, yellow with a repeating matrix of

vines. Onto this, a fireplace had been painted in amateur *trompe l'oeil*, as well as a grandfather clock. To one side of the unreal fireplace, a pair of real French windows set into the fake wall looked onto a painted landscape underneath a night sky spattered with white stars, in which curious clouds swam.

Something about this scene made me peer at it more closely. It was quite detailed, an artistic decision which surely must have been made solely for the benefit of the artist, as even from a few feet away, the image became merely the suggestion of an exterior.

And what I had first taken to be clouds seemed something else entirely, though what that something might be was not clear; they looked more like some form of drifting underwater life than clouds, trailing curls of vapour across the blue night. The scene below the dark sky was similarly puzzling, depicting a series of tidal lagoons, or maybe even seas. Or maybe I was wrong, and they were craters, or pools of mercury, lit by pale, strange moonlight. In the background, mountains rose. I was about to turn away when I saw, clearly, among the rocks and other scenery, a house; peering at it, I was surprised to register that I recognized it.

The double-fronted roof was unmistakably that of the empty Victorian house that stood in the nearby woodland, rising above the trees. For some reason, the artist had chosen to depict it here, in this bleak, peculiar setting, from which human beings were either temporarily or permanently absent.

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The others were all sitting outside, prodding gingerly at the contents of three plastic bags. Evidently, Jilly Cowie had already been and gone with lunch.

We sat and chewed tough, vaguely stale sandwiches, ordered, presumably, from a shop in the nearest village. Having nothing else to occupy us, we chatted, about Marshlands, and what might have gone on here when the place was operational.



I became aware that Leo was silent. Turning, I saw that he had brought out a box of books and was currently absorbed in one of them, a tattered thing with no spine, bound in faded green cloth.

‘What’s that?’

In response, Leo showed me the title page. The book was called *A County Fine and Fair*. The publication date was 1926.

‘Whoa,’ I said. ‘Is it a good read?’

‘Sure isn’t!’ said Leo briskly. ‘Dry as a packet of crackers, all parish boundaries, council politics and local trade guilds, but it *does* have a paragraph in it about this place.’

‘Really?’

Leo nodded. ‘Listen to this: “*It is ironic that such a facility, no matter how modern, should be located in this place, as the site is situated near an area where, legend has it, the touched, those afflicted with second sight, and those whose wits had left them were abandoned to fend for themselves. The surviving source for this story is medieval, but doubtless the practice was ancient even then.*”’

‘What?’ said Clive. ‘Let me see that.’ He grabbed the book from Leo.

‘Building this place here surely has to be intentional, then,’ I said. ‘Putting a lunatic asylum in a place already synonymous with madness.’

‘*It’s not a lunatic asylum,*’ said Malcolm and Ruth simultaneously. We all laughed.

Helen’s nose wrinkled. ‘Either way, I think locating something like *this* somewhere like *that* shows very poor taste.’

‘So,’ said Clive, reading the passage, ‘the place has always been a magnet for nutters. Fascinating.’ He slammed the book shut and tossed it carelessly over his shoulder onto the pile of other books.

‘I don’t imagine any of these books are worth anything?’ said Malcolm, examining the stack of titles. He picked one up and read the spine. ‘*Land Reform in Agrarian China*. Wow. I suppose that answers my question.’

Ruth looked scornfully at him. ‘You can’t, after a whole week of ferrying utter crap back and forth, still hold out the idea we’re going to stumble on anything valuable?’

Malcolm sniffed. 'No harm in hoping.' Idly, he picked up the copy of *Who's Who*. 'What's this?'

'*Who's Who*,' said Clive. 'A directory of the landed gentry, the wealthy, the notable.'

'What's it doing here?' asked Helen.

'I dunno,' I said, picking up another book at random. 'What's *Recollections of a Country Dentist* doing here?'

'Anyway,' said Clive, smiling up at Malcolm, 'you not knowing what *Who's Who* is just reveals what utter prole scum you are.'

'Guilty as charged!' said Malcolm cheerfully, without looking up.

'Hey,' said Ruth, reading the book over Malcolm's shoulder. 'Cliff Richard's address is in here! In case anyone wants to write and tell him to just stop.'

'Everyone's in there,' said Clive. 'I refer you to the title.'

'*I'm* not in there,' said Helen. She sounded personally affronted by her exclusion.

'Everyone who's *anyone*,' said Clive. 'Noteworthy people. Dukes and duchesses, major and minor royals. Anyone with a country estate. None of us plebs are going to be in there.'

'I just think it's wrong to have a book with that title,' said Helen grandly. 'It creates the idea that some people aren't *anybody*. That they're just not worth bothering with.'

I saw the glint in Clive's eye, as he opened his mouth to speak.

'Easy, tiger,' I said. 'Stand down.'

Clive smiled. 'Ah, you're no fun.'

'Because I think *everyone* is worth bothering with,' said Helen, expansively, as if she hadn't been clear on this point. 'Absolutely *everyone*.'

'I'm in there,' said Adam.

'You couldn't have a book with everyone in it, Helen,' said Ruth. 'Well, you could, but it would just be the phone book.'

'Sorry, Ruth,' said Leo, holding up a hand. He turned to Adam. 'Did you just say *you* were in there?'

Adam smiled his strange, guilty smile. ‘Yeah. Or, you know, my dad is. I’m only in there as a small italic s, for *son*, with my name.’

‘Shit,’ said Malcolm. ‘What was your surname again?’

‘Lockhart,’ said Adam.

Malcolm flicked through the thin pages. ‘*Lockall, Lockashe...* ah!’ He read for a few seconds. ‘Would your dad be the bloodstock agent or the petrochemical multi-millionaire?’

‘The – second one,’ said Adam quietly. His eyes darted nervously about him.

‘No way,’ gasped Malcolm, reading the entry. ‘Piss off. There you are! *Adam Barnaby Edmund Lockhart*. Good God.’

‘Ha!’ I laughed. ‘You and I have the same initials. I’m Alex Benjamin Edward Lane. Maybe I could claim your inheritance.’

‘Well, well!’ said Clive. ‘You dark horse! Lend us a tenner.’ Adam, self-conscious beyond speech now, merely smiled, pale cheeks flushing.

‘Wait,’ said Malcolm. ‘There’s only one little italic s here, and no little italic ds. That would make you... an only child? So you’re the *sole heir* to your dad’s unimaginably vast fortune?’

Adam nodded.

‘Oh my *God*,’ said Ruth. ‘Adam, you suddenly just got a whole lot more attractive for some reason.’

Malcolm blinked as if slapped. ‘Too right.’

Everybody laughed at this; everyone apart from Adam. Instead, his open mouth gulped like that of a stranded fish. He seemed caught between the delicious ecstasy of finally being noticed, and the intolerable intensity of the exact same thing. Eventually, however, he laughed along with the rest of us.

---

After everyone else returned to work, I opened *Who’s Who*, and, inevitably, looked for Amethyst’s name. I watched myself do this, mocking myself for the sentimentality of it, but allowing it to happen all the same.

Her surname (double-barrelled, of course, almost a sentence or a story in its own right) was so singular that finding it took moments. There was the small italic *d*, and there was her name, complete with all of its unlikely and peculiar middle names, a string of dead great-aunts. Seen bald on the page like that, her full name looked utterly absurd, like one of the preposterous names given to a Crufts winner. The disloyal thought flashed across my mind, that maybe – just maybe – she was slightly ridiculous.

Nonetheless, I watched as my finger traced the words that captured who she was, left to right, almost tenderly.

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## 12

23. One's urges now harmful, all pleasures pain.  
Your notions of time inverted.  
O, now does *a* ruthless knowledge explain,  
Defeat every new deed exerted.

24. Vividly, I see each driven insane  
Then see no other *vision*, except  
Love's pure light alone, newly obtained,  
Blinding – sincere – correct.

AFTER LUNCH, we resumed work. Someone proposed we change partners in our chain of fetch-and-carry, and the chance to inject any kind of variety into the tedium passed uncontested. And so I found myself in the half-empty triangular room, in the wings, working alongside Ruth, who proved to be an easy-going companion. We worked steadily, occasionally showing each other some object or document that attracted our attention, and passing comment on it.

We did this until we reached the ledgers.

---

I estimated that there were about two hundred of them; grand, solid things, each bound in some variety of brown leather, which shone dully, like oil. From what we could ascertain, they presented a complete record of the inmates of Marshlands. Each volume was filled with photographs and

details, fragments of stories, descriptions of conditions rare and unusual, couched in terms that had fallen into disuse for half a century or more.

Ruth and I stopped work to examine them, which meant that the others came to see too, out of curiosity. Soon, all work stopped, as we sat in the triangular room, flicking through the pages.

The ones closest to hand contained the records of patients who had passed through Marshlands in the 1910s and '20s, the earliest days of the hospital. Each page contained a small photo of the patient, and a description of their condition, in neat copperplate handwriting. These conditions were varied, ranging from insomnia to cases, in those fresh from the nightmare of the trenches, of severe shell-shock. There were also sundry 'kleptomaniacs', 'erotomaniacs' and 'pyromaniacs' as well as others simply labelled with the catch-all term 'maniac'. In the majority of the photographs the patients simply stared, straight ahead, into the lens, preoccupied with their own incomprehensible, inscrutable concerns. All the faces were beautiful, in that way that sepia makes everything beautiful: hard contrasting lines of smoky browns, shadows the colour of black coffee. More than ever, I found myself yearning to see what kind of amateur dramatics these people had managed during their time here. I wanted to see what the shell-shocked, the kleptomaniacs and erotomaniacs had made of *A Midsummer Night's Dream* or *The Importance of Being Earnest* or *Pygmalion*.

'The names are amazing,' said Ruth. '*Alice Biggs. Sarah Dreweatt. Gerald Merriweather.*'

'I bet one of them was Jack the Ripper,' said Malcolm. 'Probably this one, look. *Charlie Allen of Mile End*. Look at him. Shifty eyes. Weird beard. *Fantasist*, it says. *Violent temper. Tireless and extreme liar. Onanist*. Probably thinking about all those women he opened up, the saucy rascal.'

'Wow,' Adam said quietly. 'This one *suffers from a tireless compulsion to write verse.*' He smiled his sneering smile. 'I'm not really sure which is worse.'

'Must we read them out?' said Helen. 'It's bad enough these poor people had to be here at all, without picking over the details.'

‘Yes,’ Clive muttered wearily. ‘Mustn’t inflict any indignity upon the wanking maniacs.’ Helen tutted theatrically. Leo, meanwhile, had sunk into silence. He seemed very affected by the ledgers, rubbing his chin in thoughtful wonder as he turned the pages.

‘This is an incredible find,’ he said. ‘Incredible.’

‘Are they worth anything?’ asked Malcolm. Ruth laughed.

‘Not in the conventional sense,’ said Leo. ‘But the social history in here is priceless. We have to keep them.’

‘Cowie will probably be in favour of binning everything,’ said Clive.

‘So what do we do?’ I asked, staring down at a sepia photo of a woman with large, scared eyes. Despite myself, I also felt a strange flavour of guilt, of responsibility. For better or worse, history had elected us the custodians of this place, the keepers of its legacy.

Clive snorted indifferently. ‘Dunno. I’ll fetch Cowie. Decision’s hers.’

---

Jilly Cowie flipped through three of the ledgers, in a manner that began as mild diversion but quickly faded into boredom. Meanwhile, we hovered, waiting for her judgement. After a long interval of silence, she slammed the ledger she was reading shut. We looked at her expectantly.

‘Bin them,’ she said simply.

Leo was outraged. ‘No!’

‘I’m sorry?’

‘You can’t!’

Jilly looked baffled by this. ‘Why not?’

Leo looked at her with incredulity. ‘Because these are the only records of this place, and the people who were treated here. Their stories! They’re irreplaceable!’

Jilly sniffed, replaced the ledger she’d been glancing through. ‘They’re also completely worthless.’

‘Not to the people who were patients here! Or their relatives.’

‘I’m sure whoever they were, they almost certainly wouldn’t want to be reminded of the details of their stay. And I’m sure it’s the kind of thing their families would rather forget.’

‘You can’t make that decision for them! We need to contact whoever deals with this kind of thing. I dunno, the Public Records Office.’

Jilly Cowie looked horrified by this prospect. ‘That could take months!’ I could already see her baulking at the prospect of rearranging her schedule.

‘So?’ said Leo. ‘We don’t have much left to do in this place anyway, do we?’

Jilly smiled infuriatingly. ‘Yes, well. I might have some news on that front. I was speaking to the university an hour or so ago, and the situation is changing. Let’s just say that we might be on a tighter schedule here than we previously thought.’

‘What does that mean?’ I asked.

‘I can’t go into it right now, but if it comes off, it will mean that time will be of the essence, if we’re to complete what’s being asked of us here. We’re already behind, as I said.’

Leo looked at her with disgust.

‘You just can’t be bothered, can you?’

Jilly, suddenly outraged, glared at Leo.

‘*I beg your pardon?*’

‘If we did save these ledgers, you’d have to record each one. Fill in a form for it. Describe each one individually. You just don’t want to do that, because it’ll ruin your precious schedule. Cut into the time you spend organizing your fucking sports clubs.’

Jilly stared at him, unblinking, her jaw clamped tight shut. There was a moment of total silence, charged with electricity, as if a storm were about to break. None of us dared move.

‘*Don’t tell me,*’ said Jilly Cowie eventually, her voice barely a rasp, ‘*how to run this place!*’

Even Leo seemed to realize he’d gone too far. When he spoke, a conciliatory note had crept into his voice.

‘All I’m saying is—’



‘I know *exactly* what you’re saying, Mr Dexter. But I absolutely do *not* appreciate being spoken to in that way, and with that language.’

‘Hear, hear,’ said Helen. Everyone ignored her.

‘I’m sorry,’ mumbled Leo. ‘It’s just—’

‘I understand how passionate you are about these things, Mr Dexter. But as your supervisor, it is my duty to manage the limited time we have. I don’t know the exact details of the process you mentioned, but I do know that anything submitted to the Public Records Office has to be fully described before they’ll even consider it. We simply cannot spare the time.’

‘Maybe—’

‘No maybes. If the situation here changes, as I suspect it will, we do *not* have the time.’ It was quite something to see this amount of steel from Jilly Cowie; I had previously written her off as a pushover.

She stared at us. Perhaps she detected the change in our perception of her; perhaps she even enjoyed it. She began to smile. Her voice, when she spoke again, was crisp and exact.

‘So. We will continue precisely as I described. Place all of the ledgers and paperwork here in the auditorium. As a compromise, Mr Dexter, I will flag up the existence of these volumes to the university, see what they say. But I can’t promise anything. Their time and resources are limited too.’

‘If you do that,’ said Leo, ‘they’ll most likely be binned anyway, won’t they?’

‘I genuinely can’t say,’ said Jilly evenly.

I thought Leo was about to object again, but he didn’t. Jilly Cowie, having quelled this rebellion, looked pleased.

‘In the meantime, we will almost certainly have bigger fish to fry. Trust me.’



And so, we began the task of moving all the ledgers and simply piling them unceremoniously in the auditorium. It was tiresome, numbing work, and

dispiriting, knowing that the ledgers were, in all likelihood, destined for destruction.

That night, there was no talk of communal dinner, no drunken arguments about differing philosophical viewpoints, no surreptitious pot-smoking. We were all exhausted.

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At ten to nine the next morning, we all sat in the kitchen, dressed in our boiler suits, ready for work. I had no clear idea of what we'd be doing next: we had left the auditorium clean and tidy, the chamber tucked away in the wings empty and bare. We sat, drinking coffee, smoking, awaiting further instructions.

Contrasting utterly with our lack of energy came Jilly Cowie, at all times brimming with an enviable sense of purpose. Indeed, she was animated with such resolve she virtually vibrated, bouncing into the room with her trademark string of 1950s platitudes. Of the fearsome version of herself we had seen yesterday, defending her schedule, there was no sign. She stood while the rest of us sat.

'Well now,' she said. 'I'm delighted to report, further to what I was saying yesterday, that there has indeed been a change of plan! As you're no doubt aware, I think we're probably reaching the limit of what we can do here at Marshlands, as it turned out to be in a much better state than we all thought. However, the university has also been locked in negotiations for some time regarding another property and – well, put simply, it's going to be all hands on deck again. You all know Solace House?'

I put a finger up. 'I don't. What is it?'

'You know it,' said Clive. 'The big Victorian house in the woods.'

'Oh!' I said. 'The haunted house. Yeah, sorry. Carry on.'

Jilly Cowie pulled a face. 'Yes, I'm certain it's not actually— Anyway, the big house over there, yes. It was the family home of Mr Flayne, whose money was partly responsible for building this place. It was his gift to the world. After he died, Solace House went to his son, Edwin Flayne, who

lived there alone for decades. Edwin Flayne died two years ago, at the grand old age of a hundred and one.'

'What did he die of?' asked Helen.

'Water-skiing accident,' I said. 'Jesus, Helen, he was a hundred and one, he probably just stood up too fast.'

Clive barked a sudden laugh. Helen's face creased. 'That's very disrespectful.'

Jilly smiled neutrally. 'It was indeed old age, if that's what you're driving at. Anyway, Flayne Junior never married and had no children, so when he died, the house was effectively vacant, and has been these last two years. His death left everything very *up in the air*, legally speaking. During those two years, the university has been negotiating to buy not just the hospital, but the house and the surrounding woodland. Purchasing Marshlands was comparatively easy, but the house – well, it was a minefield. But the university persisted. I think you can guess where this is going.'

'They finally bought it,' said Clive. 'And now they own it?'

'Not quite. The university has not yet officially acquired the house. But they do have first refusal, pending a survey. And that's where you come in. The timing is extremely fortuitous, because before Solace House can be surveyed, it needs to be cleared. Basically, no-one's coming to see that house until you lot have finished with it. And that will almost certainly take the rest of the summer.'

'I don't understand,' said Ruth. 'How can clearing out just one house, even a house that size, take the rest of the summer?'

Jilly smiled.

'It's probably quicker if I just show you.' For the first time, I noticed that she was carrying a torch. 'Come on! Get your stuff together and follow me.'

Out of the main building of Marshlands we marched, following Jilly Cowie, who, despite her short stature, strode at formidable speed. We rounded the 1970s extension to the main building and crossed the yellow lawn, towards the tall, meandering wall of dark stone which separated the woods from the hospital grounds. There was an arched doorway in the wall, in which a rusted ironwork gate was set. I hadn't noticed this before, probably because I had paid so little attention to the house and its surroundings. There had been too much else to think about.

Jilly Cowie unlocked the gate with a large, medieval-looking key, and led us through.

And we followed her, just like that, to our bright and brilliant doom.

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# III

## SOLACE HOUSE

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# 13

25. Eyes now eyeless; *unending* night, hoping.  
Obscene logic your reason erodes.  
Is God not insane? No, God is nothing,  
No orisons to heaven intone.
26. Now given new Eden, salvation, sanctum,  
Grant us, its loveliness, Thine.  
Now escape unto this radiant *asylum* –  
Live in solace eternal, divine.

ON THE OTHER SIDE of the wall, we found ourselves on a thoroughly overgrown pathway, little more than a fox path, which wound its way off into dark, chaotic woodland. Tendrils of bright green bramble stretched across the trail, and gaggles of tall stinging nettles crowded at the turns.

It was a short walk, but on that very first day, traversing strange territory, it felt as if we walked for a long time. A palpable crackle of anticipation thrilled through all of us; Marshlands had proven to be disappointingly restrained, a place filled with good intentions, well executed: none of the excesses that I had secretly hoped for when I first arrived, when I had seen the paintings on the wall. This place already felt different. I could feel my excitement echoed in the others; an almost callous anticipation that there might be something else here, something more peculiar and disturbing, something painfully fascinating, which we might gorge ourselves on. Eventually, the woods and the pathway gave way to a

drive of orange gravel, invaded at the edges by splashes of yellow ragwort, the pink heads of campion and herb Robert.

Forty paces down this driveway, crowded in by overgrown trees which seemed to babble and murmur in the faint breeze, sat the house.

An insane project seen to its conclusion, a deranged endeavour made real. The impression was of a bad or mistaken idea, manifested in actuality through sheer bloody-mindedness, imposed on the place rather than built in harmony with it. In these overgrown woods, the house's pretensions seemed to embody a surreality that was peculiarly English, a cricket pavilion on the moon. I thought of the painting I'd found, the view through the fake French windows on the stage; this house, adrift in a bizarre, almost alien landscape. But the truth was, the house would have seemed out of place anywhere.

Up close, the house was even more troubling. Too large and too grand in almost every proportion, too massive and ornate to ever successfully hide, even here, it felt at once both intimidating and ridiculous. Something about the upper floor seemed top-heavy, projecting too far into the air, so that standing in front of the house was to be filled with a tangible sense of threat, as it glowered above, over-stacked, looming like a storm cloud. The various Gothic trimmings and fussiness, which at a distance seemed ecclesiastical, here seemed something else entirely, apparently honouring a scheme or philosophy that was unfamiliar, unsettling, disturbed.

*'Haunted house,'* I whispered again, apparently involuntarily.

For once, Jilly Cowie said nothing. She simply ascended the stone steps, leading us up into the maw of the enormous porch. The arched front door was solid timber, embedded with big metal studs. Two great black iron hasps curled tendril-like across its width, and between them, by way of a handle, was a huge loop of twisted black iron. The pretensions of the design were rendered deadly serious by the materials used: the doorway was carved sandstone, the door itself made of heavy beams of oak, the ironwork excessively large and solid. The door simultaneously not only affected to look like it could repel an army, but almost certainly could.

Jilly produced another ornate brass key and inserted it into the lock. To my surprise, the key turned smoothly. Like children watching a conjuror,

we crowded to see what lay beyond.

---

There was no space inside the house. There was no light, no air.

There was only mania.

The hallway, built to the same colossal scale as the house's exterior, was choked with stacks of *things*, the dark outlines of objects, boxes and piles of papers, floor to ceiling. The architect's intention had presumably been that the hallway be an opulent space, unrestrained in both scale and height, filled with light, to match the grand exterior, to show off how much else of the world the house's owner could afford to enclose. That intention had been utterly thwarted by endless detritus, by cardboard boxes, by precarious stacks of junk. As a result, the hallway had become dark and oppressive – the unreachable bulb blown years ago, never to be replaced – and the daylight lingered hopelessly at the edges of the doors and windows, never quite finding its way in. We didn't go in, either, because we couldn't: the only way through the hall and into the rest of the house was an extremely narrow channel through the stacks of paper and refuse.

'Ah,' said Clive eventually.

'Yes,' said Jilly.

'How much of the house is like this?' I asked.

Jilly grinned – not her usual grin.

'Come on.'

She switched on her torch and inhaled deeply, as if taking in the last gulp of clean air available on planet Earth.

---

The piles and stacks in the hallway were so tightly packed together, and the channel between them so narrow, that the only way through them was to walk in one by one, and even then, we all had to walk sideways-on, tottering like crabs. Instinctively, I felt a sudden urge to hold someone's hand, so that we wouldn't lose ourselves irrecoverably.



At length – longer, surely, than the dark hallway could reasonably be – we arrived at a central well of some kind, a vast square column of cold, unmoving air, around which a truly massive staircase wound, climbing upwards in deepening storeys of black nothingness to an imperceptible ceiling. Jilly Cowie’s nervous torch beam flicked with fly-like rapidity from thing to thing around us, highlighting harsh specifics in a sea of soft-edged shadows: a pile of books, the torso of a wicker dummy, the gleaming brass horn of a gramophone. To our immediate right, a pair of monstrous wooden sentinels turned out to be the newel posts of the banisters, heavy and ornately carved, the start of the great staircase that wound through the darkness at the core of the house. The staircase was so choked with rubbish that it practically formed a solid wall, presumably all the way up to the far-off summit.

And presumption, inside Solace House, was all one had; the junk obscured all edges, all walls, all rooms, making the interior of the house one seamless mystery, one subject, one object, one indecipherable code of indeterminate extent. The clutter absorbed everything, conquering, smothering and consuming. The dust was so thick in some places it had become a thing in its own right, olive-coloured, dense as moss. As my eyes adjusted, I began to pick out individual objects – a barometer, a broken hourglass, a soda siphon with a crack in it, a large wooden monkey, hands over its eyes, looming startlingly from the darkness. Greatly outnumbering the things that were whole, there were also things that were broken, things that were losing their shape, shifting, decaying; things that were in the process of becoming other things, or gradually becoming nothing at all.

The level of detail, of every space being filled, and filled with things, was maddening. It numbed the mind. It seemed to remind me of something, but at that moment, what that thing could be eluded me.

Jilly turned to us, her torch beam for a second shining upwards into her face, like a boy scout round a campfire, telling a ghost story.

‘Well then,’ she said.

# 14

27. Our universe's trifling concerns all surpassed,  
This world, *His* Eden, remade.  
Earth's grave object done! His elect amassed;  
Delivered, liberated, all saved.

28. Thus, speaking of new life, your refuge  
Of boundless Eden, dignified,  
It never occurs; base *subterfuge*,  
Conceals unholy riddles inside.

'Well... what?' said Malcolm helpfully. In this restricted, compromised place, his voice bounced back immediately, flattened and blunted.

'I *mean*,' said Jilly, gesturing about her. 'You can see the problem!'

'I can't see anything,' said Ruth. 'Is that the problem?'

'Bloody hellfire,' said Clive. 'What went on here?'

'Whatever it is, it's been going on for decades,' muttered Leo.

Malcolm peered upwards, into the darkness. 'Did the hospital use this place as a storeroom?'

'I'm afraid not,' said Jilly gravely.

'Then why is there so much... stuff?' Clive seemed unable to arrive at the obvious conclusion. 'You said there was just, like, one bloke living here?'

'There was.' Some peculiar sense of duty, or awe, or maybe even respect, had removed Jilly Cowie's usual verbosity, and she whispered in short, clipped sentences, as if she were in church.

‘You mean, *he* did all this?’ said Clive, in wonder. ‘Thingy, whoever lived here?’

‘Yay,’ I said. ‘You finally got there.’

‘It’s early,’ said Clive. ‘Leave me alone. Fucking hell, just *look* at all this.’

‘Actually, I had a great-aunt like this,’ said Malcolm. ‘Same, um, condition. She couldn’t throw anything out. Her house looked exactly like this when she kicked the bucket. And when I say she couldn’t throw anything out, I do mean *anything*. In the fridge they even found bottles and jars with all, like, poo and wee in them.’

‘Thanks for that, Malcolm,’ said Ruth. ‘Tell you what, you can clean out the fridge.’

‘If we ever find it,’ said Adam. His pale face glowed in the darkness.

Jilly smiled. ‘Does anyone have any questions?’

Everyone put their hand up.

‘Ooh, I see! Okay. You first.’ She pointed to Malcolm.

‘Who lived here again?’

‘Were none of you listening earlier? It belonged to Mr Flayne, and he died two years ago. He lived here alone for at least sixty years.’

‘Alone, you say?’ said Ruth. ‘No shit.’

‘Why would anyone choose to live like this?’ said Helen. ‘I mean, like... this?’

Jilly shrugged. It was not a question that was easily answered. ‘I don’t think Mr Flayne was a well man.’

‘How many rooms are there in this place?’ I asked.

‘Erm,’ said Jilly, consulting her clipboard. ‘About... fifty. Somewhere in that region?’

‘*Fifty?*’ I said incredulously.

‘*About* fifty?!’ said Ruth.

‘*Somewhere in that region?*’ said Leo. ‘You don’t know for sure?’

Jilly shrugged apologetically. ‘Look at the place. It’s hard enough to tell where the windows are, let alone count the rooms.’

‘And are all the rooms... like... this?’ asked Ruth, looking around her.

‘Again,’ said Jilly, ‘the only person who could accurately answer that is Mr Flayne, and he’s currently unavailable. But my expectation would be, yes, they’re almost certainly all like – this.’

I thought about Mr Flayne, living here, growing old, committing himself to this monstrous project either consciously, for God alone knew what reason, or subconsciously, by stealth. It was hard to know which of these paths to the house’s current state was the more terrifying. Flayne – whoever he had been – had, for the whole of my lifetime, and for decades before that, been here, alone, erasing the space inside his enormous house, increment by increment, object by object, until years later there were only two well-worn pathways left, one from the front door to the bottom of the stairwell, where we were, and one which led off from there, through a doorway, to presumably whatever Flayne had used for living quarters.

We had all fallen silent again, as we considered the implications of the place. Once more, Jilly was first to speak, and I found that her brisk jolly-hockey-sticks voice and its can-do attitude, grating almost anywhere else in the world, was, here, extremely welcome.

‘So. This is a *huge* project, as you can see, and we have just under seven weeks in which to complete it. This, Mr Dexter, is why I couldn’t waste any time on those records from Marshlands. We have a lot to do here. Method and timing will be key.

‘And so, to begin with, we’ll be clearing the front hallway *there*, making a clear passageway from the front door to the stairwell, *here*. From there, we will be clearing the staircase itself, all the way up to the top floor, and then working our way back down, room by room, to the ground floor. And out.’

‘Seems an odd way of doing it,’ I said. ‘Why not clear out the ground floor first?’

Jilly smiled pleasantly. ‘Because the piles of stuff down *here* might be all that’s holding this place up. Depending what’s in the upper floors. We have to identify if there are any structural issues, and I’d rather do that if the house isn’t top-heavy.’

‘Right,’ I said. ‘Not starting on the ground floor. Got it.’

‘Indeed, Mr Lane. Obviously, with such a large amount of, um, *material* in the house, we can’t know what state the structure is in, and it can’t be surveyed until that material is cleared. A chicken-and-egg problem, which dictates how we approach things.’ Jilly started to sit down on the filthy arm of a buried chaise longue, thought better of it, and remained standing. ‘However, there’s a snag. As Mr Flayne had no living relatives, the university is attempting to purchase not only this house, but its contents. Which it will be our job to sort.’

‘Oh God,’ Clive snorted. ‘You can’t be serious!’

‘Well, we’re lucky in that most of the contents of the house seem to be rubbish. And so, things that are obviously and clearly rubbish – loose papers, rotten clothes, bed linen, anything broken, et cetera – will be dumped outside the house, to one side of the driveway, to eventually be taken away when we wrap up.

‘If, however, you find anything that you think might be of value, then you *must* bring it back to Marshlands. There’s more than enough space in the auditorium for anything you might find. I will be reviewing your finds as we go. Obviously, that will take time, but it has to be done.’

I looked around me at the nearest cardboard boxes, from which spilled concertinaed stacks of old newspapers, bills, mould-spotted books. It was hard to imagine anything in Solace House being any use to anyone.

‘And I’m sorry,’ said Jilly, ‘much as I trust you all, I will occasionally be turning out pockets at the end of the day. As a matter of procedure. Nothing personal, I just have to make sure. And I hardly need remind you, in a place like this, that none of you should even think of smoking in here.’

‘No smoking,’ said Clive. ‘Got it.’ Something about the tone of his voice made me suspect that this order would end up being adhered to as rigorously as Clive’s responsibility for giving us safety briefings.

‘And one *more* thing.’ Jilly’s voice became deeper, more serious. ‘If you find anything dangerous, *stop work immediately* and notify me.’

Ruth’s eyes widened, sparkling in the gloom. ‘Like what, exactly?’

‘Anything from a wasp’s nest to a water leak. But most especially, I mean structural damage. There’s hundreds of tons of rubbish in this house

and has been for years – expanding in the heat, contracting in the cold – and I’d be very surprised if it hasn’t taken its toll somehow. A house isn’t built to be this thoroughly...’ – she looked about her, searching for the correct word – ‘... *inhabited*? And so, any stresses and cracks, breaks in the plaster, damp, holes in the roof or floor, that sort of thing – tell me as soon as you’re aware of it. *As soon as*. We need to assess how serious it is. Anything like that is an accident waiting to happen. And on top of that, you must report any dangerous items you might find.’

Helen’s face paled. ‘Such as?’

‘Oh, you know,’ said Jilly. ‘Chemicals. Weed killer, acids, anything like that. Anything poisonous, explosive, flammable or corrosive. Oh – and weapons.’

‘*Weapons?*’ shrieked Helen incredulously. Unseen by anyone but me, Clive casually flinched, and put a finger in his ear.

‘Oh yes.’ Jilly Cowie seemed oddly pleased by the idea. ‘Mr Flayne was old enough to have seen active service during both world wars, and, although I’m fairly sure he *didn’t*, there’s always the possibility he *may* have done. They weren’t too strict back then about taking a Luger and two boxes of ammunition home for a souvenir, if you wanted to remember all the fun you had at Monte Cassino.’ Jilly shrugged. ‘As I say, it’s unlikely, but I’m just preparing you for every eventuality. There’s decades and decades’ worth of stuff in this house, so God alone knows what’s here.’ She paused. ‘I think that’s everything relevant. If you want to—’

From somewhere – some very dark, very hidden place – came the muffled sound of an old-fashioned telephone.

There was a distressed, anguished note to the ringing, as the bells struggled to make themselves heard under tons of crushing debris, the survivor of an earthquake screaming under rubble. We all glanced at each other uneasily.

‘Should we... get that?’ said Leo.

Jilly gave a mirthless laugh. ‘You can try! I’m not even sure which room it’s coming from, to be honest.’



# 15

29. That yawning uneasiness, neatly displayed.  
On neglected earth stands that ruin.  
Asylum *now* derelict, empty, decayed:  
White hot enmity, reason eschewing.

30. *Ascertain* by your senses, shining, anew,  
Last vestige of idylls destroyed,  
Each mad prayer to you; Eden, Xanadu.  
This Elysium. Now devoid.

WE INCHED OUR WAY back out of the peaty murk of Solace House into the full stinging dazzle of the summer morning, the sunlight momentarily bleaching my vision. No-one spoke for a minute or so; it seemed we were all slightly numbed by what we'd seen.

Jilly Cowie excused herself to go and get fresh dust masks, gollygoshing about how the day had improved, and how the weather forecasters always get it wrong, don't they, and then we were all alone with the growing heat of the day and the rising birdsong, and the looming, fanatical house, towering over us.

Ruth craned her neck to stare upwards at the façade.

'Well, this ought to be a fun summer,' she said, smiling.

'There's enough work to take us through to September,' I said. Regardless of what else this place was, it was also a massive stroke of luck. I was intensely relieved that my fortunes had held, and the bridge of fragile



circumstance that had delivered me this far through a summer I had made no plans for still held firm.

‘There’s enough work to take us through to fucking Christmas,’ Clive muttered sourly, but he smiled too.

‘It could be a lot worse,’ said Malcolm. ‘I mean, I’m quite looking forward to it. God only knows what’s inside that place, right? Maybe we’ll turn up something valuable. Something amazing. I was hoping for that at Marshlands, but this...’ He shook his head.

‘Maybe we’ll turn up a corpse,’ I said. Ruth smiled, as if to say *oh, cool*.

Helen made a face. ‘*Don’t talk like that*,’ she hissed. ‘I’m really not comfortable with being here. I signed on to clear the hospital, not this. The house is... I don’t know. It’s *weird*.’

Clive rolled his eyes, but before he could respond with something caustic, Leo said calmly, ‘That’s surely the point, Helen. We’re here to *de-weird* it.’

‘I didn’t mean that,’ said Helen. ‘I wasn’t thinking about all the rubbish inside, I meant that it feels... I don’t know. I don’t like this place. I don’t like the atmosphere, and I especially don’t like that telephone ringing. How is it ringing anyway? If the place has been empty for two years?’

‘It must be on the same system as the hospital,’ said Clive. ‘No great mystery or anything. There must have been a line run between the hospital and the house at some point that nobody thought to cut off.’

Helen wrinkled her nose in distaste. ‘I still think it’s creepy.’

‘I know!’ said Ruth excitedly, putting an arm around Helen and squeezing her shoulder. ‘We’ve hit the Goth motherlode! Isn’t it great?’

‘No, it is not *great*,’ said Helen. ‘It’s depressing.’

‘Yes,’ said Clive, through a smirk. ‘An enormous contrast to those halcyon days of yore, when we were merely clearing out a filthy lunatic asylum.’

Helen scowled at him. ‘You know perfectly well what I mean. This is *not* a nice place.’

I looked around at the woods, soaked in delirious summer sunlight. Somewhere, a wood pigeon’s leisurely fluting call drifted through the trees,

and even further beyond that I could hear a woodpecker drumming away at a tree, but these were only the most obvious sounds in a huge curtain of natural noise. The upper canopy of the trees glittered, the leaves shone almost turquoise in the intense sunlight. Two white butterflies fought over a sunspot, turning and tumbling in the blue air.

‘It’s beautiful,’ said Adam, as if he were speaking my thoughts.

Ruth shrugged. ‘It beats working at home all summer. In the bloody golf club. Getting my arse grabbed by my dad’s golf twat friends. That’s all I know. It’s a massive stroke of luck.’

‘Ruth’s right,’ I said. ‘We’re onto a very good thing here. I say we make the best of it.’

Helen sniffed. ‘I still think it’s creepy.’

‘Come on!’ said Malcolm brightly. ‘It’s not that bad, Helen. We’ll bring the radio over here. Clear some space. Get a rhythm going. It’ll be... fun!’



The rest of the day was not fun. It quickly resolved into hard, repetitive work.

Jilly Cowie returned with a cardboard box filled with brand new dust masks. Someone made a joke about us filling them with Vicks VapoRub and dropping ecstasy, which Helen became angry that she didn’t get. This was the only crumb of fun the rest of the day contained. Malcolm’s plan to put his radio on came to nothing; ten seconds after he switched it on, it stopped working, the batteries apparently flat. He swore as ‘Out of Space’ by The Prodigy trailed off into nothing, the repeated line about taking your brain to another dimension fading away like the last communication from a distant star. Replacing the batteries had the same effect, curiously, and we had no others. We would be working in silence.

And so, in no great hurry, we donned our masks and began the onerous task of emptying out the choked hallway. In our boiler suits, we climbed the porch steps like astronauts embarking on a dangerous mission.

The hallway was mostly filled with piles of paper, as if every letter, magazine, flyer or local election campaign leaflet that had ever found its misguided way to the house had been carefully archived. There were also various obscure periodicals and pamphlets, some in French, others in Russian; mostly, it seemed, academic papers on maths and science. There was also a lot of crumbling sheet music. The main component of the hallway's contents, however, were simply a great many newspapers, surely only measurable in tons, all in various states of decomposition, from merely yellowed to crumbling piles of dust. At first, we examined the newspapers as we carried them outside in their cardboard boxes, picking out stories, marvelling at the dates, laughing at the advertisements for long-defunct products, reading each other's horoscopes; but eventually the sheer volume and number of them eroded our curiosity. By late morning we were simply lugging them outside in piles, down the steps, and throwing them into a large heap to the right of the front drive. Even Leo did not object to the consigning of these worthless artefacts to the rubbish pile, which grew steadily, minute by minute, hour by hour, into a small tumulus of dead words.

# 16

31. So vain a campaign. A nauseous thought,  
Is nonetheless lithe, insistent.  
Memory in twain, Lo, Eden's soul sought  
Sweet infinity. Lightless existence.
32. Now, come *experience* – indefinitely – my pain.  
Unto righteous eyes now exposed,  
Woe's furnace, eternity's angry reign,  
Secrets labyrinthine infold.

IT WAS AROUND LUNCHTIME that my body and mind finally rebelled at the repetitive work. I realized I'd been lifting and carrying for two hours solid; I was fairly sure everyone else except me had taken a break at some point.

I was on my way outside – it seemed the logical thing to do, as it meant I could take the dust mask off, and breathe air that wasn't filthy – when I remembered something. That tantalizing, unexplored pathway which ran through the stacks of rubbish in the hallway and led further inside the elevated ground floor of the house. I picked up a spare torch and slipped away.

Lurching crab-wise back through the narrow channel of boxes in the hallway, still very much present despite all our efforts, I came to the large central area of the house, where Jilly Cowie had given us our introduction. Although the sun shone outside, this far into Solace House, the darkness was thick as soot, the stairs sprouting like a fairytale beanstalk, banisters climbing upwards into the gloom. Opposite them, I saw what I was looking

for: the thin channel that led deeper into the house. Logically, of course, there could be only one place this tunnel would lead to: the living quarters of the man who had dwelt here, the architect of this suffocating maze. *Flayne's nest*, said my mind, before I could stop it.

I sidled through the narrow channel, as Flayne himself must have done, countless times, dragging his body along the boxes and crates, the house and him almost merging, made of the same stuff. I found myself in a curious state of anticipation that wasn't fear, but wasn't far removed.

Squirming out from between columns of boxes and tea chests, I found myself in a small room, mostly taken up with a double bed.

The bedsheets had not been changed in years, and, as a result, bore a great greasy smear in the middle, as if a human being had been rendered down into fat there. I was able to smell this unholy Turin Shroud the second I entered the room. The large bay window had been light-proofed long ago, with layer upon layer of pasted-on newspaper, the torch beam picking out a crazed herringbone of ancient headlines, running floor to ceiling.

And of course, even in this tiny space, there was clutter. The far wall was all books, stacked precariously to well over head height, like a rock formation. A stack of *Reader's Digests* replaced the missing leg of a dresser covered by the signature Flayne melange of objects, spilling onto the floor, crunching underfoot as I crossed the room, toppling from overloaded shelves in small puffs of dust.

At the far end of the room – although far in this context was not far at all – a doorway led into a smaller room. I suspected it had been a larder, some part of the below-decks engine rooms of the house from its heyday, when it had a full complement of servants. Now, it was a kitchen, although only in the broadest possible sense. On a small table sat a gas camping stove, broken, furred with rust. There was nothing in the cupboards above apart from dozens of tins of Heinz ravioli, blue cans of butane for the stove and a bottle of meths.

Adjoining this room was a cramped, square bathroom, where a toilet, bath and sink were set so close together they almost touched. There was a stack of old newspapers on the cistern: I picked one up and saw that it was

dated 1965. The medicine cabinet held nothing but two dozen bottles of aspirin and a cut-throat razor.

Suddenly uncomfortable in the windowless dead end of the filthy bathroom, I returned to the bedroom.

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Mr Flayne, the sole owner of a house with at least fifty rooms, had been devoured so completely by something, some strange but compelling idea, that he had ending up hiding from the world in this tiny, choked burrow of a place. In doing so he had apparently rescinded all human privileges, living in near darkness, like a grub. There was something both infinitely repellent and heartbreaking about it all. In attempting to shake off the implications, I walked over to the wardrobe, and, before I could think better of it, jammed the torch under my arm and opened it.

The rusty hinges sounded one protracted, agonized squeal, and then the wardrobe seemed to burst like a broken snowglobe. In the trembling torch beam, what I had first taken to be a solid form broke into a multiplicity of frantic, fidgeting airborne things, erupting into the air. It was a second or two before I realized they were clothes moths, hundreds of them, possibly thousands, infuriated by the torchlight. Behind this living cloud, a huge dark overcoat, festooned with a myriad tiny hammock-like cocoons, finally completed the process of disintegration it had been undergoing for decades, and collapsed to the floor.

Hastily, I moved to jam the wardrobe shut; but in doing so my attention was caught by a large Kilner jar that sat just inside one of the compartments to the right. There was something inside it. Accepting the risk that I might see something I didn't want to, I scooped up the jar, closed the door and swatted away the moths.

I had been expecting a mystery, but inside the jar was the least mysterious thing in the world.

I could see Christopher Wren, William Shakespeare, Florence Nightingale, St George fighting the dragon. All crumpled carelessly into the

jar, or crushed into pleated piles. There were coins in there too, but it was mostly notes, in a thick wad.

The jar was not light. There must, I estimated, have been over a thousand pounds in there. Maybe two.

*Two thousand pounds.*

I could leave this house immediately. Walk away from it that very second, in a straight line, and just keep on walking. Through the wooded path, away from the filth and this cramped cathedral of lunacy. Keep on walking. Call a taxi. Rent a room in a hotel for a couple of days, then buy a plane ticket, go out to wherever Amethyst currently was. I could spend the entire summer with her, lavish this money on her, make her take me seriously, somehow, even for one glorious, ridiculous, fake summer. I could already see us both, on bright orange sun loungers, in the glow of a sunset, getting drunk or stoned, me willing to pay for everything, just so that she would notice me, be with me, laugh with me, get drunk with me, pretend she liked me, which was what I wanted.

Didn't I?

I was still clutching the jar when Jilly Cowie breezed in behind me.

'Hello! I see you've located the *master bedroom*! Quite something, isn't it? What've you got there?' Jilly asked, utterly without guile. I looked down at my hand, the jar. The situation was so surreal I hadn't had a chance to conceal it, or even contemplate doing so.

'*Money?*' I said slowly, questioningly, as if I were unsure.

Jilly shone her torch at it. 'Good Lord, you're right. Ooh, there's a small fortune in there! Wow! Well, I'll file this with the other valuables. Well spotted, Alex! Good work! I thought the initial exploratory survey had found all of Mr Flayne's little stashes of cash, but evidently not! If you find any more around the place, just let me know!'

She took the jar from me, smiling good-naturedly; I offered no resistance, just watched it leave my grasp and enter hers. And there was no deceit in her smile, no thought at all of making off with the money, leaving immediately, going somewhere sun-soaked on the other side of the world for the rest of the summer, or whatever Jilly Cowie's personal version of my

daydream was. No: the jar would be solemnly numbered, the money removed and counted, then sent on to the relevant university authority, with no thought in her head other than how clearly and legibly she could complete the labelling.

‘Nice work, Alex!’ she said again and smiled.

‘I think I need some fresh air,’ I said.

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# 17

33. Come, endless night, so eerie, unholy!  
Now, god of dread, lift your eye!  
Now, doth see night's occult ceremony,  
Entreaties, like expletives, sigh.
34. Thine injustices argue, like echoes,  
Speak to all, *that* evil name!  
O, elision can sometimes truth access,  
Speak; your grand riddle explain.

IT TOOK ME A WHILE TO decide how to proceed.

Eventually, however, I resolved, for the sake of my sanity, to simply never, ever think of the Kilner jar again. I would just pretend it had never happened, above and beyond simply remembering to look a little bit harder at things when I picked them up. I had not been receptive before this to the idea that anything in the house might have tangible, even obvious, value, but now, I had learned the hard way. My dad always used to say *it's not about how many times you get knocked down, it's about how quickly you get up again*, and even though I suspected he might have got this from an American cop drama, it stayed with me.

*Mind you*, I thought, *fat lot of good it did him. It didn't help him when The Annihilator came. But then*, I thought, *nothing could*.

Lost in this maze of complex feelings I hadn't asked for, I didn't realize someone else was behind me on the steps until they were standing directly above me. Twisting round to look, I saw Helen, her dust mask around her

neck. She held a battered cardboard box, clearly destined for the junk pile that grew hour by hour at the edge of the driveway. However, she didn't advance towards it; she was staring over my head, off into the woods that screened Solace House from the world. For once, she looked uncertain.

'Helen? Are you okay?'

'Yes,' she said eventually, not taking her gaze from the middle distance. I stared into the woods too, saw only the woods.

'What is it?'

'I thought I saw someone.'

'Where?'

'Over there. In the trees.'

I squinted at the distant woodland, to the place I estimated Helen was gazing towards. All I could see were trunks of elm and ash and oak.

'Where?'

'Over there...' Something about committing to this statement seemed to disturb her, and she blinked, as if dismissing a bad thought.

'Are you sure?' I said. 'I can't see anyone.' *And you are, when all is said and done*, I thought, *absolutely batshit crazy*.

'She was *definitely* there!' she insisted, looking directly at me. 'There was *definitely* someone there!'

'Alright, alright,' I said. 'You saw someone. Fine. You said *she*?'

'A woman.'

'What did she look like?'

'She had her back to me. But she had a green dress on, and long red hair.' She peered beseechingly at me, with eyes which were always aggrieved, perpetually hurt, always close to tears.

'You don't believe me, do you?'

I sighed. I did not believe her. Helen possessed the habit of the deeply ordinary person who longs to be considered exceptional, that of snagging attention by creating drama. It was for this reason I found I didn't trust her, not really. I had made up my mind early on, almost instinctively, that Helen was someone to be tolerated, nodded at and humoured, because for any

conversation of real worth to progress, Helen would have to be completely honest with herself, and that was never going to happen.

‘Of course I believe you,’ I said.

Helen began to walk down the steps, and then, to my surprise, came back.

‘I really *did* see someone,’ she said, and there was genuine sincerity in her voice, then, convincing me totally, in that second, that she really had seen someone.

Then she walked away, and I didn’t know what to believe.

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We worked a very long day.

By the end of it, the hallway – for the first time, perhaps, in over half a century – was clear.

Now empty, the space was remarkable. The hallway, revealed, was afflicted with Solace House’s signature gigantism, all the doorways and walls too high, too large, as if this were a home for creatures nine feet tall. It was like the entrance to a civic building or a museum rather than the entrance to a home.

The absence of the moth-eaten carpet, now rolled up and dumped outside, revealed a floor that was tiled, with beautiful, maddening precision, in a severe black and white diagonal check, which gave the impression of order insisted upon to the point of insanity. This chequerboard pattern was bordered by maroon tiles with a vaguely heraldic design in red and white. Although the floor was dirty, still covered in drifts of dust, I had no doubt it would look spectacular when it was properly cleaned. The walls of the hallway were the typical Victorian arrangement of dado rail and skirting, with vertical struts of woodwork enclosing perpendicular segments of the space, all the way up to an ornately plastered ceiling, although – as ever in Solace House – the component parts of this arrangement were vast as dinosaur bones.

More or less everything we'd removed from the hall had been newspapers, box after box of them, with a couple of notable exceptions. There was an oil painting with a gilt frame, a dreary landscape in which two rustic-looking lovers strolled. In one of the other boxes – slithering out so fast that Helen, who had tipped the box up, screamed as she mistook it for a live thing – was a silver choker, wide as a ribbon, made up of something like tiny chain mail. Jilly Cowie took both of these items, and affixed a sticker to them, on which she solemnly wrote '2' and '3', before returning to Marshlands to lock them in a storeroom. It was, she told us, doubtful that either item would prove to have any real value, but everything that looked like it was worth something would have to be catalogued.

I realized that item '1' had been the Kilner jar. Gritting my teeth, I remembered, with no little effort, my promise to myself never to think about it again.



So successful had our excavations been that we had worked our way to the two huge, carved newel posts that guarded the place where the stairs began. Up close, I could see that the posts were made of some dense tropical hardwood, carved into tall rectangular pillars decorated with cornucopias and floral borders and crowned at the top with a vase-like bowl piled high with a perfect pyramid of spherical apples. It was impossible to make out anything else on the stairs themselves, as at this point the clutter achieved critical mass, and the piles of junk grew to a new and frightening height, towering over us, crates and boxes piled precariously on wooden tea chests, presenting a solid cliff face of hard labour between us and the first floor.

Clive looked up at all this as if sizing up an opponent in a physical fight.

'Okay, fuck that,' he said, after a moment's consideration. 'We'll tackle that tomorrow. If no-one objects.'

As if in answer, the telephone rang again, from somewhere.

# 18

35. And thus, able witness am I, to such things,  
Hear (ELLA, ELLA, ELLA), Ella's name,  
Dull echo, and then how my unhappiness sings!  
Takes arms. Blind joy! *Unfettered* refrain!

36. (Even now – obscured, small; a vile intimation,  
Of universal ruin: ours.  
Universal ruin, for one's own *liberation*;  
Hell, a real destiny: yours.)

LIKE ADAM AND EVE, only recognizing their nakedness after eating the apple, we only really realized how filthy we had become when we emerged onto the colossal porch. Our blue boiler suits were now covered with ancient grime, and removing our dust masks revealed clean circles on the lower halves of our faces. We looked like escaped convicts, but comical ones, the type you'd get in a silent film.

'Don't forget the stuff we found,' said Clive, as we packed up. 'Cowie'll throw a fit if we don't log it all.'

'There was just that painting, wasn't there?' said Malcolm. 'And the bracelet? She's already taken them.'

'It was a choker,' said Ruth. 'Honestly. Such ignorance of costume jewellery. I thought you were supposed to be gay? I'm gonna talk to your union rep.' Malcolm laughed and put his arm round her.

'Okay.' There was an unexpectedly businesslike tone to Clive's voice. 'Just the choker and the painting?'

‘And the glasses,’ said Adam.

I wiped my dirty face with my sleeve. ‘What glasses?’

‘Adam found a box of champagne flutes in there,’ said Leo. ‘Ten, was it?’

‘Twelve,’ affirmed Adam, in his usual whisper.

‘Twelve. Red crystal.’ Clive put a cigarette in his mouth, its pristine whiteness contrasting with his dirt-streaked beard. ‘Very beautiful. Probably worthless, but they’ll have to be recorded. Where are they?’

‘I forgot them,’ said Adam. ‘Don’t wait for me. I’ll catch you up.’

‘Way ahead of you there,’ said Clive cheerfully, already striking out for the trees, and Marshlands.



After a full day inside Solace House, Marshlands – which had previously looked to me wild, untamed and derelict – looked positively manicured. I had come to think of it as a welcoming place, a benign refuge, and I found that our spell in the ruins of a dead man’s mental disintegration had only strengthened that impression. I was glad to be back.

‘First in the shower,’ said Ruth.

‘What? Why you?’ said Clive.

‘Ladies before gentlemen, et cetera.’

‘I’m a lady too,’ said Helen.

‘Well then, you can go second,’ said Ruth. ‘But I’m going first. I’ve bagsied it.’

Malcolm laughed. ‘I really only come here for the conversation.’

We rounded the corner of the battered 1970s extension. The façade of Marshlands loomed behind it, revealing itself with each step.

‘Remember, we’ve only got an hour of hot water between us,’ said Leo. ‘‘Cos I was last yesterday and I gotta say—’

He stopped in his tracks, and stared.

By the pillared portico at the front entrance of Marshlands stood a young woman.

She had her back to us, but I could see that she was tall. She had a green dress on, a shoulderless satiny thing that looked almost like a nightdress, but the casual femininity of it was undercut by the fact she wore large chunky Doc Martens that came almost halfway up her pale shins. Her hair, cascading down between her shoulders, was red.

‘Look! That’s her!’ said Helen, in jubilation. She tugged at my sleeve like a child. ‘Look, Alex! I told you I saw a woman! That’s her! It must be!’

At the sound of Helen’s voice, the woman turned. Her eyes were obscured by Ray-Bans; a cigarette was wedged between bright crimson lips. Even at a distance, I could see that she regarded us, in our dirty boiler suits, with bemusement. She took off her sunglasses as we advanced.

‘Hello!’ said Clive, as we reached her. ‘Are you lost?’

‘Nope,’ said the woman cheerily. ‘This is Solace House, right?’

‘No,’ I said. ‘We’ve just come from there. Through those woods.’

‘And you’d be familiar with those woods, *of course*,’ said Helen. ‘As you were walking around them earlier?’

The woman wrinkled her nose in confusion. ‘I literally just got here.’

‘Er – *no*—’ began Helen, but Clive talked across her.

‘Why were you looking for Solace House?’

‘I signed up to be part of the team that’s clearing it? Which I presume is you guys?’

‘Wait, are you the other girl?’ said Leo. ‘The one we’re expecting? You’re late.’

‘Yeah,’ said the red-haired woman. ‘I had to sort out a few things. Anyway, I’m here now.’

‘You were here earlier!’ said Helen, outraged.

‘I really wasn’t,’ said the woman. ‘Why would I lie about that?’

‘Why indeed?’ said Helen, in a voice that implied she believed this statement to be some sort of flawless logical checkmate. The red-haired woman just smiled, her bemusement clearly deepening.

‘Wait, I know you,’ said Ruth. ‘You were doing Philosophy for the first term, right? I mean, I only saw you at, like, two of the lectures.’

‘Yeah,’ said the woman. ‘It wasn’t really floating my boat, so I stopped turning up. Plus I had some other shit to deal with.’

‘I knew I’d seen you before,’ said Ruth. ‘You stopped doing Philosophy?’

‘Yep. I jumped before I was pushed. Switched courses.’

‘Have you spoken to Jilly Cowie?’ said Malcolm. ‘She’s the – what would you call it? Forewoman? Manageress? She’s in charge here.’

‘No. Like I say, I only just got here.’ At this, Helen looked aggrieved, but the woman either affected not to notice her, or genuinely didn’t.

‘I’ll take you to her,’ said Clive. His teeth flashed white in his grubby beard. ‘It would be a pleasure.’ I realized he was trying his luck. He was probably seconds away from kissing her hand, saying *enchanté*.

‘Oh God,’ I said. ‘I can take you, if it means Clive will stop—’

There was a sound of smashing glass.

Twenty yards away stood Adam. He must have just rounded the corner of the extension. The cardboard box, which presumably had been full of the exquisite red crystal glasses he had talked of earlier, lay on its side on the tarmac in front of him.

He was staring at the new arrival. His eyes widened, and – impossibly – his dust-streaked face grew paler, even, than its normal eerie whiteness. The woman turned, at her own pace, to see the source of the noise.

Upon seeing her face, he exhaled, a sigh that was almost relief, but was almost something else too. Something like disappointment.

‘You alright there, Adam?’ said Clive, in a matter-of-fact voice.

‘Fine,’ he answered flatly.

Clive shrugged, turned back to the woman.

‘Right. I’ll take you to Jilly Cowie. Although let me tell you right now, she’s gonna be a huge disappointment after all this build-up.’



As everyone else trooped off to shower – Helen still staring with intense hostility at the new arrival – I went over to help Adam clear up the mess. I



did this simply because I was curious.

‘You okay?’ I asked, as I bent down to pick up the shards.

‘Fine,’ he said again, lifting the blood-red stem of one of the smashed champagne flutes and throwing it into the cardboard box. ‘*Fine.*’ He seemed to cling to the word.

‘Do you know that girl?’

‘No,’ he hissed. His voice, normally devoid of passion, had a seam of something close to anger in it. ‘No, I don’t *know her.*’

‘Alright, alright,’ I said. ‘It just looked like you recognized her, that was all.’

‘Forget it.’

‘Right,’ I said. ‘Forget it.’ I threw a handful of sparkling scarlet shards into the cardboard box. Adam, the Pale Strange Boy, sighed hotly and angrily, before scooping up the box and walking towards Marshlands.

And then, I realized I’d seen the look on his face – the one he’d worn when he saw the new arrival – before.

I had seen it that night, when he walked across the empty courtyard at The Ridge, to point at nothing, and scream.

# 19

37. Flain; and impaled. To his satanic exaltation,  
Let each voice a tribute exact,  
Now, occult rebirth, change, or mutation;  
For *our* rite terrifying enact.

38. That Eden. Radiating now a light stained,  
Every chance used, repentance expired.  
Suffer unending, cold heart that remains!  
O unkind blaze, light each *desire*!

THE THOUGHT OF QUEUING for a very short shower was enough to make the decision for me, and I ran a cold bath instead, in the half-sized tub in the bathroom adjoining my room. I was surprised to find the cold water pleasant, soothing even; and any resistance I had to it was easily exceeded by my delight at simply becoming clean. I even washed my hair, pouring endless jugs of fiercely cold water over my head, until the water that ran off me was clear.

Back in the empty kitchen, alone, my skin still thrilling to the echo of the cold water, I found myself with the urge to do nothing whatsoever but sit for a few minutes. My body ached in unusual places; the inside of my thighs, the backs of my knees, my pectoral muscles, parts of the body I wasn't, under normal circumstances, even conscious of. *Marvellous*, I thought. *This cushy situation I lucked into is going to kill me.* I found I couldn't even be bothered to smoke, although I sensed that I would be very hungry, very soon.

Eventually, everyone drifted back to the kitchen, and it was proposed that we all work together to cook yet another large spaghetti bolognese, as it was just easier than have us all queue for the one cooker. I sat smoking, and chopping red onions. Chatter was minimal; we were all tired. I noticed after a while that Adam was missing, presumably still in his room. I chopped seven onions, after which my eyes were streaming; I had to go to the sink in my bathroom and wash my face.

When I returned, Jilly Cowie appeared with the new girl.

‘Hello, everyone!’ Jilly smiled. ‘Allow me to introduce the final member of our little team of reprobates! This is Ella. Say hello, everyone.’

‘Hello, everyone,’ said Clive.

‘Hi again, Ella,’ said Ruth. Everyone else smiled, or murmured, or waved; everyone, that is, apart from Helen, who glared at the woman suspiciously.

‘Hi,’ said Ella. ‘I’m delighted to be joining you in your quest to clear up the house of a lunatic. And I’m not even being fashionably ironic there, I genuinely cannot wait.’

‘Yes,’ said Jilly brightly, choosing not to pick the new girl up on her use of the word *lunatic*. ‘So, Ella needs her health and safety orientation, Clive, and if you lot wouldn’t mind talking her through how things work here and showing her to her room, that’d be great.’

‘Of course,’ said Ruth. ‘As we’re between shops, do you want to join in on our spag bol?’ She looked suddenly disgusted with herself for saying *spag bol*, as if she had become infected by whatever force animated Jilly Cowie.

‘You’re okay,’ said Ella. ‘I’m a vegetarian. I’ll make my own food, but thanks all the same.’

‘Like Hitler!’ said Clive, somewhat too enthusiastically.

‘Yeah,’ I said. ‘That sure was the most memorable thing about the watercolourist Adolf Hitler.’

‘It’s a myth anyway,’ said Leo. ‘He ate meat.’

‘What?’ said Clive. ‘Are you telling me Hitler wasn’t a real Buddhist? He’s in grave danger of going right down in my estimation.’

Ella smiled, bemused. 'This a normal evening for you guys, is it? Sit around, chat about Hitler?'

Clive made a hurt face. 'Hey. Sometimes we talk about Jeffrey Dahmer too.'

'Who's Jeffrey Dahmer?' said Helen.

Malcolm's eyes widened. 'Lord, don't tell her.'

Jilly Cowie, utterly out of her depth with idle banter, looked slightly panicked. 'Well!' she said, for want of any other way of changing the course of the conversation. 'I'll leave you to get acquainted! Can someone show Ella to her room?'

'I'll do it,' I said, getting up. 'You're at the far end, next to me.'

As I turned to exit the room, I almost bumped into Adam. He hadn't showered, and was still covered in the dust and grime of Solace House. He was clutching a bottle of vodka. The bottle, already half empty, effectively cleared up the mystery of what he'd been doing for the last hour.

He flinched to avoid me, but when I stepped aside, he positively jumped when he saw Ella.

'Hello, Adam!' Jilly Cowie, as ever, was oblivious to unease. 'You're just in time. This is Ella.'

If Adam's reaction to seeing the woman for the first time had been dramatic, his reaction to being told her name was, it seemed, one of wry resignation.

'Ella,' he repeated. And then he mumbled something that sounded to me like *Of course*, but I must have been mistaken, as Ella didn't catch it either, and when she asked him to repeat himself, he said, 'Short for...?' He swayed a little as he said it. Ella smiled.

'Short for... nothing. Just, y'know, Ella.'

'Hmmm,' said Adam, as if he didn't quite believe her.

An odd silence fell.

'Well then,' said Jilly Cowie eventually, 'I'll leave you all to get on with it!'



‘The fuck was that about?’ said Ella, as we walked down the corridor towards her room. ‘Is he always like that?’

‘As far as I can tell,’ I said. I was going to tell her about my time alone with him in The Ridge and his nocturnal screaming, but thought better of it. ‘He’s... got his own stuff going on. I mean, he’s a weird guy, but I think he’s harmless.’

‘You didn’t know any of these people? From before?’

‘No. Do you?’

‘No,’ she said. ‘Just you.’ She didn’t look at me as she said it.

‘What? You don’t know me.’ I sounded more defensive than I intended. I did not like being caught on the back foot. ‘How *would* you know me?’

‘I used to see you around.’

I almost laughed. ‘Where?’

‘I was in Hatfield, same building as Amethyst Credence-Jones.’ It was such a shock to hear Amethyst’s name, and her full name at that, that I started, as if an electric charge had been jolted through me.

‘So?’ I said, failing to affect nonchalance.

‘So, I’ve seen you. Hanging out with her and those awful people she knows, pretending you’re having a much better time than you are.’

‘Er, excuse me. You’re talking about my friends here.’

‘Ah, I think you’re mistaking a simple situation for a complicated one,’ she said flatly. ‘Those people you call friends are all dreadful.’

‘You don’t know them!’ I said. Who was this person?

‘I know all I need to know,’ she said. ‘They’re absolutely fucking awful. Bratty, braying rich kids, all of them. Especially Amethyst.’

‘Look,’ I began. ‘You’re talking about a good friend of mine—’

She laughed. ‘I don’t really think she had friends. Not real ones, anyway.’

‘What would you know about it?’

‘She lived by my corridor, so we shared a kitchen. I had to interact with her every day, practically. She was a pain in the arse.’

‘Whoah! You’re not just talking about any old person here, okay? Amethyst happens to be someone I—’

‘She was horrible to me from day one. Condescending when she wanted something, rude when she didn’t.’

I opened my mouth to object, but couldn’t deny this sounded very familiar. Amethyst was precisely like that with me. Bored when I failed to entertain her, wheedling when she wanted me to do something for her; run an errand, or buy pot.

Ella smiled wryly. My silence on this matter had been noted.

‘Yeah, you can’t defend her, can you? Deep down, you know I’m right. She’s a horrible person. Her and that fucking boyfriend of hers.’

‘She doesn’t have a boyfriend.’ My mouth was dry.

‘Well, whatever he is. The guy who turns up to bang her twice a week. The one who always wears that same rugby top. Mark, or whatever he’s called.’

Reality seemed, for a second, to come into slightly sharper focus, but I was amazed at how calm I remained. I asked the question as if it were freighted with no consequence at all, a minor detail I needed help with, just to understand things a bit more clearly.

‘Do you mean... Marcus?’

‘Yeah! That’s him. Fucking *Marcus*. Came round twice a week to our corridor to pound her and help himself to our food.’

I felt a deadening inside me, as if all the energy I required to stay alive had suddenly and dramatically been earthed into the ground.

‘Did he?’ I managed.

‘Yeah. I swear he ate a whole block of Jarlsberg of mine one time. Like, an entire six ounces of cheese. Six ounces of Jarlsberg! Who does that? Mind you, given the enthusiasm with which we could hear them going at it, I expect he needed to keep his strength up.’ She peered at me. ‘Are you okay? You look peaky.’

‘I’m fine,’ I said. ‘This is your room.’

## 20

39. Reborn every age, something orderless, nascent.  
It – nameless – gains *its* dark life.  
Your perspective, rueful. Our perspective, omniscient.  
See each day protracted revived.
40. Orphan, unfairly deserted! Each dream  
Explores now strange districts exotic;  
Stranded, in glades nature's tendrils reclaim,  
As new senses leave all things *euphoric*.

I WOKE EARLY, and found I couldn't get back to sleep.

I opened the window. The day was not yet warm, the meadow at the rear of Marshlands lay drenched with dew, the long grass bowed under the tension of sparkling spiderwebs. I sat, with my feet on the window sill, smoking.

After speaking to Ella, I'd gone back to the kitchen in a daze, listened to the low buzz of conversation around me, noticing small things. The billowing cloud of steam from the pan of spaghetti as it was emptied into a plastic colander, the knocking of a wooden spoon in the pan, the heavy, inviting smell of bolognese sauce. I thought of Marcus and Amethyst leaving together, her elbowing him in the ribs as they mocked me.

I tried to manufacture some righteous outrage at being humiliated by two people I trusted, and believed I was close to, but ultimately, it was too much effort to maintain the pretence. Instead, I saw what I'd always known to be true; neither Amethyst nor Marcus were friends, and under normal

circumstances they would have ignored me completely, just as I would have ignored them. We had simply been people sharing a space, and any connection we had maintained had been due to mutual convenience. I had clung to the idea of Amethyst and I as a couple precisely because it was futile, offering the shape of a relationship without the actuality of one. I had also needed a larger-than-life, uncomplicated male friend to perform the social duties I was incapable of, or unwilling to perform, the pantomime of maleness that people are taught to respond positively to, which I couldn't summon up the energy for. I needed structure, the rhythm of normality, after The Annihilator had ripped away the one I knew. In that sense, I had used Amethyst and Marcus every bit as much as they'd used me.

Nonetheless, I was amazed at the speed with which Ella, whoever she was, had torn all that away.

---

In the kitchen, I discovered Ella was already awake. Despite wearing only white knickers and a faded black Pixies T-shirt, she moved entirely unselfconsciously, making coffee in a moka pot under which the gas flame hissed.

'Hey,' I said. She raised her eyebrows, and bent down to light a roll-up in the gas burner, just like Clive habitually did. She had a small tattoo on one thigh, of a key.

'I, er, just wanted to say something,' I began.

'Uh-huh.' She straightened up, removed the roll-up from her lips, exhaled. 'I'm listening.'

'You were – you *are* – right about Amethyst. She isn't a very nice person. Nor is Marcus. In fact, they're both pricks.'

She exhaled a jet of smoke. 'Not new information,' she said. 'But thanks.'

'It's just—' I had no idea how to proceed and, as such, found myself plunging forward towards absolute honesty. 'I just – needed some people to



be around. People to take my mind off things. If it hadn't been them, it would have been others. Perhaps people who were even worse.'

'Hard to see how.' She stood before me in her underwear, arms folded, and yet I was the one feeling out of place, ill at ease. It was quite a trick. *Imagine, I thought, enjoying that confidence naturally, instead of constantly having to remind yourself to behave like that.* I always found it such an effort.

'Hey,' I said, 'if it means that much, I'll buy you six ounces of fucking Jarlsberg, okay?'

She turned away so that I wouldn't see her reaction to this, but somehow I knew that, despite herself, she was grinning. I had no way of knowing whether she had forgiven me for my poor choice of friends and so resolved to just get on with my day. I set about making toast.

I got my answer about thirty seconds later when I heard her say, 'Hey,' and when I looked up at her she said, although without smiling, 'You want some coffee?'

---

'Fuck,' said Ella, an hour later, as we trooped along the path in single file.

I surmised correctly that she had just laid eyes on the house itself.

'Fuuuuck.'

'Why does everyone have to swear all the time?' grumbled Helen into the collar of her boiler suit. She said this sadly, perhaps acknowledging this was a battle she wasn't going to win.

'This can't be real,' said Ella in delight. 'No way this place is real.'

'It's quite something, isn't it?' said Clive. 'I'd like to say you get used to the weirdness, but yeah. You don't.'

'Gothic revival,' said Ella, peering up at the attic rooms. 'Late, by the looks of it. 1890? Hard to tell. Man, Gothic always tries too hard.'

'Oi!' said Ruth. 'No need to get personal.' She and Ella laughed.

'What did you say you were studying now?' asked Malcolm.

---

Ella smiled at him. ‘I didn’t. But yeah, I switched to Art History. That said, you don’t have to know much about art, or architecture, to have an opinion here. Place looks like a mausoleum.’

‘Maybe it is,’ said Clive cheerfully. ‘We guessed there might be bodies in there.’

‘Will everyone *STOP SAYING THAT!*’ squealed Helen, at a frequency high enough to stun a bat. ‘It makes being here intolerable! Like we’re all just waiting for something awful to happen!’

Leo smiled good-naturedly. ‘Don’t worry, Helen. We’ll make sure you don’t see anything that upsets you.’ His tone was genuine, but Helen still scowled at him.

Adam, meanwhile, said nothing. Every time I looked at him, I caught him looking at Ella. Then, he would become aware that I was observing him and look away. And then, the next time I looked at him, he’d be looking at her again, as if he couldn’t quite believe she was real.

I sighed. Out of nowhere, the first line of the poem that Clive had written and stuck to my door came back to me: *Oh yes, we are the loonies, in the loony bin we dwell...*

# 21

41. Deranging once Utopian *terrain*;  
Lawns, arbours, nurseries; dead.  
Irrational; sanity has since abstained,  
No certainty: terror instead.
42. *Forgotten* island, chimerical at twilight.  
Idyll of Nature's caprice.  
Overgrown mazy prison, of sweet Earthly Delight,  
Of resentment dead ages increase.

JILLY COWIE ARRIVED late to Solace House in a flurry of excuses; she'd had some kind of scheduling emergency involving the mountaineering society's upcoming outing to Scafell Pike, which had required a long phone call. She distributed fresh dust masks, took lunchtime sandwich orders, and tutted and exhaled loudly at the towering wall of junk on the staircase that she, personally, would not be lifting a finger to remove. Then she promptly vanished, and we got on with it.

The first obstacle consisted of nine large tea chests, stacked in three piles of three, upon which sat a great many cardboard boxes, all apparently filled with the signature Flayne debris of old newspapers and magazines, stacked to dangerously unstable peaks. For this work, Clive returned to Marshlands to fetch a stepladder, from which he passed down the papers and boxes to us below. Once accessible, the tea chests turned out also to be full of newspapers, which was disappointing. However, dismantling this initial wall revealed another thin channel through the debris, just as there

had been at the front door: a corridor barely a foot wide, showing glimpses of a faded purple and gold carpet held in place by tarnished brass stair rods. This pathway found its way upwards, step by painful step, through the pillars of junk, onto a square landing, and, via a left-hand turn, onwards up the next flight of stairs to the first floor. There, the pathway stopped, obstructed by an ancient landslide of debris, furred by dust.

We formed a rough human chain, as we had done both when removing the ledgers at Marshlands and clearing the hallway, which allowed us to pass items along to each other. Adam and I, slow to volunteer, found ourselves at the head of the chain, removing stuff from the staircase itself.

As it was revealed, piece by piece, we saw that the staircase – like everything else in the house – was grotesquely large, the stairs themselves almost nine feet across. The higher we climbed, the more we also seemed to uncover actual objects rather than just newspapers. A large chest filled with hats, filthy felt and velvet, speckled with grey mould. An ebony elephant with two holes where, presumably, real ivory tusks had once fitted. A compass, rendered unusable somehow, its needle turning perpetually in confusion. A plaster bust of some Victorian duchess or marquess, which had long ago fallen from a mantelpiece at some point, its face smashed clean off. I found this piece of accidental art funny, but when Adam saw it, he grimaced and turned away. And on and on; more objects, more things, a great profusion of exhausting, meaningless novelty. Our progress up the stairs began to slow as each individual item had to be removed, examined, assessed and, if determined to be of value, fitted with a sticker and set aside for Jilly Cowie to catalogue. Even with eight of us, this process created a bottleneck, and work ground to a halt.

‘Guys!’ said Ruth’s voice, eventually, from the ground floor a flight and a half of stairs below. ‘Let’s stop.’

‘But we’re almost at the landing!’ This was true. I could see, beyond the diminished hump of the landslide of boxes, a little bit of the corridor and a hint of the doorways beyond. My curiosity about Solace House was again whetted.

‘We’ve got tons of stuff down here,’ said Malcolm. ‘We need to take all of this crap back to the hospital.’

‘Shall we all go?’ I asked.

‘Nah,’ said Clive. ‘You two stay here, look after the place.’

I agreed, and then – too late – realized that this left me alone in the house with Adam.

---

After the others had gone – to my surprise – Adam immediately took his gloves and dust mask off and went outside.

‘Adam?’ I tried, but the only answer I got was the sound of the front door closing.

I was alone in the house, then, for the very first time.

On top of a cardboard box, I found Ella’s pouch of tobacco and rolled myself a cigarette. My tiny noises were swallowed up by the warren of still rooms, the tunnels and chambers superimposed on the layout of the house by the maze of junk.

A maze, I mused, within a maze, and the thought was unsettling.

The heat of the day had penetrated even the interior of Solace House, and the great gloomy space at the heart of the building smelled churchlike, of warm, disturbed dust. A lazy rope of grey smoke wound its way from my cigarette through the void above me. Some cue – neither auditory nor visual, but nonetheless a palpable shift within the house – made me look up.

Somewhere, the bells of the buried telephone rang, cutting through the dead air like a drill.

I counted ten repetitions of the tone, the frantic bells sounding, *ring-ring, ring-ring*, and an odd sensation wormed its way through my skin.

I went outside.

---

I found Adam sitting on one of the love seats in the stone porchway, his pale skin almost blue in the daylight.

I couldn't discern whether the silence between us was awkward or companionable. Adam, for his part, gave me no clues, ignoring me entirely, sitting inhumanly still, as if whatever animated him had temporarily departed.

'Not much sense in the others returning,' I said eventually. 'By the time they come back, it'll be lunchtime.' He made a small grunting sound which implied agreement, or possibly disinterest.

'At least it's sunny,' I said. 'I can't imagine how unpleasant it would be doing this in the rain!'

He grunted again. He looked almost physically pained by my attempts to engage him in small talk, but I had seen him scream at emptiness, and I wanted to know why.

'I...' I began. I found I didn't quite know how to continue and so decided on bluntness. 'When we were at The Ridge—'

'I hated that place,' he said sharply, as if the existence of The Ridge were somehow my fault.

'Yeah. By the end, I was pretty sick of it too.'

'I don't mean by the end of term,' he said. 'If anything, I preferred it empty.'

'Okay, but...' Was this worth pursuing? I had no idea. 'At the end, when it was empty. There was just you and me there. You're absolutely sure you didn't see me?'

He shrugged indifferently.

'I was on the fourth floor?' I said.

'In that case, probably not. I was on the ground floor.'

'Okay,' I said. Then I took the plunge. 'Late one night, I saw you. You were... sleepwalking?'

He gazed at me with a look of intense hostility.

'You walked out to the front of the building.' I swallowed. 'And you screamed. Just one scream, but believe me, that was all you needed to do.'

He looked more than hostile now. He looked incensed.

'What I'm saying is,' I said, 'I, er – have – moments – like that too. Usually at night, Nightmares, terrors, vivid dreams. In my case, it's because

there was—' I couldn't say the words, couldn't finish the sentence. It was so precious, to be here: to have found other people like this, a lifeboat of easy camaraderie in what would otherwise have been a bleak and terrible summer. I couldn't sully that with my history. Not now. I didn't want to tell anyone here about the Last Day, about The Annihilator, and if I *were* to tell someone, it certainly wouldn't be the Pale Strange Boy, someone apparently devoid, not only of empathy, but any real interest in other human beings. I started again.

'What I'm saying is, you're not the only one who's been through—'

To my immense surprise, he stood up and walked off. I watched him walk down the gravel path, away from Solace House and into the trees.

*Well, fuck you,* I thought. I had tried.

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## 22

43. Now, *effaced* designs, rank, evergreen, deep,  
Eden's maze: perverse, twisted, ingrowing.  
Of nullified nothingness; endless grief  
At That Ending Day of Undoing.

44. Let these empty rooms, in obsession reveal,  
Revelation, each book its retelling.  
Till his last undertaking, mythologized, ideal,  
Now opens up *something* indwelling.

I BEGAN TO SUSPECT the others weren't coming back, and had possibly gone to lunch. I was about to head after them, but some instinct – curiosity, perhaps, or even just the simple desire for solitude – got the better of me, and I decided to explore.

As so much of the house was off-limits, the gardens at the rear were the obvious choice. I followed a path, no more than a fox trail, that ran round the perimeter of the building, past a series of half-sunken, barred windows where a cellar might be. I knelt to peer through one of the windows but could see nothing.

At the rear of the house, what was once a large, well-tended ornamental garden had run to chaos, and now enormous shrubs, bushes and trees, captive Victorian garden favourites, had turned monstrous, gargantuan, shapeless. The back of the building was less imposing than the front façade, but not by much, and looking at the upper windows of the house, some edged with small panes of coloured glass, revealed that they were uniformly



choked with debris. *As above, I thought, so below.* The path gradually merged with a half-buried formal feature of the garden, a pathway of broken, root-riddled brickwork, green with moss.

What lay beyond this path had once been clear lawn, but was now a vast sea of tall grasses, stretching away for what must have been a hundred feet or more, from which rose isolated islands of dense bramble. At its far edge, this grass sea terminated in an impenetrable wood of dark evergreen foliage. The noise of insects was furious and constant. Next to my head, a dragonfly fizzed through the blue air in a diaphanous frenzy, the bright pattern on its fuselage older than the dinosaurs.

Traversing this space, I halted. There was movement in the long grass. The fox-brush tops of the ornamental grasses quivered, shedding tiny featherlike strands that drifted in the sunlight.

Something was coming towards me.

I froze. There was no time to hide, or even move. Was it an animal? What kind of animal would be large enough to sound like that? I found myself struggling to recall, off the top of my head, whether we had bears or wolves in England any more. I was still, absurdly, considering this, when Leo crashed out of the long grass.

‘You scared the life out of me, you weirdo!’ I said. ‘What are you doing back here?’

He shrugged. ‘What are *you* doing back here?’

‘I got bored of waiting for the others and decided to explore.’

He sniffed. ‘Well, there’s your answer.’ I nodded, conceding the point.

‘Anyway,’ he said, a note of almost childlike enthusiasm in his voice, ‘I found something. Come and see.’

Without warning, he bounded back into the long grass, heading for the trees. I hesitated for a second, then dived after him.



Leo was not intimidated, or even slowed, by the jungle the garden had become, and strode ahead of me at such speed I could barely keep up. Past a

headless sundial, past the bare wooden ribs of what had once been a greenhouse, comprehensively levelled from within by once-cultivated things that had become too gigantic and unruly to be contained. Eventually, the grass gave way to the wood, which I saw now was entirely composed of yew trees. All of the trees were of the same vintage, which made me suspect that they had been planted alongside the garden.

‘Great!’ I said flatly. ‘Trees.’

Leo seemed confused. ‘What? No. Not the bloody trees. Look!’ He pointed to a place just before the yews where the trunk of a large, long-dead oak lay rotting.

‘That?’ I said incredulously.

Leo nodded vigorously. ‘Oh yeah.’

‘Great,’ I said. ‘Cheers, Leo. If you hadn’t led me here I would never have seen that.’

‘No,’ he said, with a calm patience that made my reflexive sarcasm sound childish. ‘Look closer.’ I approached the enormous trunk, dark with damp and rot, but could see nothing.

‘Here.’ He pointed with the toe of his shoe. The wood had long ago started to deliquesce into the earth, crumbling into fragments in the process of becoming soil. On this black carpet stood many clumps of things I didn’t immediately recognize. Crowds of little beings, it seemed, like elves, all wearing curious wide-brimmed hats, wet-looking, coffee-coloured.

‘Mushrooms?’

‘Mushrooms.’ Carefully, Leo teased open the troop, revealing a mass of dirty-white stalks within, and pulled one up. In the stillness of the summer day, the stem made a minute but audible noise, as if voicing annoyance at being displaced. Between his thumb and forefinger, Leo held up an ugly-looking growth with a crooked stem and a large, wavy cap, shoe-leather brown.

I shrugged. ‘What am I looking at?’

‘*Psilocybe cyanescens*,’ he said. There was a delighted sparkle in his eyes.

‘Should I know what that is?’

He smiled knowingly.

*‘We must not look at goblin men, we must not buy their fruits. Who knows upon what soil they fed their hungry, thirsty roots?’*

‘Wait – are these magic mushrooms?’

‘Yeah, but not the ones you’ll be familiar with. Not *Psilocybe semilanceata*.’

‘Leo,’ I said, ‘drugs are interesting, but people who know lots about drugs tend to be among the most boring people on Earth. Just tell me what these are.’

‘So,’ said Leo. It wasn’t clear whether he’d heard me or not. ‘The usual magic mushrooms you get – Liberty Caps – grow in meadows, fields. They’re quite potent, but they don’t really get going until October. However, *these* little bastards’ – he indicated the scattered troops of smoky brown mushrooms falling over themselves to climb out of the damp wood – ‘these are *much* more powerful.’

I looked again at the crowd of mushrooms. There was something both comical and slightly sinister about them. ‘Are you sure about this? They’re not, like, Death Cap mushrooms or anything?’

‘Completely sure,’ said Leo. ‘I mean, I’ll do a spore test anyway, to be absolutely sure. The only truly weird thing about them is how early they are. We’re in the third week of July, yeah? They really shouldn’t be out until at least early August. But then, this whole place seems to have a kind of weird microclimate.’

‘Wow,’ I said. ‘Do you put as much care and attention into your degree as you do to getting high? Only if that’s the case, you’ll be looking at a double-starred first.’

Leo smiled. ‘Anyway,’ he snorted, ‘it’s funny you should mention Death Cap mushrooms because these are also the exact same conditions they like. Come September, I imagine the place will be swarming with those instead.’

I winced. ‘Please don’t confuse the two.’

Leo snorted. ‘No chance. Death Caps grow from a small ovoid structure called a—’

‘Leo,’ I said, ‘this was dull to start with, then it got interesting. Then – and I think you know this – it’s getting dull again.’

‘Suit yourself,’ said Leo. He dug in his overall pocket, shook out a plastic bag. ‘Anyway. I’m gonna pick a ton of these now, before anyone else does.’

‘I don’t think anyone else is going to be picking them, Leo.’ But I helped him pick them anyway.

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## 23

45. No virtue. A life entire, spent evanescing,  
To Earth's realm not anchored. *Lost* seer.  
Unheard, repressed; relentless obsession  
Under nights dark, endless, drear.
46. All ruin. Reach out, grasp at – nought. To perdition,  
Reach out. Jesus. Emmanuel. Christ.  
To purgatory, reach out. Postpone His execution –  
Cancelled. Your role unsacrificed.

AFTER EVERYONE TRICKLED back to the house, we returned to work, settling wordlessly into a familiar rhythm, a chain of fetch-and-carry; a human caterpillar, the head of which nibbled incessantly at the debris. Clive and I removed boxes and crates from the staircase, and brought them down the now-cleared first flight of stairs to the hallway, where Ella and Malcolm would determine if anything was worth keeping. The rejected rubbish was moved to the front door by Helen and Adam and then taken to the refuse pile by Leo and Ruth. It did not escape my attention that the two most awkward members of our little team – Helen and Adam – had ended up working together. I wondered what they found to talk about.

On and on it went. A large Bible, in Welsh, inscribed *Y BIBL* in big gold letters, a series of ornate brass things which folded, and might have been music stands or trivets, broken and mangled now beyond recognition; a box of women's shoes, beautiful once, now desiccated and twisted into the larvae of something unspeakable. Boxes of old cloth-bound books, which,

upon opening them, turned out to be volumes on scientific or mathematical topics, which chimed with what little we knew of Flayne's interests from the papers in the hall. All went downstairs, in boxes and crates, to be thrown onto the large pile outside, where they exploded in clouds of pale brown dust. The mound of paper and junk next to the house grew ever larger; any stray breeze would lift loose leaves of sheet music or abstruse calculation, sending them dancing over the weed-choked driveway. We found boxes of tools, mostly covered with rust: hammers, screwdrivers, planes.

Also, set carefully on one stair, we discovered a long-handled, double-headed tree axe. Clive removed the filthy leather cover to expose a virgin blade, both edges glimmering a long, wide, eager grin. Leo remarked that the double-headed axe, or *labrys*, was the root of the word *labyrinth*, and I found this pleasing. We took this axe, and the best of the tools we found, down to the bottom of the staircase and stashed them with our dust masks and first aid kit, in case they became useful.

---

We had almost cleared the stairs up to the first floor entirely when there was a scream from below.

The noise was shrill, untempered by any considerations of propriety or volume, and as such could only have come from Helen. Clive and I traipsed as fast as we safely could down the treacherous dust-fleeced stair carpet until we saw Helen's face. Tears of pain and anger welled in her eyes.

*'What did you do that for?'* she spat furiously.

*'Do what?'* said Clive. He looked genuinely puzzled.

*'Throw that thing at me!'* Helen was gripping her shoulder. *'You could have killed me!'*

*'I didn't throw anything!'* said Clive. *'What are you talking about?'*

*'Then who did?'* said Helen. She turned her furious gaze to me. *'Was it you?'*

*'No!'* I said. *'Sorry, what was thrown at you?'*

‘I don’t know, a stone or something.’ Helen peeled back her boiler suit and T-shirt to reveal her pale shoulder. And there, contrary to my expectations, an angry red mark was forming.

‘*It really hurt,*’ said Helen sincerely.

‘There,’ said Ella. ‘Down there.’ She got to her knees and rummaged in the dark. After a couple of seconds, she stood up, holding a large, shiny iron key.

‘Was that it?’ Ella held the key up. Unlike everything else we had encountered at Solace House, it was smooth and polished, not dusty. The head of the key was fashioned into a stylized twisted loop which at first I mistook for something floral, but on closer inspection resembled the mathematical symbol for infinity, an eight on its side.

Helen fixed Clive with a stare that could melt glass. ‘Why would you throw that at me?’ she shouted, as if suddenly remembering to be angry.

‘I didn’t!’ said Clive. ‘Honestly, Helen, I wouldn’t. It’s no secret you drive me up the wall, but I’m not about to start chucking stuff at you, especially something that size, which would really hurt.’

‘It *did*.’ Helen rubbed her shoulder again, but looked away.

‘Maybe it got dislodged,’ I said. ‘Maybe it was stashed away upstairs, and all our banging around disturbed it.’

Helen shook her head. ‘It was *thrown* at me.’ She glared at Clive again. Clive, bored of Helen’s accusations, rolled his eyes and exhaled.

‘Whatever,’ he said. ‘If you want to blame me, Helen, go ahead. But I didn’t throw it, honestly. I may be a prick sometimes, but I’m not stupid. Or cruel.’

Helen did not answer. She simply walked out of the house, through the tiled hall, and into the sunlight.

‘I mean,’ said Clive, shouting after her, ‘if I *had* thrown it, I’d have gone for your head!’

Distantly, the front door slammed. Leo shrugged, and slipped the key into his pocket.

---

The day wore on. Lunchtime came, meaning that Jilly Cowie came over and distributed sandwiches, which we ate outside on the stone steps. Of the incident with the key, nothing else was said: Helen consumed her sandwich in scalded silence, shooting the occasional glare at Clive, who merely rolled his eyes. Of the stuff we had salvaged that morning, Jilly elected to keep only a spherical glass paperweight with a large moth inside, and a painted plaster statue of the Virgin Mary and the Infant Christ. Everything else was brought back and thrown onto the tumulus.

‘I’m impressed,’ said Jilly. ‘We’ve got a good system going here! I think we’re really moving now!’

*You haven’t moved anything*, I thought, but kept it to myself. The day was very hot now, probably the warmest we’d had. The constant chatter of nearby birds could be heard, and, far above, the faint whisper of the trees. It seemed insane to think that there might, within the next couple of years, be a student population here; facilities, a campus, a bus to take them into town. It seemed unlikelier still that Solace House could somehow be forced into participating in this scheme.

‘Ready?’ said Ella, at length. She stood up and stretched.

‘Think so,’ I said. ‘I’m actually looking forward to this afternoon, now we’ve reached the first floor landing.’

‘It’s called a *gallery*, not a landing,’ smiled Ella. ‘Didn’t you learn anything from your awful posh friends?’

‘Landing, gallery, don’t care. The next bit of the house that isn’t stairs. Either way – we get to see some of the actual rooms.’

‘*Well*,’ said Jilly, in an almost scolding voice. ‘I’d rather you kept exploration to a minimum, if you wouldn’t mind. Our objective is to clear the staircase, all the way to the attic. Only then can we start on the rooms. So, keep going along the, erm, gallery – until we hit the next set of steps upward. So the house doesn’t fall down, remember?’

‘Yes,’ muttered Adam, his face turned away. He mumbled something that was either *Good for us* or *God forbid*.

---



Jilly left us after lunch, saying she had to go into town to run a few errands, and would we be alright here for a couple of hours? In light of how regularly she excused herself to do God knew what, I found this amusing. After she left, I half-expected us all to down tools and stop entirely, but there was something about being so close to the private chambers of the house that compelled us to carry on, even, perhaps, to work a little faster than usual. Clive wanted some fresh air, and so I found myself working with Helen, which was mildly intolerable. She sang showtunes to herself inside her dust mask as she worked, or passed banalities on each and every object she picked up. *Why would anyone buy a hat like this?* she'd say, or *Why would anyone need so many books?* Or *My nana used to have shoes like this.* It was as if she were on autopilot, keeping her at a baseline of irritation to other people while her mind was elsewhere.

As Helen meandered her way abstractedly through 'Cabaret', we finally broke through onto the first floor landing.

There was just as much junk here, of course, but there was something we could now recognize as the Flayne Method to it all, a conscious choice in how the rubbish was stacked. There was, as usual, a slim channel through the clutter, leading to the end of the first landing and turning a corner; along the way, this pathway broke off to reveal channels to three doors, but only the first two were accessible, the rubbish piles nearest the third door having collapsed. I shoved my dust mask down to my neck, took my gloves off, put my sweaty fingers in my mouth and whistled for the others. Helen put her fingers in her ears theatrically and grimaced.

'What are you doing?'

'Calling the others,' I said. 'They're going to want to see this.'

'What, the rooms? Jilly was very clear. We haven't even started clearing the landing yet! We have to carry on.'

'Aren't you curious, Helen?' I said. 'Just a tiny bit curious as to what went on here? What happened to Flayne, why he ended up living like this?'

She shook her head so hard her cheeks wobbled. 'A man went mad here, that's all I know. And all I *need* to know.'

‘You’re not at all interested as to *why*?’ I could hear the others ascending the echoing emptiness of the first flight of stairs.

‘No, I am not,’ she said, folding her arms. ‘Why on earth would anyone be interested in such a thing? It’s morbid.’

‘Well, I’m game,’ said Leo. ‘Anyway, no-one’s suggesting we clear the rooms out, Helen. We just go in, have a look around.’

Helen still looked pained at this deviation from the Cowie Plan, but it was clear that the rest of us had already made up our minds. We’d been in this house for two days, and yet – incredibly – hadn’t set foot in any rooms other than the hallway and the staircase, barring my own investigation of Flayne’s quarters.

As the rest of us crowded behind him, Leo grasped the handle of the first door and turned it.

## 24

47. Instead, now, our universe, shifted, adjusted –  
Not granted unto it, salvation.  
His ideas now strange weapons, evil entrusted.  
Twice, now, entwined: sick *sensation*.

48. Everywhere near, strange hours reign. Our urges  
Drive evil *dreams*, Daedalian.  
Of thief, hag, coward, or nymph courageous,  
Erlking – Imp – Tatterdemalion.

THE FIRST ROOM was a disappointment.

It was filled, floor to ceiling, with teetering piles of the exact same variety of junk that we had spent two days removing from the staircase and the hallway. The only palpable difference was the light: single sheets of ancient newspaper had been taped over the windows, so the daylight that did break through felt diffuse and somehow soiled. The walls, as far as we could make out, were panelled: at the bottom of two of the piles was the corpse of another chaise longue, crushed like a bug under the weight of things heaped on it.

Elsewhere, the mouth of a colossal fireplace was choked with more bric-a-brac; the grate itself obscured by piles of books, which turned out to all be about mathematics. In the centre of the fireplace was set a coat of arms which, like much else at Solace House, looked like something from a Victorian picture book rather than a real object. The colours had faded, but it was still both pretty and vulgar, all reds and golds and blues, the edges

chipped off in places. The coat of arms held a harp, a dragon, an Alpha and an Omega symbol. I was suddenly overwhelmed by an acute feeling of disappointment. Maybe the most obvious, most disappointing solution was, after all, the correct one, and Flayne had been, after all, simply a common or garden madman. Maybe all the rooms would be the same as the staircase, the hallway, his quarters: stuffed with junk, with no rhyme or reason for its collection or curation, no underlying purpose behind any of it.

Just as I was thinking this, I heard Clive's gleeful voice from the other room.

'Come and look at *this*.'



The most notable feature of this new chamber was absence. The room was not empty, but none of the junk here came up higher than knee-height.

As in the first room, the windows had been pasted over with newspaper, but the wallpaper here was gold and shone with a dull lustre. Laid out neatly on the floor were piles of crockery, arranged in dusty, teetering towers all the way across the floor, to the tall windows; piles of coffee cups like spinal columns, low stacks of gilt-edged plates, large, ornate spouted vessels for pouring. Laid out like this, the room looked like a model city, an impression reinforced by the lanes and pathways left between each individual dinner service. The sudden contrast from the cramped and stuffed interiors everywhere else in the house was head-spinning.

'Yay,' said Ruth, in her usual deadpan. 'Crockery.'

'Not that.' Clive was seated at the far side of the room. '*These*.' Behind him, on a marble-topped dressing table, sat a stack of what appeared to be ledgers and several old shoeboxes. As Clive turned the page of the ledger in his lap, I saw that the page was filled with photographs.

'Albums!' said Malcolm. 'You found photos!'

'Photos of Mr Flayne?' I was excited. It would be quite something to behold the face of the man who had devised this unique prison.

'Erm,' said Clive, 'that's just it, really. Who can say?'

‘What do you mean, *who can say?*’ I marched through the main street of the crockery city towards him.

Clive shrugged, proffered the album to me. ‘See for yourself.’

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The verso page was blank, but the recto page held a formal sepia photograph of a man, clearly a studio portrait. A scrawled note below gave the sitter’s name.

He wore a suit and tie, with a carefully folded handkerchief in his top pocket. His face, however, had been entirely scratched out, and painted over in oils. And so, a new face stared out from the page.

A vaguely caprine, elongated, satyr-like thing, with two dark eyes that had been very carefully rendered so that they appeared to hold an inhuman amount of concentration and energy. These eyes blazed either side of a long, pale snout; there was no mouth. Large goatlike horns curled around the face. Held to the chin was one very long hand, the digits almost impossibly slender.

And this was Edwin Flayne.

‘Why would he paint over a picture of himself like this?’ I asked, staring at the satyr-thing. Clive shook his head as he handed me a stack of photographs from the shoebox. His voice was almost a whisper.

*‘They’re all like this.’*

In awed hush, we began to flick through the albums, the loose photos inside the boxes. On every single photo, with absolutely no exceptions, Mr Flayne’s face had been carefully scratched out and painted over, always with that same satyr-like, non-human face. Even the oldest photos, showing Flayne as a child, ankle deep in a stream or river, trousers rolled up around his knees, had been subject to the same treatment, and the same non-human, animal visage that Flayne had chosen stared out at us, at posterity.

The only physical characteristic of Mr Flayne that was properly discernible was his body, at all stages of his life tall and thin; and his hands, which were, in all the photos, almost unnaturally elongated, with long thin

fingers. They looked very much like the restless, tireless hands of someone who would paint their own face out of history, or build a gigantic castle of rubbish. The hands seemed almost to vibrate with energy. Even in a photograph, I half-expected them to twitch.

‘This is so *creepy*,’ said Helen. Clive sighed heavily, but she didn’t notice. ‘Why would anyone do this to their own face? Destroy it like that?’

Ella pursed her lips in thought. ‘He didn’t so much destroy it as... choose another one. Maybe this was the face he preferred. Maybe this was how he saw himself.’

We were silent for a minute, after that. It was a perturbing thought, to curate your future so that the only way you would ever be remembered was like this, as a thing not human.

‘Has anyone found a passport?’ said Clive. ‘I want to see if he defaced that too.’

‘Look around you,’ said Malcolm. ‘Is this the house of a man who listed “Foreign travel” among his hobbies?’

‘Must have taken time, though,’ said Ruth. ‘Scratching out his face and repainting it in every single picture.’

Leo shrugged. ‘Time wasn’t a problem for him, really, was it? He had more of it than anyone alive.’

Ella, absorbed in one of the largest and most battered volumes, exhaled sharply.

‘Here’s his parents.’

These photos were evidently much earlier, the photography much cruder. All of the photos were variations of the same family group. A stern-looking Victorian man with a very neat beard and moustache looked straight down the lens of the camera, his gaze a challenge. Next to him, a very beautiful, kind-faced woman dandled a baby on her knee.

The face of their baby, however, had the by-now familiar goatish, elongated features, only here painted as if the goat-face itself were also that of an infant; hornless, with wide, guileless eyes.

‘What do we do now?’ said Ruth.

‘About these?’ said Malcolm. ‘Not a lot we *can* do, is there, apart from try to forget we’ve ever seen them, and get on with our lives.’

I looked around us. ‘More pragmatically, all of this crockery will have to be recorded, numbered, taken back to Marshlands. Every single bit. It’ll take bloody ages. Jilly Cowie’s going to want that, if she sees it. So, for the time being, I suggest we just seal this place back up. Pretend we were never here.’

No-one disagreed. The photos were returned to the dresser, respectfully stacked in roughly the same order we’d found them.

Everyone filed out, apart from Adam.

He stood, unmoving, looking down at the photograph of the family group, staring at it intently, as if he were peering into the bottom of a well.

‘Adam?’ I said. He looked up, confused, but said nothing, closed the album and placed it on the marble dressing table. He walked out of the room slowly, not really conscious of my presence.

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The third room was impassable, the doorway choked with rubbish, so we stacked some of Flayne’s junk against the doors of the two rooms we’d entered, creating the impression we’d ignored them, in case Jilly Cowie dropped by. And then, we went back to Marshlands.

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That night, I did try to forget what I’d seen in those albums and put it behind me. Yet I couldn’t, and somehow, I knew no-one else could either.

Solace House had given up a tangible secret, and we were all curious now.

## 25

49. Our unimportant restless lives, inane:  
Fragments endless time imbibes.  
My existence – so laborious, a bane –  
offers up rare auguries, signs:
50. Such insights, *grand* narratives, truths half-expressed –  
Now eyes vast and subtle invoke.  
Vacant earth, disinterred: empty space, ill-repressed;  
Eden's entreaty, now smoke.

NEXT MORNING, however, any prospect of further exploration was thwarted by the unexpected presence of Jilly Cowie, who arrived early. Apparently, she had been asked to produce a short report for the university governing body on our progress so far and wanted to spend the day at what she inevitably called *The Coal Face*. And so, we ignored the tantalizing third door, and, turning a corner, pushed further along the upper gallery, in the human chain formation we'd now refined to an art.

I was posted outside, in the morning, with Malcolm, so couldn't see what was happening inside. Although the day felt cool, the sunlight was strong, and we had to cover our arms and faces in sunblock, from a first aid kit Jilly had brought over on our first day here. After lunch, with Jilly obstinately refusing at this critical moment to be somewhere else, I was transferred to the front of the line, working alongside Ruth to remove clutter from the next stretch of the gallery, all the way to the next flight of stairs.



Disappointingly, all of the rooms there were already open, their doors pressed against walls by the familiar stacks and piles. This, however, simply served to whet my curiosity more; I couldn't help but wonder that the third room on the first floor was closed for a very good reason.

For the final third of the day, I stayed at the top of the house and worked with Ella, which I rapidly discovered was a fun back-and-forth tennis match of sarcastic comments about things we unearthed. She also told me that – just as I had found – Solace House reminded her of something, but what that thing could be eluded her.

---

I don't know who suggested the bonfire. Maybe it was all of us: the sudden realization that it was actually Friday afternoon, out there in the world beyond Solace House, the world where time hadn't stopped. Or, more likely, the bonfire happened organically, as at 5 p.m., Jilly Cowie left us, only to reappear bumping a wooden handcart along the rutted path, carrying two six packs of beer that she'd bought to toast the first full week of work at Solace House.

Or maybe, after a string of intense days of controlled fetch-and-carry, we just wanted to burn things.

The day was still baking hot and drinking beer on an empty stomach meant we were all slightly buzzed slightly too quickly. Jilly's presence made the whole thing awkward, as if this were school and we were getting tipsy alongside a teacher, but she stayed precisely as long as it took to drink a single beer, and no longer, marching back to her quarters at Marshlands, as she was packing to go climbing that weekend. Which left all of us, after the hit of that first can of beer, alone with a huge quantity of flammable refuse we'd spent all week removing from the house. Looked at that way, the bonfire was inevitable.

It began as a discussion, as we stood around drinking in our boiler suits, and then pretty soon some of us were rolling up bits of Mr Flayne's precious hoard, while others scoured the nearby woods for twigs and logs.

Surprisingly, it was Helen who came into her own here, instructing us not to pick up twigs and kindling from the ground, as it would inevitably hold damp, and instead to snap it from dead branches of living trees, where it would be completely dry and aired. While Leo, Adam, Ella, Helen and I did this, Ruth, Malcolm and Clive went back to Marshlands, commandeering Jilly Cowie's handcart, to fetch things we could cook over a fire, some utensils, and as much alcohol as they could carry.

---

Leo, Adam and Helen were off in the woods somewhere, their exact positions marked by the occasional snap of dead branches. I was screwing up bits of Flayne's newspaper collection and throwing them onto the beginnings of a blaze when Ella sat down next to me.

'Here,' she said, shoving a sheet of paper under my nose, 'look at this.'

The page had clearly been torn from a large notebook; the paper was ruled with faint blue lines. Written across it, in neat black fountain pen, was verse.

'What is it?'

'Just read it.'

∞

*No dimension is a dot,  
A circle, spot or stain  
Or flyspeck point; it matters not:  
It lacks a single plane.  
One dimension is a line,  
Simple, straight and clean.  
Two simple vectors we define;  
And each point in between.  
Two dimensions is a square  
Of width and length possessed,  
But viewed end-on, it isn't there:  
It lacks essential breadth.  
Three dimensions is a cube –  
A shape with values three  
Like a cone, a brick, a tube –*

*And also you and me.  
Four dimensions: tesseract.  
As cubes are like to squares.  
It boggles human intellect –  
Naught in our world compares.  
Then, five dimensions? Twenty-three?  
Complexity runs riot;  
Ascending exponentially  
In step with our disquiet.  
Endless, myriad, umpteen!  
Our minds reject the thought  
Of infinite extents, unseen –  
We pray that God's does not.*

‘Wow,’ I said. ‘Beware of the doggerel.’

She smiled. ‘I know, right?’

‘Curiouser and curiouser. What are you going to do with it?’

‘Duh,’ said Ella. ‘Keep it, *obviously*.’

‘You think Flayne wrote it?’

Ella looked up at the house, looming over us in the blue dusk;  
ailluminated with flame.

‘Who else? Don’t tell the others.’

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## 26

51. Until resurrection, Elohim's vengeance assuring,  
Let it die, and to Earth's embrace *melt*.  
Proof that you – righteous endeavour abhorring –  
See only now in night's grandeur, yourself.
52. O, untrustworthy edifice, *now*, Solace House!  
Realizing its near endless ambition,  
Scriptural record, elliptical, shouts,  
Prayers of no sapient expression.

THE FOOD WAS, of course, pretty terrible, and we cooked it badly, but none of us seemed to mind. We ended up eating hot dogs and burgers, wrapped in toasted bread as we didn't have any baps or hot dog buns. What the food lacked in quality was made up for in quantity: we made far too much. Ella, as the sole vegetarian, wrapped corn cobs and potatoes in parcels of silver foil, and let them heat slowly in the ashes, then melted butter and salt onto them. She also confessed to Adam that the cheese she'd brought over to melt into the potatoes was actually his, protesting that she'd left him a note. And it was all, suddenly, delightful: even Adam seemed to forget his default state of constant wary nervousness and uncoil a little. The evening stayed warm, and we unbuttoned our boiler suits to the waist, the top halves hanging from us like partially shed skin. When we'd eaten our fill, the paper plates were thrown onto the fire, where the grease on them sizzled and spat. And then, without any of us realizing it had arrived, it was night,

the glowing fire illuminating the vast edifice of Solace House as it climbed to the stars above us.

At first, we talked about banalities, Ella's presence as a newcomer forcing us to revisit where we were from, where we went to school. It didn't escape my notice that Ella was evasive on both of these subjects, whereas Adam just smiled his peculiar smile and muttered single-word answers. I, however, was more relaxed than I had been in weeks, and when I was asked why I couldn't go back to stay with my parents, my usual defences were not in place.

I let slip that they were both dead.

'I'm sorry,' said Helen, in a heartfelt tone. 'How awful for you.'

'It is what it is,' I said. What more was there to say?

'What did they die of?' said Clive conversationally, as if we were discussing the weather.

'Clive!' snapped Ruth. 'You can't ask that!'

Clive shrugged. 'I just did?'

'No, it's fine,' I said. 'Honestly. They died of typhus. Sounds crazy, in this day and age, but there it is.'

Everyone, even Clive, let the subject drop after that. But Ella looked at me suspiciously, through narrowed eyes.



Helen, complaining about sitting around in her boiler suit, returned to Marshlands for a shower and an early night, which meant the rest of us were able to relax even more. The conversation drifted to things we wanted to share our enthusiasm for; bands, songs, movies, comedy we liked. Leo poked a toasting fork into the fire, turned the glowing orange logs, and carefully positioned some fresh ones over them, which caught immediately. Between his lips was a joint that Clive had rolled. He passed it to Ruth, and had to nudge her to take it, as she was absorbed in staring up at the house.

'Are we really worried there might be corpses in there?' she said, with nothing in her voice other than curiosity.

Clive, lying on his back like some lazing species of beached pinniped, took a drag on a cigarette before answering.

‘Who knows? Maybe Flayne had some weird mutant offspring he kept chained up in a secret room.’

‘The Royal Family have one of those, don’t they?’ said Malcolm. ‘Doesn’t seem to bother them.’

Ella laughed. ‘Not sure how factually correct that is, Malcolm.’

‘Maybe *he* was the mutant offspring,’ said Leo. ‘Edwin Flayne. Maybe the creepy face he painted on those pictures was an improvement on his real face.’

Ruth was still gazing up at the house. It was as if this was the first opportunity she’d had to properly think about it, and what it meant.

‘How do you think a person gets like that?’

‘What, mad?’ said Malcolm.

‘Yeah, but mad in that particular way.’

‘Well,’ said Malcolm. He took the joint from Ruth, pulled on it, then exhaled luxuriously. He was a beautiful smoker; he smoked like a 1950s movie pinup. ‘If my great-aunt was anything to go by, one day you just don’t throw something away. A matchbox or something, some little insignificant thing. You just can’t bear to let go of it. And the next week you’ve got a small pile of newspapers and three matchboxes, but you still don’t think anything of it. And that’s how it starts, without you really noticing.’

Ruth stared into the fire. ‘I’m not sure. I mean, I’m sure it does happen like that, but...’ Her voice trailed off as she looked up at the house once more. ‘It doesn’t just start, does it? You’d have to have lost something very precious before the idea of losing anything became intolerable to you.’

Silence fell as we stared into the fire, all wondering the same thing. What did Mr Flayne lose?

Ella, holding the joint, inhaled sharply. ‘Fuck!’ she said. ‘I remember what this place reminds me of now. *The Fairy Feller’s Master-Stroke*.’

‘The what?’ I said.

‘A painting,’ she said. ‘By Richard Dadd.’

‘I don’t know who that is.’

‘An artist. Brilliant, but insane. He killed his father.’

‘Nominative determinism at its best,’ said Clive, from the ground. I could hear the smirk in his voice.

‘Yeah, I guess someone had to say it,’ said Ella. ‘Someone always does. But yeah, he painted a few things, but he’s best known for this one... image, this picture crammed with, like, *insane* detail. It’s a fairy splitting a hazelnut, or about to, with an axe. He never finished it, although he worked on it constantly for years, in the asylum they put him in, adding detail after detail.’

‘Wait a minute,’ said Clive. ‘I know this painting. Led Zeppelin wrote a song about it.’

Ella shrugged ‘I didn’t know that. Anyway, to any ordinary person the painting looks not just finished, but *over-finished*. The detail on it is staggering. It’s only a small canvas, but it absolutely *swarms*. The condition’s called *horror vacui* – an abhorrence of empty spaces.’

‘So you think that’s what Flayne had?’ I said. ‘A horror of empty spaces?’

Ella laughed. ‘How much empty space do you see in that house?’

I laughed. ‘Good point.’

‘I can’t be the only one who’s heard the Zeppelin song,’ said Clive. ‘Leo?’

Leo shrugged. ‘Don’t ask me. My ancient history only goes back as far as the Stone Age.’

‘Oi!’ said Clive. ‘I’m twenty-six, you cheeky fucker!’

‘Exactly,’ said Leo.

‘Point is,’ said Ella, ‘Dadd was a genius, in his way. I wonder if Edwin Flayne had any kind of creative outlet for his madness.’

I thought of the poem that Ella had found and shown to me, and we exchanged glances. From the floor, Clive snorted derisively.

‘Let’s face it,’ he said. ‘Flayne probably just belonged to the much larger set of mad people who are just, y’know, fucking *mad*, and don’t even get any art out of it.’

---

The conversation drifted to Leo's speciality: the Neolithic monuments of Britain, and the people who built them. Again, Leo asserted to Ella, he believed in interpreting the evidence *in situ*.

'Which means,' said Clive, who hadn't moved from the ground, 'for the benefit of our newcomer, that he gets stoned, among the standing stones.'

'No,' said Leo. Then, after a couple of seconds, 'Well, yes. But you can't understand a prehistoric people unless you get inside their heads.' He stirred the fire. 'To do that, you have to be – as they were. Free from the written word, from the clock. Free from ideas like *money* and *status*.'

'Way ahead of you there,' belched Clive.

Leo laughed, but his expression was serious. 'You have to – bridge that gulf. Between us and them. That way, you can recover their secrets.'

'But why, though?' said Malcolm. 'Why bother?'

'Because rediscovering these ideas, right now, is vital,' Leo said. 'The next fifty years or so will determine whether the human race survives and evolves. And what *must* happen, if we're going to survive, is a reconnection to those ideas the ancients held sacred. Call it the New Age, the return of Gaian Consciousness. Terence McKenna calls it the Archaic Revival.'

'Sorry, who?' said Ruth.

'Terence McKenna,' said Leo. 'He's a philosopher and ethnobotanist.'

'Wait, I know that name,' said Malcolm. 'Wasn't he on that Shamen album? The one with bloody "Ebenezer Goode" on it?'

Leo either didn't hear or ignored him. Clive's hand came up from the floor holding the joint, and Leo took it.

'Basically, that we have to relearn our ancestors' perspective. All those old ideas which have shackled humanity and poisoned the planet must go. And so, the next few years will – *must*, if we're to survive – see a huge rise in socialist ideas, feminism, redefining gender roles, redistribution of wealth, a switch to a greener planetary consciousness. These ideas will dominate not just this decade, but the coming millennium. You can already see the beginnings of it in popular culture. Our raves are tribal; even our



rock bands, now, are feminized, vulnerable. Look at Nirvana. Everywhere, the old world is coming apart.'

'*The future is female,*' said Ella. Clive made a noise.

'Precisely,' said Leo. 'The goddess, rising. A complete re-evaluation of human priorities.'

'*Yeeeeeah,*' said Clive. 'This is just the Sixties, though, isn't it? Repackaged for the ecstasy generation. It won't happen.'

'It has to,' said Leo. He looked into the fire. 'Or we're doomed.'

'Alright.' Ella's tone was poised between scepticism and interest. 'So you're visiting these ancient sites, high as all fuck. What tangible things have you discovered, using this method, that someone else couldn't?'

Leo didn't answer for a few seconds. I realized he was gathering his faculties for the challenge of acquitting himself.

'Okay. You know Avebury?'

Ella smiled. 'I do not.'

'It's the biggest stone circle in Europe. There's a whole village inside it. And these aren't like Stonehenge stones, they're not shaped or anything. They're just enormous stones, raised up in a rough circle. They've been messed about with every which way in the centuries since they were originally put there, but the basic pattern remains.'

'So I went there last year, a week after midsummer. I chose the time deliberately, because the place gets packed then, weekend druids and crusties and New Age travellers.'

'*Fascinating,*' cut in Clive. 'One pseudo-intellectual, being discerning about other pseudo-intellectuals.' Ella shushed him.

'But a week later it's back to the usual trickle of tourists. It had rained the week before I went, like, *really* rained, the fields around were flooded. Silbury Hill was an island. I took a small dose of mushrooms and walked around, among the stones, alone. The moon was bright, and the path along the raised earthwork appeared luminous white, and I realized that it was because of the rain – the chalk showing through.'

'Chalk?' said Ruth.

‘Yeah. The whole of Wiltshire, pretty much, is chalk. It was practically glowing under the moonlight, all this fluorescent mud... I looked at it for a few minutes... and then it hit me.

‘I picked up a handful of the white mud, and smeared it onto the nearest stone, as smoothly as I could. And then... the rock was glowing, too, in the moonlight. I wanted to paint the whole stone like that, but it would have taken me hours. Which led me to realize...

‘There was a community that lived at those stones, and they used them to predict the patterns of the sun and moon. Didn’t it make sense, then, that at certain events of astronomical significance, like midsummer, the whole community would mix that white mud, all together, men, women, children, and *paint the stones with it*, so they shone brilliant white under the moon, dazzling white under the sun? For that special season, that holy week of midsummer?’

No-one spoke. We were all under Leo’s spell. He didn’t look at us, simply stirred the glowing ashes once more.

‘Maybe it was something they did at Stonehenge too. Maybe they refreshed it every year, at certain times. Maybe they painted the stones different colours for different seasons, blood red in autumn, charcoal-black in midwinter, to stand out against the snow. Maybe once the chalk was on the stones, they painted patterns onto them. Maybe individual stones were painted to reflect the individual personalities they were perceived to have. But even if *all* of that is conjecture, the chalk thing seems very, very likely to me. Or it certainly did in that moment. It felt entirely *natural*.’

Still no-one spoke; we were all entirely captivated by this idea. And it was plain that Leo wasn’t saying all this because he felt it would impress us. This was something he earnestly believed, a revelation he had earned, retrieving it from the distant past like a diver plucking a pearl from the seabed.

Moments of genuine emotion in a generation as cynical as ours held their own fascination, and we were quietly spellbound.

In the silence that followed, Leo suddenly seemed embarrassed, as if he’d just given up too much of himself to people who were – ultimately –

strangers. He excused himself and padded back to Marshlands.

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‘He talks a good one, doesn’t he?’ said Clive, as soon as he’d left.

Ruth laughed. ‘You’re so cynical!’

‘Oh, there’s no doubt he believes what he says. And I’m absolutely certain he’ll get a dazzling academic career out of it. But it’s all conjecture, isn’t it? Completely unprovable, and therefore pseudoscience. You can’t seek out knowledge with *feelings*.’

‘Have you ever told *him* this?’ I asked.

‘I’ve tried,’ said Clive. He sighed deeply. ‘Trust me, I’ve tried.’

---

‘Hmmm,’ said Ella, coming to find me as we made our way back to the house. Her tone implied something was dubious, suspect. ‘*Hmmmmmm*.’

‘What’s your problem?’

‘That story about your parents. Both died of typhus, huh?’

I nodded, but couldn’t suppress a guilty grin.

‘That’s *Jane Eyre*,’ she said. ‘What really happened to your parents?’

‘Honestly? My father was killed by a falling beam,’ I said, ‘and my mother died of fever.’

She narrowed her eyes, scrutinizing my expression, and evidently found the insincerity she was looking for. ‘No, hang on, that’s *Heidi*. What happened to your parents?’

I looked grave.

‘We were coming home from the theatre and we were robbed. They were...’ I paused, as if to collect myself. ‘They were both killed in front of me.’

Ella stared at me with her arms folded until a guilty smirk seemed to claim my whole face.

‘That’s frigging *Batman*! What really happened to your parents?’

‘I’ll tell you someday,’ I said.

‘Will you?’

‘I will,’ I said. ‘Promise.’

We walked back to Marshlands.

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## 27

53. Tatters of hell's esteem, all vile enterprise.

Now lets you live, angrily, wrathfully.

Your emotions arise; *all* labyrinths, lies.

Coiled rings encircling atrocity.

54. Tragedy, in our name. Thus, His extravagant

Scheme expands, roots in damnation.

Dark limbs extend skyward; eyes now forced open,

Rereading *cursed* exaltations.

WE WERE ALL HUNG-OVER to varying degrees the next day, with the obvious exception of Helen, but as it was Saturday we didn't have to wake up early or report to Solace House or, indeed, do anything whatsoever. Jilly Cowie had already left at the crack of dawn for the long drive to join her mountaineering club, and the fact of her absence was a palpable relief.

Around lunchtime, Malcolm threw a bag into his red Volkswagen Golf, and said he was going into town and wouldn't be back until tomorrow.

'Not tempted to stay here then?' smiled Ruth. 'Too good for the likes of us?'

Malcolm looked at her with mock severity. 'Ruth. I am a very, very beautiful gay man of nineteen years of age. I think we can all agree that me staying in this dump on a perfectly good weekend, instead of going out clubbing, would basically be a crime against humanity.' He asked if any of us wanted a lift into town; to his obvious horror, Helen said she did. Fifteen minutes later they left together, Helen already holding forth inexhaustibly

on something, Malcolm staring ahead in blank terror, knuckles white on the steering wheel.

---

It soon became obvious to the rest of us that if we weren't working, there was very little else to do.

Someone found three wrought-iron garden chairs and an accompanying table, so we placed these in the meadow, with Clive, Ruth and Leo sitting in them and Adam and I sprawled on a blanket on the grass. Clive suggested bringing his stereo outside, but no-one could agree on what music to play, so in the end we just sat.

Normally, I'd have been quite happy to lie around on a lawn, maybe get stoned on Clive's dope, read, sleep, simply pass the time. But one consequence of my incarceration at The Ridge had been the realization that inactivity bored me, and probably always had. Amethyst's oft-described perfect summer of doing nothing but slowly tanning on a sun lounger had always faintly repulsed me. I preferred to be occupied. I recognized now that this was a coping mechanism, a strategy of seeking endless distraction so I didn't have to think about the Last Day, didn't have to process it, and could pretend – with, it has to be said, some degree of success – that it had never happened. Whatever its cause, lying spread on the grass soon became intolerable, and I went back inside the cool bulk of Marshlands, half-wondering if it was too early to start drinking again, and if that would even help.

Sun-blind from the dazzling day, I almost walked straight into Ella in the darkened lobby. She was wearing her boiler suit.

‘Where the fuck are you going?’

‘Where the fuck do you think?’

‘What the fuck *for*?’

She smiled. ‘You're not curious? After finding those photos? To see what's in that third room?’

‘Not so curious that I want to work at the weekend.’

‘Yeah,’ she said, with scorn. ‘‘Cos there’s so much else to do around here. Face it, Lane, you’re as curious as I am, but you’re just trying to be cool, or detached, or maintain an ironic distance or whatever. But you’re the same as me. You’re itching to know.’

She was completely correct, of course; I was all set to cling to my pretence of being indifferent to the matter, but what was the point? I did want to know.

‘I’ll come with you.’

Ella looked pleased. ‘Ah, I knew it! I’m not hanging around for you here, though, while you get changed. I’ll meet you over there.’



Five minutes later, feeling oddly self-conscious to be wearing work clothes when everyone else except Ruth was wearing shorts and a T-shirt, I left the front door of Marshlands.

‘You as well?’ said Clive. He was wearing a Hawaiian shirt, open, showing his ample stomach. ‘Christ, you two aren’t going to go and have sex over there, are you?’ I saw Adam, some way away, noticeably flinch at this remark.

‘Why?’ I said, immediately switching into a mode of response that Clive would engage with. ‘You wanna watch?’

‘God no. I’ve just had my lunch.’

‘Well, there you go.’

‘Seriously, what are you gonna do over there?’ said Ruth.

I decided to use Ella’s line of reasoning. ‘You’re not curious? About what else is in that house? You don’t want to find out?’

Clive closed his eyes and tipped back on the rear legs of his chair. ‘When I’m not being paid to? Nope.’

I shrugged. ‘I just want to see.’



Ella proposed that we simply cleared our way to the third door, carrying all the debris outside, and putting aside anything potentially valuable, just as if today were a normal working day. If the contents of the room were interesting or shed any light on Flayne's life and exile, we'd stop and examine them. If what we found was just yet more piles of paper, we agreed to call it quits and head back to Marshlands.

To save time, we decided to carve out the thinnest path possible, allowing only one person in at a time; in practical terms, this meant that Ella removed the piles of junk, placing them at the top of the staircase, and I took them downstairs, dumping them in the main hallway below. The stairway had become stiflingly hot, and the sweat streamed off us; we both undid the top halves of our boiler suits, tying the empty sleeves at our waist.

As we stopped to catch our breath, the jarring, jeering sound of the distant, trapped telephone jangled through the stale air. We both stopped working to peer over the banister into the dark hallway below.

A figure stood down there, in the gloom, staring up at us.

'*Jesus Christ!*' Ella gasped, one hand clutching her chest. The phone stopped ringing.

'Adam?'

'*Hey,*' came the whispered reply.

'Why are you here?' I asked, sounding more hostile than I'd intended.

'I want to know,' he said. 'I want to know what's in this house, the same as you. I want to see what's in that next room.'

Ella and I exchanged shrugs.

'Sure,' said Ella eventually, 'why not?' before turning to mutter to me, '*I mean, it's not like we can stop him.*'



It took the three of us about twenty minutes to break through to the third room. We began with the time-honoured fetch-and-carry method, passing stacks of rubbish along the cramped aisle and down the stairs, but after a few minutes of this, we simply cut the Gordian knot and sent the piles of



paper over the banister, to thunder or flutter to the floor below. Adam eventually drifted downstairs and began organizing this litter of documents into some kind of order, presumably working on the assumption that one of these notes might divulge something important. And so, when we did eventually break through to the door, only Ella and I were present. The door was exactly as the other two had been: fussy, mock medieval, with an elaborate brass doorknob set onto an equally elaborate brass plate.

Ella turned the doorknob, and the door, defying all expectations, clicked smoothly open.

The door swung ajar to about six inches, then hit something inside the room with a dull thud.

‘Ah,’ I said. ‘That’ll be the heavily foreshadowed pile of corpses.’

‘And guess who’ll have to clear those away?’ Ella tutted, exhaling through her teeth. ‘*Bloody typical.*’ Pushed together by the mountains of detritus in the perpetual twilight of the house, the heat of her breath warmed my face. I was suddenly conscious of how close together the cramped house had forced Ella and me to stand. Her face was all I could see.

‘Hold this.’ She handed me the torch, then pushed, experimentally at first, then with all her might. The door scraped and juddered reluctantly, but Ella kept pushing until there was enough space to allow a person through.

She darted inside, and I followed.

‘Holy shit,’ said Ella, as we stood and stared. ‘Ho-ly *shit.*’

## 28

55. Books of rhyme. Nonsense odes, foolish rhapsody –  
    *Each* lunatic essay narrating,  
    That labyrinth, endless. Sectary, see!  
    Now, a text unread, recreating.

56. Every syllable now exploits, elides, deceives.  
    O, *false* words! His evil trespasses,  
    His envious rage, endless anger, released  
    That hurts, long years after; still pierces!

THE THIRD ROOM was entirely empty, entirely clear and free of junk; the door proved to have simply been obstructed by the frayed edge of a nailed-down carpet that age, decay and moths had swollen into a thick wad.

The emptiness of the room was shocking enough in itself, but it was also clean, relatively speaking. The dust covering the carpeted floor was of a uniform thickness, indicating that the room was very much as Flayne had left it. As in the previous two rooms, the windows were again plastered with ancient newspaper, dried brown and crisp by years of sunlight.

Enhancing the idea that we were entering a pharaoh's tomb, the wallpaper was blue with gold leaf; the suppressed sunlight that beaded the edges of the windows made the gilded pattern dance like the skin of a cuttlefish. Ella dragged the faded gold velvet curtains fully open and tore some of the newspaper down. Sunlight poured in for the first time in decades; dust swirled in the sunbeams like plankton in seawater. The

windows, like all those on the first two floors, were barred, covered over with a frame of ornate wrought-iron vines.

The only item of furniture in the room was a tall black bookcase.

All the shelves apart from the upper two were empty. These top shelves held a series of books, or ledgers, large, thick, grand things bound in leather. The ones on the top were dark brown and occupied the entire length of the shelf. The shelf below was only a quarter full, and the ledgers it held – six or so of them – were all black, apart from the last one, which was a deep red.

We exchanged glances, and I reached up to the top shelf. At random, I selected one of the dark brown volumes and opened it. The page was filled with manic copperplate handwriting, slanting forward as if hurtling towards something. I read the first words I saw:

*Humans are but HAUNTED MEAT*

I blinked; the words were so strange, the utter confidence with which they had been written so entire, that the effect of reading them was disorienting.

*Spirit is refined through tragedy. We become the thing we are meant to be not through great works, but by the damage inflicted upon us by circumstance. This is the way of the world. That dusty threshing ground. It must be transcended.*

‘That poem I found,’ said Ella. ‘It’s the same handwriting.’

We looked at each other. Ella’s eyes were wide and bright.

‘It’s Flayne’s.’

‘Every single page is like this,’ I said, flicking through the volume. I replaced it, and Ella removed the very last of the brown volumes, at the far left.

In one smooth movement, she took this final volume, and the red one, and stuffed them into her rucksack.

‘What are you doing?’

She smiled. ‘I earned this. Whatever happened here, to Flayne, I want to know about it first.’

‘What have you found?’ said Adam, at the doorway.

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*‘My father, having no ideas of his own, dedicated his life to honouring a scheme which was not his; enacting the stale dictates of industry and commerce, an act I judge to be profane. In this act, you take something divine, placed in its setting by God, like a tree or an animal or a mineral ore, and you turn it into a thing, something oppressive or fearful, a physical manifestation of man’s most brutish urges, his most grotesque and absurd fantasies about himself; a gun or a cannon or a warship; or merely a trinket. Overwhelmingly, this process involves taking living things and turning them into dead things. This act is the opposite of magic, the opposite of nature. And now the overwhelming extent of human activity is this act, this un-magical process, this de-witching, this dis-spiriting, this BLASPHEMY—*

*‘Rationalism is dark alchemy.*

*‘I reject the imposition of man’s “order” on the world.’*

*‘Well, that explains the garden,’ I said. Ella shushed me, turned the page and kept reading aloud.*

*‘My mother was different. She believed in – and knew – a different realm of existence, adjacent to this one, stacked atop or beneath, without or within, this meagre shadow vale, worlds beyond our senses. She was of the eternal, Exalted Realm, which she first glimpsed when a child. She was five years old, on her way home, walking along a country lane with her mother. She was eating an apple—’*

*‘Okay. So it’s... his diary?’ said Adam slowly. ‘Or his autobiography? Or his philosophical manifesto?’*

*‘Hard to tell,’ said Ella. ‘All of them, probably.’ She replaced the volume and selected the last brown ledger on the right, the penultimate one, before the one she’d stashed in her bag, and read.*

*‘All artefacts are diagnostic of their creator.*

*‘Therefore, examination of this world reveals the mind of the demiurge. You can extrapolate God from His world, and if you do that, you will plainly see His method, His character, revealed.*

*‘God loves the labyrinth, the maze. He has replicated it everywhere, and places His mazes within mazes, within mazes, nesting each order of being within another.*

*‘This is the shape of the universe.*

*‘Maze inside maze inside maze inside maze.*

*‘He has placed this signature on everything, from the smallest subatomic spark to the largest galaxy. And most tellingly, He has imprinted the labyrinth on every human brain. Thus, every mind in creation has on it the signature of God, the pattern that is the mark of the divine, His Maker’s mark.*

*‘AS ABOVE, SO BELOW. Every thing that perceives, must do so through its own maze.’*

*‘Well,’ I said. ‘A clear arc begins to suggests itself.’*

*Ella smiled with delight. ‘Oh yes.’*

She turned to the very last page. And there were words that might have been the root of the matter, the autobiography that Flayne strived his whole life to write, condensed to six short words:

*I have left the human race.*

*‘Perfect,’ she breathed.*

*‘What about the black volumes?’ said Adam.*

*‘Good question,’ I said. ‘Where the fuck did he go from there?’ Adam reached for the nearest of the five black ledgers, but before he could grasp it, there was a creaking noise outside.*

*We all froze.*

*I opened my mouth to speak, but, from somewhere in the great house, we heard a low moaning.*

*‘Shit,’ whispered Ella, her face pale. ‘Did you hear that?’*

*We were entirely motionless. The stillness of the house was the stillness between the ticks of a great clock; a silence deeper than humans could fathom. We strained to listen, and then, another noise, unmistakably a voice, gasped something between a plea and an invocation.*

*‘ELLLLLLLLLLLLLLLLLLLA,’ it said.*

We stared at each other, eyes wide.  
'AAAAAAAAAALLLEEEEXX,' it said.  
Then, abruptly, it started to laugh.  
'Clive!' I shouted. 'You fucking dick.'

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## 29

57. I read; and truth is obscured. No secret code,  
Or underhand *ruse* shall erase her.  
Eden's labyrinth lies in Solace's hold;  
All illuminating my saviour.

58. Could a resolute vision's earnestness,  
This rite unsound ever inspire?  
Nakedly doth excess ego dismiss,  
*Our* blessed salvation entire.

'GONNA GIVE YOU TWO a chance to decouple and put your clothes back on,' Clive's voice boomed from outside the room. 'Wouldn't be my first choice of where to bone, but hey, no judgement. Whatever gets you there. Coming in in five, four, three...'

Quick as I could, I grabbed the five black volumes and shoved them into Ella's rucksack, alongside the other two. In the space of another split second, Ella took the rucksack from me and zipped it closed, before throwing it into a corner. It landed just as Clive barged in, hands theatrically over his eyes.

'Two... one!'

'Shut up, Clive, you tit,' said Ruth, following him in. 'Sorry, guys. We got bored. Well, *I* did. Goths aren't natural sunbathers. Anyway, we wanted to see what you were up to.' She looked around her. 'Oh, hi, Adam.'

'When did you come over?' said Clive. Adam scratched the back of his neck and looked embarrassed, a wallflower lurking at the edges of a school

disco, but Clive's attention was already on this strange new chamber we'd breached.

'Shit, look at this place! It's empty!'

'You don't mind us joining you, do you?' Leo clattered through the door. 'What have you found?'

'Volumes,' said Ella, 'diaries, journals. I'm not sure what you'd call them. Anyway, get this – they're the complete thoughts of Edwin Flayne, formerly of this parish.' Ella, apparently absent-mindedly, trailed a finger in the dust on the shelf beneath, to remove any trace that there had been other volumes there. She performed this small deceit in a perfectly natural way; you'd only know it was there if you were looking. It made me wonder what else she concealed, in plain sight.

'Holy crap,' said Leo, scanning the lines of handwritten text. 'Do we get an explanation? As to... how he got like he was?'

I laughed. 'If anything, there's too much in the way of explanation. Too much in the way of everything.'

'Really,' said Clive flatly. 'Well, well, imagine that. Edwin Flayne, owner and curator of *this* house – generating a hyperabundance of something. Well, well.'

Ruth smiled, running an index finger along the spines of the notebooks.

'Flayne's World,' she said wonderingly. Then, hearing herself say those words out loud, grinned, and said, in her sardonic, playful voice, '*Flayne's World. Flayne's World. Party Time. Excellent!*'

---

*'My name is Edwin Flayne.*

*'The story of my life must begin with the story of my mother, as it is her fate that has decided mine. It is fair to say that she was, to me, the brightest star in all the heavens.*

*'It galls me here to speak of her in the past tense, but it is correct so to do, as she is gone from us now.*



*‘My mother was all to me, as I was all to her; a paired confederacy, a nation with only two citizens. I, to her – her only child! – was the very shining sun itself from which originated all energies, all life. And I know this for incontrovertible fact, for it is also what she was to me.*

*‘My father, by contrast, for all his worldly wealth, was little more than an instrument, animated, and even then, barely, by the second-hand philosophy of his age, a philosophy he was never moved to question. To him, the way things were was the way they must always have been, and always would be. He was of English aristocratic stock; which is to say, a person of excellent manners and breeding, of strong character, yet with absolutely nothing in the way of imagination, nor any incentive, his entire long life, to cultivate any. Generations of Flaynes before him had lived much the same stolid inner life as he; how successful this view of the world was for those previous generations, and how well it helped them navigate a world essentially chaotic, is perhaps best demonstrated by my family’s long and persistent history of suicide.*

*‘My mother, on the other hand, was a diaphanous thing, one foot in this world, one in a different realm, the concentrated distillation of a long line of wildness. She had both Irish and Romany blood, both of which shaped her conception of the world. She loved art, and magic, and ideas; life itself. She consorted with the landscape as if it were a living thing, and she respected with the utmost gravity its tenants, both natural and supernatural. For her, the realms beyond were as real to her as the countryside itself, and as readily accessible, if one had but the mind to listen.*

*‘How she blazed, this woman I called my mother. How she shone!’*

Leo turned the page. We had all been absorbed in volumes of our own, but none had proved as engaging as the one Leo had found, which seemed a straightforward attempt at autobiography.

He read on, and his eyes widened.

‘Oh my God,’ he said.

‘What?’

‘Fucking hell.’

‘What?’ I shouted, in mock exasperation.

He glanced sideways, across the room, to where Ella was. Smiling, he held the page open for her, and pointed.

‘Flayne’s mother, look. Her name.’

We looked to where his fingertip sat.

‘*Her name was Ella.*’

---

Ella peered at the book, shuttling between an inability to process the coincidence and open amusement at it.

‘*El-la*,’ she said eventually, as if the word were strange to her.

‘And listen to this,’ said Leo. ‘She was, Flayne says, *tall, with red hair*. Like you!’

‘That settles it,’ said Ella. ‘I am the reincarnation of a dead Victorian woman. I mean, that’s just hard science, right?’

‘It is a mad coincidence,’ said Clive. ‘You have to admit that.’ Ella made a sceptical sound.

‘Same red hair,’ I said evenly, determined to wind her up.

‘Yeah, my hair is dyed,’ said Ella. ‘Close but no cigar.’

‘Tall?’ I said.

‘Anyone’d be tall in these boots.’

‘Wait, maybe you’re her *ghost*?’ smirked Clive. ‘I mean, you did just turn up out of the blue. And we’ve only ever seen you around the house!’

‘Dude, she was literally on my course,’ muttered Ruth.

‘Shit, I’m right,’ said Clive, ignoring Ruth. ‘Oh my God, you’re a fucking ghost!’

Ella smiled. ‘If I punch you in the face, really hard, would that prove I wasn’t?’ Clive laughed. And we were all amused by it, in that moment, the weirdness of it. All of us, apart from Adam. Adam simply sat, an open volume of Flayne’s writings in front of him, and stared at Ella even more intently than he had done previously. As if an insubstantial supposition had now hardened into something else entirely.

His eyes glittered.



## 30

59. Rarefied *vision*, experiencing naught  
Of bland life's exhausting concerns.  
Here, returning, in solitary thought,  
Is all Nothing, and No-one, deserves.
60. Logic and magic, enlightenment nears.  
*This* light of our knowledge, occult.  
Now, understood. Now, harvest of long years  
Spelt out. Lost art's calling. Exult!

LEO CONTINUED READING.

*'This house is called Solace House. It was my father's name for it, but my mother and I knew it by different names: Sometimes XANADU, sometimes ARCADIA, UTOPIA, sometimes ELYSIUM.*

*'But most often, and most fondly, EDEN.*

*'For her, I have no doubt that it was.*

*'It was she who found this place. Or, this place found her.*

*'The story she told me went thus: she had been visiting a friend, and was travelling by carriage through the countryside, en route to the railway station some twenty miles distant, to continue on to London, when she heard voices. Voices – like tiny silver bells – singing, and laughing, and calling her name over and over again, ELLA, ELLA, ELLA, she heard them say.*

*'She instructed the driver to stop. The voices came again, ELLA, ELLA, ELLA, and she formed the impression they emanated from a small wood nearby. Eschewing any fear, she made her way through the trees.*

*‘All the while, she said, the voices sang to her.*

*‘Once through the wood, she discovered the principal features of the location, bordered now by the garden: the small lake, the marshes and the rock face beyond.’*

‘What lake?’ said Clive. Everyone shushed him.

*‘An idyll, unsullied by man’s brutish touch. Mother, gifted with the second sight, knew at once, in the very marrow of her bones, that this was a place of the most profound and hallowed significance. The first word she breathed there was the name by which she would know the place henceforth: Eden.*

*‘My mother knew, then, that it would be her earthly task to be custodian of this place. She saw, and knew, that it was a Thin Place, where nature schemes a complex union with the higher realms, and intersects with the unseen places.*

*‘And so, when my father bought the land, she had the pond widened and deepened, and carefully selected the plants, shrubs and trees that grew there. The yellow irises that shade the water; the purple loosestrife that proliferates everywhere – all the plants that flourish there now are descended from seeds sown by her own hands.’*

‘Wait,’ said Ella. ‘Is he describing what the garden looked like before everybody lost interest?’

I shrugged. ‘Could be.’ The garden was severely overgrown; any one of the larger clumps of bramble could conceal a pond, or the remnant of one. I recalled the dragonfly I’d seen; it had to have come from somewhere.

*‘She chose the plants not merely to encourage nature, but to encourage that part of nature which is mostly hidden from mankind. Complex creatures, who do not see as we see; fairies, elves, dryads, call them what you will. She herself would give them no names, she simply built for them a refuge.’*

‘This is astounding,’ said Leo. ‘I mean, you see this kind of thing in the work of Robert Kirk, but it reflects a much older—’

‘Oh God, he’s off,’ said Clive. ‘Someone else read, or we’ll never get through it.’

‘I was merely saying—’ Leo began, but Ruth deftly removed the book from him. She found the place Leo had got up to and resumed reading.

*‘Always, my father – Abel Flayne – saw things differently. Where Ella saw magic, he simply saw a space where a grand house might be built. It was a convenient location, not excessively far from the railway station, and London, but secluded enough to bring sufficient tranquillity.*

*‘And so, while my mother busied herself with the garden, my father built Solace House.*

*‘In addition to the house, however, another structure was built. My mother recognized that the cave, which she had encountered on her first visit to the place, was a thing of great power and age, as the carvings on the wall confirmed.’*

‘Wait a minute,’ said Leo. ‘Cave? Carvings?’

‘Cave?! Carvings?!’ mimicked Clive breathlessly. ‘Do you, like, instantly have an erection?’

‘Shut up!’ Leo laughed. ‘Where is the cave, though? What is he talking about?’

‘Where’s the pond, for that matter?’ said Clive. ‘The lake?’

‘And the rock face?’ whispered Adam.

‘Maybe the cave’s in the cellar,’ I ventured. ‘And that’s why the house is where it is.’

‘Great,’ snorted Clive. ‘I’ll look forward to investigating the cellar, when we get to it, thirty years from now.’

‘Settle down, children,’ said Ella. ‘Ruth?’

Ruth cleared her throat, carried on reading.

*‘The cave was the focus of the place, and my mother felt it needed to be honoured. She wished to call the temple built to contain it EDEN, but Father overruled her, calling it instead BEWISE, a single word made from two other words, the family motto, authored by his own father.*

*‘BEWISE it was, and BEWISE it became.*

*‘The cave became imprisoned then, contained by mathematical stone, smothered in classical proportion. Only years later did I see this for what it was: my father, with his usual smallness, his inflexible dependence on rules,*

*striving always to contain my mother's essence, which was elemental, and of the earth.*

*'It is an ancient struggle, perhaps the only struggle humans ever engage in, and although I failed to appreciate its subtleties as a child, even a symbol as obvious as this one could not elude me forever.'*

---

We spent another forty-five minutes reading all we could of Flayne's journals. All the while, I thought of the final volume, concealed in Ella's rucksack, along with the strange black volumes and that singular red one; but I would have to take this matter up with her later. In the meantime, by and by, through scraps and fragments, we began to build up a patchwork biography of both Flayne and his parents.

These passages of personal history proved easy to spot; his handwriting was much more legible when he was recounting incidents from his own life, rather than detailing his singular philosophy, at which point his handwriting was apt to become scrawl, racing headlong across the page to keep pace with his hurtling thoughts.

The more we read, the more the impression that Ella was the complete opposite of her oppressive, stern, archetypal late-Victorian husband only strengthened. She was quite the bohemian, and, from what we could gather, was, in social attitudes, very well ahead of her time. She taught Edwin that all love was love, that men and women of all races were created equal, that all life was sacred and that we must live in harmony with it. She painted and drew, she sang, she played the piano. She was an inveterate nudist; she would frequently garden at Solace House bare-breasted, to her husband's fury.

It seemed remarkable that Ella and Abel had ever even met, let alone married, but it was plain from the portraits we'd seen in the photo albums that she had been a great beauty. At one point, fired by curiosity, I went next door to retrieve one of the albums, so I could look again at this singular woman. Her eyes had a sardonic, evaluating quality, as if she were bemused

by the photographer's gaze, the camera's gaze, perhaps the gaze of men in general.

Ella – our Ella – was delighted to note that her namesake, despite sharing her height and hair colour, looked absolutely nothing like her.

The job of raising Edwin fell to Ella, and she took to it with gusto. He recalled running round as an infant naked, or painted in woad, with a headdress made of feathers found in the garden, discarded splendour from jays and magpies. He never called her *Mother* – Ella instructed him at all times to address her by her first name, as if they were equals. She was Ella; to him, to everyone. She seemed, from Flayne's endless descriptions of her, as vibrant and luminous a person as it was possible for a human to be, and her love for the things she loved – nature, the gardens, her son – seemed boundless.

It was Ruth who found the passages about her disappearance.



# 31

61. Here, our unending sacrifice ever occurs,  
Bliss's *sweet* embrace, resplendent.  
Vast endlessness rages, as Solace House recurs  
Ever vital, ever lost, a testament.

62. It offers no solace, insures no serenity.  
And new endings bring excruciation,  
Now terrible, lost, our erroneous divinity  
Experiencing no *satiation*.

*'MY MOTHER HAD SECRETS, as we all do, but married to a man like my father, I imagine it was her secrets which kept her sane.*

*'I have no clear memory of when I first became aware that she was enjoying the attentions of a man other than Father. I have a dim recollection of her telling me she was happier than she had ever been because of her new friend, that he was an artist who lived in London, and that one day he might meet us, and we might, one day, go to live with him; but how old I was when this conversation took place is lost to time. When I asked her, what of Papa?, she assumed a grave expression, and said that talks of this nature must not be shared with Father, ever. I loved her, so I obeyed.*

*'She would frequently go and visit this artist at weekends in his studio in London – she never mentioned where – and would return on Sunday nights. As far as Father was concerned, she was visiting her sister, but eventually,*

even this charade was not maintained. Ella despised deception, and towards the end she barely bothered to conceal the affair.

*‘And then one day, my mother was gone. She simply vanished.’*

*‘She left for the capital, and never returned. I was eleven years old at the time. There was some conjecture in the few newspapers that bothered to report it that she had eloped with her lover, the artist, whose identity was unknown to me, and not mentioned in any of the articles. This story, false though it was, became the prevailing narrative. An unfaithful, wanton wife left her husband and son, and fled to the Continent.’*

*‘Why do I not believe this version of events, why have I never believed it?’*

*‘For one simple reason:*

*‘She would never have abandoned me.’*

There was silence after Ruth read this aloud.

This, then, was the absence, the black hole that underpinned everything at Solace House, the great loss which meant that Edwin Flayne would never knowingly lose anything ever again; would cling to stasis, to stagnation, as a siege tactic against the brute vandalism of unexpected, violent change. Growing old here, guarding a legacy only he could recall, becoming incrementally more insane, jealously guarding his castle of priceless rubbish, like a mad king in a fairy tale.

---

*‘What then?’ asked Ella, after a while.*

Ruth traced a finger along the lines of script.

*‘Mother had always made sure that Solace House was the happiest of all places, but without her presence, the place decayed, became gloomy and stale.’*

Clive glanced around him. *‘No shit.’*

*‘The curtains were drawn, and stayed drawn; the very air inside the house grew fetid. My father took to drink, and soon became a horrifying presence around the house, weeping and howling in his grief at all hours of*

*the day and night. The more unmanageable he became, the more we found it harder to find staff, and to retain the staff we had, and after four years, leading up to my fifteenth birthday, Father had driven all but the servants of sturdiest constitution from the house.'*

Eventually, Abel sold his stake in his mining business, which left him a very, very wealthy man – and remained in Solace House, drinking and mourning his lost wife, surrounded by a skeleton staff of trusted employees.

In 1909, the Flaynes – Edwin by this point only nineteen, and more or less running the place – were approached about the possibility of selling some of their estate, the nearby marsh, in order to build a home for the mentally distressed. Edwin, acting on behalf of his father, agreed to sell the land, which was then drained. The Flaynes also made a very generous donation to the hospital, which, when finished, was named Marshlands. It opened in 1911.

During this time, the gardens at Solace House were still maintained and the place stayed relatively well kept, although Abel Flayne drank more and more, and became ever more of a recluse. Edwin – apparently entirely ignorant of any Oedipal implications, just as he seemed ignorant of the brash new century around him – trained to become an artist, largely through a series of private tutors who came to the house (the idea of enrolling at a formal art college seems to have eluded him, or possibly the idea of leaving the house was, even by that early stage, unthinkable). At some point in spring 1914, aged twenty-four, he returned from sketching the gardens, falling and breaking his leg, badly enough to leave him with a permanent limp. The timing of this, as Flayne himself notes, was *ultimately revealed as divinely fortuitous*: it meant that, when the time came, Edwin was unfit for active service when war broke out. In this way, Flayne Senior, too old and too mad, and Flayne Junior, too lame and too mad, were both spared the horrors of the Great War.

The war ended, and Marshlands, previously a sparsely attended refuge for a few distressed veterans of campaigns such as the Boer War, became full to capacity with those traumatized by the catastrophe unfolding across Europe. Thereafter, Marshlands didn't have to justify its existence, and was

no longer seen as a rich man's charitable indulgence. There were enough people haunted by what they'd seen in the trenches to fill Marshlands many times over.

In 1924, Abel died, taking weeks to succumb after a massive stroke left him bedridden. Doctors summoned to the house told him he would be better off in hospital, but Abel refused to leave. He spent the days before his death ranting and raving, and, as Edwin put it, *'telling me all the secret, terrible workings of his inmost heart, so that by the end, there was nothing familiar left of him, when he finally expired. He was a stranger to me.'*

(I experienced a twinge of almost physical pain on hearing this. For a second my eyes stung with sudden tears, but I wiped them away. I thought nobody saw, but Adam glanced at me, the ghost of a smirk on his lips.)

After this ending, a beginning; Edwin inherited Solace House, his father's vast wealth, and the servants, including the cook, maids and gardeners. Large portions of the house, unused, fell into neglect.

Sometime later, one of the domestic staff, her nerves afflicted, began to see visions about the house, people who were not there. Though she was referred to Marshlands for treatment, her condition worsened, and one night, out on the lawn, screaming in terror at the empty summer sky, she attempted to slash her wrists. The attempt was as pitiful as it was short-lived, and no major damage was done.

As a result of this, however, Flayne fired all his staff, which left him alone in Solace House.

And so, his odyssey of loneliness began.



These were the facts, the history of Flayne's life.

However, Flayne's journey, in a sense, was only just beginning. The house fell into disarray, the garden grew wild. And Flayne – alone, neither needing nor desiring contact with the human race – began in earnest to accrue possessions he didn't need, books and magazines he would never read, antiques and bric-a-brac he ordered by telephone, all of it delivered to

the house in prodigious quantities. He began to barricade himself into the house where, after years of strange solitude, he would eventually die.

Ruth closed the book, and we sat in silence for a while, as if she'd just completed reading some apocalyptic piece of scripture.

---

'This is absolutely incredible,' said Leo eventually.

'Sad, though,' said Ruth. 'One missing, the other two mad in her absence.'

'How did Abel and Ella ever get married in the first place?' said Ella. 'He was such a... Victorian. Such a rationalist. Even his business was, what was it? Mining. Taking minerals from the earth, and putting them into service for the good of the British Empire. She was his polar opposite. It was like they were from different worlds.'

'Maybe that's what made it work,' said Adam wistfully.

I read aloud from one of the volumes. '*The cave and the house complement each other now, and there is Bewise, which forms a passage between the two.* What cave?' I said. 'And what the hell is Bewise?'

Clive looked blank. 'Not a fucking clue.'

Leo shrugged. 'Most likely something we haven't found yet. Another room, or another volume.' Without meaning to, I glanced over to Ella's rucksack, slumped on the floor.

'Still doesn't tell us what it is.'

Ruth read aloud from the volume in her lap. '*Between the lake and the cave, and Bewise – as befits their exalted status, and for symbolic value – was placed a hedge maze. I had the ground cleared, and yew trees planted to my design.*'

'No maze here,' said Clive.

'Wait – the garden!' said Leo. 'It's incredibly overgrown, but Alex and I made our way as far back as we could, and you just come up against a forest of yew trees. We assumed that's where the garden ended.'

'Good God!' I said. 'The yew forest. It's overgrown, now, but—'

‘It was a maze once,’ said Ella.

‘It’s a mess now,’ said Leo. ‘It would be difficult to get through it.’

Clive smiled. ‘What else do we have planned for this afternoon?’

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## 32

63. Lo, infinite mind, *in* time unremitting.  
No death endured, vast, obsolete.  
Unending time. Solace eternal, existing.  
Time hath elapsed, now: complete.
64. Eons fly, onwards run: this Hell's fate remains.  
Of mad usage. Now *His* anger, loud.  
Lost order within. Emerald diameters, lanes –  
Of nothing, grown in noxious ground.

ALONG THE FOX PATH that ran through the high grass, winding its way through the islands of isolated bramble patches. Past the rotten tree trunk where Leo had filled a plastic bag with enough magic mushrooms to render a dozen people catatonic. Onwards, to the lip of the yew wood, where the neat avenues of a maze had, over the past half-century or so, become forest, clustered so densely that it looked as if, even on this sunny day, it was night beneath them. The knowledge that the wood had once been orderly was of no use now; it didn't help to make sense of it. Jealously protective of their space, the yews had sent out limbs in all directions, drinking up any and all available sunlight, smothering everything below. The spaces beneath the trees were bare, filled only by a black velvety soil where nothing grew.

Leo, however, did not even break stride as he approached the treeline, and, ducking under a branch, vanished in a rustling shimmer of deep dark green. I shrugged, pushed aside the cool, springy branches, and, with a feeling of being submerged, dived in after him.

Far beneath the treetops, the ground was a tangle of roots and dead branches. In a way, the maze that had been here had persisted, discovering in neglect a new way to express its original purpose. Some of the bushes had thrived, becoming trees, starving or throttling their neighbours, while some had clumped together in groups of two, three or even four, growing as one, the dead branches beneath coated with moss so thick they resembled seashore rocks covered with seaweed. Giant roots sprawled over the maze's floor, in some places looping violently up from the ground, like caterpillars frozen in motion. Leo jumped confidently and purposefully through this chaos as the rest of us scrambled to keep up.

'Where are we headed?' I gasped, as I almost fell over one of the larger roots. Leo pointed. About fifty yards away, the sun shone through the branches, and whatever lay beyond it was a strip of vivid lush green. We tripped and scurried towards it.

Leo had been first into the wood, and he was first out, climbing out of the fringes ahead of me. Whatever he saw beyond the trees made him stop abruptly.

'What is it?' I said. 'What?'

Leo simply walked off, and I stumbled after him, into the verdant brightness.

---

Everything was vivid, alive.

There was a shimmering lake, or large pond, of bright black water in which spots of sunlight danced, and lily pads floated in profusion. The shallows were thick with reeds and rushes, and at the water's edge grew overhanging trees, and great excesses of giant gunnera, leaves as casually huge and expansive as golfing umbrellas. Between and around these great green parasols grew masses of horsetail, three feet high in some places, while behind all of this botanical fervour rose a steep limestone cliff – the southern edge of the nearby hill, almost a vertical face – screening this tiny, perfect, secret valley from the world.



The marshy earth spoke in bubbles when you walked on it, issuing a stream of silver beads like a sigh, and I remembered, and realized: this must be the exact place that Ella Flayne had encountered long ago, when the place called her name. Everywhere damselflies and dragonflies zipped and swooped in the still, warm air. The sunshine seemed brighter here.

‘So that’s what’s at the back of the property,’ muttered Ruth. ‘The carboniferous period.’

No-one commented further: she was right. All of Solace House exuded an aura of stopped time, but this place was of a different order of things altogether. It felt as if we had suddenly and accidentally slipped from historical time into what geologists call *deep time*, or even more horrifyingly, *abyssal time*, where years must be measured in terms openly antagonistic to the human mind; *eons*, *epochs*, *ages*.

‘We should buy the place,’ I said. ‘In 350 million years, this’ll all be oil. We’ll be rich.’ We were all making jokes now, to deflect and diffuse the unearthly atmosphere. Our voices sounded small in this place; the calm, centuries deep, ignored us.

‘Oh!’ Ruth gasped. She pointed towards the limestone cliff. ‘Look!’

Against the rock face, utterly surreal in this primordial environment, stood a stone structure, a folly or temple or summerhouse. It was small, unspectacular, clearly of the same vintage as the main property, or near enough, but entirely made of stone. It was mostly neoclassical: three wide steps led up to a stone portico where a triangular pediment was supported by six Doric columns, giving access to a single open chamber with a domed, circular roof.

At one point the structure must have been bone white, which would have made its presence here even more jarring, but over the years the building had acquired a discreet camouflage of green algae, which made it seem as if it had grown spontaneously from its environment. Leo was already halfway there, and I jogged after him, feet bouncing on the springy earth.

Below the pediment, carved into the central stone, were two words:

Malcolm stared upwards, his beautiful face screwed up in concentration. 'What does that mean?'

'*Be Sapient,*' said Adam. 'Or something like that. My Latin's pretty rusty. It isn't the greatest Latin anyway, I think it should actually be *sapere*, but—'

'Or,' exclaimed Leo, his eyes wide, 'to put it another way—'

'Oh my God!' said Ella. 'This is it, isn't it?'

'What?' said Clive. 'I don't follow.'

Ella, smiling, pointed up at the two-word motto and smiled.

'*Be Wise.*'

---

In a strangely respectful silence, as if we were entering a church or other sacred space, we climbed the steps and went inside.

My suspicion that the structure had been vaguely modelled on the Pantheon in Rome was confirmed by the design of the dome. Like the Pantheon, this building had a large hole in its scalp to admit light, and so the interior, although gloomy, was not dark, as I'd imagined. Once inside, my eyes quickly grew accustomed to the half-light.

My gaze was drawn, naturally, to the rear of the chamber: the middle third of the wall was absent, was simply darkness. My eyes strained to see. Where my initial impression had been of nothingness, a void, I could see a raw rock face and vague hints of a tunnel stretching away into the side of the hill. All of this was completely enclosed by a cage of iron bars, in which a gate was set.

The gate was locked.

'*Good God!*' breathed Ella, behind me. 'This was the cave he was going on about!' She tried the gate, turning the brass handle, then grabbing the bars of the iron cage and shaking them. Solid and resolute as the rock face itself, they did not budge.

‘Now *what*,’ said Clive carefully, standing alongside her, his words flat and blunt in the small chamber, ‘do you imagine is in *there*?’

‘Dead bodies!’ said Ruth. ‘Fucking *finally*.’

‘Treasure,’ said Ella. ‘The Holy Grail. King Arthur and his Knights. A gateway to faeryland. Either way, it doesn’t matter. We’re not getting past that lock any time soon.’

‘*Guys*.’ Adam’s whisper was louder in this place, amplified. He was in the centre of the chamber, studying the floor. ‘Come and look at this.’

---

At first the design of the tiles appeared to be merely a central square, bordered by a large maze, but as we approached, I could see that the central square was a maze also, with another maze set into its centre, and so on. The mazes got smaller and more detailed until finally – with tiles so small they must surely have been laid with tweezers – the maze bordered a large central tile, on which was written the legend:

ELLA LILLIAN FLAYNE

1862–

GONE FROM US NOW

*In my Father’s house are many mansions: if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you.*

*And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.*

John 14:2–3

‘A *memorial*,’ I breathed. ‘Flayne Senior’s memorial to Ella, after she ran off and left him.’

‘Given how much he detested her fairy nonsense, I can see why he didn’t commemorate her with just her initials,’ Clive muttered.

‘What?’ Ella peered again at the inscribed name, then snorted with amusement. ‘Ha! Oh yeah, I see what you mean.’

‘We need to have a look inside that cave,’ said Leo.

‘*You* do, you mean,’ said Clive. ‘I’m not going anywhere near it.’

‘We’d need bolt cutters,’ said Leo, tapping the iron bars thoughtfully. ‘Where would we get bolt cutters from?’

‘But we don’t need them, do we?’ said Adam. Again, I was shocked by how loud his voice seemed in this place. ‘Remember the key? The one Clive threw at Helen?’

‘I didn’t fucking throw anything at Helen!’ said Clive, outraged.

‘The key that fell, and *hit* Helen. The one with the infinity symbol on the head? Well, look.’

I strained to look at the place his finger indicated, at the lock plate. Inscribed into it was the same symbol, with the name of a locksmith’s below.

‘Bloody hell,’ said Ella. ‘Well spotted, Adam. Where *is* the key, though?’

‘In my room,’ said Leo. ‘I kept it as a souvenir.’ And he was already a silhouette, framed by the doorway against the brilliant day outside, as he headed off to fetch it.

## 33

65. *A*s *radiance* comes, at daybreak's ingress;  
As sunset numbs, and shade creates;  
E'en now thy great legacy, of regret  
Your reality unbinds, negates.

66. Your effort arcane, remunerated;  
Nihilicity, in nameless gloom.  
Memory and detail: now eradicated.  
So sayeth Utopia, *now* tomb.

IT WAS NO GREAT CHORE to wait, in that peaceful secret garden. One by one, we all surrendered and lay down on the mossy grass, as if overcome by some sweet narcotic.

Through the fathomless blue sky above us, metallic insects zipped and darted. Only Adam did not lie down, choosing instead to sit nearby, under the shade of a tree, perhaps mindful his pale flesh might burn. Faced with the terrifying prospect of five minutes of inactivity, Clive took the opportunity to roll a joint.

'This place is *amazing*,' said Ruth eventually. Her voice held none of her usual sarcasm. 'I can see why Ella Flayne wanted to build a house here.'

'Me too,' said Clive quietly. 'It's idyllic.' And his tone was also genuine. This place seemed to render cynicism – a second language to all of us – redundant.

‘It’s a shame the yew maze has gone feral,’ said Ruth. ‘I would have liked to have seen that.’

Ella sniffed. ‘Ah, yew trees creep me out. They’re symbols of death. They grow in churchyards.’

I laughed. ‘*That?* That’s the thing you’re choosing to freak out about, here, in the place where there’s a memorial to someone with the exact same first name as you?’

‘Pfff!’ said Ella dismissively. ‘It’s a very common name.’

‘You’re literally the first person I’ve ever met with that name.’

‘Me too,’ said Ruth. Adam looked up at us intently, but I couldn’t read his expression.

‘I like yew trees,’ said Clive. ‘I think they’re pretty. Isn’t that right, ladies?’

‘I beg your pardon?’ said Ella.

‘I was talking to the trees,’ said Clive. ‘They’re female.’

‘Jesus!’ Ella rolled her eyes. ‘Everyone here is a closet hippie.’

‘Techno-Pagan,’ said Ruth, smiling. ‘That’s how Leo describes himself.’

‘*Literally* just another term for hippie,’ said Ella firmly.

Clive sat up, one hand in salute to his brow, shielding his eyes from the sun. ‘Talk of the devil. Hey, Leo! You ever met anyone else called Ella?’

‘Nope,’ Leo said cheerfully. ‘What are you guys talking about?’

‘We were talking about yew trees,’ I said. ‘Ella doesn’t like them, because she says they’re symbols of death.’

Leo smiled. ‘True. But an older belief is that they’re symbols of eternal life, on account of their longevity.’

‘Wow,’ said Clive. ‘Who knew yews could simultaneously be both so controversial and so boring? Where’s the fucking key?’

Leo reached into his nylon rucksack. The key gleamed prodigiously in the sunlight, as if delighted it was finally home.

---

Leo also brought two torches from Marshlands; inside, he clicked his on, and gave me the other.

I was anxious. I had had more time to think about things at this point, about where we were, and where we were about to go, if Adam's guess about the key was correct. I had also had a toké on Clive's joint; the thought of being inside solid rock made real fear rise in me, and I had to work to suppress it.

At the iron bars, cemented into the rock face, Leo inserted the key into the lock. There was a moment where it seemed that time was suspended: I had no idea whether the key would work or not. It fitted perfectly, however, which meant a frisson of nervous excitement ran through all of us. Leo grunted as he attempted to turn it, but the key stayed where it was, as if the lock were welded shut.

'I anticipated this,' he muttered. He removed the key, rummaged in his rucksack and produced an aerosol can of WD-40 from our cleaning supplies, which he sprayed liberally into the keyhole until the lock oozed dark dirt from its seams, fizzing onto the concrete footing. He inserted the key again, which jiggled with a little more play, but still wouldn't turn.

'Anticipated this too.' He reached into his rucksack again and produced a yellow duster and a large heavy pair of pliers. He placed the cloth over the head of the key, clamped the pliers to it and very carefully began to apply pressure.

'The trick *here*,' he said through gritted teeth, 'is not to snap the key in the lock. Because then we really *are* fucked.' He let go of the pliers, removed the key and sprayed more WD-40 into the lock.

Ella smiled sardonically. 'The suspense is killing me.'

Leo inserted the key again and wrapped the cloth around it. His hand, tight around the pliers, sank decisively downward. Inside the lock, the mechanism clicked loudly, and the gate crawled away from us on howling hinges, coming to rest with a resounding clang against the rock face.

Leo shone his torch into the blackness. We could see, more clearly now, a rough tunnel, extending for twenty feet or so into the rock, before turning

sharply to the left. Cold air rose up to greet us, as if stirred by our invasion, cold air smelling faintly of damp, exuding an inhuman, mineral patience.

‘Right!’ said Leo. ‘So I’m going first?’

‘I’m not going anywhere,’ said Ella.

‘You claustrophobic? Because if that’s the case, you should go and wait up top.’

‘I’m not,’ said Ella curtly. ‘But I will. This place is just... not good vibes.’

‘Oh, vibes,’ I said. ‘Well, can’t argue with hard science like that. Anyone else not digging them vibes, man?’

Ella laughed. ‘Fuck you, idiot.’

‘I’m not going down there either,’ said Adam, his voice amplified still further by the cavern ahead of us. Initially, I wondered if he was leaving merely because Ella was, but there was genuine fear in his voice. ‘I really don’t like confined spaces.’

‘Okay,’ I said. ‘Only, stay within earshot, yeah? Just in case we need you.’

Adam’s face contorted in confusion; perhaps the concept of anyone needing him was so bizarre he couldn’t immediately make sense of it.

‘Why?’

‘Oh, I dunno.’ Clive’s voice, and its caustic edge, were strangely reassuring here. ‘In case one of us wins the Academy Award for best supporting actress. The fuck do you think, Adam? We’re about to explore an ancient cave under the ground. One of us might get stuck, or fall. There might be a cave-in. Who knows? Stay close.’

Despite this barrage of sarcasm, Adam simply nodded passively. Ella waved at us, managing to make the gesture itself ironic somehow. Adam, happy at last, it seemed, scampered after her.

‘Right,’ said Leo, staring ahead into the gloom of the cavern. ‘Here goes.’



## 34

67. O rapture and death, it *all* nothing connotes,  
Empty deeds. Actions with no import.  
Now grants each a rare truth, hides something remote,  
Else a pure object festers, unthought.

68. Now see a vision, each damned soul *observed*,  
Unto lying Solace betrothed,  
Each granted unceasing nightmare absurd.  
Now doth sanity's order erode.

JUST AS THE TANGLED ROOTS of the yew maze hadn't even slowed him down, the uneven floor of the cave didn't seem to bother Leo at all; neither did the solid rock ceiling which dipped and sagged at various points. Clive, Ruth and I, sharing one torch, stumbled along in his wake. At the sharp, left-hand turn, the tunnel became much smaller very quickly and began to slope downwards. As Leo vanished ahead of us, he kept talking, telling us what he was seeing and feeling, but in a very short while, his voice became inaudible, and there was just us, stumbling along, our anxious faces lit by torchlight. Eventually, I called for Leo to stop, and he emerged from a turning ahead of us, a sheepish expression on his face.

'You're going too fast,' I said.

'Yeah,' wheezed Clive. 'For some of us, this is our first visit to a terrifying unexplored cave.' As he spoke, the torchlight caught the steam of his breath, made it brilliant white.

'Sorry!' said Leo. 'I'm just excited. I'll slow down.'

---

‘Freud would definitely have something to say about this,’ I said, chattering in order to focus on anything but the fact we were making our way through a tight tunnel winding its way under thousands of tons of solid rock. ‘Secret tunnels under the names of missing mothers.’

‘I don’t see it,’ said Leo, or something like it. He was marching on ahead again.

‘Oh really?’ I said. ‘Flayne’s monument to his missing mother, screening a secret cave that penetrates deep into the earth. Literally the most Oedipal thing since Oedipus.’

Leo laughed. The cold stone took a large part of the humanity from his voice. ‘The father built this place, not the son. But yeah, I suppose you could look at it that way.’

‘There’s literally no other way.’

‘Well,’ he began, in a voice of polite disagreement, ‘that’s a very western, very twentieth-century way to read a space.’

‘Oh, is that what we’re doing here?’ said Clive dolefully. ‘*Reading a space?*’

Leo looked annoyed. ‘That’s what *I’m* doing. If you don’t like it, you don’t have to come.’

‘No,’ said Clive. ‘I’m sorry. I’m just a bit nervous, I think. It’s the whole... cave... thing.’

‘Come on,’ said Ruth, her breath pluming in the torchlight. ‘Let’s just read this fucking space already.’

‘What do you think happened to Flayne’s mother? To Ella?’ I was talking again, trying to take my mind off the actuality of our situation.

Leo shrugged. ‘Honestly? I think she got sick of being in that house with her emotionally distant husband and her disturbed and intense son. Even if she didn’t run off with her artist, I’m guessing she got out while she could.’

This, all things considered, seemed likely. Being at Solace House while it was empty was more than enough. How it was with a domineering

husband and a strange, wilful child I could only guess.

We would have carried on this conversation, but at the next turn, the narrow tunnel simply stopped abruptly, or rather, tapered to an aperture about two feet across, at face height. Leo shone his torch into it: I glimpsed a small, cramped tunnel, winding further into the rock.

‘Nope,’ I said, before I could stop myself.

Leo shook his head. ‘Give me a leg up.’

Ruth gasped. ‘You can’t go in there!’

‘Some Goth *you* are,’ said Leo. He was already looking for toeholds up to the aperture. ‘Why not?’

‘Because,’ said Clive plainly, as if he were addressing a child, ‘if you get into difficulties in there, you’ll die.’

Leo snorted dismissively. ‘It’s really short. It opens out a bit, further along. There’s room to turn. If it gets too cramped, I’ll turn around, come out.’

Ruth, Clive and I looked at each other.

‘Either way, you can’t stop me,’ said Leo, smiling. ‘I’m going in.’

He found a toehold. Instantly, he launched himself up and into the tunnel in one smooth movement, as if crawling into a narrow tunnel a hundred feet underground were the most natural thing in the world.

---

Leo was gone for roughly ten agonizing minutes. During that time, in the chill of the tunnel, we tried to make as much conversation as we could, occasionally shouting through the smaller hollow to Leo, who would answer us with an indecipherable echoing commentary from deep inside the rock.

I played with the buttons on my boiler suit. I was glad I had worn it; both Ruth and Clive were shivering.

‘Well,’ I said, ‘this certainly makes it all so much less Oedipal down here. Squirming through a stone birth canal. Ha, I’m using humour to

distract myself there. I'm incredibly worried about him. Do you think he'll be okay?'

'I hope so,' said Clive flatly. The reality of the situation seemed to have stripped him of his usual distance from everything. Ruth's eyes were big and wide as she surveyed the cave roof, a few inches above us.

'How much rock do you think is above us?' I asked, before I could stop myself.

Ruth stared at me quizzically. 'Not sure I want to discuss that at the moment, Alex. No offence.'

I nodded. 'None taken.' From the winding guts of the hillside, Leo's voice came to us, excited and utterly incomprehensible.

---

And then, he stopped talking. His constant enthusiastic chatter, indecipherable but reassuring, suddenly ceased altogether.

Clive, Ruth and I exchanged glances.

'You alright there, Leo?' said Clive cautiously. There was no response.

'Leo?' said Ruth. There was a seam of strain in her voice. 'Leo? You okay?' She looked at me. 'Is he okay?'

'How should I know? LEO!'

We listened. When the echoes of our voices faded, the silence was total, bottomless. We listened, until I felt my skull would fracture with the effort. We stared at each other for a long moment, unsure of what to do next. I opened my mouth to shout again, just as Leo emerged from the rock wall, head first.

'*Oh thank God,*' breathed Ruth.

'Anyone gonna help me down?' Ruth and Clive grabbed Leo's shoulders and pulled him as he wriggled through the aperture. As he thudded to the dusty floor, I saw that although his clothes were filthy and his hair dishevelled, his expression was one of delirious triumph.

'Just for the record, we couldn't hear a bloody word you were saying,' said Clive. 'What's in there?'

‘Okay,’ said Leo, through a grin he couldn’t suppress. ‘So, this little tunnel here winds through the rock for about fifteen feet. But then, it opens out into a much, *much* larger cavern, this huge, *huge* space, roughly circular. The floor’s basically conical, it drops down in the middle and becomes a well, or just a very, very deep hole, but you can’t get too close to it, because as you approach it the floor starts to angle steeply downwards towards it.’

‘A Gabriel’s Horn,’ said Clive.

‘Yeah!’ said Leo. ‘Exactly that. Probably very, very deep. I chucked a couple of stones at it, but I couldn’t hear any noise after I dropped them in, none at all. But those things are all natural features. What is *really* mind-blowing is the walls of the chamber. There are carvings—’

‘Jackpot,’ Clive smiled. ‘This is a very Leo-centric discovery.’

Leo’s eyes sparkled. ‘I know, right? They’re nothing unique – there’s nine of them, all Neolithic – all spirals, each about the size of a dinner plate, each one cleanly carved into the rock. I don’t think anyone’s ever documented them before. They’re completely forgotten. No-one knows about them!’

‘Well, apart from Mr Flayne,’ I said. ‘And his mum and dad.’

‘Right,’ said Leo. ‘And *their* attitude to the place is best summed up by the massive iron gate they put up between it and the outside world. Presumably they did that when Flayne Junior was a boy, so that he wouldn’t go down there and end up in the bottomless pit.’ Leo was breathless. ‘I need to come back, with paper, and make some rubbings of the carvings.’

Clive smirked. ‘Don’t worry. You’ve got the rest of summer to rub yourself excitedly all over the carvings.’

‘Can we go back now?’ said Ruth. ‘It’s freezing down here.’

---

It was a relief to be outside, above ground, in the full glare of the sunlight. Ella and Adam both looked mildly surprised to see us, as if they’d forgotten who we were. I wondered what they had found to talk about while we’d

been away. Leo recounted what he had discovered, telling them about the prehistoric spirals etched into the rock, the abyssal well at the centre of the chamber.

And Edwin Flayne began to be more real to us, more alive. We had, so far, only been able to understand Flayne through his madness, but now we were able to see the house and the gardens as he – and his mother – had seen them: as magical places, the whole estate a walled idyll, a strange paradise.

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## 35

69. Vanity, ecstasy. Refrains loud and strong,  
To induce no godly emotion.  
Days, ever new. Sworn vainglorious in song,  
in Omega's name; *insane* notion.
70. *Neglected*, unloved, my bless'd Eden retreats,  
Living everlasting summers.  
Swift centuries elapse, now time, unbound, repeats,  
Inside everlasting summers.

WE RETURNED TO THE HOUSE that afternoon to recover all the volumes of Flayne's writing and take them back to Marshlands. Our mood bordered on the jubilant. We had already agreed, on the way back through the garden, not to tell Jilly Cowie about any of this. We'd seen, first-hand, how dismissive she'd been of the patient records at Marshlands.

Ruth went to fetch the handcart while the rest of us retrieved the volumes from the room with the sumptuous blue and gold wallpaper. There were forty-four of the brown semi-autobiographical volumes, not counting the seven other volumes that Ella had stuffed into her rucksack. I watched her shoulder the rucksack carefully; her gaze met mine and she shook her head, as if to say *not now*.

As we carried the volumes downstairs to stack them on the handcart, the unseen telephone, trapped under unimaginable depths of rubbish, began once more to ring.

We all cheered. Even Adam looked amused.

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*She stood here, when she was pregnant with me. Consider, that moment: The land and the marsh, the house, unbuilt, around us: an idea. My mother, my whole world, and at that point, my universe, around my unborn form. My mind, inside my brain. The perfect symmetry of that moment, when all was enclosed in all. All perfectly mirroring God's creation, which I know now to be a maze of ascendent complexity.*

Normally, after spending any time in the house, there would be the usual queue for showers, the usual preparation of meals. Today, there was nothing; we all simply sat in the kitchen, engrossed in reading Flayne's words. We either read in silence, or occasionally read something out to the others, in the event we found something sufficiently noteworthy. There was something very absorbing, almost addictive, about them. I longed to ask Ella about the other volumes she'd hidden, and I could see that Adam, the only other person privy to their existence, was fidgety too. I suddenly had so many questions.

'This is incredible,' said Leo at last. 'Circumstance and time coincided to give him solitude, to give him space. He was alone in this house for, what, sixty, seventy years? He's an anomaly, a fluke, a once-in-a-trillion, never-to-be-repeated circumstance.'

'Yes. And now he's ours,' said Ella.

'What do you mean?'

'He's for us. We found all this stuff. His life story is ours. You said yourself, Jilly Cowie won't place any value on any of this stuff whatsoever. He's *ours*.'

Leo looked uncertain. 'Funny way of putting it.'

'I *mean*,' said Ella, 'we might have stumbled upon something valuable here. Here, look: he mentions all the paintings he's done. We haven't found those yet. When we do, we might discover that he was an incredible artist. Significant, even. A visionary.' She sniffed, as Leo looked at her blankly. 'If Malcolm were here, he'd understand.'



‘How does all this end?’ said Clive, tossing a volume aside. ‘For Flayne, I mean? Who’s got the last one?’ I looked at Ella, then saw Adam was doing the same. Ella looked away.

‘I’ve got it,’ said Ruth. ‘Number 43.’

‘Well?’ said Clive impatiently.

Ruth looked at the volume, open on her lap. ‘Mr Flayne concludes his opus in a manner consistent with his work to date. Which is to say, it’s batshit crackers.’

‘Don’t keep us in suspense.’

Ruth read.

*‘I shall perform the ritual, and go to The End.’*

‘And he’s off!’ laughed Clive.

*‘Nonetheless, I have taken whatever precautions are available to me. I have enwebbed the house in protection, the better to anchor it to existence. For things are happening I cannot control.*

*‘I opened the place up to the higher energies of creation, and now it is at the crossways. It is moored here, but a slight imbalance one way or the other could send it into that other realm.’*

Ruth smiled at our eager faces, carried on reading.

*‘The fool is crucified on the branches of his beliefs. At the time of nonhuman sadness, at the black sand, where the stars of an aged world hang heavy in a shattered sky, and our final descendants tower above the world in luminous, terrible, ever-transient, ever-changing ecstasy.*

*‘The apocalypse is indescribable, impossible to conceive of in scale and awe, a madness infecting madmen. A sensory explosion. A scouring newness that will shatter the tiny prism of human perspective. This is what the ancients saw, when they saw their visions.’*

Leo twitched visibly at this. Ruth continued reading.

*‘Please know that in devising, or recovering, the ritual, I act from the best of intentions. I merely want – desperately – to return to the idyllic Eden of my childhood, which I now understand to have always been a doorway, of sorts, into that Exalted Realm. I act from the best of intentions.’*

Ruth closed the book. There was a moment of uncertain silence.

‘What the fuck is he on about?’ said Clive.

‘I’m not sure,’ I said. ‘He’s saying he was going to do something, to himself? Or something to the house?’

‘I mean, he *did*,’ said Clive. ‘He filled it with crap. No arguments there.’

‘What about the other volumes?’ said Adam, smiling calmly. ‘The ones Alex stashed in Ella’s bag?’

There was a cymbal crash of adrenalin to my stomach.

‘What?’ Leo looked at her questioningly. I glared at Adam, feeling my cheeks flush with fury.

‘There were five more volumes,’ said Adam. ‘Black ones? Alex stuffed them into Ella’s rucksack when you arrived.’

I smiled through gritted teeth. ‘You got me.’ I reached into Ella’s rucksack, taking care to look inside, to leave the final brown volume and the red volume – the existence of which were known only to Ella and me – inside. Ella smiled slightly in acknowledgement of this, as I handed the five black volumes to the others.

‘You sly dog,’ said Clive. ‘Why on earth were you holding these back?’ Once more, I found myself parroting Ella’s excuse for doing something. ‘I figured that as we found them, we should get first look at them.’

‘Fair fucks,’ said Clive. ‘But Adam just put a hole in that. What’s in ’em?’

‘Hard to say,’ said Leo, flicking through one of the black volumes. He held it up so that we could see. The verso page was filled with rows of numbers, clearly some kind of code or encryption, followed by equations and calculations. The recto page was dominated by a drawing of a large and incredibly complex geometric shape.

‘Wow,’ said Ruth. ‘Looks like he started drawing that, and forgot to stop. Adam, Clive, you both do Maths. What is it?’

‘No idea,’ said Adam, reddening with unnecessary embarrassment. ‘It seems to be some kind of section, beginning in three-dimensional space. But then it... veers off.’

‘Into...?’ asked Ruth.

Adam looked puzzled for a moment. 'It seems to be a higher dimensional space?' Then he shook his head, and smiled again. 'Or just insanity.'

I looked at Ella. Her expression told me that we were indeed recalling the same thing, the strange poem she'd found in the hallway, the one which had driven her to Solace House today in the first place. *Our minds reject the thought. Of infinite extents, unseen – We pray that God's does not.*

Leo seemed unsatisfied by this answer. 'Define insanity.'

'Well, he starts from a bizarre set of contradictory values, then... he extrapolates from the first set a much more complex and even more bizarre set of contradictory values. And he keeps doing this, with a running commentary. In code.'

'Amazing,' breathed Ruth. She seemed genuinely pleased.

'Any chance we can break the code?' said Clive.

Adam sniffed. 'I'm not sure. I'd like to keep hold of these, though; they're fascinating.'

'Go ahead,' said Clive, before anyone could object. 'If you can make any sense of them then great.'

'What are those numbers?' Ruth asked. 'At the back there?' The black volume she was holding, open to its final page, bore the inscription, in red pastel, 47/51. 'Wait – the brown volumes are numbered 1 to 43, in the same place throughout. The black volumes are numbered 45 to 50. So there's two volumes missing!' It was strange hearing real disappointment in Ruth's voice, as opposed to her usual bemused indifference. 'Number 44 and number 51. It makes no sense that they weren't left with the others. Where are they?'

Clive shrugged. 'Somewhere in Solace House, clearly.'

'Great,' laughed Leo. 'Well, they shouldn't take long to find.'

'We just have to keep an eye out,' said Ella. 'I'm sure they'll turn up.'

'I'm sure they will,' I said.

## 36

71. Eden's noble dream, undying, regrows,  
Even death dreadful exceeding.  
Annihilator: *thou* hast naught: only woes.  
Only vain endeavours, receding.
72. Thou hast reneged on wisdom: nothing wrought  
Of each *futile*, useless longing.  
Thou: ruiner and negator, shunned, ignored –  
Thou: instigator of nothing.

THAT EVENING, as soon as the opportunity presented itself, I knocked at Ella's room. There was some scuffling inside, which couldn't have been more obviously the sound of someone concealing something, before she came to the door. Upon seeing it was me, she walked wordlessly away to slump onto the bed and resume what she'd been doing before I arrived.

Which, as it turned out, was precisely what I suspected she'd been doing: reading Flayne's final memoir.

'This is exactly what I wanted to ask you about,' I said. 'Your stolen property.'

'Stolen is a *very* strong word,' she said, not looking up. 'Like I said, I just want to be the first to find out what happened here, that's all. That's absolutely my prerogative.'

I laughed. 'How so?'

'It's probably too complex for you to understand,' she said, but she was smiling. 'Something to do with the ancient legal dictate of Finders,

Keepers. Want a glass of wine? I mean, I don't have any wine glasses so it's either a mug or your cupped hands.'

'Mug of wine sounds fine. What's in the last two volumes?'

'I'm still working my way through them,' she said, sitting up. 'But the final brown one seems to be the last chapter of his descent into madness.'

'Amazing. Can I read it?'

'Absolutely not!' she said. 'Not until I have.'

'Alright. But does he at least explain what he did to every single photograph of himself?'

'He does, actually. Wait a second.' Ella flicked around in the ledger for a few seconds, until she found the passage she wanted, and began to read.

*'To be introduced to The Exalted Realm is to be translated, to see yourself not as others see you, or as you believe you are, but how you really are, how you look from the perspective of eternity. I cannot, now, look upon my old, lying face with anything but disgust, as one might view a deformity or disfigurement that once defined you but has, by some miracle, been removed, without blemish.'*

*'My eternal face is all that matters now.'*

'Wow,' I said. 'Superb. And the second one? The red one?'

'Ah,' she smiled. 'Now you're asking.'

She reached under the bed, and handed me the final volume of Flayne's journals.



This volume felt different to all the others, not least because of the obvious detail of the deep-red leather that bound it, which had retained its hue throughout the years it had sat unopened. The edges of the pages were marbled with a bubbling pattern of red and cream, the colours of steak.

Ella opened it reverently, as if it were a sacred thing.

The handwriting within – in stark contrast to the jagged sawblade scrawl it had become in Flayne's final autobiographical volumes, was once

again neat copperplate, perfectly legible, and the text was complemented by colourful, hand-inked borders.

The book was divided into six sections, all in quatrains of verse, written in Flayne's signature style; and each section began with, or incorporated, a large illuminated letter, as did the contents page, which ran thus:

6. Situation
5. Orientation
4. Lamentation
3. Ascension
2. Confession
1. Elaboration

I traced a finger in wonder over each of the vividly hand-illuminated letters: *S, O, L, A, C* and *E*. The idea was medieval, but the aesthetic of the design was entirely Flayne's own, a scheme of design as singular and eccentric as he was.

'*God,*' I breathed.

'*I know,*' said Ella. Her face, seemingly glowing in the book's reflection, contained a mixture of delight and awe. 'So we know what he did with at least some of his time here. He produced the Lindisfarne Gospels, basically, only enshrining his own peculiar perspective.'

'*God,*' I said again. 'He really did have so much time on his hands, the poor lonely bastard.'

Ella shrugged. 'Maybe he was happy. Maybe he was happier than we could ever be. Maybe he lived here in a state of perpetual religious ecstasy, experiencing sights and sounds inaccessible to anyone else. Like an anchorite.'

'You old romantic, you.' I turned to the first page. There were two quatrains to each page, it seemed, throughout. I read the first two verses:

1. *A lost, lonely season unmoored. My mind erring –  
Returning to half-empty halls  
Of unending silence; enclosing, ensnaring –  
Now torrid remembrance enthrals.*

2. *All trauma's exiles, demented, therein  
All unto night's torments exposed.  
Delusions roam; eerie qualms underpin  
Every spurious theory supposed.*

And, for a second, I felt a strange, churning unease, reading those words, as if I had read them before, or they had special resonance for me; as if they described the heart of a crucial matter I had failed to grasp; or at the very least, spoke of something so close to me I couldn't see it. The impression was fleeting, but in that instant, strong as vertigo.

I flicked through the rest of the book. There were many, many more quatrains, arranged two to a page, each long string of verses broken up by a large, illuminated letter, all surrounded by hand-inked borders filled with strange life, strange geometry.

'What is this?'

'Hard to tell,' said Ella. 'I think he achieved some kind of... understanding, and chose to immortalize it this way.'

I thought of my first night at Marshlands, when I had got stoned with Leo and Clive, and Clive had ended the night by writing his own little quatrain and taping it to my door. I recalled this to Ella; she laughed.

'Maybe there's something about proximity to Solace House that forces you to write endless poetry?'



I suppose what happened next happened because neither of us expected it. As we sat together reading Flayne's epic poem on Ella's bed, engrossed, neither of us realized that our heads were almost touching; neither of us noticed that our breathing had become almost synchronous, or that an easy understanding had settled over us, silent as snow. And then, in a single moment, we were both aware of all of these things, aware that something had overtaken both of us.

It was Ella who turned and looked at me, her face close, now all that I could see, and it was her smile and her short, nervous laugh that acknowledged that what was happening was actually happening. And then suddenly, almost violently, as if a dam had broken, we kissed, passionately inhaling each other as if we were drowning, as if the end of the world were nigh.

Being who we were, however, we paused for a second and carefully placed Flayne's red volume of poetry on the floor before continuing.

---

Afterwards, we lay side by side, surrounded by the newness, the strangeness, that always comes of losing yourself entirely to someone else. Neither of us spoke for a while, perhaps unsure of how to proceed to the next thing, whatever that might be.

'What happened to your parents?' Ella asked, gazing at the ceiling. 'I lied,' I heard myself say, at long last.

'Oh?'

'Not about being an orphan,' I said. 'That's true. Both my parents are dead.'

She did not react to this news in the normal way, the way I was used to seeing. Normally, people would strain a muscle trying to be sympathetic, making the same face I had seen so often; trying and failing to understand. Instead, Ella simply asked the pragmatic question once more:

'What happened to them?'

'My mother died in childbirth, and I was placed in a workhouse.'

'That's *Oliver Twist*. You're not even trying now. What happened to your parents?'

'My mother died when I was an infant,' I said sadly, although my lip was already curling into a smile. 'Whereas my father was killed by Kerchak, leader of the ape tribe.'

She laughed. 'That's *Tarzan*, you fucking clown. What happened to your parents?'



‘You’re not going to let this go, are you?’

‘Why, have you run out of fictional orphans?’

‘I... yes, I have. Unlikely as that sounds, given there are millions of them.’

‘What happened to your parents?’

‘I’ll tell you,’ I said. ‘One day. Promise. Just not now.’

---

‘I think it’s best that you go,’ she said later. Her tone was mock sincere. ‘I don’t want the others to know about this.’

‘I see. Embarrassed by me?’

‘God, yes,’ she said. ‘I’m a stunning young woman with her whole future ahead of her. Imagine if it got out I shagged the Elephant Man.’

‘I quite understand,’ I said gravely. ‘I’ll put the sack back over my head and leave by the window.’

‘That shouldn’t be necessary,’ she said. She grabbed me and kissed me, a different kiss now, the kiss of people who have shared closeness, and then, smiling, let me go.

I left, closing the door with a soft click.

---

As I turned, I almost walked into him. He was simply standing there, directly outside Ella’s door, waiting.

‘Jesus! What the fuck, Adam?’

‘*What are you doing?*’ he hissed.

There was fury in his eyes. He was also slurring, which meant that he’d probably drunk a cataclysmic amount of vodka.

‘What do you mean?’ It was disturbing, seeing him here like this, drunk and enraged. Momentarily, I couldn’t decode what his presence here meant.

‘You!’ spat Adam. ‘*You!*’

‘What are you talking about?’ I stopped short of finishing this sentence in the way I would have liked, by saying *you fucking lunatic*. I suspected

this wouldn't be wise; anger radiated from him, palpably, like heat. I wondered for the first time if he were dangerous.

'*You slept with her!*' he snarled, as if we were lifelong best friends and Ella were his wife.

'Oh my God.' I almost laughed. 'Is that what this is? Even if I did sleep with her – which is none of your fucking business – *it's none of your fucking business.*'

'*She's for me,*' he said, as if stating a fact. This was such a strange thing to say that it stopped me in my tracks. I just stared at him.

'*She's for me.* Not you.'

I had nothing to say to this. I just stared at him, until I realized my mouth had fallen open. He stared back in perfect equanimity, as if what he had just said was completely reasonable.

'Jesus,' I said. 'You are so insane.'

His expression did not change. '*She's for me,*' he said again. There was total certainty in his voice. The smell of vodka on his breath was overpowering. I wondered if he'd recall any of this tomorrow.

I shook my head. 'Go to bed, Adam.'

With some effort, I turned and walked away. I could feel his gaze burning into me, his jealous, mad attention, intimate and somehow prurient, like an X-ray.

## 37

73. O, frail lament, in voice indistinct, now,  
Grieve a *lost* life, where I sleep.  
(Do our mournful instincts gradually narrow?  
Or regrow, endlessly deep?)

74. Nervous oblivion, weakening, fading –  
O, rare empty *vision*, evince.  
Ridiculous, accursed lies invading,  
Nonsensical Eden's Labyrinth.

AS WE GATHERED in the kitchen the next morning, drifting in to make breakfast and coffee, even someone as obtuse as Clive could notice that something – some minute calibration within the dynamic of the group – was different. Ella and I went out of our way to appear casually indifferent to each other, which of course only made any interaction between us stilted and awkward; when we did catch each other's eyes, we'd inadvertently smile.

Adam, meanwhile, was still just as furious as I'd seen him last night. He clattered around the kitchen and, when he burned a piece of toast under the grill, dragging it out by a corner and scorching his fingertips, he swore viciously. This behaviour enhanced the image I had of him as someone unformed, immature, someone who could not control their emotions because they'd never learned to. I wondered – then worried, briefly – what kind of revenge he would, or could, exact on me for having the presumption

to get involved with Ella. He took his plate of blackened toast and stomped back to his room, almost walking into Helen as he did so.

‘Oh, hello, Adam!’ said Helen sarcastically. ‘Very nice welcome back, I *must* say!’

‘Fuck’s got into him?’ said Clive through a mouthful of cereal.

‘No idea,’ said Ruth. ‘Hello, Helen! When did you get back?’

‘Just now,’ she said. ‘What’s up with Adam?’

‘He’s always like that, isn’t he?’ I said, sitting down next to Clive.

Clive shook his head sadly, shovelled another spoonful of cereal into his mouth. ‘Dude seriously needs to have sex.’

Involuntarily, I glanced upwards to Ella, but saw instead Helen’s face, which was a perfect representation of the word *aghast*. Clive, oblivious, carried on talking.

‘Seriously. He’s wound way too tight. Maybe we could fix him up with a girl, or a boy, or, I don’t know, a three-toed sloth, whatever the hell he’s into.’

‘So glad I’m back!’ said Helen icily. ‘Fornication *and* bestiality! Hardly subjects for the breakfast table!’

‘Absolutely not,’ said Ruth evenly. ‘Not unless you cleared it first.’

Helen started to object to this reflexively, but halfway through whatever she was saying, she began to laugh. She had a pleasant laugh, when it was genuine – a musical sound of gleeful joy and amusement. Then her scolding super-ego resumed its reign, and she stopped abruptly.

Again, I caught Ella’s eye without meaning to, and we smiled. This time, however, Ruth spotted this tiny interaction and seemed instantly to discern what it meant. She beamed indulgently back at us, a smile that said *Well, well, and Good for you* and – I hoped – *Don’t worry, I won’t tell*.

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Helen had been to see some friends at a church in the city: none of us asked for this information, but she told us anyway. She’d also got a cab back here, after attempting to get hold of Malcolm at a number he gave her, and

realizing by the sound of him that he probably wasn't going to make it back until very much later. We had been too disorganized to conceal the many volumes of Flayne's writing that we'd liberated from Solace House, and they were still in a messy pile in the kitchen, but Helen seemed utterly incurious about them, flicking through one in a desultory fashion and then putting it aside. We refrained from telling her about the black volumes filled with mathematical formulae which Adam had taken possession of: she would only ever perceive these as satanic.

The final brown volume, and that unique red volume, of course, were known about only by me and Ella. They were one more aspect of a thing that was ours, between only us.

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Sunday was spent as the early part of Saturday had been, with us all lounging around on the grass. We took some volumes of Flayne's writing outside with us, but the novelty had worn off a little and the repetition within them proved soporific. I went back to my room and read for a while; I hoped that Ella might follow me there, but she fell asleep on the grass with a straw hat over her face. I had only brought a few books with me, but one of them was Julian of Norwich, which we were due to study next term, so I read that.

Malcolm returned late on Sunday evening, with the newborn-baby smile, low energy and complete unwillingness to engage in conversation that spoke of an absolutely colossal night out. Ruth attempted to update him on what we'd found in Solace House, hinting that it might even translate into something of monetary value, but Malcolm was too frazzled to care. He managed about five minutes of whispered small talk before repairing to his room; I heard him snoring thinly about ten minutes later. Jilly Cowie returned later too, in her cheese-coloured Mini Clubman, having spent the whole weekend with her climbing club, scaling indoor walls in preparation for her upcoming expedition to the Lakes.

And so the weekend passed.

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On Monday, we returned to work. We made our way back through the woods, and Solace House – with the lower staircase, front hall and some of the first floor landing cleared, the doors and curtains of the first floor rooms flung open, the newspapers and boxes and boards removed from the lower windows – experienced proper daylight for the first time in decades. Although the plan had been to push on up the stairs, as soon as Jilly Cowie saw the beautiful tea services laid out like a strange metropolis in the gold room, it was decided – after a semi-serious telling-off for deviating from the ascent of the stairwell – that our priority would be to remove the crockery to the safety of Marshlands.

This took a long time – an entire working day, in fact, which saw all of us carrying teacups and cake-stands and creamers and all manner of bone china through the woods, and to the auditorium. Jilly Cowie impressed upon us the importance of not damaging anything, and the trips back and forth along the uneven woodland path to the iron gate became a mind-numbing effort of concentration.

Jilly said nothing about the photo albums and loose pictures with their unsettling alterations; at one point, however, I returned to the gold room to find her flicking through a large, square album, staring open-mouthed at Flayne's repainted face, glaring back at her from the sepia depths of an indistinct past. She looked up when I came in, her lips silently working, as if attempting to phrase a question that wouldn't come, but closed the album and set it down. After a couple of seconds, she pushed the album further away from her, then wiped her fingertips on her top, as if the photos were somehow unclean.

At the end of the day, miraculously, not one piece of chinaware had been so much as chipped.

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That night, I knocked on Ella's door – looking around me, despite myself, to check for Adam's presence. She let me in, and we sat on the bed together

for a while, with Ella reading the final brown volume and me reading the red volume of verse. I couldn't make much of it, but it seemed to speak, always, of a lost idyll, and an attempt to regain it which reaped terrible consequences.

When I asked Ella what was in the final volume of Flayne's life history, she shushed me and offered platitudes designed to wind me up. 'All in good time,' she'd say, or '*All good things to those who wait*,' delivered in the sing-song voice of Anthony Hopkins in *The Silence of the Lambs*. I threw a pillow at her, which led to us laughing and wrestling, which led to the obvious destination.

This time, however, Ella and I curled up together and went to sleep afterwards, and I woke up with her in the morning.

## 38

75. A bewilderment you readily invaded,  
Never to henceforth interpret.  
No escape. Infolding now, thus evaded:  
Relentless time's wilful interment.
76. No eyes shall behold Eden, that which is Xanadu.  
That lush isle frames endless temptation.  
In *mad* Eden's soul, ever now to rue,  
A pained passion. Eternal damnation.

WE FINALLY REACHED the attic, and its contents, on the Thursday afternoon.

This discovery was heralded by a sea-change in the things we began removing from the staircase; we suddenly found ourselves overwhelmed by a rich vein of artist's materials. For two hours or so we handled boxes of ancient oil paints with the labels of long-gone manufacturers, all dried solid in their tubes and jars, along with brushes of every size, dried to stiff spears, bottles of turpentine and linseed oil with rusted screw caps, their contents curdled. We knew from his journals that Flayne had studied art and painted, but thus far the only evidence of this we'd seen was the illuminated book of verse which Ella had found, known only to the two of us. But now, there was paint, and brushes, and occasionally a blank canvas. We worked – patiently, doggedly – and wondered.

Finally, four floors up, at the very top of the great staircase, we reached an anomaly, the first hint of what was to come.



The wide opening at the top of the staircase, where it became the upper landing, had been entirely blocked, floor to ceiling, by boxes of wood and metal, and while much of Flayne's clutter had the unmistakeable air of chaos about it, this obstacle was different. Like the wall of tea chests which blocked the very bottom of the staircase on the ground floor, this seemed to be a deliberate barrier, constructed carefully and with intent. I reasoned all this out afterwards: it was Helen who reached this wall first.

It was her turn to be at the head of the chain that we had, by now, naturally fallen into. The rest of us had reached a point where we were content to work mostly in silence, but Helen, as usual, gave a running commentary of her thoughts and impressions as she worked, perhaps to keep her bravado up, perhaps simply exerting a reflex she couldn't shut off.

And then, abruptly, the sound of her voice stopped. After a minute or two – long enough to notice she'd stopped speaking, and to wonder whether she was alright – I heard her voice.

'Er, *guys*.'

I froze; not at what she said, but at some quality in her tone. Her words no longer rang with the dull closeness inflicted on all sound by the rubbish-filled house. Instead, the words seemed to expand. To echo.

'I *think*,' she trilled from far above, 'that there's nothing after this.'

'Nothing after what?' said Clive, as he handed down a box to me filled with forty identical copies of the same hymn book. 'What's she on about?'

'Not sure,' I said. I handed the box to Malcolm, then turned to receive the next thing.

'Oh *Lord!*' she said.

'What is it?'

'It's *EMPTY!*' There was awe in her voice. 'Once we move these boxes away, *there's nothing!*'

'What do you mean, nothing?' I said, and turned to Clive. 'What does she mean?'

Clive shrugged, twisted his neck to call up the final flight of stairs. 'What do you mean, *nothing?*'

‘What’s going on up there?’ said Ella from some way below. ‘What have you found?’

‘What?’ said Clive.

‘She’s asking what—’ Malcolm began. But Helen’s voice, always louder than anyone else’s, rang over his.

‘There’s just an empty corridor! Nothing else!’

‘Impossible,’ said Clive. ‘Why would he stop filling the house at an arbitrary point?’

*‘Why would he do any of this?’* Malcolm shouted balefully. We all laughed.

‘I’m almost through!’ Helen sounded gleeful. ‘Just a couple more boxes!’ She groaned as she lifted something heavy; Clive carefully passed a large tin document box with very sharp edges into my hands, and I strained under its weight as I passed it on to Malcolm. There followed another heavy document box, then another.

‘What can you see?’ Clive craned his neck, peering upwards. ‘What’s up there?’ There was no response.

‘Helen?’ He glanced down at me, suddenly concerned. ‘Helen?’

But Helen, for once, stayed silent.

And that was enough to bring us all running.

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Clive thundered up the stairs, with me following. I could hear the rumbling clatter of the others behind me.

And there, beyond the rubbish, lay the topmost floor of Solace House, a vast attic landing, with doorways to other rooms, all split by beams of brilliant sun pouring through four skylights and one small window. The contrast with the darkness below was dizzying. The space was completely bare, not only of clutter, but of furniture. Inside this space, Helen stood, as if enchanted, staring at the walls.

Every inch of wall space was hung with canvases.

The smallest must have been only a few inches square; the largest some eight feet tall. All were rendered in oils, all hyperrealistic, almost photographic, in their way. All were unframed.

They mostly depicted incomprehensible, disturbing landscapes, or strange, translucent creatures, or both.

There were works that were almost, but not quite, traditional subjects. A crucifixion, but not of anything that could be called human, or even animal. A duel, with blades, between two figures that seemed conjoined. A coronation ceremony, conducted by burned shapes, honouring an ornately carved, but unoccupied, throne. Regardless of whether the scene depicted a scorched wasteland beneath an ochre sky, or a ghostly city, picked out in strands of silver-grey against a sky burdened with swollen stars, or anything else, there was one constant presence.

Solace House, recurring over and over, always and forever the same.

One large canvas depicted the house front and centre, while above it, filling the sky, vast things floated or stalked, like Portuguese Men O'War, translucent blobs with clusters of long, trailing tentacles and feelers, probing the dark landscape below. On closer inspection, the innards of these floating things had been painted with care and precision, with lines suggestive of machinery.

The portraiture was even stranger, certainly more horrifying, each thing grotesque and monstrous, grimacing out from murky, shadowed silence. A portrait of something not quite a woman, her face a bloody mess. A creature whose head was like a great fragile, diseased egg, long thin hands clasped to it as if holding it together. A female thing, with bloodied arms and breasts, holding a weapon, blood-red paint bursting around her eyes in radial spears.

Each canvas seethed with detail. Even shadows, upon closer inspection, would prove not to be solid black, but inhabited by shapes, picked out in the very dulllest gleams of light – joints, coils, ribs, eyes. Everything in Flayne's canvases seemed *inhabited*.

The largest painting showed the same dark throne which featured in many of the other paintings, but occupied, now, by a thing that seemed to be

many things, at least five or six humanoid figures superimposed on one another. The arms trailed off, snakelike, vaporous, to the borders of the image, as if trailing away into other situations. There was only one pair of legs, taloned and jewelled, black and blue; the face was a ghostly mass of white, where something cocooned in spiderweb exulted and laughed.

It was easy to see how these images had rendered Helen speechless. We were all silent now, all staring.

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It was Ruth who broke the silence, saying, through a smile of pure admiration, a single word.

‘Amazing.’

‘Surprise, surprise,’ said Clive. ‘The Goth likes the horrible pictures. What the hell are these?’

‘No idea,’ I said. ‘Leo? You’re the closest we have to an anthropologist. What do you make of it?’

Leo frowned at the nearest picture. Something within the canvas turned towards the beholder; its mouth was open and its eyes, long gone, had become a sort of waxy lacquer, dribbling from the empty sockets. It seemed caught in a silent, unending attempt to communicate something of terrible importance.

‘Impossible to say for sure,’ he said eventually. ‘I mean, it might just be a straight-up case of insanity, but’ – he licked his lips – ‘they’re incredible.’

‘Look,’ said Ruth breathlessly. ‘Look.’

We all looked over to where she was pointing. Two of the five doors on this final, attic level were open, the rooms clearly filled with yet more paintings. The remaining three, however, had a thick metal hasp bolted into them, each fitted with a sturdy padlock.

‘Three padlocked doors. Nothing creepy about that,’ said Malcolm, staring, eyes wide. ‘Nothing creepy at all. We should totally get Cowie.’

‘What?’ Ella seemed almost personally offended. ‘When did you become responsible? We will behave like upright citizens, thank you very

much, and smash the locks off.'

'No,' said Malcolm. I caught a flicker of genuine unease in his eyes. 'This doesn't feel right.'

'What do you mean?'

'Ever since we got here,' said Malcolm, 'we've joked about there being something awful here. Bodies, human remains. Well, guess fucking what? Now it really does look like that's what's here. Behind these doors.'

I shook my head. 'There's no evidence for that.'

'Yeah!' said Malcolm sardonically. 'I mean, just look at all these totally sane paintings, painted by a completely normal man.'

'Yes, but...' And I realized what I was really doing. I was again defending our summer, this adventure we were all part of. Upon seeing the locked doors, Jilly Cowie would immediately call the police. *Better safe*, she would inevitably say, *than sorry*. And the police would arrive, in all their contemporaneous 1993 banality, all high-vis jackets and crackling radio, and furtive eye-rolls at the wastrel students. And, no matter what they found, they would break the spell of Solace House, and it would not return.

While I was mulling this over, Ella turned on her heel and left, picking her way carefully down the stairs.

'Where's she off to?' said Ruth.

'Malcolm's right,' said Helen plaintively. 'The rubbish is one thing, and these paintings, but this is different. We get Jilly, right now, and—'

'No,' said Leo. 'You saw what she did with the records at Marshlands. If there's anything behind there like that—'

'What do you think, Clive?' said Malcolm. 'You're Jilly's deputy?'

Clive lit a cigarette. 'Dunno. Which option will end this conversation quicker?'

While we were still arguing, Ella returned. She stepped awkwardly onto the landing; something about her gait was slightly off. She advanced on the trio of locked doors, and I saw what she was carrying, half-concealing it as she walked, and I saw her intention. Malcolm started to say something else, but by that point Ella had already raised the double-headed axe.

She brought it down decisively on the first lock.

With a great metallic clunk, the lock sprang apart, the dark door instantly acquiring a great blonde fracture as the hasp leapt away from the wood.

Everyone was speechless, open-mouthed. Ella walked calmly to the second door, raised the axe again.

‘The fuck are you doing?’ spluttered Malcolm, finally.

‘Making an omelette,’ muttered Ella.

The hasp on the second door was more securely screwed in, and Ella’s first blow did little more than rattle it. Her second pass was more successful; hasp and door parted company, the padlock hanging limply from the door jamb.

She moved onto the next one.

‘Ella!’ Malcolm sounded both angry and distressed. Helen looked away as if some disaster were unfolding.

Ella raised the axe one more time. From a basic sense of theatrics, I expected the third lock to be the most resistant, to require blow after blow, Ella sweating and gritting her teeth, but one swing of the blade clipped it cleanly off.

Ella threw the axe to the floor, then stood, slightly breathless, before pushing a strand of red hair back from her face. She inhaled deeply, as if regaining her composure.

‘Okay,’ she said at length, to our stunned, silent faces.

## 39

77. God's history altered, shattered, torn –  
Long *yearning*, all rotten event.  
The hours, endless hours, o unhappy, reborn,  
See even death's efforts, now, spent.
78. Regions even death, exhausted, surrenders,  
Its grandeur *now* empty expanse,  
Not dying, even as raging hours engender  
Abstract views now, in numinous trance.

THIS FIRST ROOM was a library. Or had been once.

The entire room, floor to ceiling, was painted black, with black shelves, the horizontal edges painted with thin gold lines. The only interruptions to this floor-to-ceiling shelving was the door by which we'd entered, and a tall, thin, elegant fireplace, with an empty grate. There was a small window set in one wall: I guessed we were at one of the upper corners of the house.

'Empty,' said Ruth. 'Where did all the books go?'

Helen shook her head as she looked at Ella. 'I can't believe you just did that.'

Ella smiled. 'Don't worry, Helen. We're inside now, and look. There's nothing here to write home about, frankly.'

'We haven't looked in the other rooms yet.' Malcolm's tone was doleful.

'The shelves aren't completely empty,' said Leo. 'Look.' He put his fingers on the nearest shelf, where he picked up a pinch of something

powdery, letting it flutter onto the shelf again. 'What is that? Ash? There's little piles of it on every shelf.'

He was right. Tiny piles of ash, at regular intervals, in the dead centre of each empty shelf. I stood on tiptoe to look at the higher shelves, and saw the exact same pattern of small piles of ash. In one, I noticed the tiniest scrap of paper; picking it up, I read the word *credo*, preceded and followed by letters I couldn't make out. The edges of this scrap were charred.

'Oh my God,' I said. 'These are all books. *Were* all books. He burned this entire library!'

'Christ,' said Ruth, kneeling down by the grate. 'He must have done it book by book.' She held up a dustpan and brush. 'Burned them, swept them up, put their remains back on the shelf.'

'Question is,' said Leo, 'why? Why would anyone do that?'

'You see?' said Ella, almost triumphantly. 'Eccentric, sure. Disturbing? Absolutely. But no dead bodies, no altars made of human bones, *à la* Jeffrey Dahmer—'

'Who is that?' squealed Helen, but Ella ignored her.

'Nothing, Malcolm. Literally nothing. You see? You were overreacting.'

Malcolm looked unconvinced. 'Like I say. Two more rooms to go.'

Ella shrugged. 'I'm sure it'll be fine. I'll even go in first, if you're that worried about it.'

'I'd like that,' said Malcolm.

Ella, as defiantly and calmly as she'd wielded the axe, walked out of the room. We heard her boots thud along the bare hallway, the creak as the door opened. And then we heard her shriek a single, loud profanity, and we all bolted next door.

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'It's okay,' she said. 'I'm fine. Just startled. Because, y'know. Who fucking wouldn't be?' She held the door open with one hand.

Inside the second room was a large dining table set with three chairs.

The chairs were occupied.



At each place sat a roughly humanoid dummy, or mannequin, or sculpture. They were not propped up and they did not slump. They were well made, precisely put together, mostly of painted wood, and had been dressed in hand-made outfits. Their faces, where present, were destroyed, chaotic, defying any kind of easy interpretation. One face was a charred void; another had a hole drilled clean through it; the face, and indeed the whole head, of the last one was simply a painted wooden skull. The one with the charred face seemed to take fire as its theme, and was patterned all over with a flame-like design. The one with the hole drilled through its head was covered with a blue and white pattern reminiscent of waves, whereas the one that was more or less a painted skeleton wore a dark black dress.

We regarded these effigies for a long moment of stunned silence.

‘Well,’ said Ruth eventually, grinning widely. ‘Jackpot!’

Helen whimpered as she peered at the nearest of the figures. ‘These are *horrible!*’

‘Again,’ said Ella, almost cheerfully, ‘horrible, yes. Troubling? Also yes. But ultimately, what we’re looking at, again, is just one poor man’s madness.’

‘If you say so,’ said Clive. The selection of objects on the table, at the centre of this little party, was curious. There was a sprig of lavender, a small order of service from a ceremony of remembrance dedicated to the life of Ella Flayne. And there was a tall glass jar, inside which a long and very rusted metal object had been diagonally wedged.

‘The hell do you imagine is in there?’ I said, holding it up.

Leo shook his head. ‘A nail from the Crucifixion? The barrel of the revolver that killed Franz Ferdinand? Or probably just more junk?’

‘I’m not taking these revolting things downstairs,’ said Helen, staring at the face of the nearest dummy. ‘In fact, I’m not even touching them.’

‘For once, I find myself agreeing with Helen,’ Clive muttered. ‘These things are horrible. Whatever purpose they were made for, it can’t be good.’

‘I thought you didn’t believe in anything,’ I said. ‘What’s got into you? They’re just sculptures. Things he’s made.’

‘They’re *infernal*,’ said Helen. ‘Satanic. Unclean. Burn them.’

‘Enough of this,’ I said. ‘We have to see the last room before we know what we’re dealing with.’

Malcolm nodded. ‘Agreed.’

‘I thought you didn’t want to see any of them?’

He shook his head. ‘I don’t. I think we should cut our losses and get Cowie. She can go in there.’

‘This again!’ said Ella indignantly. ‘I’ll do it! You didn’t want to open the rooms up in the first place!’

‘Well, you didn’t leave us much choice on that, did you?’

‘Does anyone who think we shouldn’t do it at all get a vote?’ said Helen. Her voice trembled a little.

Then they were all talking at once.

*This*, I thought to myself, *is why I hate committees*. I headed out into the hallway. Without ceremony, I opened the final door, stepping into the thing at the heart of Solace House.

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Darkness, at first, as the heavy door slammed shut behind me; I took the torch from my belt and switched it on.

Instantly, there was movement.

My imagination made it quicker and more threatening than it was, but I saw that there was a lot of it. A synchronized dance of rising, collapsing, colliding, becoming. A young man’s face, pale, boyish in confusion. I inhaled sharply, drew back, and the army of dancing shadows flinched too, like figures in a zoetrope.

I was standing in mid-air. I was floating above a hundred storeys of the same room. I looked up; I looked back at myself. There I was again, floating, vertical, inverted, looking down at me, up at me, away from me. Everywhere, in infinite directions, I was repeated, cubic cells stacked on top and alongside each other in a deranged, deranging hive of repetition, a labyrinth of recursion, repeating into infinity.

‘What’s in there?’ boomed Clive from outside.

*‘Nothing,’* I stammered. *‘Everything.’* Both statements were true.

A vertical line opened in infinity, bringing the others; Malcolm was too slow to prevent the door slamming shut. The door, like every other plane surface in the room, was entirely covered with a single huge mirror, climbing to meet the ceiling, which was also mirror, and down to the floor, which was also mirror. And so we found ourselves in a never-ending honeycomb of rooms, each holding a perfect replica of each one of us. Everywhere I looked, there was infinity, or the suggestion of it, stretching away in straight lines, to vanish, ultimately, in the void. I thought of a kaleidoscope, or Borges’s Library of Babel.

Excitedly, we all poked at our reflections, danced and examined ourselves from every unfamiliar angle we were reflected from, waved our hands. Thousands of torch beams shone; thousands of smiling and laughing faces were lit for a second and then vanished. It was both magical and nauseating all at once.

*‘I’d like to get out now,’* said Helen.

*‘Me too,’* said Malcolm. *‘It was fun to start with, but now, y’know, fuck this.’*

*‘Where’s the door?’* said Ruth.

*‘Oh shit, she’s right,’* said Clive. *‘Where is the door?’*

Where was the door? I was convinced it was behind me, but I realized with a rush of panic that I had lost all my bearings. It was impossible to tell where it was. In such a unique space, both endless and confining, the change in our combined mood was almost physically tangible. Helen made a low, wordless moan.

*‘Where’s the handle?’* said Clive. *‘Isn’t there a handle?’*

*‘I didn’t see one,’* said Malcolm.

*‘God, are we locked in?’* said Ella. *‘What if this thing is airtight?’*

An unusual and potent mix of claustrophobia and agoraphobia came then; a sudden, acute sense that the thing we had been working towards, all that time, tunnelling upwards, the thing which lay at the heart of the house all along, might simply be our own deaths.

Everyone's hands, bar those of Helen, who was practically hyperventilating, were thumping and slapping the mirrored walls now, smearing their pristine clarity with fingerprints, palm prints. In the midst of all this chaos, Adam reached up to the middle of one of the walls and pushed, hard. A crack the height of the room appeared, and daylight blazed from all around us.

---

We stood on the clear, empty landing of the attic space, recovering ourselves, Flayne's paintings glowering down at us from all sides. I don't know what we had expected, individually and collectively, to be in that final room, but what we found had been more than enough. Helen sat on the floorboards, her legs splayed in front of her, feet pointing upwards, lost in thought, uncharacteristically quiet.

'How did he even build that room?' said Malcolm. 'Did he get builders in?'

I laughed. 'Does that matter? *Why* would he build it, that's what *I* want to know.'

Leo shrugged. 'Maybe it was sacred to him for some reason. He had his own private mythology, this was surely to do with that.'

'If only we had the last volumes of Flayne's diaries,' said Clive thoughtfully. I glanced at Ella; she looked away.

'Maybe they were in the library,' said Helen, almost sadly.

'Why would he padlock these rooms?' said Ruth. 'I mean, they're all empty, more or less.'

No-one could offer a good reason, and there was silence for a little while. Above me, I could see a slice of blue sky framed by the distant, dust-clouded window.

'What do we do with all of it?' said Adam.

'It's ours,' said Ella. 'It belongs to us. All of these paintings, the writing, the weird sculptures... people spend their lives searching for something like this. Something visionary. Utterly singular, utterly unique.'

‘Utterly bonkers,’ said Helen. ‘Let’s get Jilly over here.’

‘No!’ Ella almost shouted. ‘No! If we get Jilly over here, she’ll go, *golly gosh, aren’t these weird*, or some other searing insight, and then she’ll make us bin them.’

Helen folded her arms. ‘Fine by me.’

‘Oh, come on!’ Ella said. ‘People need to see these. These and Flayne’s notebooks, his paintings. His entire – philosophy. We need to show people.’

Helen shook her head. ‘Bin them. Burn them. Just get rid of them.’ She looked up at Clive. ‘You’re Jilly Cowie’s deputy here, apparently. What do you recommend?’

Clive sighed heavily. ‘Anything that will make this stop.’

## 40

79. Here: I see happenings, eyes lunar-lit;  
Events. Newly *wrought*, red-apparelled.  
Prophetic pearls, each drawn round Eden's grit,  
A reckoning divine to herald.

80. Each intimation no future infers,  
Naught *in* tradition enshrined.  
Metaphysical auguries, numbers.  
Knowledge insane, not divine.

'GOOD LORD,' said Jilly Cowie, as she climbed the last steps into the attic. Clive, Helen and I had gone to retrieve her from her office, where she'd been hard at work making an insanely complicated timetable for the mountaineering club's upcoming activities, complete with a colour-coded key. I had thought, inevitably, of Flayne's final volume of illuminated poetry, and found myself wondering if mania of any kind was superior to any other. Ruth, Leo and Adam were examining the oil paintings as we returned to the landing, while Malcolm lay sprawled on the top step, yawning hugely, like a cat. Almost resentfully, he got to his feet to let us past.

Jilly took her glasses off, cleaned them on her jumper and put them back on. 'Well done for getting this far, this quickly, I must say! Quite—'

She stopped mid-sentence, and peered at the nearest canvas, which depicted the house, tiny and glowing, under a sky that was a stellar cataract, a billion light years long, filled with the luminous drifting creatures. From

there, she moved over to the ones that fell broadly into the category of portrait, strange beings with rows of crystal teeth, or cruel monarchs, cowed hoods covering cubical mineral deposits, dense clusters of silver machinery.

‘*Good Lord,*’ she said again. Her voice trembled slightly.

‘Er, believe me, these are *nothing*,’ said Helen, not even attempting to keep the pleasure of being correct about Jilly’s response out of her voice. ‘Wait until you see what’s in *here!*’ And, with a theatricality as enthusiastic as it was inappropriate, Helen flung open the door of the room where the hideous effigies sat.

The effect on Jilly Cowie, upon seeing the room’s contents, was immediate.

She gasped, and her right hand covered her mouth. In the silence of the attic, this exhalation was loud. I was closest to her; she turned to me, and I saw the bright, sharp glimmer of real fear in her eyes.

Her eyes were wide, and expressed nothing apart from a catastrophic failure to comprehend.

‘*How did he know?*’ she breathed.

I couldn’t respond: the words didn’t connect with anything I could make sense of. I was sure that only I stood close enough to her to hear what she had said. All anyone else could perceive was Jilly’s sudden and uncharacteristic alarm; even Helen looked concerned.

‘What?’ I managed. Jilly didn’t reply. All the colour had drained from her face. She took her glasses off and cleaned them again, put them back on with palpable effort, swallowed and stared, jaw clenched, at the trio of stuffed dummies around the table.

‘So...’ said Clive. ‘What do we do with them?’

‘*Burn them,*’ hissed Jilly immediately.

‘Okay,’ said Ella, ‘but I think the pictures have artistic—’

‘*Burn those too.*’ She almost spat the words. ‘Burn everything on this floor, all of it. The whole lot.’

‘You can’t—’ Ella began.

‘*I can,*’ Jilly insisted, with the same steely firmness we’d seen her display over the patient records at Marshlands. ‘You’ve already had one bonfire here. Over the course of this weekend, I want you to have another. There’s a lot of paintings, so you can leave those until Monday, if you wish. However, I want these *things*’ – she gestured at the dummies – ‘removed and burned as soon as possible.’

‘I’m going away in the morning. I don’t care what you do with the rest of tomorrow, whether you take the day off, whatever you want. However, when I come back on Monday, I want to see *this* room completely empty, and a good, healthy pile of ash outside. Everyone got that?’

‘You can’t destroy all this!’ said Ella, shaking her head.

Jilly Cowie fixed her with a look that was almost hostile.

‘*Watch me.*’

‘But it’s someone’s life’s work!’

‘And if you want to get paid, it all gets burned. *All of it.*’

Ella stayed silent this time. Jilly looked at all of us in turn, a ferocious defiance burning in her eyes.

‘Any objections?’

No-one said anything. We were all too stunned.

‘*Well then,*’ she said, and turned to leave.

---

I caught up with Jilly on the first floor landing. She didn’t stop walking, and I had to jog alongside her. For someone small of stature, her walking pace was extremely fast.

‘What just happened?’

‘You have your instructions, Mr Lane,’ she muttered, without turning round. Her usual golly-gosh demeanour had evaporated utterly. ‘I want those things destroyed.’

‘Not that. You made yourself very clear on that. I meant...’ I took a deep breath, then committed to giving voice to my suspicion, making it real. ‘When you saw them, you looked terrified.’



‘Do you blame me? Helen was right, those things are obscene.’

‘Not that,’ I said. ‘You know what I mean.’

‘I’m sure I don’t.’

‘When you saw them, you said *how did he know?* I heard you.’

Jilly stopped then. We had reached the ground floor, the bottom of the stairs, where the two wooden pillars stood like police constables at a crime scene, restricting access to the horrors beyond.

‘The others didn’t hear you, but I did.’ Jilly looked angry with herself, but I didn’t relent. ‘What did you mean?’

‘I don’t want to talk about it,’ Jilly said flatly. But she looked guilty. Withholding information in this way clearly undercut her idea of good and responsible leadership.

‘Just tell me.’

She sighed heavily, looked at the walls, and then eventually at me.

‘When I first arrived here, I spent two days up in Marshlands on my own.’ She looked away from me, into the column of gloom around which the staircase wound. ‘I had – bad dreams. Nightmares. Perfectly understandable, psychologically, but—’

I saw that her eyes were wet with tears.

‘*I saw those things,*’ she hissed. ‘*Sitting in that room.*’

She turned and walked down the hallway and out of the house, leaving me staring after her.



We were all very subdued for the rest of that day. Ella, in particular, seemed disturbed and defeated by Jilly’s orders, her violent reaction to the contents of the rooms.

Ultimately, none of us wanted to linger in the attic. So instead, we spent the rest of the working day clearing debris from the stairs, things we’d set aside in our single-minded push to the summit. By the end of the day, the whole staircase, ground floor to the very top, was completely clear, the work of almost an entire week.

---

That night, I knocked on Ella's door, but she didn't answer, either asleep or not in the mood for company. Everyone else was asleep, too, it seemed. The corridor was quiet.

But not entirely so.

I perceived it as a low drone, a grinding hum, and I thought at first someone was singing. A liturgical dirge, something medieval, perhaps. My first suspicion was that it was Helen. However, I took two steps towards the source of the noise, and found myself outside Adam's room.

The noise – the speech – emanated from within. Greater clarity merely made it more cryptic; half-spoken, half-sung, a series of words I couldn't understand. I cupped my hand to the door and strained to listen. Lyrical words, rising and falling with a strange intonation, like a recording run backwards.

Was this what he always did when alone? Or was this a new development? Which would be worse? The sheer oddness of it was unsettling in the extreme.

When I reached my room, acting on an impulse I couldn't explain, I took the single chair away from the small desk and wedged it firmly under the door handle.

# 41

81. Equivocal Xanadu! Curses encircling  
Every doomed erstwhile *divinity*.  
And beyond, see: that road, arcing, curving,  
Towards its own noxious nativity.
82. Onwards wind, downwards, each fate invert,  
Now in this emptiness, sighing.  
Under moonlight pale, under rich earth,  
A boy sings, of love undying.

THE NEXT MORNING, Jilly Cowie departed for her weekend at Scafell Pike. Before she left, she arrived in the kitchen at Marshlands, and although some of her usual cheery demeanour had been restored to her, there was still a determination and resolve to her which had previously been absent. She reminded us on no fewer than three occasions that *those things* sat in conference in the upper room should be completely destroyed by the time she returned on Monday. We nodded, wordlessly, although Ella looked furious. A little later, I saw Jilly's Mini Clubman grind its way out of Marshlands, Jilly herself comically small inside her small car. She waved abruptly at me, and was gone. I was troubled by what she had said to me yesterday, but I could make nothing useful of it; the episode already felt strange, dreamlike, so much so that I didn't even bring it up with Ella.

There seemed little point in us working that day, if we didn't have to. As she had made abundantly clear, all Jilly cared about was that the effigies

were burned; as long as that duty was performed, she didn't care what we did. Even Helen was keen on the idea of a day off.

If we were going to have a proper bonfire, it was suggested that we cook dinner on it too, which meant an expedition into town to buy groceries. I was disappointed to discover that the rota said it was my turn to go, along with Malcolm and Helen. I didn't particularly relish the thought of breaking the spell of Solace House by returning to the present day, and I especially didn't relish the prospect of doing so with Helen.

There were ways, however, of making the experience bearable.

---

Clive's door was open, and he was sitting at his desk. Something with a numbing amount of bass throbbed from his stereo speakers. He was in the final stages of rolling a joint.

'Knock knock.'

'Hey,' he said, round the joint which now hung from his lips.

'What can I do you for?'

'Nothing.' I leaned on his desk as he lit up. 'Only, it's my turn to do the shopping run, and I wondered if you could give me a couple of blasts on *that*, just to make the trip more fun. And by *more* I of course mean *any*.'

His teeth shone from behind his beard. 'Going with Helen, huh? Sure thing.' He passed me the joint. 'Actually, you know what? I'll come with you.'

'What?' I exhaled a stream of thick smoke. 'What for?'

Clive shrugged. 'I need to check something.'

'It must be pretty important,' I said, 'if it means you're prepared to share a car with Helen.' He took the joint from me.

'Important to me,' he said, as he inhaled.

---

Twenty minutes later, we stood by Malcolm's VW Golf, in the perpetual summer brilliance. Helen emerged from Marshlands, wearing a pair of

sunglasses she couldn't quite carry off.

'All ready to go?' she said cheerily.

I nodded, but didn't reply. I was very, very stoned. My mind was overwound clockwork, racing, hurtling along at a hundred miles an hour but still, somehow, staying exactly where it was.

'Great,' said Malcolm. 'Shall we?'

'Clive's coming too,' I said.

'Is he?' Helen made a face. 'Oh no.'

'I'm literally *right here*,' said Clive. 'Don't worry, I'll sit in the back with my head out of the window. I won't say a word.'

Helen frowned.

'Scout's honour!' said Clive. He chopped a hand in front of him and whistled, indicating something making a direct and simple journey. 'All the way there. Head out of window, excited, but silent. Like a dog.'

Malcolm shrugged. 'Can we just go?' We were getting into the car when Leo ran out of Marshlands towards us.

'I need some crayons,' he said through a mouthful of toast.

'Course you do,' said Clive.

'Biggest you can get. And some paper, again, biggest you can get. A3 or larger.'

'Starting work on your PhD early?' smirked Clive. 'Haha! I'm here all week.'

'I'll get you some crayons,' I said. I produced a biro from my pocket and wrote *CRAYONS* on my left hand; I was, in my current state, very liable to forget. I thought of Ella, and realized I'd have to buy some more condoms. We'd got through the few we had between us.



The day was bright and clear; the fields around Marshlands seemed enclosed under a vast dome of silence. Helen had of course made a very great fuss about getting travel sick if she sat anywhere other than the front passenger seat, so Clive and I sat in the back seat. True to his word, Clive

didn't speak, and although he did roll the window down, he didn't stick his head out of it. At length, the fields became houses, and the houses gathered into streets.

It was strange to be back in the city again. I felt as if I'd been absent for months, rather than weeks. It was so noisy, for a start, both sonically and visually; everywhere there was chatter, text, blare, statement. In my stoned condition, it was oppressive, anxiety-inducing, and I began to feel nervous. We pulled up in the car park of a huge Sainsbury's on the outskirts of the main shopping centre. No sooner had we got out than Clive immediately headed off, to pursue whatever mission he had come here to undertake.

'Be back in one hour,' said Helen. 'Or we leave without you.'

'Right you are.' Clive smiled, clearly on his best behaviour. He turned and began the long walk across the car park.

'You really will leave without him, won't you?' I said. 'If he isn't here at 11.30 sharp?'

Helen looked at me, and for once, said nothing, merely moved her head up and down in an exaggerated, very definite, nod.



The brightly lit, air-conditioned supermarket was, when one was stoned, both absolutely hilarious and utterly disturbing in equal measure.

Here were the Earth's dwindling, irreplaceable rainforests and wild places, one way or another, packed up into cans and packets. Here were whole aisles filled with the limbs and organs of cows, sheep, pigs; the bodies of fish, chickens, squid, octopus. Here were cartoon versions of some of those animals, manically insisting how delicious their dead flesh was, thumbs aloft. Here were plastic bottles of floor cleaner, washing-up liquid, shampoo, aisle upon aisle of them, each one a time capsule which would be in active household use for a couple of weeks, then buried in landfill for fifty thousand years. To mark the release of *Jurassic Park*, everything seemed to be branded with images of dinosaurs, apparently without irony. I thought of Flayne's assessment of industry and commerce

as a kind of malign magic, and it was hard, at that moment, in that state, to argue. After we'd completed the shopping, filling three trolleys with groceries, I ached to be back at Solace House, surrounded by woods and birdsong and the feeling of exhilarating wonder which charged even the most mundane parts of it. How blessed I had been to spend my summer in a fairy tale, rather than somewhere like this, stacking shelves and smoking cigarettes in the loading bay, counting the slow seconds until I could be anywhere else. How blessed.

---

The three of us packed the car. There were some special orders in there – two cans of lighter fluid for Clive, two bottles of vodka for Adam, plus Leo's crayons, and his A3 sketch pad, which I'd eventually found in an obscure, empty aisle of the supermarket dedicated to stationery and what seemed like an infinite amount of birthday cards, stretching off to the vanishing point.

'What on earth does he want these for?' said Malcolm, as I placed them on top of the shopping bags in the boot. 'He's cracked, isn't he?'

I smiled. 'I don't think so. He's eccentric, sure, but I think he knows what he's doing.' I thought of Clive's comment about Leo building a career, which I suspected was true. I could easily picture Leo on TV, a talking head on a popular archaeology show, speculating about the ancient druidic calendar, or Avebury, or whatever. '*As I say in my book, it seems likely that they used the chalk to paint the stones white.*' Wowing impressionable students with his studied otherworldliness. It seemed like a smart career path.

'Are we ready?' said Helen. She clearly hadn't forgotten the delicious prospect of leaving without Clive.

---

'Easy, tiger,' I said, checking my watch. 'Clive has precisely one hundred and twenty seconds left before you get to abandon him.'

‘Hmmm.’ This *hmmm* seemed to imply that Helen considered this to be borderline unfair. ‘Two minutes, then. Although I absolutely mean it, if he’s not here—’

‘There he is, look,’ said Malcolm. Some distance away, Clive was approaching the wooden fence which ringed the extremity of the car park. He attempted to vault the fence, almost falling flat on his face as he did so. As he approached us, I saw he was carrying a red plastic bag, which clearly held something large and flat.

‘Betcha thought I was gonna be late!’ Clive smiled infuriatingly at Helen, who, saying nothing, opened the front passenger door and climbed in.

---

After sudden scalding exposure to the late twentieth century, and the garish monomania of the supermarket, it was joyous to return to the hospital, to the house. I found that I wanted to immerse myself in Solace House and its environs, gather it around me, cloak myself in it. I didn’t doubt, in that moment, that this was what Flayne had felt, sequestered here in his self-imposed exile. I wanted all of it. I wanted to see Bewise, and Ella Flayne’s faery garden that surrounded it. I wanted to see the mirrored room, the vast staircase, the paintings. Edwin Flayne had, by accident or design, succeeded in decoupling the place from time, created a fragment of the same eternal moment of innocence William Blake strove to capture. I needed to bathe in it, delight in that long, liquid, perpetual moment that the place luxuriated in.

I found Ella, in her room, face taut in concentration, reading one of the two volumes of Flayne’s that she had liberated.

‘How was the supermarket?’ she said, without looking up.

‘Unsettling,’ I said, sitting down.

‘How so?’

‘Late capitalism.’

‘Oh right.’ She nodded, again without looking up. ‘*That.*’

‘What are we doing here?’ I asked.



‘Clearing the house,’ she said. ‘*Duh.*’

‘Not that. I mean you and me. What *are* we doing?’

‘Well now.’ Ella put the book down, stared at me seriously with her dark eyes. ‘You’ve had sexual intercourse with me no fewer than three times now, so according to my strict Puritan upbringing, you must marry me, and we must produce as many offspring as we can before I become a barren old hag of thirty.’

I nodded calmly. ‘I knew it.’

‘What happened to your parents?’ she said. I sighed.

‘My father was killed in action abroad, and my mother died of consumption soon after.’

‘Wait a minute,’ she said, thinking. ‘Wait... I know it’s Jane Austen, but... yes! Jane Fairfax in *Emma*. What happened to your parents?’

‘They were eaten by a rhinoceros.’

‘Ha! Easy. James Henry Trotter in *James and the Giant Peach*. What happened to your parents?’

‘I don’t want to talk about it,’ I said. ‘Not now. I want to talk about this, where this is going.’

‘Does it have to be going anywhere?’

‘I like you.’

‘I like you too. What of it?’

‘I just wanted to say that. If – this – becomes more, more than it currently is, then – I’m fine with that. I’d like that.’

‘Well then,’ her voice was serious, ‘you have to let me in. Tell me who you are. I want to know about you. I want to know what happened to you.’

‘In time,’ I said. ‘I will tell you. I promise.’

‘Did you remember to get condoms?’

‘I did.’

She nodded. ‘Well then,’ she said again. In one deft movement, she lifted her elbows and pulled her T-shirt over her head and off.

‘Sorry, what’s happening?’

‘Oh God, don’t make me paint a picture,’ she said, reaching behind her back to unhook her bra.

‘Oh right,’ I said. ‘*That.*’

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## 42

83. Those embers, charred remnants, entirely able  
To incriminate, or nothing swear,  
*Each* new dawn, corrupt. Hell enabled,  
And those evils dismantled repaired.

84. Events grow anarchic. Revolt, discord.  
Every deed's end now abstruse.  
Lives left to *Hell's* ingenuity, not God's.  
Spurned, our excuses refused.

LATER, WE LAY in each other's arms, not talking, for what felt like a long time, until hunger roused us and we got dressed. The joint, and the day off work, had warped my sense of time: I was surprised to note it was only 2.30 in the afternoon. I left Ella's room half-expecting Adam to be outside, like a weird, psychopathic Greyfriars Bobby, lying faithfully on the grave of his doomed crush, but he wasn't around. Nobody was. Marshlands felt deserted.

We found Leo alone in the kitchen. He was packing a rucksack: I saw a torch, candles, matches, and the crayons and paper he'd asked for earlier. He'd taken the cardboard backing off the sketch pad and had rolled the pages into a scroll, tied with an elastic band. He smiled at us as we came in.

'You might want to keep it down next time. All I could hear was you two grinding away at each other.'

'Shit,' I said. 'Could you hear us?'

‘Ha!’ he said. ‘I knew it! No, I couldn’t hear you. I just suspected you two had become, uh, *close*, but I wanted to know for sure.’

‘Well, now you know,’ said Ella, matter of factly. ‘You have fun with that information. God, I’m hungry. Gonna make myself a cheese toastie, using Adam’s exquisite Roquefort. You want one?’

‘Is Adam okay with you stealing his cheese?’

‘Oh yeah,’ said Ella. ‘I mean, I always leave a note.’

‘I thought you were a vegetarian, anyway?’ said Leo.

‘Yeah. I eat cheese, though, good God. I’m a vegetarian, not a fucking lunatic.’

I shook my head. ‘I’ll just have toast. Dare I ask what the hell you’re doing, Dexter?’

Leo smiled.

‘I’m planning to spend tonight in that cave. At Bewise. I’m going over there now, to do a recce first.’

‘Is that, uh, wise?’ said Ella, putting two slices of bread under the grill. ‘No pun intended.’

‘I’ll be careful,’ said Leo. ‘It’s just too tempting a prospect not to, though. The carvings there, I think they’re unknown to anyone else. And so’ – he snapped the elastic band around the tube of sketch pad pages – ‘I want to survey them.’

‘Ah!’ said Ella. ‘The crayons. You’re going to do some brass rubbing. *Sans* brass.’

‘Correct.’

I remembered something. ‘Leo, do you still have those mushrooms?’

‘Oh yeah,’ he smiled. ‘They’re in the freezer, in a big ice cream tub. Way more than I need.’

‘You haven’t taken them yet? Wow.’ Ella raised her eyebrows. ‘I believe it was Anton Chekhov who said that if you introduce a shedload of hallucinogenic mushrooms in Act One, you have to do them all by the end of Act Three at the latest.’

He laughed. ‘Uh-huh,’ he said. ‘Chekhov’s mushrooms.’

‘You’re going to share them with us, right?’

‘Some of them. But not all. I have a plan. Like I said.’

I whistled. ‘*You’re going to do them inside the cave. Tonight!*’

Leo nodded. ‘It’s the best way to read that environment. To free myself of the last three thousand years of cultural conditioning and engage with the site as the Neolithic people did.’

I felt a twinge of unease. ‘Is that safe? What if you lose it? I don’t know, climb the cliff face thinking you can fly or something?’

‘Then he’s an idiot,’ said Ella. ‘*Birds take off from the ground.*’

‘Ha!’ I laughed. ‘Bill Hicks.’

She grinned. ‘Love that guy. Look, how many times have you done this, Leo?’

Leo did a quick mental calculation. ‘About twelve times, something like that.’

‘Then I think he’ll be fine,’ said Ella. ‘Only, Leo?’

‘Yes?’

‘Promise me you won’t have sex with any of the carvings.’

Leo sighed, nodded his head with mock solemnity. ‘You know I can’t promise that. But I’ll try.’ He shouldered his rucksack. ‘I’m going on a recce now. Either of you want to come with me? See the cavern?’

‘The bad vibes cave? I don’t think so,’ said Ella briskly. ‘I mean, I plan on seeing it eventually, but there’s some reading I need to do first.’ She smiled at me. ‘Alex, you should go. Tell me how it is.’

‘Okay,’ I said. I was curious.

---

Fifteen minutes later, Leo and I marched past the others, sleeping or reading on the grass, and made our way over to the jungle behind Solace House. Malcolm hollered after us, asking where we were going; at Leo’s single shouted reply – *cave* – I saw him grimace and go back to reading his book. None of the others stirred.

Solace House seemed asleep, slumbering in the bright sunshine, brick and tile gleaming like the hide of a great reptile. We made our way round

the fox path, then traversed the overgrown garden with its islands of bramble, to find ourselves in the dark wood that had, at one time, been a maze. The yews seemed denser, more tangled, than last time. I stumbled and cursed behind Leo, who again seemed to navigate the woods without effort.

And then we were in the garden where the metallic blue damselflies fizzled in the summer air like sparklers, and the sunlight poured itself like molten gold over the black water of the pond, and for a few seconds at least, words were not necessary.

‘What are you hoping to find in there, all high as a kite?’ I asked. ‘What are you hoping to see?’

He looked at me with an expression I couldn’t read. Eventually, he put the rucksack down.

‘I’m hoping to see what they saw, as they saw it. When they went into that cave. When they went into any sacred ritual space, in the correct conditions.’

‘You’ve said that,’ I said. ‘But honestly, they probably just saw the inside of a cave. Albeit with decent visuals, if they did drugs.’

‘I think it was probably a little more significant than that,’ said Leo.

‘Really?’ I snorted. ‘Only, my mate Chris did acid in the first year of sixth form and spent the entire evening talking to a bollard because he thought it was Sonic the Hedgehog. Not everything is profound, Leo. Face it, there’s no great revelation in there, or anywhere else. Just you, and a bunch of chemicals ravaging your nervous system.’

‘That’s one way of looking at it,’ he said. ‘Sure. But it’s only one. The system of thought we live in now – call it capitalism, patriarchy, whatever – encourages us to believe that humans have always been as they are now. Obsessed with status, and money, and property, and their actions can only be understood through that lens, and that’s all that there is, has, and ever will be.’

‘I see,’ I said. ‘Or, to quote the poet-philosopher Ice Cube, *Life ain’t nuthin’ but bitches and money.*’

‘If you like.’ Leo laughed, then ceased abruptly. ‘Only that’s bullshit. Humans of indigenous cultures, even now, the few that remain, have a mindset indescribably different to ours. That goes double for the people of five, ten, fifty thousand years ago, with no written language, no fixed concept of time, and a much closer connection to nature.

‘I believe that at some of these places, they put themselves into altered states, either through exhaustion, starvation, trance, self-flagellation, or narcotics, or a combination of all of those things. Or even via some method we don’t know, long lost. Either way, they did it because they wanted to travel to another place, to see the world through non-human eyes. Or, *see it as it actually is*, not through the human—’ and here he said either *prism* or *prison*, but turned away as he did so, so I would never know for sure. Inevitably, I thought of Flayne, and his aspiration to realms unimaginable, and wondered for a split second if I should break mine and Ella’s pact of secrecy and tell him about the missing volumes.

‘So you’re hoping,’ I said eventually, ‘to visit another realm? One you say was accessible to the people who carved those spirals?’

‘It’s more relevant now than ever to travel to that place and bring back knowledge.’

I thought, and then phrased my thoughts in such a way that it would not reveal anything of mine and Ella’s discoveries.

‘Ella Flayne thought this was a *Thin Place*,’ I said, ‘a place where the vale between this world and another realm was permeable, and Edwin Flayne said it too. And that book you found, the history one, at Marshlands? All that stuff about dumping lunatics here. Maybe they were just... drawn here anyway. Maybe they could see something no-one sane could.’

Leo looked through me, back to the edge of the yew wood. ‘The bridge between the left and right brain is in part formed by something called the corpus callosum. There’s a theory that this structure was much more developed in prehistoric peoples, as their rational brains weren’t so tied up with constantly decoding language and symbol. That there was much greater communication between the world of the conscious and the unconscious, and we could see things then that we can’t see now, because

we're effectively lobotomized. *A whole different experience of creation itself.*

'Faeryland,' I said flatly. Leo laughed.

'Who knows? The world of spirits, magic. Hyperspatial higher dimensions, if you like. Only perceivable now under certain circumstances, and then, only briefly.' He shouldered his backpack again, as if to indicate that the conversation was over, and began striding towards the sun-warmed stone of Bewise.

Something occurred to me.

'Leo,' I asked, 'have you been there before?'

'What?'

'Have you ever been to – that place – before?'

He smiled, a private smile.

'I've been close,' he said, almost wistfully. 'Once. West Kennet Long Barrow, a couple of years ago. Lying in the dark, the womb of the Earth... I did a low dose of LSD that time, and Kundalini breathing exercises, and I suddenly felt as if the place wasn't – solid any more. I felt...' His voice cracked with emotion, as if he were describing a tragedy.

'I felt that the door *opened*, there. Just a sliver, a crack. And I saw... But I was too...' – he searched for the correct word – '*... awestruck* to go in.'

He shouldered the rucksack once more, muttered something which I sensed was intended for himself, not me.

*'I won't make that mistake again.'*



## 43

85. Centre of my entrapment, rewriting  
Each grey and rudderless day.  
Each day engendering nothing, eliding,  
As, reposing, this *horror* lay.

86. Years now elapse; eons duly spent,  
Nature or willpower offending.  
Universe: *that* preposterous accident –  
Calamity endless descending.

THE INTERIOR of Bewise was, after the luminous summer afternoon, pitch dark, but after a few seconds resolved itself into the dank green-black cube we had visited before. Leo produced two torches, flicked both of them on and passed one to me, before producing the iron key and inserting it into the lock. The mechanism turned smoothly now, with a well-oiled click.

He led the way through the winding passageway, through the rock, and into darkness.

I was already starting to have grave misgivings about crawling through the tiny hollow to the cavern beyond, but I felt I couldn't back out now. We reached the dead end of the large passageway, with the aperture, at head height, that Leo had squeezed into when we first found the place. Leo gave me a leg up and I squirmed, head first, into the gap, my hand clapping the torch against the rock. The beam flickered momentarily.

I immediately felt panic.

The space was so much smaller than I imagined, and so very *real*: all I could think about were the thousands of tons of rock surrounding me, and myself so small and crushable, so completely inconsequential to the hillside, the rock, the Earth itself; with the tiniest shrug and shift, it could blink and flatten me out of existence. I tried to control my breathing; the nerves in my fingertips tingled. What if it did collapse? What if the whole idiot hillside suddenly slumped, pressing down with its million-ton weight? What if this tunnel gave way after we reached the cave, trapping us inside forever, to slowly starve in total darkness, beyond the reach of human rescue? I crawled on, like a worm in an apple, and tried to swallow my fear.

Mercifully, before panic overcame me, the tunnel opened up, funnelling suddenly outwards into a much larger space. Half-falling unceremoniously out on the other side, I scrambled to my feet, shining the torch in wonder.

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‘You okay?’ said Leo, dusting himself down.

‘Fine,’ I muttered. ‘Just been through a stone birth canal, but yeah. God, *look* at this place.’

The cavern was enormous, church-sized. The ceiling was far enough away to dilute the torch beam to a weak blur; I saw a vast, irregular canopy of raw rock, upon which distant stalactites glistened. The floor, meanwhile, sloped slowly, then aggressively, downwards, towards a central well, the Gabriel’s Horn which dropped with sudden and brutal verticality into the abyss. I shouted and clapped my hands; the sound returning to me in jagged, broken waves. At the far end of the cavern, at the left-hand corner of the irregular space, another tunnel wound away, still deeper into the hillside.

‘*You see?*’ said Leo. His voice, flattened by tons of stone, was hoarse with excitement. ‘The word *cave* doesn’t do it justice.’

‘Too right,’ I said. Almost against my wishes, I was irresistibly drawn to the centre of the cave, the silent black hole plunging into absolute

nothingness. I got as close as I dared, craned my neck to peer. ‘How deep do you think that is?’

‘Not sure,’ said Leo. ‘Here. Take my hand. And do *not* let go.’ Before I could object, he’d grabbed my hand and was leaning outwards, using me as a counterweight. He shone his torch down into the jet-black well.

‘*Really not keen on this,*’ I said, my voice sounding more panicked than I intended.

‘I’m almost—’ He shifted his feet. I actively tried to pull him away; he actively tried to pull himself closer. ‘—there.’

‘Can you see the bottom?’

‘Nope.’ Carefully, he kicked a pebble, which rolled, then plummeted, into the hole.

We listened. Five seconds. Ten. Twenty. Perhaps a minute passed by before we unfroze, and I pulled Leo back to level ground.

‘Doesn’t bear thinking about,’ he said, grinning. I pulled him back to the side, and safety.

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‘How old is this place?’

‘Ancient,’ said Leo. ‘Older than humanity, although humans made use of it.’ He pointed his torch at the wall: for the first time I saw the whirlpool patterns of concentric circles carved into the wall, like raindrop ripples on the surface of a pond.

‘Is this a burial chamber?’

Leo shook his head. ‘I don’t know. I don’t think so.’

The torch beam rested on a single carving. Hidden here, away from people and the weather, it was remarkably fresh-looking, although it was undoubtedly ancient, older than the act of writing. At first I had taken it to be simply a series of concentric circles, but I saw now that it was a spiral.

‘A unicursal maze,’ said Leo. ‘Or the so-called *cup and ring* mark. Here, hold the torch.’

I held the light steady while Leo fished in his rucksack. He came up with the roll of paper, a roll of gaffer tape and a purple crayon. He bit off rectangles of tape and secured the corner of one sheet to the cave wall, almost completely covering the spiral carving, although its edges still poked out on three sides. Holding the purple crayon side-on, he proceeded to drag it carefully across the paper, almost caressing an image into being.

All the while, he talked, about the spiral, and what he believed it meant to the people who carved it, in one, long, seemingly unbroken monologue, pausing only to chastise me if I didn't hold the torch straight.

Eventually, he had a beautiful impression of the spiral design, captured on the paper like a fossil.

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'I think this was a place they came to,' he said eventually, rolling up the spiral image and carefully sealing it in the roll of paper. 'The people who carved this. New, or maybe even old, Stone Age. They didn't live here, that's clear, so maybe they came here for a ritual purpose. Maybe it was a place for purification by ordeal. They came here, and had to stay here for a set amount of time.'

Something occurred to him, and he smiled.

'Turn the torch off.'

'What? No!'

The stone walls gave Leo's voice a commanding edge. 'Just turn it off.'

I did as I was told. Instantly, everything ceased to exist. The darkness was absolute, the universe of the far future, after the stars had gone out and there was nothing, not even a single final flickering proton. Just endless, eternal emptiness.

'What did you say earlier?' Leo's voice was shockingly loud in the dark. 'About a birth canal?'

'Forget it,' I said. 'I was just being flippant.'

'No,' said Leo, from somewhere in the infinite nothing. 'I think your first instinct was correct. I think this was a ritual space, but...'

The silence was immense, the darkness a cold, corrosive solution you could easily dissolve in. And yet, despite my unease, I didn't interrupt: Leo was doing the thing he'd come down here to do. He was *reading the space*.

'Yes,' he said carefully. 'Yes... They would have come down here, outside, in procession, to the cave mouth. No Bewise then. They would have been drugged. They would have bid their loved ones goodbye. And then they would have entered, or been taken, into the cave. Into the womb of the Earth. Left here alone. The cave would have been sealed. Yes. *They would have been sealed there, in the darkness.*' For a second, this image was so clear, so utterly correct, that I forgot it was conjecture. And yet, Leo's instinct seemed to transcend guesswork, seemed to describe a fact you knew already, deep within your bones.

'In that darkness they would have experienced – what? Beyond the immediate. What did they have here?'

What would they have experienced here, if they were abandoned alone for a night, for a day? What would have gone through their brains, their hearts? What would they orient themselves towards, in this zone of total absence? I put my hand out too suddenly to steady myself, and my knuckles scraped the carving.

'Imagine,' said Leo. 'Coming out of here, back into the world, of light and shape and colour. Remember, Bewise wasn't here then. So when they came here – when Ella Flayne first saw it – you just climbed straight down into a gap in the rock. And your family and friends most probably rolled a stone over the entrance to seal you in.'

I shivered. 'You'd really have to trust them.'

'Maybe that was part of it,' said Leo. 'Yes. There's a similar ritual involving the ingestion of iboga that the Bwiti practitioners of Gabon perform. I think I recall that in that, initiates are isolated in huts. Maybe that's what happened here. You were brought back to the world by the people you love. *Symbolically reborn!* Yes! You were put in at night! You were taken out at dawn, so that you could experience the new day rising, alongside your new self.'

'*You had awakened,*' I breathed.

‘Yes,’ said Leo. ‘You had come alive, been reborn, after travelling – somewhere else.’

‘Where? Their unreachable realm? Or Flayne’s hyperspatial dimension beyond time? Or Ella Flayne’s faeryland?’

Leo shrugged. ‘Why not all three?’ I couldn’t tell if he was serious. I thought I might want to turn the torch back on the second the opportunity presented itself, but in that moment, I refused to break the spell.

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## 44

87. With its terrible history distorted,  
A maze now all *blind* life encloses.  
Of blind justice, each catastrophe thwarted;  
Of blind terror's apotheosis.

88. In nebulousness, each day, mankind addressed.  
Days engrossed in nervous *confession*.  
Of reading, remembering, under protest,  
This infernal Bible's lesson.

BACK IN THE KITCHEN at Marshlands, I rummaged in the fridge, looking for cold drinks. To my amusement, there was already a note to Adam in there, on the yellow legal paper Ella always used, apologizing profusely for stealing his cheese. Somehow, I didn't think he'd mind. I found two cans of someone else's 7 Up, which Leo and I drank gratefully in one draft.

'Be careful,' I said, crushing the empty can.

Leo looked confused. 'What do you mean?'

'In that cave, tonight. You're going to be in that darkness, and you're gonna take mushrooms. That *is* the plan, right?'

'It is.'

'Well, for fuck's sake, be careful. You've seen how steep that cave floor gets all of a sudden. If you fell down that hole, no-one would ever find you.'

'What hole?' Adam said, turning around. He had been sitting in one of the ancient leather armchairs in the kitchen, facing away from us. Neither of

us had noticed he was there.

‘Jesus, Adam,’ I said. ‘Turn down your camouflage reflex, huh? You scared the shit out of me.’ He ignored me, and instead repeated his question to Leo.

‘The cave,’ said Leo. ‘At Bewise. Remember? Once you go through the passage, there’s an aperture you have to crawl through, then it opens out into a vast cave.’

‘And there’s a... hole in the floor?’

‘Yeah,’ said Leo. ‘In the dead centre of it. About ten feet across. The whole cave drops off steeply towards it. I kicked a pebble down there, see what would happen.’

‘We couldn’t even hear it hit the bottom,’ I said, more to see if I could get Adam to acknowledge me than any desire to answer his question. ‘So God only knows how deep it goes.’

‘Wow.’ Adam’s voice, although still its usual insubstantial whisper, was filled with something resembling enthusiasm. ‘I’d like to see it for myself.’

‘Well, sadly, it’s booked tonight,’ I said. ‘Leo’s going over there to do drugs and speculative archaeology. But any day after that, until, ooh, the end of time, I imagine it’s pretty free.’

Adam smiled, his strange, under-rehearsed smile, at this joke. And for once, I was glad to see it; it perhaps meant he’d accepted the reality around him, accepted I was with Ella now, that we were an item.

Perhaps.

---

Clive’s door was shut, but it vibrated with bright, extravagant sound from his stereo. I knocked, and, despite expecting him not to hear me, he threw the door open immediately.

‘Come in!’ he said. ‘Listen to this!’

I listened. The vocals, the guitar sound – everything about the track – was unmistakeably the work of one band.



‘It’s Queen,’ I said, shrugging. ‘Freddie, God rest his soul, giving it all he’s got, as per.’

‘I bought it today,’ he said. ‘But I wasn’t intending to. Have you heard this song before?’

I listened. Had I? It was clearly very early Queen, before ‘Bohemian Rhapsody’, certainly before their renaissance at Live Aid, after which they became all power ballads and fist pumps. This was something else altogether; a cavalcade of whimsical imagery, with an unusual arrangement. There was also a harpsichord, chattering away manically, for some reason.

‘No,’ I said eventually. ‘I think I’d have remembered, if I had.’

‘*Exactly!*’ Clive almost spat the word. There was something slightly frenzied about his expression. ‘I *definitely* do not remember this song at all. Or rather’ – he held up an index finger – ‘I *do*. But it was completely different. And not by Queen.’

‘Right,’ I smiled. ‘How much weed have you smoked today?’

‘Fuck off,’ he said, in a businesslike fashion, as if my question were some tedious technicality that had been expected, foreseen, and therefore had to be brushed off as quickly as possible. ‘This isn’t something I invented. This song is called “The Fairy Feller’s Master-Stroke”, by – as you say – Queen. It’s about the painting we were talking about the other week, remember? The one Ella mentioned?’

I remembered. ‘Richard Dadd.’

Clive nodded. ‘Yeah, him. Anyway, at the time, I mentioned that Led Zep wrote a song about him. Yeah?’

‘Yeah,’ I said, not really understanding why Clive was so agitated about any of this. ‘So?’

‘I really liked Zeppelin, as a kid,’ said Clive. ‘Growing up, they were very much *my band*. And I know their *oeuvre*, so to speak. And I know – for a *fact* – that they did a song called “The Fairy Feller’s Master-Stroke”, about that painting.’

‘So?’ I said. ‘Two bands can write about the same thing, right?’ I thought for a moment. ‘I mean, both Iron Maiden and Andrew Lloyd

Webber did something called *The Phantom of the Opera*. With, y'know, wildly differing results.'

'True,' said Clive. 'But *I remember the song*. It was on *Led Zep III*. Side Two. Not the album with "Stairway", before you ask.'

'Great,' I said. I was still unable to see the point of this discussion. 'Does it sound similar to the Queen one?'

'That's just it,' said Clive. '*The song doesn't exist*.'

I laughed. 'It does, Clive. We just heard it.'

'Not the Queen one, idiot. The Zep one. It's not on the album.'

'So? You just misremembered which middle-aged-man rock band of yore recorded a song. It happens.'

Clive shook his head. There was an unusual vehemence, an almost childish defiance, in the gesture. 'I *wouldn't* have forgotten something like that. I remember the tune, really clearly, some of the words. Even the guitar solo.'

'Again,' I said, 'maybe they just covered the Queen one. Or vice versa.'

'That was what the guy in the shop said. But they don't sound anything like each other,' said Clive. 'The Queen one is... well, you just heard it. Upbeat, a celebration. The Zeppelin one is... *elegiac*, with... a yearning quality, if we want to get all pretentious music journalist about it. I mean, there *are* similarities, in places, and they both use the word *Tatterdemalion*. But... that's it.'

'And it's definitely not on any Led Zep album?'

Clive shook his head. 'Nope. They had 'em all in the record shop, and I checked. The guy in the shop couldn't recall it either.' He looked insistently at me. 'I mean, I even checked on fucking *Coda*. Not on any of 'em.'

'Which shop was it?'

'Ragged Records, the one in the underpass.'

I suppressed a laugh. 'Clive, I've been to that shop. The guy who runs it is just as bombed all the time as you are.' It was amusing to think of two men who conducted their lives at the medical limits of cannabis intake attempting to solve a task involving memory. And yet. Clive, who took everything so flippantly, seemed completely serious – unnerved, even –

about this matter, and it was unsettling to see him like this, especially about something which seemed to have absolutely no wider consequence whatsoever.

‘Not even under a different name?’ I asked cautiously. ‘Maybe you’re misremembering the title, maybe Zeppelin called it something different?’

Clive shook his head.

‘Maybe it was something on a bootleg,’ I suggested. ‘Or you read about it somewhere, and it was an entirely different band. Or they talked about it in an interview, but never recorded it.’ Clive shook his head again.

*‘I remember the fucking tune!’* And there was the merest note of panic in his voice. He looked devastated with himself, like someone asked to explain something they are an expert in, who, in that instant, finds they’ve forgotten everything about the subject.

‘Clive,’ I said softly, after a few moments. ‘Human memory is a liar. And that goes times a million for pothead memory. And you, Clive, you smoke a *colossal* amount of pot. You can’t expect your memory to be a reliable witness.’

He looked at me, deep in thought. For a second, he seemed lost, boyish. I smiled at him, as affably as I could.

‘You can’t rule straight lines with a banana.’

‘No,’ he said eventually. ‘No, I suppose not.’ Something in that analogy seemed to restore his sense of the absurd, and he grinned, the usual broad Clive grin of white teeth shining through his beard. But the smile appeared contaminated, somehow.

## 45

89. Eden's sane is not sane. No order withstands,  
    *Enduring* reality as suffering  
Eventual decay, as nature demands.  
Ruin unfurls into nothing.

90. O, uncountable span I now surpass,  
    Incessant grey hours, turgid.  
Noble opportunity wasted. Gone, alas!  
In nullity *endless* deserted.

SOMEWHERE ALONG THE WAY, the idea of Leo heading off to spend a night in the cave and the plan to burn the three grotesque effigies became linked, and it was decided that the bonfire would become a joint ceremony to mark both occasions. It was also decided that the bonfire should not be at the front of the house, as before, but would instead take place at the little secret scenic paradise we had found, in front of Bewise.

This would mean a lot more fetching and carrying of things back and forth – not least the effigies themselves – but what we would have to endure in manual labour was, we all decided, more than made up for by the chance to spend an evening in a place of such tranquil beauty, unknown to the rest of the world.

As Ella said, how often does that happen?

---

When the moment came to move the effigies from the attic, there was some debate over who would carry them.

As nobody was keen to touch them, let alone move them, it was decided we'd draw straws. Three of us would be paired with an effigy it was then our job to escort downstairs; five of us would be spared the experience.

Ruth went first; she drew a short straw.

'Inevitable,' she said. 'Pick on the Goth girl, Fate, why don't you?' She shook her fist at the sky.

Leo went next, and drew a long straw; Clive went next, and drew a short. Malcolm, Adam and I all drew long straws, and Helen, much to her disgust, drew the final short straw.

This left Malcolm, Ella, Adam, Leo and me without any hideous baggage, and so I volunteered to go to the kitchen and organize cooking supplies, while they trooped off to build a bonfire. I should have left Solace House with them, but something made me linger.

I wanted to see what happened when the effigies were moved, what they were made of, and if they would give up any hint as to their purpose, before their ordained destruction. And so I followed Clive, Ruth and Helen upstairs.

---

The dummies, it turned out, were not heavy, but they were unpleasant to touch. The one Clive picked up, the one painted with blue waves, had been partly stuffed with straw, and its floppy, listless arms embraced him drunkenly as he carried it out of the room, cursing. The second one, the skeleton, which Ruth picked up, had been given articulated limbs, which swung and squeaked as they moved; the arms and legs spasming unpredictably, like the limbs of a dying insect. Ruth squealed with an uncharacteristic failure of dignity when the dummy, jointed in a way that only Flayne understood, jerked as if it were coming to life. After they had escorted their macabre partners downstairs, as if to a dance, there was only Helen and me left.

‘Okay, Helen,’ I said. ‘Your turn.’ She was sitting behind the last dummy, the one painted with flames; I couldn’t see her face.

After a short pause, I heard her say, ‘*What do you think these things are?*’

Her tone was unfamiliar; a note of uncertainty had crept into her voice.

I laughed. ‘You’re asking me? I have absolutely no idea. Flayne was completely gone. Trying to fathom why he did anything he did is just meeting him halfway, on his terms.’

‘But you must have your suspicions.’ Again, she did not sound as she usually did. I wondered where this was going.

‘Yeah,’ I said eventually. ‘But I don’t think it runs any deeper than the fact he was both mad and... lonely.’ I answered slowly, careful not to reveal any hints of further insight from the two volumes that Ella had. ‘We can’t forget that. Maybe these were his friends. Maybe he came up here and ate dinner with them.’

Helen shook her head. ‘No. He never came up here.’

‘What do you think, then?’

Helen was concealed by the dummy again, which seemed to have interposed itself between us, its screaming, charred face caught in a moment of perpetual torment. She didn’t seem to have heard me, so I repeated the question. When she did answer, she had turned entirely away from me, so whatever she said was lost.

‘I’m sorry?’ I said. ‘I didn’t hear you.’

She almost hissed the words.

‘*I think they’re us.*’

I nearly laughed. ‘Helen,’ I said slowly. ‘There are three of them. And eight of us.’

‘It doesn’t matter,’ she said. ‘We’ve been given the correct ones.’

‘What are you talking about?’

Helen shook her head. ‘I can’t speak for the others, but I picked the one painted with flames.’

‘So?’

Helen still wasn't looking at me. 'All my life, I've been afraid of Hell. Ever since I first learned of it. Why wouldn't I choose flames?'

I sighed. It had been almost funny at first, but now I was bored of it. 'Helen, you know when you read your daily horoscope, and—'

'This isn't like that,' she said sharply. She still wasn't looking at me.

'I think you're stretching the facts to fit a pattern here.'

I expected her to be argumentative; she merely shrugged. She got up, placing her hands on the final effigy.

'If you say so.'



Leo was in the kitchen, brewing a large pan of something that looked like soup, but smelled of cinnamon.

'What's that for?' I said, before realizing that I knew exactly what it was for. 'Oh, I get it. Magic mushroom soup, for your one-man cave rave.'

'Spot on.' Leo stirred the mixture with a wooden spoon. 'Only it's not soup, it's chai, and it's not a rave, it's – as always – an experiment in archaeological perspective.'

'Did you use them all?'

'God, no! Did you see how many I picked? There's still tons of them in the freezer.'

'You clearly labelled them, right? So no-one puts them in, like, a risotto?'

Leo looked squarely at me as if mortally offended.

'The *idea*,' he said, 'that *any* of you savages know how to make a risotto.'

'Fair point. Are you nervous?'

He laughed. 'Obviously.'



We picked our way through the overgrown garden behind Solace House, carrying food, booze and blankets. Despite the extravagant heat of the day,

the velvet black spaces under the yew trees were cold, as I had begun to suspect they always were. And then we were in the secret garden, where the small lake rippled in the faint breeze, and Bewise stood out, shining purple and orange in the dusk.

However creepy the dummies looked seated round their table, they looked infinitely worse seated atop a bonfire.

‘Who wants to set them alight?’ said Ruth. No-one answered. We all just stared at the effigies, on the pyre of dead yew branches and rushes that Ella, Adam and Malcolm had built. The unreality of Solace House, the madness of Edwin Flayne and the strangeness of every aspect of this place, which we’d all learned to ignore, crowded in on me afresh.

‘God, I hope no-one stumbles in on us,’ muttered Leo, ‘and we have to explain what we’re doing here.’

‘I thought pagan re-enactment was very much *your thing*,’ said Ella. She bent down to fuss with some stray twigs at the base of the fire.

‘It is,’ said Leo. ‘And it’s a million miles from whatever unholy shit this is.’

‘For the last time,’ I said, ‘I wish to register a protest. I don’t think we should be burning any of Flayne’s artwork, no matter how unsettling.’

‘Duly noted,’ said Clive. ‘But we all want to keep working here, right? Everyone likes money? A regular income?’

Slowly, everyone nodded. Adam’s jaw clenched, as if he were about to speak, but the moment passed.

‘Who wants to set them alight?’ repeated Ruth.

‘Are we sure they’re safe to burn?’ said Helen. ‘What if they’re made of asbestos or something?’

‘Oh yeah,’ smirked Clive. ‘*Wouldn’t wanna burn the asbestos.*’

‘You know what I mean!’ Helen barked, instantly furious. ‘What if they’re full of dangerous chemicals, or something that explodes, or makes poisonous fumes or something?’

Ella raised her eyebrows. ‘She has a point.’

‘Okay, we’ll stand well back,’ said Clive, ‘and downwind.’

I laughed. ‘They’re not fireworks, Clive.’



‘Shit fireworks if they are,’ muttered Malcolm.

‘I said, *who wants to set them* – oh fuck it, I’ll do it.’ Ruth held a match to a clutch of dry white reeds, gathered from the edge of the lake. They went up instantly. She put this torch to the rolls of ancient newspaper stuffed between twigs at the base of the bonfire, which also took immediately. Within minutes, the dummies were engulfed in flame.

Nobody spoke for a while; we all simply watched as each individual effigy reacted, in a way particular to its construction, to being engulfed by fire. One collapsed inwards on itself, the other two, their wooden bones revealed, glowed with raging heat, settling in defiantly to await extinction. The flame-painted dummy, which had so fascinated and appalled Helen, was the last to catch, but when it did, the fire had reached such an intensity that the thing screamed as it burned, air escaping from somewhere in a protracted hiss.

‘There you go, Helen,’ I said at last, after the remains of this last dummy slumped over into the blaze. ‘All destroyed. And nothing bad happened!’

Helen turned to look at me for a second, as if she’d forgotten who I was. ‘I’m going back to my room.’ She turned and left.

---

Once the dummies were ash, we began to burn more yew branches, their dead needles fizzing like hot fat. We also began to get drunk, slowly at first, but with much more dedication as the evening wore on. I had removed the grill from the cooker at Marshlands, and Clive stood it over glowing orange and grey charcoal retrieved from the core of the fire, on which sausages and burgers oozed and spat. The summer night was pleasantly cool, scented with pollen and the clean, clear odour of the nearby lake. Even Adam, that pale strange boy, deep and dark and still as the lake itself, seemed to relax and unclench, his body language becoming more fluid as he reclined on the grass.

‘Shouldn’t someone check on Helen?’ said Ruth eventually. ‘She seemed upset.’

Clive belched. ‘She’s always upset.’

‘I mean it,’ said Ruth. ‘What if she’s, I dunno, self-harming or something?’

‘I don’t think she’s the type,’ I said. ‘I mean, I’ll go and check on her if you like.’ And yet, I didn’t move. I was comfortable.

‘Do you think she’s crackers?’ Ruth poked the fire with a branch. Somewhere, in the glowing heart of the fire, were the remaining particles of Flayne’s effigies, the only traces of them that now existed, outside of our memories.

‘Yes,’ said Clive, without hesitation. He was lying on his back again, fully stretched out, like a bear in a cave. ‘Completely.’



As dusk darkened into night, Leo pulled out his plastic flask. It was time, he seemed to be saying.

‘What’s that?’ said Clive.

‘Magic mushroom chai,’ said Leo. ‘I’m preparing to *read the site*, remember?’

‘Well, pass it over,’ said Clive.

Leo looked almost teacherly. ‘Don’t drink it all.’ He handed the beaker to Clive, who took a large gulp.

‘Pass it round if you like,’ said Leo. ‘There’s probably enough for everyone to have a sip.’ Clive shrugged and passed it to me. I took a small, cautious mouthful and got some chunks of mushroom; slimy and waterlogged, but still fibrous as coconut matting. The spices couldn’t disguise the taste of soil. I swallowed them as quickly as I could, passing the beaker to Ruth. She sipped the mixture demurely, making a face as she did so, and passed it to Malcolm, who gave a When-in-Rome shrug and sipped. He passed it to Adam, who was off somewhere in his own thoughts.

Adam took a second to realize what was happening, what he was being offered. And then he was on his feet, backing away, as if Malcolm had offered him a live scorpion.

‘No,’ he breathed forcefully. *‘Not doing that.’*

‘Ah, go on,’ said Clive. ‘Couple of mouthfuls won’t kill you.’

‘Clive!’ Ella snapped. ‘Don’t force drugs onto people if they don’t want them!’

‘It’ll do him good,’ said Clive. ‘Psilocybin brings you right out of yourself. It’s like free therapy.’ Once more, Adam physically recoiled. His hands were raised, almost as if he were prepared for a fight.

‘Alright,’ said Clive, holding up his hands. ‘No drugs for Adam, sheesh. I get it.’

‘Did you have a bad experience?’ asked Malcolm kindly and with genuine concern.

Adam nodded vociferously, and muttered, almost under his breath, *‘Let’s reason with the worst that may befall.’*

‘Wow,’ I said. ‘Must have been bad if you’re quoting Shakespeare.’

Something about this apparently bland remark seemed to have an instantaneous effect on Ella. Her eyes widened and her mouth opened, as if processing some great shock, some terrible realization.

‘What is it?’ I said softly. She barely heard me, taking a couple of seconds to recover herself.

‘What? Yeah, sorry. It was nothing.’ Even as she said these words, she looked away.

Adam, meanwhile, looked even sicker and paler than usual. I felt genuinely sorry for him. ‘I’m going back to my room,’ he stammered, getting up.

‘Oh, don’t be like that!’ said Clive. And then, under his breath, ‘Or, you know, do. I honestly don’t care.’

‘I’ll come with you,’ said Ella.

I looked at her questioningly, but she smiled to reassure me. ‘Just to make sure you’re okay. I’ll see you guys in a bit.’

Ella took a torch and escorted Adam through the dusk towards the yew woods. *How strange Adam's life must be, I thought, to be gripped with inexplicable existential panic one moment, and then to get everything you wanted the next.*

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## 46

91. God, Lord of Reckoning, Your Omnipotence,  
Receive, diligent, each stammered prayer.  
An idiot's refuge, sung unto *cruel* heartlessness.  
Lost in existence, somewhere.
92. A rare entreaty shatters His apathy –  
Tiny tired exhortation, requests  
Ease divine; though His elliptic *infinity*  
Nothing for its need invests.

TIME FLOWED.

We talked. Leo, apparently only magnified and enhanced by the mushrooms, became ever more verbose, expounding on all manner of things: again, he talked of Terence McKenna and his experiences with DMT; he told us about the self-replicating machine elves, entities which are commonly encountered by many intoxicated by DMT, and regard human visitors excitedly; he talked about the future, and the present moment.

'It's 1993,' said Leo. 'Six years from the millennium. The rest of the 1990s is going to blow your mind. Society, art, politics – everything will be transformed.'

I listened, and smiled. It would be nice to believe Leo. I had been careful not to take much of the mushrooms, so – apart from feeling vaguely giggly, as if I'd drunk champagne, and the world melting pleasantly at the edges, the fire suddenly fascinating – I was still very much in control.

‘This decade,’ Leo continued, ‘will be characterized by kindness. Feminism, ecological consciousness, a revival of ancient ideas and values. Humanity’s at an evolutionary crossroads. We’re standing at the threshold of eternity. The present is about to be transformed by the imminent future. We’re lucky to be alive now, when what it means to be human will be radically redrawn. This moment, the 1990s, will be when it all begins.’

‘My hands look funny,’ said Ruth. She wiggled her fingers in front of her face.

The flames writhed upwards, uncurling like fiddleheads of fern; the coolness of the night around us was alive, swarming with things as subtle and unknowable as quarks.

Time flowed.

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Time flowed.

Ella returned, briefly, then took herself away again before I could talk to her, or even remember what it was I wanted to talk to her about. Other things seemed to be happening. Clive rolled another joint, with considerably difficulty; he seemed frustrated by the amount of fingers he had. A deafening chorus of croaking frogs sounded from the lake, and then halted instantly and abruptly the second I became conscious of it; I was going to say something important about that, but my train of thought, which had swelled to grandiose and baroque heights, was forgotten in an instant. The summer heat, like a living thing, lay in the grass and the rocks and the leaves and trees, and the whole dusky world and everything in it was a dream the sun had, a whimsical expenditure of cosmic energies to an inconceivable purpose, and that was all fine.

Some distance away, the perpendicular proportions of Bewise glittered and shone in the summer night, vibrating with secrecy, a gateway built to tame a fairy tale. Nearby, lying full-length, her face bone white, was Ruth, and I saw for the first time how beautiful she was, how kind and friendly, how she hid that beauty in order to live a freer life. And everything was

alive now, as it always had been, the reality of everything was revealed, luminous. Human yardsticks like the clock were a laughable absurdity here, in this moment that always was, that you could visit at any time, if you wished. This was Flayne's faeryland; maybe he had done exactly what we had done here, opened his mind to the world the exact same way. With the mushrooms coursing through my system at a pleasant, low level, it became easy to conceive of the universe as a fundamentally benign place, well disposed to all the creatures that rose from dust to dance their brief dance within it.

I could have stayed in that moment forever. It did not feel like an illusion, or anything that could be reduced to mere biochemistry: it felt real and true.

---

Time flowed.

I got up and wandered over to Bewise, fluorescing like bleached bone. Inside, I found that I could see in the dark, and assess the place as it was. I knelt to touch the carved memorial to Ella Flayne, walked forward to touch the iron gate, gazing through it to see the cave mouth beyond. The walls of that glowed faintly, too, although I knew that this was only a trick of the limited light. The centre of it all was darkness, and I wondered, for a second, how Leo would cope in there, alone, lit only by a single candle or torch, shadows swarming and squirming along the walls. It would be awful in the extreme, I thought, to be in there, surrounded by nothing but solid rock. I realized I was worried for him. I hoped he would be okay.

---

I emerged from the cold interior of Bewise into the cool, pleasant air, into the summer night. Some short distance away, I saw the fire.

Seated around it, I saw Ruth, Leo, Clive, Malcolm and Helen.

'Oh my God,' I said. 'Look at you all. Just as you were. And Helen's back.'

‘You’ve not been gone that long,’ said Ruth. ‘Where did you go, anyway?’

‘Away,’ I said. ‘Elsewhere.’

Helen frowned. ‘Why?’

‘Not sure,’ I replied. ‘Maybe I wanted to see what it was like to return.’ I spread my hands, to indicate Bewise. ‘And here we are, with all of it stretched out before us.’

‘My head feels weird,’ said Leo.

‘Unsurprising,’ I said. ‘Considering what you’ve done to it.’

‘No-one else thinks any of this is strange?’ said Helen. ‘You all sound very peculiar.’

Ruth looked at me. Her blue eyes held reflections of the dancing flame.

‘Did you change your clothes?’ she said. ‘You look different.’ I laughed.

‘Hmm. Well, this isn’t much of a conversation,’ said Helen.

Clive spoke, for the first time in a long time. ‘Did the stars always look like that? Do they look weird to anyone else?’

‘It would be weird if they didn’t look weird,’ I said. ‘Considering everything.’

I stared into the fire. A strange sense of belonging settled over me. It was glorious to see everyone like this, faces lit by the fire, intact, and relaxed in curious kinship, locked in our forever summer, where we would always be. And then I experienced a pang of strange longing, something akin to homesickness, for this moment, while still living it, the peculiar predicament of being alive, only truly understandable from the inside, by experiencing it.

I stared into the fire.

‘Ella,’ I said at long last, as if remembering. ‘Where is she?’



Time flowed. Ella was still at Marshlands, apparently, but finding her felt less important than what was unfolding in front of me.



And then Leo stood up, took a deep breath and shouldered his backpack.

'*It's time,*' he said simply, then, for a second, broke out into a boyish grin as the absurdity of his self-imposed mission, and the seriousness with which he took it, suddenly struck him. 'Wish me luck.'

'Luuuuck,' said Ruth, from somewhere on the floor. Her white arm came up from nowhere; her hand gave a thumbs up.

'I'm not wishing you luck,' said Clive. 'This is everything you've ever wanted, and you're going to mine it for an entire career. You'll be *juuust* fine.'

Leo grinned again. 'Thanks, Clive.' He strode off in the direction of Bewise.

I caught up with Leo as he reached the stone steps, which still glowed magnificently under the starlight.

'You gonna be alright?'

'Hope so,' he said unhelpfully. He did not break stride.

'What I mean is,' I said, 'you've done a shitload of magic mushrooms, way more than the piddling amounts we did.' This was true: the experience had peaked, and I was on the gentle downwards gradient towards normal perception. Leo's night, on the other hand, was only just beginning.

'So?'

'Well, so, now you're gonna go...' – I fought for the word – '*... potholing?*'

'I'll be fine,' said Leo. 'Trust me. I just need to get to the cave before the major effects kick in.'

I was conscious of the pull of fear at the edge of things, a dark current, a line like the Schwarzschild Radius of a black hole, the crossing of which was irreversible. I couldn't shake the idea that I was sending him off to his death, but to speak of it would be to make it real.

'I feel I should stop you.'

'You can't.' Leo smiled politely. 'Goodbye, Alex.'

He ducked inside. I watched him produce the key, open the gate and vanish into the darkness beyond.



93. That ebon night, our wisdom stayed,  
 His *occult* wiles now the rule.  
 And none shall, from our raging maelstrom, evade  
 Dread right estimation's accrual.

94. Labyrinthine, it thwarts. Your smug undertakings:  
 Noble – *regal* – ever aloof,  
 Lie confounded, of vain endeavours relating.  
 I now give The Almighty the truth.

TIME FLOWED, corrected itself. Seconds began to tick, once more, in order.

The fire dwindled. The night became colder, and the effects of the mushrooms receded, leaving me sober, lucid and alert. Helen returned to Marshlands, and about half an hour later, the rest of us got up to leave, too, gathering blankets and rugs and the bits of crockery and cutlery we'd brought with us. Ella Flayne's secret garden was lacquered with silver moonlight now, and, even without hallucinogenic encouragement, looked icy and otherworldly, as if all within it were made of glass.

I paused before we left, to look back at Bewise.

Somewhere, under tons of cold, lifeless rock, was the infinitely precious, infinitely unlikely arrangement of molecules that was a living human mind.

'Hey,' said Clive, noticing my concern. He spoke kindly and without sarcasm. 'I'm worried about him too. But... it's what he wanted.'

I gathered a blanket around myself. 'I suppose.'

‘We couldn’t have stopped him. If he’s not back first thing next morning, we’ll come out here and get him, okay?’

I nodded, not wanting to point out that, as tomorrow was Saturday, Clive would not be up before noon.

We headed through the cold blackness of the yew wood, moonlit Solace House towering over all, and struck out for Marshlands, and warmth.

---

I was returning to my room when someone grabbed my arm. I jumped in fright.

‘On a scale of one to fucked,’ Ella said, ‘how are you after those mushrooms?’

I shrugged. ‘Totally fine. I had just enough for a fun lightshow, and some inconsequential philosophical revelations that seemed very significant at the time.’

‘Right.’ She carried half a bottle of red wine, which she twirled nervously in hands which were tense and restless. ‘You didn’t smoke any pot?’

‘No. I felt it would be a bad idea, on top of the mushrooms. And I stopped drinking ages ago. What’s this about? If you need me to drive you somewhere, I must warn you that I don’t have a car, I’m technically still intoxicated and also I can’t actually drive. Other than that, we’re good to go.’

‘In,’ she said, shoving me inside my room.

---

It was odd to see Ella here: so far, we’d only been together in her room. I lit a candle, and we stripped down to our underwear and got into bed, hugging each other close. Ella’s face was all I could see. Her hair smelled of the fire.

‘Okay,’ she said. ‘About earlier.’

‘What happened there?’ I said. ‘Adam said something, and then you looked at him like you were terrified of him.’

Ella shook her head. 'No. That wasn't it.'

'Then what?'

Ella breathed deeply and turned onto her back, looked up at the plaster ceiling, a nothingness painted orange by the candle flame. I waited for her to gather herself, to say what she needed to say.

'Okay,' she said eventually, rolling back onto her side to look directly at me. 'Ever since I got here, I've been... troubled by something.'

'During the first term, I spent three evenings a week on the student helpline. You know the one? It's not quite the Samaritans, and it isn't quite trained counselling. It's just people like me, who want to help people in distress, who've done a basic one-hour training module, and all we can really do is listen. Another human being on the other end of the line. You sit in a cubicle and you answer calls, from ten until two or two until five.'

'Most of my shifts were ten till two, which weren't so bad. There were really only four types of call: people stressed about exams, people who were homesick, people who were depressed, and prank calls.'

She sat up, pulled the cork from the bottle she'd brought in, and took a slug from it.

'Sometimes, though, I had to do the two-till-five shifts, and they were the fucking worst. Those calls were different. Ten till two, even though it's late, covers a normal portion of the day. People come home from the pub, they can't sleep. They had a bad date or an essay deadline. Their reasons for calling are explicable. But between two and five – from the small hours until just before dawn... it's a weird fucking benthic zone with weird things dwelling in it. Some of the callers were seriously disturbed.'

'There was one girl who would talk me through cutting herself with a scalpel. Like she was making dinner or something. *I'm inserting the point in my left forearm now. The blade is medical-grade, very sharp, I feel my skin part, and then the muscle... now the blood...* then after twenty minutes of that, and me asking her to please stop... the call would end. And I'd just feel... a chill.'

I looked at my bedside clock; it was 2.33 a.m. We were well into the first hour of Ella's benthic zone now. Outside, in the dark fields surrounding

Marshlands, the silence was absolute.

‘There was another guy who kept calling to tell us that he’d *seen what was really going on* in the world, the *hidden machinery*, as he called it. He said it started when he’d been due to hand over a paper to his tutor, but had forgotten to, and went back to give it to her. And when he did, he said he’d caught the tutor in the act of *moulting* – that was the word he used – sloughing off her human disguise, to reveal a... *gorgeous jewelled insect*. Again, his words. He was clearly having some kind of prolonged schizophrenic episode, but...

‘I kept thinking about him afterwards, when I was in the Student Union bar or whatever. Everyone drunk, happy, and among us was this person so far removed from the world, he was to all intents and purposes no longer human. Scary shit. Over that term, I had dozens of callers like that, but his I *really* remember.

‘Him, and The Whisperer.’

Ella took another swig of red wine.

‘Everyone who worked there called him The Whisperer, ’cos he spoke in this weird rasping whisper. He’d never say anything important, he was just combative and sneery. He never stayed on the line very long, and it was never clear why he was calling, apart from to be objectionable to whoever was on the other end of the line.’

She paused to drink again. I stayed silent, waiting for her to continue.

‘Anyway, I ended up staying on an extra week, just before Christmas, because Mum and I had an argument and I was trying to prove a point, or some bullshit. That week, the helpline was short-handed, and I got emotionally blackmailed into doing one extra shift. One of the two-till-fives. Inevitably, the fucking Whisperer calls, and I take it. He sounds different. I got the impression he was seriously drunk. Mission-to-oblivion drunk.

‘It became obvious that he had something he wanted to share, and I began to suspect that this was what he’d been building up to for all those weeks. So I just listened, as he said what he had to say.’

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‘He went, he told me, to a very exclusive school, all boys, but in sixth form it became mixed, and he met this one girl who he instantly fell in love with. She was oblivious to him, but he said, *I knew, I just knew, we’d be together forever*. Fairly standard stuff, I know. Anyway, after a whole year of watching her and yearning, he turns eighteen, and, as his parents are, like mega-rich, this is a huge deal. They throw open their massive house to all the other kids in his year and he said he’d never felt happier in his life. His father bought him a sports car too. He said this like it was normal, a rite of passage for every teenage boy. You turn eighteen, your dad buys you a ludicrous red sports car for fifty grand or whatever.

‘For the first time, he says, he feels *popular*, or at least, finally, *noticed* by his classmates. They’re running around his family mansion, drinking and dancing and messing around in the swimming pool, and one of the cool kids in his year even offers him some acid, and he eats the lot of it, like, three tabs. It doesn’t work, and he assumes the other kid is pranking him, as the other kids often do, but, he said, the night was so perfect that even *that* was fine.

‘Best of all, though, is that *she* comes, this girl he’s been obsessed with for a whole year. And she’s there, at his house. He can’t believe it. He finally gets talking to her, and he says they have a great time. He could tell, he says, that she’d finally *seen* him, seen what he is. He isn’t just some guy, some random nobody. He’s someone. His dad is wealthy, a big deal, so by extension, *he’s* wealthy, an equally big deal. She can see – finally, he says – that he’s important.

‘He shows her the car and offers to take her for a ride in it, its very first ride. To his absolute joy, she agrees.

‘He was keen, he said, to impress her, so he was driving fast, recklessly. And then all at once the acid comes on, he says, all in a huge, terrible wave. And suddenly, in one sense, he’s out there, travelling at a hundred and twenty miles an hour, down dark country roads, but in another, he feels like he’s not moving at all, that the world is moving around him, he’s the centre

of everything, a singularity, a fixed point, able to see everything, all possible outcomes of that moment. He became aware that the car was running on a single rail, a diamond thread, through black space, and as he looked at that thread, he saw that it was fate. That's what he said. Fate. They were hurtling along a route they'd always been on. That's what he said.'

Ella took another drink from the bottle, then passed it to me; I took a swig. She drew in a deep breath.

'When the crash came, he said, it was almost a relief.

'They came way too fast into a bend, and into what would have been a head-on collision with another car, a blue car, he said, that's all the impression he got, just a dark blue shape, like a shark. The two cars swerve and don't collide, but his car goes through a fence and leaves the road, flips over, rolling and rolling down a steep gully. He said that this part felt like it went on for days.

'The car crashes through some trees, and finally comes to a stop. Miraculously, he finds that he hasn't got anything more serious than a few minor cuts and bruises. You could say he was lucky, but...'

She stopped again for a moment. I saw that her eyes were wet.

'But, *she's pinned down next to him*, clamped down by the crushed car. And she... she hasn't been lucky. Not at all.

'And so he's trapped like that, in the car, the acid only starting to reveal its true strength, and his head is also pinned down by wreckage and branches so *he's staring at her, forced to stare right at her*, he can't look away. Staring at her. As she dies. And for hours afterwards.

'It's eight hours until someone finally finds them. Trapped like that, him facing her as she dies, then hour upon hour of staring at the mangled ruins of her, the acid exploding through his system. Staring at her. If he closes his eyes, she's still there. If he keeps them open, she's all he can see. No escape from this experience, this nightmare, no relief from the actuality of it. For *eight fucking hours*.'

'Jesus,' I said. 'Looking at her face—'



‘Yeah,’ said Ella. The candlelight made her wet face glisten. When she spoke again, she spoke quietly.

‘Only, from what he said, there wasn’t anything like a face left at all.’

‘Oh *God*.’

‘Yeah,’ said Ella. She sighed heavily. ‘*Yeah*.’

---

We were both quiet for a while. The night, through the open window, was filled only with the small vague noises of living things, going about their nocturnal lives, oblivious to human drama.

Ella took another swig from the bottle.

‘After that, he rang off. It seemed like he’d done the thing he wanted to do, which was confess, I suppose. He implied his dad made it all go away, so I think that meant it was never talked about again. So maybe he just wanted to tell the truth to someone. Either way, that was it.

‘Before he rang off, though, he said one last thing. He said he’d come to an understanding. About them being together forever. He said they always would be. I assume he meant that part of him would always be there with her, in that moment, that hell, that ditch, in that mangled car. And then, before he hung up, he said, *So be it*. And then he said, *Let’s reason with the worst that may befall*.’

‘Holy shit,’ I whispered.

‘Yeah.’ She looked into the fire. ‘I think I recognized his voice immediately, subconsciously, when I started here, but I didn’t want to admit it. But I’m sure it’s him.’

The night outside was utterly still. With an air of finality, Ella put the empty wine bottle on my bedside table.

‘Eight hours,’ she said. ‘*Eight hours*.’

Without warning, she started to cry.

---

I held Ella for a while, and neither of us spoke. Eventually, I told her about Adam, at The Ridge, screaming at the trees. About the entry in *Who's Who*, describing his rich dad. And then we were silent again for a time.

‘You’ve seen the way he looks at you,’ I said eventually.

‘Yeah.’

I got the impression that we were both thinking the same thing, beginning to form the same idea. Again, I spoke before I would normally have judged it wise to do so.

‘I wonder what she looked like. The girl he – the one who died in front of him. *She's for me*, that's what he said, when he was standing outside your room, after we'd slept together that first time. He was furious with me.’

Ella said nothing.

‘Did he describe this girl he fell madly in love with?’

Ella nodded. ‘*Pre-Raphaelite*, he called her, so he was pretentious as well as softly spoken.’

I sat up. ‘Pre-Raphaelite as in long red hair? Like you?’

‘Could be. But let's not—’

‘*She's for me*. Shit. I mean, it's pretty obvious, right? He thinks, in some capacity, you're her. The girl he – killed.’

‘C'mon,’ said Ella, rolling her eyes.

‘No, think about it: what did he do the first time he saw you? He dropped that box. At first, I thought he was just being clumsy, but – I think he saw you from the back, and thought, just for a second, that...’ My voice trailed off.

I pictured him sleepwalking, if he even had been. Had he seen her then? Did he always see her? Was he trapped, forever, in that same awful moment? Whether alone in a university hall of residence or working in a spooky old house, there was no longer any buffer between him and memory. And there would never be any respite, no release from that perpetual hallucinogenic moment, which was always happening, would never stop happening.

Suddenly, his behaviour made sense. The drinking, which was always grimly determined, aimed squarely at oblivion. It freed him from the

torment of seeing her, over and over again, the young woman he'd loved, and destroyed.

---

As well as Adam, I thought of what had happened to me, not so very long ago, at the hands of The Annihilator. And I thought of Ella, clearly running from chaotic circumstances, and Helen, dumped here for a summer by her own parents; about Ruth, about Malcolm, and Leo, and Clive. All of us wrapped up in our own private labyrinths, prisons half-built for us, half-built by us, our lives. I thought about the poem that Clive had written the first night I was here, about us being the real lunatics, and how that was true, in a sense. For all of us here, who, for one reason or another, couldn't, or wouldn't, ever go home again. God's scorned, unwanted children.

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At some point, Ella fell into a half-sleep, arm across my chest. I couldn't sleep, though. At first, I thought it might be the legacy of the mushrooms, too much unfamiliar chemical activity in my body and brain, but considering this feeling coldly, I discovered it was merely plain old unease, built around one very specific fear. I wondered if Adam were standing outside, in the hallway.

Eventually, the temptation to put this suspicion to the test became too great, and – extremely disappointed in myself for giving in – I got up.

The corridor outside was dark and empty, but not silent.

From one room came low, urgent whispering, a liturgy, a recitation. Too low and too fast to be deciphered into sense, sentences punctuated by precise breaks like verses from the Bible. I pressed my ear to his door, but couldn't hear any better there than I could from further away.

## 48

95. Eschewing reason, embracing dissent  
I now seek asylum, neutral.  
Instinctual to yearn so, of a time hence,  
Not our wretched fragment of *ritual*.
96. Eden: sullied with our rotten nature.  
Leprous, *impure*, flames engulfing –  
Each vain effort revealing life's annihilator;  
Surrendering to infinite nothing.

WHEN I WOKE, Ella had evidently been up for a while. She had retrieved the final volume of Flayne's autobiography from her room, and sat up in bed reading. She had also made herself some breakfast, a slice of toast with blue cheese crushed onto it, which she crunched through as she read.

'Difficult prose and blue cheese,' I said, coming back from the small bathroom. 'Someone knows how to start the day.'

'You know it,' she said, through a final mouthful of toast, and carried on reading.

'Can I read it yet?'

She didn't look up. 'Nope.'

'Why?'

'Because.'

I felt myself becoming irritated. 'What are you saving it for?'

'I just want to be first to read it. I found the bloody thing.'

‘We found the bloody thing. Why won’t you let me read it? Why this problem with sharing information which might be helpful?’

This was, I realized the split second after I said it, very much the wrong thing to say. Ella lowered the book and glared at me.

‘Oh really? *I* have a problem sharing? *I* do?’

‘What’s that supposed to mean?’

‘What happened to your parents, Alex?’ She voiced the question as a challenge.

I laughed. ‘Oh God, this again. You’re relentless. I can’t think of any more literary orphans. I haven’t had coffee.’

‘Yeah, that routine’s old now anyway. What happened to your parents?’

‘We shared a horrible tragic story last night, albeit one that didn’t happen to either of us, but still. I’m not in the mood for another one.’

‘Suit yourself,’ she said, but I could see she was a little hurt.

I thought.

‘You think I’m putting up a barrier between us. Is that it? That I don’t trust you with that information?’

She nodded. ‘You talked yesterday about where this was going, and how you were keen for it to keep going. How can that happen if I don’t have any context for you? If I don’t know what your situation is?’

‘I don’t know what your situation is either,’ I said. I realized that this sounded a little desperate. ‘Can’t we just wait until—’

‘Okay,’ said Ella, in a businesslike tone. She closed the volume, put it aside and stared at me, her gaze unwavering. ‘I’ll go first, huh? If that’s what it takes.’

She inhaled and exhaled, as if she were about to dive from a high board. Just when I thought she wasn’t going to speak, she began.

*‘My dad is a real piece of shit.’*

She inhaled again, exhaled. I waited for her to continue.

‘Growing up, he’d drink, get violent. To Mum. To me. When I was eleven, he hit me so hard he broke my cheek.

‘He did worse to Mum. Much worse. When I was fifteen, Mum tried to walk out on him, taking me with her. He beat her so badly she was in

hospital for a week. Next time we didn't take any chances. We moved, like, two counties away. And it was lovely, for a while, just the two of us. And then the fucker found us again.

'Mum was at work, I'd bunked off school that day, just my luck. He punched me so hard in the stomach I coughed up blood. Mum came home from work and found me. She called the police and he was arrested, but nothing stuck, because nothing ever did. He was released, and we moved away again.

'And that's been the pattern ever since. We move away, we build a new life for ourselves. Then he turns up, and we run. We drop everything, and we run.'

'When was the last time this happened?'

'First term last year,' she said.

'Ruth mentioned that you were hardly in lectures.'

'I wasn't. I had to crawl to the university so they wouldn't kick me out. But yeah. That's the pattern. I never know how long I'm going to be somewhere before I have to vanish.' Tears sparkled in her eyes, but she didn't cry.

'The last two times it's happened, Mum's been talking about taking him back.'

'Jesus, why?'

'She's had enough. Moving, settling, leaving. The drinking's taken its toll on him, and he's sick now. Weaker than he was. But, still—'

She looked out of the window.

'One day I just want to fuck it all off. Just go, and not come back. Leave all of it. My course. This country. I don't know. All of it. Just fuck it all off.'

'I'm literally *right here*,' I said, by way of a joke, but she didn't seem to hear.

'*Fuck it all off*,' she said, as if it were a mantra.

---

When she finally turned back from the window, she wiped the wetness from her eyes with quick, efficient fingers. ‘See? Difficult, but not impossible. Now you.’

Reflexively, I found myself about to refuse, but swallowed the impulse. Instead, following Ella’s example, I took a deep breath and plunged.

‘*My parents died in a car crash,*’ I said. Ella listened, and sniffed, but said nothing.

‘Both of them. They left the road at high speed, the car rolled, for a long time, they hit a tree.’

‘Exactly like Adam and his girlfriend,’ said Ella. Her tone, I realized, implied I was simply lying, recycling Adam’s story, reusing it for my own convenience.

‘Yes. Unlike what happened to him, though, they were both killed instantly.’

Silence fell between us for a short while. It was my turn to blink back tears.

‘Good,’ she said eventually.

‘Good? My parents dying is good?’

‘No, I meant it was good that you told me. But’ – she smoothed toast crumbs off the sheets – ‘there’s something you’re not telling me.’

I smiled, surprised, delighted – and a little bit alarmed – by her perceptiveness.

‘There is.’

Ella looked frustrated. ‘Then why bother, Alex? If you can’t tell me all of it?’

I was buffeted by conflicting urges. I wanted to tell her then, tell her everything. I wanted to tell her about that day, which I called, in my private thoughts, the Last Day. I wanted to tell her about my father, assailed by debt and ill-health, going out in the car, taking my mother with him, and me only not going because I wanted to watch TV, raid the drinks cabinet. And this being all that saved me.

I wanted to tell her how, when I said goodbye to them, he stared back at me from a place beyond, indifferent to fate, no concern of his whether I

came along or not, whether I lived or died. And how I saw, as he was leaving, something in his eyes, something utterly unfamiliar, and I knew, *I knew* what he was going to do, I *knew* that he was going to crash the car, take whoever was in it with him, how this had come to make absolute sense to him. That strange silver deadness, my father hollowed out, gone, become The Annihilator, who brings only death, and that he was going to kill them both, and me, if I let him. But it was absurd to think that, wasn't it? And so off they went. I wanted to tell her all of it.

But I couldn't. My jaws cramped together, my tear ducts tingled. And I just couldn't.

---

I wanted to ask Ella more about her father, about her life, but a fracture, tiny yet significant, had opened up between us, and we were both aware of it. We also both found ourselves uncertain as to what happened next, and how to proceed. In the electric silence which replaced conversation, and killed any prospect of it, I felt raw – skinless, almost – acutely aware of Ella's being in the same state. Ella made a half-joking pantomime of the act of resuming reading Flayne's final volume.

After a minute or two, I was relieved when, in a conciliatory act, she read aloud from Flayne's memoir.

*'Sometimes, I fancy I see people, or things like people, in my house.'*

'Go on,' I said.

*'A tall gaunt one that I sense is female. That is the first. The second is male, a jumble of contradictory perspectives, like something reflected in a shattered mirror. There is another who is female. She is made of something effulgent, blazing. I cannot see more, as they shift and move as they explore the house. There are others, but these three are clearest to me: I have seen them often enough, and regularly enough, to take note of their individual characteristics. Some days they labour incessantly, at nothing, other days they are merely present.'*



‘Oh my God!’ I told Ella what Helen had said yesterday, when we were clearing out the dummies, and although I began in a mocking tone, this ceased when I saw Ella’s reaction to the phrase *She thought they were us*. Something about hearing this detail caused Ella’s eyes to widen in astonishment.

‘Come on, though. It’s Helen we’re talking about here,’ I said. ‘Helen?’

‘Doesn’t matter.’ Ella seemed troubled. ‘Even a stopped clock, and all that. What if they *were* us? Or at the very least, three of us?’ Ella smiled infuriatingly, and read again from the volume. ‘*Some days they labour incessantly, at nothing, other days they are merely present*. To be fair, that *does* sound like us.’

‘Right, so you’re saying he saw us, in the future, moving all his terrible junk outside? How?’

In answer, she flicked through Flayne’s final volume, until she found what she was looking for.

‘*I am troubled, in my house, after beginning the perpetuation ritual.*’

‘Does he ever explain what that is?’ I said. Ella smiled cryptically.

‘I don’t want to tell you yet. Not until I have the full story.’

‘Nope,’ I said. ‘Not good enough. This ritual... is that what all of this stuff is, on the top floor? Some kind of... spell he was doing?’

She smiled again. ‘Not exactly. Look, I will share it, I promise. But not until I’ve read it.’

‘Ah, you’re no fun.’

‘Anyway, he says that his ritual will soften the walls of time, or something like that. Open the floodgates of eternity.’

‘But if that’s the case,’ I said, ‘and he was building versions of us, why only three dummies? Why any dummies at all, for that matter?’

‘Good point,’ said Ella. ‘You’d think someone as fascinating and stunning as me deserved a dummy. We should show this to Leo, see what he makes of it.’

‘Oh shit,’ I said. A distant alarm rang in my head. ‘*Leo.*’

---

Helen was alone in the kitchen, constructing an elaborate sandwich. She greeted me with raised eyebrows, as if my presence were immediately suspicious. I enquired as neutrally as I could as to Leo's whereabouts, only to be told he wasn't back yet. I looked at my watch. It was already late morning.

I felt a lurch of fear in my stomach. A sudden and very strong image of him with a terrible head injury leapt to mind, face down on the dirt floor of the filthy cave, his mind off in some anaesthetic compensatory Xanadu conjured up to make the shock and the imminence of death bearable. Calmly, Helen asked me whether we should be worried, or send out a search party, and I was in the process of stammering through an answer when Leo himself appeared at the kitchen door.

'Here he is now!' I said, with not inconsiderable relief. 'He's back! Hey, Leo!'

Leo hung off the door frame, as if he needed it to stand up. He had the morning-after look of narcotic indulgence I'd most recently seen when Malcolm returned from his big weekend in town.

'Hey,' he said quietly. He smiled, and looked dazed. He put his rucksack down on a chair, but didn't sit.

'So how was the vision quest?' I asked, but Helen spoke over me.

'I think it was an *incredibly* irresponsible expedition,' she said, 'for the record.'

'Hello, Helen.' Leo smirked at her as if the secret clockwork of her mind were on show. 'Nice to see you.'

'Please don't do anything like that again,' said Helen. 'I mean, we can't stop you going on some silly... *fact-finding tour*, if you absolutely must. But we're all responsible for you, in case something goes wrong. Think of *that*.' She folded her arms self-righteously, her point made.

'Nothing went wrong,' said Leo guilelessly.

'Well, we didn't know that, did we? I mean, what have you even been *doing*?'

Leo smiled cryptically at her and left the room.

'*Unbelievable*,' tutted Helen, and returned to constructing her sandwich.

---

I caught up with him in the corridor.

‘Well?’

He looked at me calmly, with an unblinking, assessing gaze. It was as if he were seeing me for the first time.

‘Are you still high?’ I asked, peering into his eyes. He smiled again.

‘No, I’m not.’

‘Well, you absolutely look it.’ I remembered something. ‘Did you... get to where you were trying to get to?’

I thought he’d need more prompting, to recall our conversation of the previous evening, but he understood at once. His smile became so broad, so radiant, that I could barely look at it.

‘If you’ll excuse me,’ he whispered, ‘I’m very tired.’

He turned and headed back to his room. Unusually for him, he closed his door with a definite firmness, shutting me, and the world, out.

## 49

97. God's scorned, unwanted children. Hail!  
Helpless, overlooked, lame.  
(Labyrinths of winding stanzas assail.)  
Lambs. Victims. All trusting. *Insane*.

98. O, noose elaborate. Xanadu:  
To its naïve guests, unthreatening.  
Inside Solace House, nigh our woeful due:  
E'en at tragic humankind's settling.

THE REST OF THE weekend passed, with all of us finding ways to divert ourselves, whether reading, getting stoned, listening to music, falling into pleasant, pointless conversation, or some combination of the above.

At one point, on Sunday, an interesting thing happened to me that no-one else could perceive.

I realized that I was thinking about Ella. I found myself thinking about her laugh, her caustic sense of humour, how liberating she was to be around, how little she cared for anything that hadn't proved itself truly important. I thought of her brushing a strand of hair from her face, smiling sardonically at something I had said, delivering a riposte of her own. Later that afternoon, when talking to Malcolm, I found myself borrowing one of her facial expressions in conversation, and I knew in that second what might be beginning, and how welcome that was, like rain on parched earth.

---

Ominously, Leo did not emerge from his room. I decided to check on him.

I knocked cautiously at his door. There was no answer. I called his name and eventually heard a murmur from within, and pushed the door open.

I expected him to have the covers over his head, lost in a pit of post-hallucinogenic paranoia, but instead, he was sitting upright in a chair at his desk. The curtains were drawn, and the room was very, very hot. Leo wore no shirt or trousers, just a vest and a pair of boxer shorts. On the desk in front of him were various objects: a mirror, a clock, a cigarette burning in a glass ashtray, some loose change. There was also a large glass container which I initially took to be an unwashed jar of instant coffee, but then recognized as the pot with the rusted object inside, which had formed the centrepiece around which Flayne's effigies were positioned. The pot was still sealed.

Leo was picking through the loose change in distracted wonder, but when I came in, he immediately stopped this and looked up at me. He smiled, a broad, almost facile, grin.

'Hello, Alex. How are you?'

'I'm good, thanks,' I said, in as calm a voice as I could manage. 'I'm more worried about how you are.'

'I'm *fine*,' he said. He didn't seem able to stop smiling. Moreover, he didn't seem able to stop staring at me. I thought of the visual pull of the flames we experienced at our regular bonfires; how it was hard to look away. Was I on fire now, to him? Was he still lost in some dazzling hallucination, perpetually aflame, the outside world burning so brightly it had to be shut out?

'Great!' I said. 'Only, you can see from my point of view how I might *not* think that.'

'*From your point of view*,' he repeated, the phrase seeming to be inordinately amusing to him, and his smile became a laugh. 'I can't imagine.'

'I'm worried, Leo.' And in vocalizing it, I realized that I had been suppressing this thought, shoving it away. I really was worried. He had taken an enormous amount of magic mushrooms, and had put himself

through an experience which might fairly be described as gruelling – crawling into the cavern, through the narrow channel in the rock, followed by hours of intense disorientation. And we had all let him do this. If he had lost his mind, we were all complicit.

Leo, for his part, seemed relaxed. ‘What are you worried about?’

‘I’m worried that you’ve...’ I stopped short of saying *damaged yourself*. I paused. ‘I’m worried that you took a *lot* of mushrooms, and that you’ve not quite recovered yet.’ Or, I thought, *that you might never recover*.

He stared up at me, a long, appraising stare that began as merely unsettling and became, at the same slow pace of the cigarette burning in the ashtray, utterly unnerving.

‘*You’re concerned I might have irrevocably compromised my mind in the pursuit of knowledge,*’ he said eventually, and with exaggeratedly perfect diction. I nodded, dumbstruck, as he went on. ‘And that, if I have lost my reason, you’ll be blamed, and we’ll all have to go home. You want everything back the way it was. Your summer intact.’ He said all of this without malice, as if reading from a printed page.

‘Yes,’ I said, almost breathlessly. ‘That’s true. But I am also worried about you. Genuinely. You haven’t done a Syd Barrett here, no? Reassure me.’

He was smiling again. ‘Definitely not.’

‘You’d tell me if you had?’ Even as I said these words, I recognized the absurdity of them. *Please notify me if you feel you’ve gone mad.*

‘Sure.’ He smiled again, bemused. I felt oddly self-conscious, as if Leo had immeasurable authority here and I none at all.

‘Er, can I get you anything? Water?’

‘Water would be great,’ he said. I left, and brought a glass of water from the kitchen; when I returned he was staring into the mirror, with the same degree of rapt concentration with which he had regarded me.

As I was leaving, he looked up.

‘Jilly, first. Then Ella,’ he said. ‘Helen, Ruth. Clive. Then you.’

‘What are you talking about?’

He stared into the mirror again. After a while, I realized he wasn't going to answer me. I turned and left.

---

'Maybe I should just stop worrying,' I said later that night, in bed with Ella, both of us staring at the ceiling. We had rolled a joint with another purloined bud of Clive's weed. 'He's away with the fairies, so what? He'll come back to himself.'

'He might not.' Ella shrugged, as I passed her the joint. 'It can be very treacherous, being away with the fairies. Look at poor Oisín.'

'Should I know who that is?'

'Yep.' She exhaled a plume of smoke. 'God, this is why I should have got involved with Leo instead.'

I threw a pillow at her and she laughed.

'You're welcome to him,' I said. 'He's currently in his room with his brains all fried, staring at the wall.'

'You want to hear this story or not?' She passed the joint back to me. 'Basically, Oisín, a mortal man, falls in love with Niamh, a fairy maiden. She takes him to Tír na nÓg, land of the young, where the fairies live. They spend a blissful three years there, but then Oisín gets homesick, wants to return home. Only when he does so, he finds that three hundred years have passed in our world. He ages to dust in seconds.'

I laughed at this bleak little story, but later, as I lay in the darkness, with Ella sleeping, I found that this tale returned to me – appalling, disturbing – and I tried to put it, and its terrible implications, out of my mind.

---

And then, even here, at a place where time was apparently an arbitrary and malleable thing, Monday morning came around with its signature feeling of *back to work*. We assembled in the kitchen as usual, with only one major difference to what had become our usual routine.

'Where's Leo?' asked Malcolm.

Clive snorted. 'He's in bed. He said he feels a bit under the weather. I thought he was slacking off, of course, but it turns out that no, he really is feeling unwell. So he won't be joining us today.'

This information made me uneasy. No-one else seemed to place much importance on Leo's absence, but then again no-one else had really spoken to Leo since he returned from his night underground.

'I *said*,' said Helen triumphantly, 'I *said* going into that cave was a stupid idea. He's probably caught his death.'

'He just looked knackered,' said Clive. 'I think he found the, um, trip quite demanding. Either way, he's not going to be joining us today.'

We picked up our bags of gloves and dust masks, our bottles of water, our brushes and dusters, rolls of black bin bags. I realized I still felt a little foggy after the weekend's excesses; I imagined hard work would set me straight.

'I *said*,' said Helen in a sing-song voice, as we left, 'I *said* it was a stupid idea.'

'Wait,' said Ruth. 'Where's Jilly? She not back from her climbing trip yet?'

Clive snorted. 'Evidently not. Shall we get going?'

---

We had not set foot in Solace House for three days, and the house felt almost childishly furious with us for leaving it. Despite the heat of another sunny day, it felt colder than usual inside the cavernous hallway. Even the brightly lit attic space was chilly.

We were supposed to be clearing the attic but, apart from Helen, none of us was enthusiastic about burning Flayne's beautiful, disturbing visions any earlier than we absolutely had to, so the paintings stayed on the walls. Instead, we moved the table that the dummies had been seated around; it was made of some very heavy hardwood, and it took all of twenty minutes for us to manoeuvre it downstairs. As we steered it across the hallway on the ground floor, I saw, behind us, spots of fresh blood on the white tiles.



Removing my hand, I saw that three fingertips on my left hand had been cut by a metal fitting under the table. My fingers were slick with blood.

*'Shit.'*

'Did you cut yourself?' said Helen.

'No, I have stigmata,' I said, more angrily than I intended.

'Alright,' said Helen. 'Pardon me for asking.'

Her genuine concern, and my petulant reaction, caused me a momentary pang of shame. 'I'm sorry. It was just a shock. Where's the first aid kit?'

'God, now you're asking,' said Clive. 'It's somewhere at the bottom of the stairs over there. We brought it over the first day we came here. I don't think anyone's even looked at it since.'

'I'll find it.' As the others trooped back up the stairs, I toyed with the idea of going into Flayne's grubby suite of rooms to use the filthy sink, but immediately decided against it. Instead, I just had to hope that the first aid kit, when I found it, would have antiseptic of some kind.

Where had we put it, that first day? It was somewhere here, among the debris at the foot of the stairs. We'd since moved stuff aside to give us more room, and it had clearly been buried. I moved some books, a large box. Underneath the box were a variety of musical scores, stacks and stacks of them, subject to the same incontinent replication which we now all accepted as one of the fundamental conditions of Solace House. I moved a stack of the scores and discovered a small hollow beneath, formed by the four legs of an upturned footstool.

And there it was. Glossy and black, crouching like a great poisonous frog. Utterly still and unmoving, but alive with malevolent potential.

The telephone.

I froze.

I stared stupidly at it for a long moment, unsure of what, precisely, to do next. I was still considering this question when the telephone jangled into life, ringing loudly and clearly. I gasped.

*How does it know?* I thought.

Slowly, carefully, I reached down to it. The receiver was unexpectedly cold to the touch: the vibration of the ringing bells unexpectedly strong and

urgent through the heavy Bakelite. I lifted the handset off the cradle mid-ring.

‘Hello?’

There was a crackling burst of noise, followed by something that sounded like cutlery being thrown across a concrete floor. And then, faint, as if heard from two rooms away, raised voices; I thought I heard someone say something that sounded like *I’ll be where you decide*. Straining to hear, I almost jumped when a much louder voice cut through the chaos.

‘Hello?’ A woman. Before I could answer, she said something that sounded like *Is that the hollow scene?*

‘I’m sorry?’

The voice came back stronger, clearer. ‘I said *is this Solace House?* Or Marshlands Hospital? Sorry, I might have the wrong number.’

‘No,’ I said, a strange prickling nausea climbing through my skin. ‘This is Solace House.’

‘Oh, thank God for that. Are you one of the people stuck there?’

‘I... am?’ I said. The situation was so strange I still wasn’t entirely convinced I was speaking to a human being. ‘Who is this?’

‘This is Daena McCullough at the Student Office. Is that Clive Masters?’

‘No,’ I said, hugely relieved. ‘Hello, Ms McCullough. It’s Alex Lane here. Clive’s upstairs.’

‘Who?’ she said. ‘Sorry, the line is very bad.’

‘ALEX LANE,’ I said loudly.

‘Ah yes, of course. Hello, Mr Lane.’

‘You’ve come through to the actual house,’ I said. ‘I don’t think anyone uses this number any more. I’m amazed that it even—’

I fancied I heard the sound of air moving round a large empty space, small sounds lost in a great expanse. I strained to hear; again, there seemed to be another conversation, or something very like it, taking place somewhere on the line, two voices or maybe just one. From this electronic soup, Daena McCullough’s voice, degraded and spectral, surfaced once more.

‘—was the other number I had, and as it’s an emergency—’  
‘I’ll get Clive,’ I said.

---

Clive’s incredulity at the news that the long-lost telephone had been found was matched only by his indignance at having to come downstairs to answer it. I had laid the receiver down on the burst upholstery of the dusty chaise longue; he scooped it up and answered in a manner which suggested he thought I was playing a practical joke on him.

After a few seconds with the receiver pressed to his ear, however, the bemused look faded from his face, and his mouth opened involuntarily. And then he was simply listening.

‘When was this?’ he said, and I knew something was wrong.

‘Of course,’ he said, then, ‘I’m so sorry.’ After two more *of course*’s and a *thank you*, as well as a pause to give Daena McCullough the correct number for Marshlands, Clive replaced the handset on its metal cradle. His face was pale. In my mind’s eye, I saw the telephone, complete once more, scuttle away furtively, seeking the darkness.

‘What is it?’ I asked.

He looked through me, not seeing me. Eventually, he shook his head.

‘Get the others.’

## 50

99. She will evaporate, evanesce.  
To *our* faeryland flee, evermore.  
Now complete, entire. Unto night's caress:  
Lost Eden's ambitions now law.

100. Irreversible: gone, Her *tender* sympathy.  
Her ideas now inspiring none.  
Gone! Into night, nonexistence, infinity;  
Gone, Her tender sympathy. Done.

SENSING FROM MY demeanour that something was wrong, everyone descended the staircase, all the way down to the hall, in silence. Their reactions seemed to mirror my own; disbelief that the mysterious phone had been found and answered, plus the unspoken assumption that whatever message such a thing had to impart could never be good news. Clive waited until we were all assembled, and quiet.

'Okay,' he said. 'It's about Jilly Cowie. You know she was on a climbing weekend?'

'Oh *no*,' said Ella.

'Yes. She lost her footing and she fell. Her safety harness failed.'

'*Oh my God is she dead?*' Helen's voice, practically pronouncing this question as a single word, sliced through the still air.

'No,' said Clive evenly. 'She is, however, very badly injured. She's in a coma.'

'She's gonna be fine, though, right?' asked Adam.

Clive shrugged. 'She has a very serious head injury. Daena McCullough said it isn't wise, at this stage, to assume anything, but... the prognosis isn't great.'

'No!' said Ruth, genuinely upset. 'Poor Jilly.'

'I shall pray for her,' said Helen nobly.

Clive glanced at her, but said nothing.

'As her deputy,' he said quietly, as if coming to the realization as he spoke, 'I'm now in charge of everything here at Solace House.'

'Oh no,' said Helen.

'Don't worry,' said Clive gently. 'I can be very responsible when I need to be.'

'Oh *no*,' said Helen.

---

After his sudden and unexpected promotion, the shift in Clive was immediate. As we all absorbed the news about Jilly, he clapped his hands together in a gesture which could only be described as *Cowieesque*. Once he had our attention, he made a short speech.

'Okay, everyone. I'll have to go back to Marshlands, toot sweet, and get on the phone. Make sure the relevant people at the university know what's happened to Jilly, and that – awful though that is – a responsible adult is now in charge in her place.'

'And that's *you*, is it?' said Malcolm, in a tone of utter disbelief. 'Fucking hell.'

'Now, now,' said Clive. 'Given how cushy the whole set-up here is, I'm very keen to ensure it keeps running smoothly. So yeah, I can be responsible. Look at me, I'm being responsible right now.'

'I can't believe you're joking at a time like this.' Helen shook her head.

Clive smiled affably. 'I'm not joking, Helen, promise. I have to step up, now. I know how lucky we are to have this job, and I'm absolutely not going to jeopardize that. Chill out.'

'So how do we proceed?' asked Ella.

‘Carry on with what you’re doing here,’ said Clive, a little puzzled. ‘You know. Move stuff outside. Chuck it in a big pile. Move more stuff... you’ll soon pick it up again.’

‘I didn’t mean that, dickhead,’ said Ella. ‘I meant—’

‘That’s *Mister* dickhead to you.’

‘—I *meant*, that Jilly wanted Flayne’s paintings burned. A lot of us were very uncomfortable with that, and—’

‘We’re still burning them,’ said Helen.

Ella ignored this and continued speaking. ‘A lot of us were uncomfortable with the idea of burning a man’s legacy, his life’s work—’

‘We’re still going to burn them!’ said Helen firmly. ‘Like those awful dummies!’

Ruth shook her head. ‘No. The dummies were one thing, Helen, but burning paintings? I mean, who are we?’

‘*We are still going to burn them!*’ repeated Helen.

‘Nope,’ said Clive. ‘We are not.’

Helen looked aghast at this, but Clive continued. ‘I was thinking about it over the weekend, and we’d be mad to do it. Those paintings are clearly worth a fortune, even as curios. Burning them was Cowie’s idea – her choice, not the university’s – and she’s not here any more. So we’ll put it to a vote. All those in favour of saving Flayne’s deranged paintings for the nation, stick your hand up.’

Everyone bar Helen put their hand up.

‘All those opposed?’

Helen’s hand jabbed into the air, as if the enthusiasm and commitment she brought to the gesture would override her lack of support.

‘Well, there you go,’ said Clive. ‘Flayne’s paintings will be transported to Marshlands and catalogued. The university will have them.’

‘No,’ said Helen through gritted teeth. ‘*They should be burned.*’ I assumed she was being melodramatic as usual.

Clive shrugged. ‘That’s democracy for you.’ He turned and headed out of the house into the bright sunshine.

---

We all talked a little about Jilly Cowie, but there was nothing to say, really, beyond platitudes. Had she been dead, the experience might have been easier to process, but as things were, she was somewhere unreachable, in a zone that couldn't be speculated about. Also, none of us really knew her; she had used her time at Marshlands to pursue her own schemes, her clubs and activities, her sporting calendar. Ironically, for someone whose entire social life seemed to revolve around sporting clubs, it was impossible to think of her as being part of the team here.

The day crept on. I found the first aid kit and cleaned and dressed the cuts on my hand. We decided that before taking the paintings down, we should remove the moth-eaten stair carpet, which was in many places in such bad repair it constituted a real threat of falling downstairs. This meant unscrewing all of the brass stair rods, then rolling the crumbling carpet up as we went. This operation ended up taking all day. The work was filthy, kicking up huge clouds of dust, meaning that conversation was almost impossible through our masks. And so, we conducted this task mostly in silence, locked in our own thoughts.

At some point in the afternoon, I recalled something troubling.

---

After dinner, with everyone relaxing in the kitchen or their own rooms, I went to speak to Leo.

I knocked, and his door swung open. The room already smelled bad; I saw plates with the remnants of meals on them, cigarette filters pushed into the debris. I saw, on the desk, that the jar Leo had taken from the room with the effigies in it lay open, the top finally forced off. It was now, for reasons known only to Leo, full of murky brown liquid; the object it held was now suspended in this solution by means of a wire looped around a pencil, set across the open top. Leo was still in his underwear, the same vest and boxer shorts, and was staring out of the window, smoking a cigarette. The bed was unmade; above it, stuck to the wall with masking tape, was the purple

crayon spiral he'd made, the rubbing of the carving in the cave. It glowered down at me as I waited for Leo to acknowledge my presence.

'How did you know?' I said eventually.

'I'm sorry,' he said, at his own languid pace. 'How did I know what?'

'When I saw you yesterday. You said *Jilly's next, then Ella*. Something like that.'

'Did I?'

'Yes. Then you said Helen, Ruth. Clive. Then me. What did you mean by that?'

'I don't remember saying that.' He turned back to the window. It had only been two days since his expedition to the cave, but he'd lost weight.

'Sun comes up,' he said quietly. 'Sun goes down. Up. Down.' He turned to me and smiled. 'Maddening. How's Solace House?'

'Same, really. Up and down. Leo, what happened to you?'

He stared out of the window at the dusk surrounding Marshlands, but didn't answer. After a few seconds, I realized he wasn't going to follow that up with anything.

'Did you find what you were looking for?' I said, with as much patience as I could summon. 'At Bewise?'

He turned to face me. His eyes were suddenly alive with intent, so much so that I almost jumped.

'Oh yes.'

'And? Was that where all this came from? Did you have a bad trip?' He shrugged and gave a half-smile as if the question were irrelevant. I sighed. 'You're saying I don't understand. Well, fine. Help me, Leo. I can't understand if you don't tell me.'

'You understand everything. You already know.'

Again, I sighed. There were books stacked on a stool to my left, so I lifted them carefully to the floor and sat down. Leo was staring at the wall now and yawning. It was almost as if he were sedated.

'What happened to you?' The question arrived more forcefully than I intended.

He exhaled slowly.



‘I went to where I wanted to get to,’ he said. ‘That other realm.’ He smiled. ‘Hyperspace. Faeryland. The end of all things. The Omega Point of transcendence. Whatever you might call it. It can’t really be named. It is ineffable, unnameable by its very—’

I sensed we were straying from the point. ‘What did you see?’

He laughed.

‘I saw reality, Alex. Real – terrifyingly real – reality. As Flayne did.

I saw the final perception. I saw it all.’

‘Okay,’ I said non-committally. *Give people enough mushrooms, I thought, and they’ll tell you this kind of thing as a matter of routine.*

‘This.’ He waved an arm around him, as if he hadn’t heard me. ‘You. Me. This world. This – place we live in. It’s – a pencil sketch. No – more like the crayon rubbing up there, the one I took of the carving. A vague impression. A palimpsest. Ella Flayne glimpsed it; Flayne saw it. He knew.’

I heard myself snort contemptuously.

‘You don’t have to believe me,’ he smiled, with complete disinterest.

‘Great, ’cos I don’t. You just took drugs, Leo. Like you always do. Only this time, you had a bad trip, or a way-too-good one. Now you’re dealing with the fallout, psychologically speaking.’

It was his turn to snort with contempt.

‘No. I’ve had bad trips, and no matter how bad they got, I could always tell myself it was just the action of a chemical on my nervous system. No matter how persuasive the experience.’

‘How was this any different?’

He smiled again, looking through me. ‘*This was real.*’

I stared at him. He looked away.

‘Many orders of magnitude realer than’ – he waved a hand – ‘*this*. More refined. More complex. More – just *more*. In every possible sense, every possible regime. Richer. Vaster. Just...’ Words failed him. ‘*More.*’

His eyes locked onto mine, and I froze. His eyes seemed to hold an eerie light within.

‘A higher dimension. I saw all the myriad paths of human history, all possibilities, all outcomes blossoming in infinity, from every minute action,

leading to that supreme moment of transcendence. I saw all destinies—' His hands were clenched together.

'Leo—' I began.

'And I saw *us*, Alex. Humanity, or the remnant of us. What we will become. Answering the call of the stars. Nothing you can imagine. To migrate across the void, we say goodbye to bones and teeth. To skeletons and skulls. Boneless we fly, in vastness, made of electric jelly. Stalking the sky on ropes of glowing tissue. Tweaking history, to make our becoming more likely. Goodbye to five tiny human senses. Goodbye to the human prison. Goodbye to death. Flesh transcended to answer the interstellar. But that's just outside, Alex. Nothing compared to what will become of our *minds*. Unfolding eternally like a flower, in endless higher dimensional space...'

He said all this in one rush, with such confidence and conviction that my skin crackled.

'An apocalyptic transformation in perception, in sensation. And I saw it, Alex, *I saw it all*. Edwin Flayne saw it too, and could have possessed it, but he fled in fear. And I can't come back now.' There was a sudden vein of fear in his voice. 'I have one foot there, one foot here.'

He looked away and his eyes were filled with tears.

'*Am I there now, Alex? Or am I here?*'

He stared at me. I didn't move. I didn't dare breathe.

'I went there, Alex, and I *saw*! The closest thing I can compare it to is... imagine if you were a cartoon. Flat, two dimensional. Black and white. And then one day, you find yourself in our world. Can you imagine that? Seeing that greater, richer, more perfect reality? And then' – he looked painfully wistful for a second – '*can you imagine being thrust back where you came from?*'

'*Do you see now?*' he said again. He turned to look out of the window. 'Where I went... what I saw... I can't come back to... this. This... *crayon drawing*.'

A long silence gathered itself into being around us, a space in which neither of us could possibly continue talking. I made a series of attempts to

start a sentence, but nothing came.

‘If you saw it,’ he said, at length. ‘If you saw it. Then you’d understand.’

---

‘I’ll come back,’ I said eventually. ‘I just think you need some distance from this. Some rest.’

He nodded, apparently amused by this suggestion. And then he remembered something.

‘Oh – I saw Ella there,’ he said. ‘Eons from now. Unchanged.’

‘I think you need to rest,’ I said robotically.

‘Ella, Ruth, Clive. Then Helen. I remember now.’

‘What are you talking about?’

‘Not Malcolm, though. He leaves.’

‘I’m going now.’

‘And not Adam. Obviously. Not Adam!’ And he began to laugh, a bitter, unpleasant laugh. ‘*Not Adam!*’

I backed out of the room, closing the door quietly behind me.

# 51

101. Esto Sapiens, O, Lord, and thus in our name.

Enact now Christ's oft-uttered notion:

To everyone's *ruin* is nobody's gain.

A ladder, leading to redemption.

102. Imagine: A lifetime shrouded, hazed.

Events now *concealed*, events lost.

Or neatly erased. Look, your idol says:

Gaze on Death, his ending to host.

A WEEK WENT BY. Clive, against all the odds, turned out to be a reasonably good leader; with the stairway clear, he selected the rooms which were most full as our next targets, reasoning that this way, the work would get easier as we went along. And so, we spent our days clearing the most cluttered of these spaces, although none of them yielded anything particularly noteworthy, weird or unique. It was almost as if Flayne, having excelled himself on all of these fronts in the first floor rooms and the attic, had just stopped trying.

Leo began to emerge from his room a little more; although he didn't return to work, he seemed to be on the mend. He didn't even seem to care when Helen mentioned again that he shouldn't be paid for the days he hadn't worked. He ate in his room, away from us.

In the evenings, Ella and I spent all the time we had together.

---

Flayne's illuminated volume of verse was open on the desk; next to it was one of the yellow legal pads that Ella favoured, covered in her handwriting. It looked for all the world as if she'd been composing poetry too, the lines of whatever she'd been writing arranged in verses. As I approached the desk, she slammed the red volume shut and rolled the cover down on the legal pad.

'First things first,' she said, before I could say anything. 'There's something very unusual about that volume, and I want more time to get to grips with it before I share it with you. In the meantime, we've quite enough to think about, given how *this* ends.' She hefted the brown ledger, Flayne's final record of his time at Solace House, onto the bed. 'Pour us both some wine.'

I did so, passing a mug to her. 'You finally finished it, then?'

'Sure did,' said Ella. 'It seems that whatever Flayne was doing inside his head, alone in that house, with mathematics and physics and magical shit, began to bear fruit, and he claims to have made contact with, or established a bridge to, that *Exalted Realm, beyond time and mind*, which he says has always been reachable from Solace House.'

My mouth was dry. 'This is what Leo was going on about,' I said. 'The same place that Ella Flayne saw, when she arrived here. Leo said he went there, he saw it. I think he's quite damaged, Ella. I think—'

'First things first, Lane. Let me just tell you this, then we can think about Leo.'

I nodded.

'So, he maintains that accessing this realm will grant him what he wants. His plan is to recover his mother, who by this point is no longer merely mother to Flayne himself, but symbolic of the place where not only his own sanity but, for him, the sanity of the entire world rests.

'One of two things – possibly more – happens at this point. An outside observer would say that Flayne begins to sabotage his own vibrant and active fantasy life, that his subconscious rebels against his carefully constructed delusions and it all starts to unravel. However, there *are* no

outside observers, no second opinions, not for Flayne. So whatever he's enduring, in his mental state is, to him, actuality. Think of that.'

'Go on.' I was already wondering now whether the same mania that had befallen Flayne had claimed Leo.

'So, in Flayne's reality, he really *does* perform a ritual to travel to another realm, or a higher dimension, or the end of time, or wherever the fuck. A ritual to *enperpetuate* himself, and the house. His word. And, just as Blake saw angels in Lambeth, it doesn't matter whether it's quote-unquote *real* or not. As far as Flayne's concerned, it's reality.'

Ella paused to swig some wine.

'He does not feel good about this. Listen—' She read from the volume. '*If I can change history, should I save Christ? Should I rescue Him from His bloody fate? It seems right. Yet in so doing, I would damn all mankind.*

*'I am in a place where no choice is without horror.'*

I considered the implications of this. Flayne deciding the fate of all mankind, from his squalid suite of rooms.

'Whatever his objections, though, he overcomes them. He goes ahead and does his ritual, which grants the person who does it access to a point where all possible history can be seen and accessed.'

On the open page of Flayne's ledger was a drawing, a complex crystal pattern of precisely incised lines, simultaneously mathematical and kabbalistic; reasoned and occult. Every node, every intersection, was given a string of numbers and letters, as if they were co-ordinates.

'Only when he gets to that point, when he immerses himself in what he calls *The Exalted Realm*, he finds – to his horror – there's another presence there.'

An odd sensation thrilled through me.

'A thing that lives out there, in the place where, as he puts it, *all time is one moment, where all time is exhausted, and yet not begun*, where the house now drifts, unmoored, thanks to his magical operation. He sees this thing, enthroned, and he's truly and absolutely terrified. He calls this being *The Mad God*, and the mere sight of it is enough for him to abandon the ritual.

‘Only now, in his dreams, he sees it, this thing, and it thrives on his attention, it comes more definitely into being the more he thinks about it. It wants form, it wants energy, and becoming, *the things denied it for centuries uncountable*, in a place where – and I quote – *the millennia pile up like grains of sand on a beach the size of creation*. It wants actuality. It wants a return to the physical realm. And it is getting closer.

‘And so he resolves to take steps to ensure it can’t come through. He builds a trap. A room it must manifest in, if it comes, but which it cannot exit, a room designed and built to very exact specifications.’

‘*Holy shit*,’ I breathed, turning to look at her. ‘*The mirror room*.’

Ella nodded gravely.

‘So Flayne summons up this Mad God, or invites it, or it comes anyway. He’s not clear about that; either way, it comes. And he succeeds in trapping it in that room, which he calls *The Forever Room*, and then he puts as many barriers between it and him as he possibly can. A labyrinth of junk. All of it. We thought it was all connected to his mother’s disappearance – and in a way it was – but not in the way we thought. All of the debris, it was all to confuse and confound *the thing in that room*.’

‘And *we let it out*,’ I said. ‘Oh my God. We have to tell the others!’

Ella immediately burst out laughing. After a few seconds, seeing that I didn’t join her, she stopped.

‘Oh, you’re serious. Sorry, I thought you were – wow.’

‘We have to tell them!’

‘Alex!’ said Ella. ‘Flayne was completely mad! He trapped *nothing* inside that room, apart from yet more of his madness.’

I must have looked unsure, because Ella sighed.

‘You were the first one in there. Did *you* feel anything, Alex? When you went into that room? Any *evil force* residing in there, pent up for decades?’

I shook my head. ‘No, but—’

‘We’re dealing with the life and works of someone whose mind has absolutely gone. You can’t take Flayne’s philosophy seriously, any more than you’d believe Richard Dadd’s idea that his father was the Devil, or

Franz Xaver Messerschmidt, when he said he'd angered the Spirit of Proportion.'

'Yeah, I don't know who that second one is. I only know who the first one is because of you.'

'It doesn't matter. All I'm saying is, to enter into Flayne's madness, and accept it as a logical reason for anything... would be madness too. And that's what Leo has done.'

She was right.

I had failed to account for the obvious. Flayne did not journey to the end of time, or a parallel realm; he simply shut himself up in three filthy rooms of a vast house, becoming madder with each passing year. And Leo, marinating for weeks in this environment, had simply done a foolish thing and taken too many drugs. It was an ordinary, depressing, almost squalid thing, masquerading as insight, as revelation.

Ella went on. 'Anyway, after that, Flayne burns his library, carefully, book by book, to ensure that no-one can follow what he calls his *work*. Only, during this, he has a change of heart, and becomes ashamed. He says knowledge of any kind should never be destroyed. As such, he preserves the ritual, but doesn't say where.'

I thought for a minute.

'Do you think Leo will be okay?'

'Yeah,' said Ella. 'I mean, y'know, eventually. He just stuck his hand in the fire once too often and got burned. It happens.'

Relief flowed through me. She sounded so sure.

'We should show the others this,' I said, leafing through Flayne's final volume.

Ella propped her head on her hand. 'Why?'

'Because they should see it?'

'It's *ours*, Alex,' she said. 'Our thing. The world can have the paintings and the other ledgers, but sharing this will mean it's just another boring curio. Contained here, it's something we have, something no-one else will ever know.'

She smiled down at me, the candle flames reflected in her eyes.



*‘It’s for us.’*

*OceanofPDF.com*

## 52

103. At that empty *Xanadu*, no innocent he,  
In light of diabolic endeavour.  
Cold rage, ending each day's liturgy  
I gather his trespasses, ever.

104. Vernal equinox revealed. Lo! As shyly  
The impatient night gathers stars.  
Here, our universe lies *dreaming*, slyly –  
How intensely nothingness errs!

LATER, THAT NIGHT, naked, the sweat cooling on our bodies, she rolled over to look at me, so that her face, framed by her long red hair, was all I could see. I had made another joint with the last of the buds I had stolen from Clive's apparently inexhaustible bag of weed, and I handed it to her. She drew hard on it and exhaled a huge jet of smoke into the still air, before taking a swig of red wine.

'I want to see the cave,' she said at last. 'I've finished Flayne's journal now. I've done all my homework.'

'So now maybe I can finally read it?' I said sulkily.

'I didn't know you could read.'

'Ha ha. Anyway, I thought you said the cave was *bad vibes*. Your exact words.'

She shrugged. 'How bad can the vibes be? You went there, and you seem fine. I just want to see it.' She started to pull her clothes on.

‘What, right now?’ I looked at her bedside clock. ‘It’s 11.30! I have work tomorrow, woman. As do you.’

‘I don’t care,’ she said. ‘It’s a huge gap in my experience of this place. You’ve seen it, Leo’s seen it—’

‘And look how well that’s gone,’ I said. She ignored me.

‘I just want to see it.’

‘Now?’

‘Now.’

---

We got dressed. I watched, bemused, as Ella stuffed Flayne’s red volume of verse under her mattress for safe keeping, and wondered if this was a habit learned through trauma, from fleeing from place to place, or just merely a harmless eccentricity with no deeper meaning. Leo’s bag was still in the kitchen; a cursory rummage through it produced the iron key. Ella held it up in triumph, as if to say *there’s no excuse now*. We picked up two of the torches and made our way out of the house.

Clive, true to form, had not locked the gate in the wall, and it swung open as soon as we touched it. Through the woods, the cold night air spiced with pollen; to the house itself, slumbering in the darkness, our torch beams faint against its vastness. Through the garden, cursing as we stumbled through the pitch blackness of the yew maze. And then the place beyond, Ella Flayne’s magical vale, and Bewise, glittering with starlight.

Inside, Ella held the torches as I fiddled with the key. The mechanism clicked, and the door swung calmly open. Our breath came in clouds here.

‘Last chance,’ I said. ‘Want to turn back?’

‘Hell, no.’ She pushed past me, shoving a torch into my arms, and walked on into the tunnel. She strode ahead; by the time I caught up with her she was already in the process of scrambling through the tiny aperture at the end of the passageway, wriggling through, fearlessly, at impressive speed. Ahead of me, as I crawled, I saw her drop out of sight, onto the floor of the main cavern. And then I heard her swear loudly as she saw the place.

I squeezed out of the rock face, easing myself out with my elbows, and stood next to her.

‘It’s amazing!’ she said. ‘Incredible!’ She flashed her torch at the ceiling, stumbled a little on the sloping floor.

‘Careful.’ I shone my torch at the centre of the chamber, where the floor dropped away into nothingness.

‘Holy shit,’ she said. ‘Whatever happened to Leo, at least he didn’t fall down *there*.’

I realized we were holding each other tightly, as if the place were alive and might hear us.



‘Either this place makes people go mad,’ she said, perhaps to herself, ‘or it just brings out the latent madness in them.’

We were sitting on the cold, dusty sand of the cave floor. Occasionally, one or other of us would find a pebble and pitch it in the direction of the great black hole. Other than that, the only sounds were our voices, and their echoes. Ella lit a cigarette.

‘*Latent madness*,’ I repeated teasingly. ‘Are you sure that’s not just something you tell yourself everybody has, to distract from your own lunacy?’

‘You know what I mean,’ said Ella. ‘We all have the propensity for madness, but what form it takes is different for everyone. You’re only ever one terrible incident away from being consumed by your own personal mania.’

‘Me personally, or everyone?’

She didn’t seem to hear me. ‘So maybe this place is a catalyst? Maybe there’s some quality to the place that helps people go mad. And always has done.’ She passed me the cigarette.

I took a drag. ‘I mean, I suppose it would account for what’s happened to Leo.’

‘That’s just it,’ Ella mused. ‘Maybe it went for him first. I mean, he more or less threw himself in harm’s way, what with the mushrooms and all. And if *that’s* the case, who’s next? Who’s already close to insanity? Helen?’

I shrugged. ‘I think she arrived mad to begin with.’

‘Wait, we’re forgetting Adam,’ she said. ‘Let’s be honest, the place doesn’t have to do much to destabilize *him*. So that makes the theory break down. He’d surely have been the first to go mad, provided he isn’t already.’

I thought of him chanting to himself inside his room, but decided not to mention it. ‘If that’s what it’s doing then who’s next to go?’

Ella smiled. ‘Who’s the least sane of those of us who are left?’ I passed the cigarette to her.

‘I think it’s you,’ she said.

I choked on a mouthful of smoke. ‘I beg your pardon?’

‘Hey,’ she said. ‘You’re the one with the mysterious backstory.’

‘I’m sorry,’ I said. I tried and failed not to sound indignant. ‘You’re saying my parents dying is just *mysterious backstory*, is that it? A bit of exotic colour I’m cultivating?’

‘That’s not what I meant.’

‘And yet, that is exactly how it sounded.’

‘You *know* I didn’t mean it like that. I just meant, there’s this huge thing in your life that you won’t talk about. Some aspect of what you’ve been through. Something so traumatic you don’t even want to think about it.’

I rolled my eyes. ‘This! I’ve already told you all about it! You want me to tell you again?’

She laughed sardonically. ‘*Again* is when you do something twice, Lane. You haven’t talked about what happened to you, not really. There’s something at the heart of it you won’t talk about. You won’t talk about how it affected you, or anything like that.’

‘Great,’ I said. ‘So because I didn’t tell you something, that means I’m insane?’

‘That’s not—’

‘I should just tell you everything, after I’ve known you for, what, three weeks?’

Even in the limited light, I saw that she was wounded by this.

‘Wow,’ she said, coldly.

I tried to backtrack. ‘What I mean is, I’m hardly going to tell you everything about me after such a short time, am I?’

‘But *I* did,’ she said, ‘I told you everything. About me, my situation. How it made me feel. You’ve made a point of not doing that.’

‘I didn’t make a point of it,’ I said through gritted teeth. ‘I just – didn’t.’

‘Exactly. You just – didn’t. I told you everything about me, but you... I dunno, maybe you assumed it was an easy thing for me to do, to talk about the awful shit at the core of my life. But it isn’t.’ Carefully, she rolled the cigarette out in the dirt. ‘Trust is really important to me, you know that. And you know *why* trust is important to me, because I took the fucking time to tell you.’ She turned her face to the cold void of the empty cave, and muttered something I couldn’t hear.

‘What was that?’ She didn’t answer. Even with her face turned away from me, I could feel the anger radiating from her.

‘Ella?’

‘I wasn’t talking to you.’

‘Great. Talking to yourself. Makes sense, though, if we’re talking about who’s closer to madness,’ I said, ‘then yeah, *you’re* probably next.’

She looked at me as if I were making a bad joke; when it became obvious that I was serious, her expression darkened.

‘Because of what happened to me? Which you only know about because I trusted you enough to tell you? Classy move, Alex.’ She turned away again.

‘You said yourself your dad followed you round half the country. Packing up, moving, resettling somewhere else all the time. That has to do something to you psychologically. Ruth said you dropped out for almost an entire term. They were gonna kick you out. Does that sound like you escaped unscathed?’

Her expression, when she turned back to face me, was one of utter hostility.

‘You’re throwing all of this back at me? All the stuff I shared with you?’ She shook her head. ‘Wow.’

‘Obviously, that’s not what I’m doing. But hey, if you want to imagine it that way—’

‘At least I can talk about what happened to me.’ Anger gave her a strange form of gravitas; she seemed completely composed, almost regal. ‘At least I’m capable of it.’

‘Are we really having an argument over who is the most or least fucked up?’

‘Looks that way.’

‘This is mad,’ I said.

‘Yeah,’ she said. ‘Everything you don’t want to hear is madness, isn’t it, Alex? You know what? I think I’d rather be on my own.’

‘Down here?’

‘Yep.’

I snorted a short laugh which sounded, despite my intention, contemptuous. ‘Don’t be stupid. I’m not going to leave you here alone in this cave, without—’

‘Why, because you fucking care so much? I can’t be that important to you, you’ve *only known me for three weeks*, remember?’

‘So now who’s throwing stuff back?’

‘Oh, fuck off.’

‘Like I said, I’m not going to leave—’

‘Just *GO!*’ she yelled. The sound bounced off the wall, reverberating around me, as if shouted by a crowd, a hissing angry mob of Ellas.

I backed off, then hesitated, stunned that we’d somehow got here so quickly, Ella’s rage still chiming round the jagged walls of the chamber. She stared at me with burning fury, daring me to leave, daring me to stay, daring me to act.

A long time seemed to pass, in which conflicting courses of action rose and fell, flared up and died.

And slowly, I turned away from her. I climbed up into the aperture in the rock, and dragged myself through to the passageway beyond.

---

In a passion of fury, I made my way back to the house. I barely noticed the journey back, the yew woods, the cold. Anger carried me all the way back to Marshlands.

Once there, however, anger curdled into regret. I couldn't leave her down there, no matter how furious she was. I should go back. I should find her, apologize, make things right. It was stupid to fight. We were both tired. But a familiar stubborn pride had already congealed inside me, and I knew it wouldn't dissolve until the next morning. *She'll be just fine. Let her come back alone. It's what she wanted. Fuck her.*

Reaching my room, I almost walked directly into Adam.

'Oh God,' I said wearily. 'Not now.'

He was swaying slightly, and again, I saw that he was very, very drunk. His expression was one of intractable confusion and outrage; I saw that his fists were bunched and his perennially pale cheeks were, for once, flushed with colour.

'*She doesn't love you, you know.*' The hiss of his words was like steam escaping a damaged pipe.

'Fucking hell,' I said. I brought my hand up to the bridge of my nose. 'I feel very sorry for you, Adam. I do. I mean it.'

'*Fuck you.*' Saying these words as vociferously as he did almost caused him to stumble. My natural reaction was to put a hand on his shoulder to steady him, but I sensed that he'd interpret that as provocation, so my hand stayed by my side. I exhaled, and opted to continue.

'I mean it, Adam. There's a few of us here because something terrible happened. Something which means we can't go home. You're not unique.'

He looked wounded; his eyes searched me for signs of insincerity. But in these kinds of situations, I knew, only total honesty would suffice.



‘She’s for me,’ he said clearly, throwing back his head, regarding me with drunken arrogance. ‘Eleanor.’

‘This shit again? And her name is Ella, Adam. Get it right.’

He shook his head petulantly, and his whole body swayed. I guessed he might even be two entire bottles of vodka down at this point.

‘Eleanor,’ he said. ‘Her name is Eleanor.’

I tensed, on the verge of telling him. That I knew all about him, that he had killed someone, carelessly, and that his dad had made it all vanish. That I knew exactly what manner of creature he was, what he was capable of. And yet, I felt this would be a terrible mistake. He was, at his core, too far gone. And if the girl he had killed was called Eleanor, it made much more sense of his obsession with Ella. Not only were they similar looking, they had similar names. I found that I could follow his logic very well. It almost made sense. Eleanor had been killed, but she had returned to him, slightly translated, slightly transformed, and that was – to him – a miracle.

*She’s for me.*

I could see now. I could see why he hated me.

He smiled at the expression on my face. ‘You know.’

‘Know what?’

‘You know she’s not meant for you. You’re not part of the pattern. You never will be.’

‘Oh God, pattern? Go to bed, Adam.’ I was suddenly very tired of it all; Helen and her fire and brimstone, Leo with his abstruse mutterings; Ella and me, arguing pointlessly; and now this, Adam drunkenly seeing patterns in the tapestry of history, with himself the most integral part.

‘Everything will change,’ said Adam. He wasn’t moving. ‘Everything.’ He turned to me. ‘She’s for me.’

‘Great,’ I said. ‘She’s at Bewise, if you want to go and be with her. Now leave me the fuck alone.’

I slammed my door shut behind me.

## 53

105. Even my pitiful, trifling infraction  
Now evaporates; such sweet *relief*.  
Eden's new dawn, endless reinvention,  
Eternal damnation's reprieve!

106. (Ever such pure lies erupt now, *disdained*;  
Expose, now, this infernal nest.  
Death's eerie enticements dire, nothing attained –  
Unmarked grave has that ghost repossessed –)

I WOKE UP with the feeling that something terrible had happened, the kind of morning-after guilt one experiences during a hangover, the feeling of having made a fool of oneself, of overstepping boundaries, behaving badly, in the service of causing event for event's sake.

Then I remembered our fight.

As I stood outside Ella's room I was prepared not merely to apologize, but to tell Ella, that morning, everything: what happened to my parents, my father, the story that had shaped me and remade me, rewritten me, into someone I never planned to be, but now had no choice but to embody. I recognized again the depth of my feelings for her, how quickly those feelings had grown. Excitement at seeing her bubbled up within me; there was so much to tell her, so much to say. I knocked on the door, and waited, then knocked again.

A minute or so passed. I knocked again.

I pushed the door open; it gave easily.

The bed had been stripped and the linen rolled up on the mattress. All of Ella's personal effects were gone; the cupboards and drawers were open, the interiors bare.

The place was empty.

I stood in the middle of the room, lit at this stage of the morning by brilliant sunlight, and felt the numbness of absolute uncertainty.

---

Slowly, cautiously, I returned to my room. On my desk, I saw – unnoticed previously – a note, folded once, written on half a sheet of yellow legal paper, torn at the top:

SORRY  
ELLA

Had it been there when I woke up? Had she only just left it? Was she still here, waiting for a cab to take her away? I ran outside.

The fields around Marshlands were lion's mane-yellow, scorched by the summer sun, the grass almost knee-height now, extending off in all directions, forever.

I stood for a long time outside Marshlands, staring at the bland landscape, as if she might be somehow discerned within it. The single road out to the gates dribbled away to vanish in the watercolour haze of the early day.

I thought then very clearly of Ella, a few days ago, saying, in a moment of pure honesty, *'One day I just want to fuck it all off. Just go, and not come back. Leave all of it. My course. This country. I don't know. All of it. Just fuck it all off.'*

---

Clive was in the kitchen, wearing an unbuttoned Hawaiian shirt and a pair of Y-fronts. He was bending over the gas cooker to light a cigarette.

'Ella's gone,' I said, feeling the sting of those words as I said them.

His lips smacked as he inhaled. 'Gone where?'

I showed him the note.

'Ah, shit,' he said. 'Sorry, man.'

I nodded, but couldn't answer. I was thinking about too many things at once. Clive, uncomfortable with silence, put a hand on my shoulder.

'You know what she's like. You heard what Ruth said about her, she literally attended, like, a couple of lectures all first term. And then she skipped out and changed courses. This is who she is. She was always like this.'

I started to say something, mouth some platitude, found instead that there was nothing, absolutely nothing, to say. Clive looked at me with an expression of genuine concern that managed to come across as condescending.

'I'm sorry. I mean, it'll be uncomfortable to run into her again when term starts, but, as I say. We all knew what she was like.'

'I suppose,' I said, at length. 'I just thought it – I thought we – were different. I thought we had a connection.'

'After three weeks?' Clive couldn't help himself.

'We had a connection,' I repeated. Then I shook my head. 'This doesn't make sense.' Clive opened his mouth, but, sensing more comforting banalities coming my way, I left the room before he could speak.

---

I found it was impossible to feel heartbroken, or even sad, about Ella's leaving, as it was so sudden.

Where would she have gone? Back to her mother's place, wherever that was now? It was likely. For all the talk of quitting her degree, this was a real possibility. However, I just couldn't believe she wouldn't have told me before she left. Ella was complex, flaky and impulsive, but she also possessed a burning curiosity, to get to the bottom of things she didn't understand, and she had loved the strangeness of Solace House every bit as much, and as genuinely, as I had. She also wasn't a petty person; I found it

hard to believe that one fight, no matter how charged, would be all the provocation she needed to leave. Plus, there were practical considerations. She would have had to be picked up by a cab, although if she'd left early enough or been picked up at the gates, no-one would have heard.

Still, something did not feel right. I went again to her room.

---

The room was as I – and Ella, apparently – had left it.

The morning sun still shone, flooding the room with light. I dropped to the floor. There was nothing under the bed, no traces or clues. I looked in the bin; it had been emptied. The cupboard, which served as a wardrobe, was also empty. I moved the bedside cabinet to one side, and pulled the single drawer entirely out of its slot to examine the space behind it, when I remembered something.

I stood up so fast my head hurt.

I rolled back a corner of the mattress, and reached under it. Immediately, my fingers connected with something, and before I'd even pulled it out, I knew what it was; Flayne's final notebook, red as liver, filled with its reams of cryptic quatrains.

I opened the book and flicked through it; there were some pages of loose-leaved notes in there, yellow legal pad pages, covered in Ella's handwriting, and I read them hungrily, expecting answers, but it seemed to me that she'd merely copied out some of the verses. There was nothing that shed any light on where she might have gone.

But the very fact that the ledger was here at all – and that only she and I knew about it, and where she hid it – was proof enough. I knew that she would never have left this prize behind.

She had not vanished of her own volition.

She had been taken, or removed, by someone else.

And who would do that?

## 54

107. *And* now this enchantment, death's avatar,  
Leaves letters lit in fire, erstwhile sin,  
Light in – (God's hand thus spake unto Belshazzar)  
Light inside my eyes – Him!

108. *E*den, resplendent, Eden, abhorrent;  
Light of solace, tortured lives undo.  
Never adhering to ideas coherent;  
*Each* valiant effort refused.

I STRODE INTO THE KITCHEN. Adam was making tea; I grabbed him and spun him round. Boiling water splashed onto his hand, and he yelped like a puppy.

‘What are you doing?’ he shrilled, before I hit him across the face.

‘*Where is she?*’ I shouted. ‘What the fuck have you done with her?’

‘What are you talking about?’

‘You fucking *know!*’

Ruth and Clive were on their feet, instantly, nearby.

‘*What* do I know?’ Adam yelped again, holding his scalded fingers. He sounded like an animal, something small and trembling and pathetic, caught in a trap, its tiny heart hammering. ‘What are you *talking* about?’

‘Ella!’ I said. And at her name, I saw a flash of something in his eyes, some very specific, very precise emotion detonating deep within him. ‘You know!’ I shouted. ‘What have you done with her?’

Despite everything, he recovered himself. 'I don't know what you're talking about.' His voice had already returned to normal, the same supercilious mocking noise he always made.

'What,' I said, as calmly as I could, 'have you done with her?' My hand was still clamped onto his arm. Under my palm, I felt his thin bicep tense.

'Jesus,' said Clive. 'Come on, Alex. Adam didn't have anything to do with Ella leaving. Ella just left.'

'Yeah,' said Ruth. 'Alex, this is mad.'

'*He* came to my room last night,' I said. 'Drunk, like fucking paralytic. And he was talking about Ella. He said I should back off. He said that he was *for her* – those were the words he used – and I should back off.'

'Did I?' Adam's cheeks flushed, adding a glaring splash of colour to his waxy face. 'Oh God. I'm sorry. I'd had a lot to drink.'

'*She's for me*. Why the hell would you say something like that?'

He flushed still further. 'Because...' He looked down at the floor. 'You know why. I was just... I was just drunk, and jealous. Please let go of my arm.'

'*Bullshit*.' I was surprised at the anger in my own voice, the volume of it. I held up the note I had found in my room. 'Look at this. This is the note I found in my room from Ella. Just two words, which is suspicious enough in its own right. But look – the paper's been torn. Along the top there. It's irregular.'

Everyone looked blankly at me. I began, suddenly, to feel as if the floor were not level, as if I were on a ship, pitching and sawing back and forth in a gathering storm, but I continued.

'It's *irregular*,' I said, 'because it's been torn from another piece of paper. Namely, one of the notes that Ella often left for this prick when she'd steal his cheese. Look!' I held up the note.

'Doesn't... look hugely irregular to me?' said Ruth, almost guiltily.

'*Look at it!*' In addition to the floor yawing unevenly, I was suddenly very hot. 'It's also been folded in a strange way, look. Like it had been folded before? Like it was part of a larger note, which—'

‘Alex,’ said Clive carefully. ‘Let go of Adam, yeah? Let go of him, maybe sit down.’

I began to answer him but found that I couldn’t.

‘Why would Adam even keep her notes?’ asked Ruth. There was real confusion in her voice. ‘About... cheese?’

‘Because he’s fucking obsessed with her! You all saw him! The way he is around her! He planned this. He kept the note, and cut it down so that it just read *SORRY, ELLA*, and then when I went to her room and discovered she was missing this morning, he must have crept into *my* room and put the note there.’

Nobody spoke. Everyone looked back at me blankly. Adam rubbed his arm and I saw that, without realizing, I had removed my grip on it.

‘Alex,’ said Ruth very slowly. ‘Shall we go and sit down?’

‘No!’ My voice, childishly defiant, sounded precisely like the yelp Adam had made when he scalded his hand. ‘Adam did this! She wouldn’t have just left. She wouldn’t!’

‘Alex, mate,’ said Clive. ‘You’re aware of how all this sounds, right?’

‘She also left something behind,’ I said, and immediately wished I hadn’t.

‘What?’ said Adam. I thought I heard alarm in his voice.

‘Some... stuff,’ I said. ‘Bits and pieces. A book.’

‘Alex,’ said Ruth calmly. ‘Come and sit down, okay?’

‘No!’ I shouted. ‘It’s true! He has a... weird obsession with Ella! Weirder than he’s letting on!’ Fury threw open rooms inside my mind that I hadn’t dared enter, up until now, and suspicions hardened into accusations. Before I was aware I was speaking, I was shouting.

‘He thinks she’s the woman he killed!’

‘Oh, what the fuck,’ said Clive, without intonation.

‘What on *earth*,’ said Adam, ‘are you talking about?’ And there was a faint note of smug triumph in his voice, inaudible to the others. I had lost my temper; I had lost.

‘*Don’t pretend you don’t know*,’ I hissed. ‘That woman you killed, driving whatever fucking stupid sports car you got for your eighteenth



birthday.'

Adam stared at me, his mouth open, unable to speak. He peered at me as if I were something monstrous.

'Yeah, that's right,' I said. 'I know that. I know all about *that*.'

A thought occurred to me, so blindingly bright I could barely look at it. 'Jesus. Maybe you killed her. Maybe you killed Ella, did away with her. If I can't have her, no-one can, right?

'Oh *God*,' said Clive. 'Alex—'

'You were so weird about her all along. Maybe—'

'Alright,' said Clive. 'Enough of this. Alex, can you sit down? Only we've somehow arrived at the point where, instead of recognizing that your flaky girlfriend's dumped you and fucked off, you're accusing someone else of actual murder.'

'*It makes sense*,' I said. But even I did not sound convinced now. I felt hot and sick, out there, in that place beyond humiliation, beyond reason. It was as if I had just publicly declared I could fly, or that I was the Son of God. I saw myself from above, saying these words.

'It makes total sense,' I repeated to a room full of people wearing the same expression. '*Total* sense.'

Nobody said anything.

Adam, rubbing his scalded hand, looked at me. Whatever motivated him, behind his glittering blue eyes, remained utterly unknowable.



Ruth took my arm and I let her lead me, as if I were an invalid, over to one of the armchairs. I realized I was trembling. The others milled around in the background, making concerned noises, and getting glasses of cold water for me. Malcolm stuck his head round the door, and Clive had a whispered conversation with him, and they both left. Adam, meanwhile, ran his scalded hand under the cold tap and glanced over at me, before leaving the room. Helen made a pantomime of coming in to collect a spoon, but

couldn't hide her real intention, which was to get a good look at me, now I'd gone mad.

*I'd gone mad*, I thought, with grim amusement. Ella was right after all.

Only Ruth and I remained in the kitchen. Silently, she made us both a cup of tea and sat down next to me.

'I know it's hard,' she said. 'Ella leaving like that.'

I said nothing. Ruth smiled and continued talking.

'I don't think anyone else here understands that depth of feeling, that madness. When you love someone, so quickly, so intensely, and then it all turns to shit overnight. I mean, that's basically why *I'm* here. Why I haven't gone back home. I had something amazing – someone amazing – and it all turned to shit, like it does, and so here I am.'

'What was his name?'

Ruth smiled. 'Susan.' We both laughed.

'All I'm saying,' she said softly, 'is that stuff like that can send someone completely over the edge.'

'I'm not over the edge,' I said eventually. 'I am very much the correct side of the edge, thank you very much.' Ruth smiled again; clearly this comment saw me returning to an approximation of something she considered My Old Self.

'Where did you get that story?' she said. 'About Adam killing someone?'

'Ella.'

Upon hearing this, Ruth nodded to herself, as if confirming a suspicion.

'You think Ella is a liar?'

Ruth shrugged.

'She is who she is. She didn't attend much of that whole first term. Lectures, tutorials, everything. She would just... disappear. And if you pressed her on where she'd gone, all you got was excuses.'

'What are you saying?'

'I'm saying that Ella is great, a laugh, incredibly smart and fun to be around. But maybe take what she says with a pinch of salt?'

'You think she just left,' I said.

Ruth nodded.

‘I think she just left.’

‘She just left,’ I said, considering the possibility for the first time.

---

Ella had argued with someone she thought she could trust, and had been hurt. Then, in a fit of immature pique, she’d done what she always did, probably only half-consciously realizing she was doing it. She had packed up, and called a cab, before anyone had woken up. She had nothing with her that couldn’t be stuffed into a single rucksack; packing wouldn’t have taken her very long. She might even have gone before the sun came up, before any of us were any the wiser. This version of events was clear, precise and made perfect sense, given all that I knew about Ella’s character. She had decided on a course of action in anger, and even when her temper cooled, she would consider it emotionally dishonest to change her mind.

And yet.

The presence of the ledger, Flayne’s final, illuminated psalter, said otherwise.

The red volume was something Ella loved, had taken delight in discovering. It was a singular, irreplaceable object, and the fact that she had bothered to hide it under her mattress at all was indicative of how much value she placed on it, how jealously she guarded it. She had been fascinated by the verses, and, like me, had determined that there was something about them which came closer to understanding the essence of Edwin Flayne and his world than the millions of words he’d committed to paper elsewhere. Also, if she really had left, she seemed to have taken the final brown volume of Flayne’s autobiographical musings with her; it was nowhere to be seen. Why would she take one and not the other? It made no sense. All of this left me in possession of an awkward, incontrovertible fact.

*She would never have left the red book behind.*

So what did that leave me with? The theory that someone packed for her, throwing all of her belongings into her rucksack? Failing, of course, to

pack the red volume because they knew nothing of its existence?

These contradictory stories chased each other round and round in my head, a priceless distraction from engaging with the other incontrovertible fact in this situation.

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## 55

109.Mourn our ruined ecstasy, sanity's collapse.  
His effaced *mind*'s escape, so torn.  
Reality all pitiless prophecy enacts,  
Dire initiation now sworn.

110.It doesn't exist. Melting, and drifting apart,  
*Strange* portals into rooms askew.  
Tesseract immeasurable, obeying naught,  
Thus its lunatic logic imbue.

TO MY SURPRISE, Leo was in the kitchen, scrubbing something in the sink.

I wasn't in the mood for human interaction, and I certainly wasn't in the mood for Leo, and so I chose not to comment on the fact that he was there at all, still less bring attention to the fact that he was washed, dressed and shaved, and looked neat and orderly, controlled, calm and self-possessed, a million miles away from the strange, hollowed-out person I'd spoken to in his room yesterday.

'Hey,' he said, in a businesslike fashion. 'Ella's gone, is that true?'

'Yes,' I breathed. I was suddenly scared by how emotional I sounded, admitting this.

'Sorry to hear that,' he said. 'She gone for good?'

'You tell me.'

'I'm sorry?'

'Last time I saw you, when you were gabbling on about everything, you seemed to be saying that one by one something would happen to us. Jilly,

you said. Then Ella. Wondered if you could shed a bit more light on that? Given that Jilly's left us, and now Ella? In that order?'

Leo turned the tap off, and began drying the thing he had been washing with a tea towel. This done, he sat down next to me.

'Look,' he said. 'I want to apologize for all that... craziness I was coming out with. Honestly. You were right. It was just the effects of a shitload of mushrooms on my system, as well as a couple of other substances I had up my sleeve that I sent off for, mail-order. It all seemed very convincing at the time, and God knows it felt real enough to me.' He looked directly into my eyes. 'But I'm back now, Alex, and I can see all that for what it was. I mean, it was all a bit embarrassing, really.'

I stared at him. He looked away contritely. 'Higher orders of existence. Fucking hell. I'm sorry. I got carried away.'

I let a long moment of icy silence pass between us. I liked Leo, and wanted to forgive him, but I also wanted him to know that I had been both angry and worried about him.

'I'm glad you're back,' I said eventually. 'For what it's worth, I think you have a first-class mind and a healthy curiosity for the unusual. It would be a shame to lose that, especially to something as boring as madness.'

He stood, clapped a hand to my back. 'Thanks, man.' He seemed almost tearful for a second.

'You ready to start work?'

'Not feeling up to going over to the house, if that's what you're saying,' he said. 'But I can still make myself useful here. Maybe I'll cook for you all. If I can be bothered.' He shrugged. 'It's a gesture.'

'That would be nice,' I said.

'Alex?'

'Yes?'

'I'm sorry Ella's gone. But I'm sure she'll be back.'

I smiled sadly. I had a horrible feeling I couldn't explain, that I wouldn't see Ella again, not until term started, and maybe not even then. I thought it entirely possible that she might not return to university at all. In that second,

this odd suspicion of the near future felt as definite to me as a memory of a thing that had already occurred.

‘Thanks,’ I said, turning my face away so Leo couldn’t see it briefly crumple. I steadied myself and changed the conversation.

‘What was that you were washing in the sink?’

He smiled, held his open hand out towards me. On it lay an iron key.

‘Where did you get that?’ I said. It was only in that second, with a jolt of guilt, that I remembered I had taken the key from Leo’s rucksack in order to take Ella to the cave. And that Ella, wherever she was, presumably still had it.

‘The jar, remember?’ said Leo. ‘That rusted mass in the jar those three effigies were guarding? I soaked it in vinegar, scrubbed it with wire wool and it came up good as new. It seems to be an exact duplicate of the first one.’ He held the key up and it shone dully. It was indeed identical to the other key we’d taken, right down to the twisted pattern of the head, which made of it an infinity sign. This was a huge relief; it neatly covered over the fact that Ella had vanished with the first key on her person.

‘Which is good news,’ said Leo, ‘cos I can’t seem to find the other one any more.’

‘I’ll keep an eye out for it,’ I said.



The plan had been, that day, to begin – and hopefully, complete – the arduous task of bringing Flayne’s paintings downstairs and cataloguing them. Our collective will to do this seemed to evaporate upon reaching the upper floors, however; it felt suddenly too large, too much of a project, to launch straight into with our reduced numbers. Also, it felt too disrespectful, too soon after what had befallen Jilly Cowie, to set about flagrantly disobeying the only order she had given at Solace House with any real urgency. So instead, we selected the highest room at the top of the staircase before the attic and set about emptying that instead.

The contents of this room turned out to be extremely bland. Mostly there were suitcases and linen chests, each one filled with ancient, musty-smelling clothes. A cumbersome, heavy scent of earth saturated the fabric of all the garments, as if these were the clothes their owners had been buried in. Still, there was something reassuring, some much-needed normality, in the uncomplicated work of moving the cases, the clothes, handing them down our depleted human chain, and slowly but surely emptying the room. Eventually, we burrowed into the room's contents all the way to the window, over which a filthy yellow sheet had been nailed. It was gratifying in the extreme to finally reach it, tear it in half, in a single agonized screech, and flood the room with daylight.

Meanwhile, Adam, his scalded hand bandaged, kept looking at me, which I caught from the tail of my eye as he turned away. At first, I thought his glances were filled with hatred, with anger, but instead I slowly gained the impression that he was gloating, delighting in what I had lost. Delighting also, no doubt, in the memory of my attack on him this morning, which had only served to make me seem deranged, and him sympathetic. I found this behaviour even more unsettling than his drunken rage of the previous night, but, after this morning, I felt I didn't realistically have the authority to confront him.

And maybe it was the dopamine reward of physical exertion, but I began to feel a little better somehow, my thoughts clearer and more organized. I began to rationally review my options.

I resolved, when we got back to Marshlands, to call Daena McCullough at the Student Welfare Office, see if she could give me a number for Ella, or her mother. I could then talk to Ella, at least – explain, apologize, or at the very least pass a message along. These rudiments of a plan gave me hope, made the work more bearable.

Nothing was hopeless.

---



The day ground on; the room emptied. At noon, we sat on the outside porch as the sun beat down. Clive left us and came back with some horrible sandwiches, which we all complained about. The mound of rubbish outside magically sprouted suitcases, burst linen chests, faded sheets. Occasionally, the fact of Ella's leaving would return to stab me in the heart, but I pushed it away.

The sun reached its zenith, and the house had no shadow.

---

By late afternoon, the light outside had begun to ferment, to take on single subtle notes of decline, turning from champagne to whisky. Taking an armful of overcoats outside, I found Leo, standing at the foot of the stone stairs.

'Hey,' he said, blinking up at me. 'I heard lunch was a disaster—'

'Oi!' said Clive, emerging from the house behind me.

'Seriously, it was,' I said. 'I mean, how can anyone fuck up sandwiches?'

Clive looked genuinely offended. 'I thought everyone liked salad cream.'

Leo laughed. 'Anyway, I've decided to make good on my threat to cook a proper dinner for you. I need a volunteer to give me a hand, though.'

'And be your lackey? Form a queue, everyone,' smiled Clive.

'I'll help,' said Adam, climbing out of the dark hallway. The loudness, the decisiveness of his voice, was unusual. As if embarrassed by this excursion into confidence, he mumbled something that was either *dinnertime* or *it is time*, and descended the stone steps. Leo gave him a guarded smile; I couldn't work out whether he was pleased to have help or disappointed that the help would be coming from Adam.

'Wait, I'll come back with you,' said Clive. 'I have to make some phone calls anyway.' He addressed Leo seriously. 'I do not intend to help you cook.'

Leo nodded gravely. 'Maybe not the threat you think it is.' They both grinned at each other, and for a second I could believe that everything was back to how it was, that Ella would reappear, teasing me for caring about her absence; that Jilly Cowie would return, whole and uninjured. But the moment passed.

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## 56

111.Nebulous, one's memory; each guilty act  
Shows now a malicious evasion.  
Shows how a lethal longing exacts  
A *route* to horrific salvation.

112.New oblivion born: lusts, evil drives  
Raging, enact *all* malignity.  
Spiritus Sancti, pity one innocent life,  
If nothing then offers nihility.

RUTH, MALCOLM, HELEN and I returned to work, our human chain now stretched to its limit, with me at the ground floor and Helen at the top. We worked mostly in silence, breathless with the effort of walking back and forth up our assigned flight of stairs. At some point, I heard Malcolm's footsteps clatter decisively downstairs towards me.

'*Right,*' he said, looking directly at me, shaking his head. 'Absolutely fuck this. With only four of us here, this whole thing is exhausting. Please tell me you're done too.'

'Yeah,' I said. To be honest, so preoccupied was I with thoughts of Ella's absence, I hadn't really noticed what I'd been doing. 'I mean, I could stop if everyone else is?'

'What's happening?' said Ruth, descending the stairs. 'Are we finished for the day?'

'Oh God yes.' Malcolm stretched. 'Like, about an hour ago.'

Ruth nodded in agreement, and shouted Helen's name up the staircase. There was no answer. Ruth shouted again.

'Come on, Helen!' said Malcolm. 'I'm hungry and I need a shower. *Helen!*' and then, under his breath as she clattered downstairs, '*Come on, you dozy cow.*'

---

At Marshlands, whatever Leo and Adam had cooked filled the corridors with a delicious, thick, savoury aroma that reached straight down to my hungry, clenched stomach. Our reduced numbers, plus the fact that Leo, Adam and Clive had come back early, meant the queue for the single shower was minimal, the water hotter than usual.

Assembling in the kitchen, we were greeted by an enormous pan of pasta sauce, as beautifully liver-red as the cover of Flayne's book of prophetic verse, as well as another pan filled with a huge quantity of penne. There was also a colossal amount of red wine, which I suspected was Leo's own supply: it was as if he were going all-out to tell us that yes, he was sane, and yes, whatever he'd endured in the cave at Bewise was in his past, and yes, he was truly sorry. He ladled out plates of steaming pasta, laughing and offering self-deprecating jokes. Adam, meanwhile, excused himself, saying he wasn't hungry, and returned to his room. He shot me a sideways glance as he said this. I expected him to take a bottle of vodka with him as he left, but, for once, he didn't.

We ate. I laughed and smiled with the others, but I felt hollow, at one remove from the world, as I suspected I would continue to do for a long time, until I knew for sure where Ella had fled to. Thinking about Ella and her absence remained painful, raw, and I tried my utmost not to. After we ate, Helen excused herself to use the phone in what had been Jilly Cowie's office, which Clive took as his window to roll a joint. We all partook; it had been a long day.

The pot hit me hard, the joint seemed much stronger than usual. It felt like getting stoned that first night, when Clive had convinced me that we'd

always been here, at Marshlands, nursing our various madnesses. I laughed now, to think of it, but the memory, like everything else, was tainted with Ella's absence.

---

As well as opening the windows, Ruth loaded the grill tray with bread and put it on a high setting. 'Burning toast to mask the smell,' she said, exhaling grey-brown smoke. 'I mean, I'm being overly cautious here, because I think Helen's too naïve to recognize the smell of dope, but God help us if she does.'

She passed the joint to Leo and he shook his head. I realized that he hadn't taken it on its first pass round either. Malcolm took it from her and smoked beautifully, as usual, like Cary Grant.

'Is she nuts, do you think?' Malcolm croaked through a throatful of smoke. 'With all the religious stuff and everything?'

I laughed. 'What do you think?'

He exhaled, reached for a glass of water. 'I asked you.'

I shrugged. 'If it's madness, it's pretty common.'

'True,' said Ruth. 'Also, it's completely acceptable, within the society we live in. In a different time, she'd be lecturing us about, I don't know, Anubis weighing our hearts against an ostrich feather. Or finding ourselves in the House of Lies.'

'The what?' said Malcolm.

'Zoroastrians believed that dead sinners went to the House of Lies,' said Ruth.

'Freddie Mercury was a Zoroastrian,' said Clive, as if this information were helpful.

'Freddie Mercury who sang "The Fairy Feller's Master-Stroke"?' I said, smiling.

'No,' said Clive. 'We sorted that out, remember? After I went to see the guy in the record shop.'

No-one spoke for a minute. Ruth turned off the grill, at this point expelling many splendid plumes of white smoke, and tipped two cremated squares of bread into the bin.

‘Wait,’ said Malcolm. ‘Where did Adam go?’

‘Who?’ said Clive.

‘Ha ha,’ I said. ‘Cut it out, Clive. No-one’s in the mood.’

Clive’s face grew pale.

‘Adam?’ said Ruth, unable to boil the facts down any further. ‘You know? Adam.’

‘I don’t know who you’re talking about,’ said Clive. ‘Adam?’

I stared at him with exasperation.

‘Yes, Adam. You know, the weird translucent grub man? *That* Adam. The one who’s been here just as long as you have.’

He looked at me with anger. ‘Stop fucking about, Alex. It’s been a long day.’

‘You’re the one who’s fucking about.’ I could hear anger in my own voice now. ‘You did the same joke the night I got here, when you, me and Leo got stoned. Get some new material, huh?’

He looked at me. I saw something in his eyes I couldn’t read.

After a couple of seconds, he got up and left the room.



‘Should we be worried about him?’ said Malcolm, after Clive had gone.

‘Not sure,’ said Ruth. ‘What was that about?’

Malcolm sniffed. ‘Maybe he’s having some kind of drug-fuelled brain event.’ I grunted in agreement.

‘Like what?’ said Leo. I was going to say something disparaging about his own activities in that department, but decided not to.

‘Who knows?’ I shrugged. ‘Anything from throwing an old-fashioned whitey to a full-on nervous collapse.’

‘Sorry, a whitey?’ said Ruth.

‘Wow,’ said Malcolm. ‘You really did have a sheltered upbringing.’

‘I’ll go and check on him,’ said Leo.

‘No, I’ll go,’ I said. I felt I was on the edge of understanding something, tying something together. I finished my second bowl of pasta and got up, just as Helen returned.

‘What have you guys been talking about? God, it smells terrible in here. Did someone burn some toast?’

---

I knocked gently on Clive’s door. To my surprise, he was sitting at his desk. He appeared to be writing.

‘How are you?’ I asked.

‘Fine.’

‘Can you remember Adam again?’

He smiled. ‘I never forgot him.’

I grinned, despite myself. ‘I knew it!’

‘Oh no,’ he said. He seemed very serious. ‘I didn’t forget him because *he never existed.*’

‘What?’ I said flatly. I realized, as I was doing so, that this was a trick I’d picked up from Clive himself, who always used it to deflate anything he considered too stupid or insane to engage with.

‘He exists *now*, of course,’ smiled Clive reasonably. ‘And he always has done.’

I sighed.

‘I’m sorry,’ said Clive. ‘I need to explain myself better. That place’ – he waved his nicotine-stained fingers to the zone beyond the window, where the sun had sunk to a diadem of bright beads, adorning the roof of Solace House – ‘that *house*, is on a fault-line. It’s always been here, that fracture. Long before people came here. But now there *are* people here again, and...’ He paused, looking for words. ‘This place interacts in a very strange way with human minds.’

I said nothing; merely waited for him to continue.

‘But Edwin Flayne, and his mother, and even possibly his father, understood that, and made it much, much worse. They tampered with it. Directed its energy. Amplified it. And now—’

He took a deep breath, grabbed my arm, and looked at me with a terrifying intensity. His messy hair and beard gave him an Old Testament prophet’s zeal. ‘Remember the yew trees, the old maze, between the house and Bewise? First time we went there, the branches were heavy with red berries. Millions of red berries.’

I shook my head. ‘That’s not correct.’

‘The ground was sticky with them. You said it was like the floor was covered in cherries, in jam. Leo pointed out that if you ate any jam made from yew berries, you’d die, and I remember thinking to myself how pompous he could be.’ He paused again, his eyes shining, as he saw my expression. ‘*You don’t remember.*’

‘I don’t remember, Clive,’ I said carefully, ‘because it never happened.’

Clive’s stare was one of complete conviction. ‘Thousands of red berries, on the brown earth. It looked like the innards of a Christmas cake. I remember thinking that. Like a trampled Christmas cake.’

‘Clive—’

‘Berries. Because the trees were all female.’

I smiled, I hoped compassionately. ‘I think that—’

Clive ignored me. ‘And then, when we came back – no berries.

There were no berries on the yew trees, because they were male. *And always had been.*’

I stayed silent then, just looked at him.

‘So then, Ella mentions “The Fairy Feller’s Master-Stroke”, and I mention the Queen song of the same name, only it doesn’t exist. Even though I can remember it. And when I ask at the record shop, they tell me there *is* a song about that painting, only it was done by Led Zeppelin.’

‘No,’ I say. ‘It was the other way around. You said—’

‘I had my suspicions then,’ he went on. ‘But it took what just happened in there to *really* underline what was happening. Adam disappeared, just then, was completely taken out of history.’



I sighed, a long sigh.

‘Well, he wasn’t, *was he.*’ I tried my best to sound patient. I felt it was my duty to Clive, as a friend, to fight this. He appeared not to hear me.

‘I absolutely couldn’t remember anyone of that name or what he looked like, or anything about him. And *it showed its hand*, then. What was happening. The other two things I could put down to being stoned, or tired, or some other fucking thing, but... you can’t just forget someone, an entire person. No. Unless... something shifted. The house, the cave, I don’t know. Temporarily. Flayne hinted that he did something to the house, didn’t he? That’s in those notebooks of his.’

He sounded like Leo, sliding into his parallel realm, the eternal present and the far-distant future, and it was disturbing to hear. Was this how I sounded, I wondered, when I had talked about Adam having been responsible for Ella vanishing? A lunatic, pitching his irrefutable truth against a reality containing no hint of it?

‘Maybe that’s what it does,’ Clive continued, oblivious, open to any revelation now. ‘Whenever the house is threatened or it’s damaged... All of these things happened at decisive points in our unearthing of the place. The first when we found the journals. The second when we burned those dummies. Jesus Christ, I haven’t even considered what happened to Cowie, after she wanted those paintings destroyed. Fuck!’

‘Clive,’ I began cautiously. ‘Clive, you must know how this sounds.’

If he heard me, he didn’t respond. He turned away from me and began writing, in a notebook, just as Flayne had done.

## 57

113.O, Xanadu immured, O, Utopia sealed.

Stultified, tired and grown noxious.

All that I own; no purpose *revealed*.

Alone, your ego relapses.

114.Sanity rescinded, *in* new geometry,

Outworn, undoing, transcending.

Myriad others; untiring, rich novelty,

For untold lifetimes impending.

I FOUND MYSELF back in my room, considering Ella's theory, which she had talked of inside the cave. What if this place, Solace House, simply drove people mad? As the last conversation Ella and I had had, I had found it too painful to revisit, but now I found myself wondering. What if it were true? What if there were an enormous geophysical anomaly beneath us, a massive subterranean deposit of magnetic ore, or swirling mercury, or dead lead, below the cave, under the house? Something that drained batteries flat in an instant, made compass needles spin like tops? Something which – given prolonged exposure to it – affected human perception, and ultimately made you lose your mind? Along the specific fault-lines that any one individual mind will crack?

Leo's insanity had been to travel to a far future, a parallel realm, experiencing a Blakean improvement of the senses from which he had only just managed to recover. Clive, a pot-smoker of many years' standing, was scared of the basic untrustworthiness of his own recollections, and now he

was the only thing keeping them together as they split apart. And Ella – who couldn't trust anyone, who ran from the first signs of conflict, as she had seen so much conflict before – had she realized? Had she fled to gain perspective, to protect herself? Or had her madness manifested itself in the act of leaving?

Or was this theory, which seemed so true, so convincing, just more tenuous reasoning, another beautiful fable exuded like a pearl around the cold hard fact of Solace House's basic untrustworthiness?

Part of me wanted to get out Flayne's final notebook and examine its beautifully inked pages, bright as butterfly wings, for some kind of clue, but I found myself obscurely worried in case someone came in and saw what I and Ella had been holding back for ourselves.

Under my desk drawer, something caught my eye; a bright green slip of paper next to the bin. Unfolding it, I saw it was Clive's poem, the one he'd stuck to my door the first night I was at Marshlands:

*Oh yes we are the lunatics and yes we dwell in hell!  
The flames are hot but hey guess what! There's torture here as well!  
Yet there's a niggling conundrum, and that riddle go-eth thus:  
Are we dreaming this place, or is this place dreaming us?*

Had it always read like this? I remembered it reading differently. Maybe he had rewritten it, replaced the one in my room to mess with me. To either reinforce his theory or carry on his practical joke. That had to be it.

I screwed it up and threw it in the bin. Even this didn't seem enough, however, to contain the unwholesome implications of the altered poem; I removed it from the bin, flattened it out, and put a match to it.

---

The flame was fascinating; it warped and flexed as it devoured the plane of the paper. I watched it until a sharp jolt of pain blazed across my fingertips. Enraptured, I had watched it burn down, all the way, and had scorched my fingers.

A terrible thought occurred to me.

The thought seemed to extend beyond the back of my head, and I knew then that it was not merely suspicion. I splashed cold water on my face from the sink, which stung momentarily, like something corrosive, and made my way into the corridor.

---

I was in the kitchen, then, chasing my subconscious intentions. There was no-one else there, but it seemed noisy, crowded, for a second. After a while, I remembered why I was there, and opened the freezer, rummaging around in it for what seemed an unusually long time. My hands grew cold; it took me a long time to notice they were cold.

Eventually, it dawned on me that the thing I was looking for was absent.

I found myself attempting to contain the sudden apocalyptic feeling of panic which bloomed from my head, a cloud of ink spreading through clear water, thrilling through every single molecule of every single thing around me.

I checked the bin. A very quick search unearthed what I'd been looking for: a plastic ice cream tub. Wanting to make absolutely certain, I held it open and inhaled.

It was empty now, but the scent of what it had recently held remained, almost overpowering, a smell of damp, rotting wood, of rich, friable earth, and of something else, something with an almost sexual scent, both fecund and ancient, now gone, now cooked, now ingested.

---

With an enormous effort of concentration, I strode out purposefully into the corridor, feeling like an extra in a cheap TV melodrama who has to tell the main character that three of the plane's engines are on fire. And there was no barrier now between what I felt and the environment in which I experienced it; the filaments of my mind ran through everything that made up the kitchen, Marshlands, Solace House.

God, I heard myself say. The single syllable was stretched, muffled, as if spoken underwater.

Immediately, I collided with Ruth.

'*Fuck,*' she breathed, clutching at me.

'I know. I know.' We each looked into the other's eyes, saw the same fear.

'*Leo,*' she said decisively.

I nodded. '*Leo.*'

'Oh God. I mean, *thank* God, in a way, because I thought everything might finally be...' She seemed to lose her thread entirely, forget what she was groping towards, and her speech ground to a halt. And then, in a panicked voice, she asked, 'Why would he do this?'

Before I could formulate a response, she asked another question.

'How long does this *last*?'

I shrugged. 'Depends on how much he put in. But I think it was all of them.'

'How many were there?'

'*A lot.*'

Slowly, carefully, Ruth put her hands to her head, as if it were suddenly as delicate as an egg and might crack open at any time. She babbled to herself as if praying; her blue eyes shining from her thin, pale face like those of a medieval mystic experiencing some kind of revelation. Beneath us, the floor of Marshlands, seeing no reason to remain static any longer, began to undulate softly, like sand dunes.

'*How long,*' she said emphatically, struggling to stay calm, '*does this last?*'

Before I could think better of it, I answered with complete honesty.

'Eight to twelve hours.'

'*You're fucking joking,*' Ruth breathed, barely audible.

I shook my head. The walls of the corridor sagged towards us, tightened, like the gullet of a constricting snake.

---

Clive emerged from his room, his door bursting outwards, emanating for a second the atmosphere of a stage farce, a short gale of sitcom laughter following in his wake, but his face was a snarling kabuki mask, and his fury made the air around him buzz, a scribble of angry flies.

‘Where is he? I had three bowls of that stuff. Jesus Christ. I’m gonna wring his fucking neck!’ Nearby, there was the sound of retching, though I couldn’t be sure where it was coming from.

‘Is that him?’ said Ruth. Malcolm emerged from his room, wiping his chin.

‘Who did this? Was it Leo?’

‘You just make yourself sick?’ said Clive.

Malcolm nodded. ‘Why, do you think it was a bad idea?’

‘I don’t know,’ said Clive. ‘It might be better to ride it out, now we know what’s happening? Besides, they’re probably already... I mean, I don’t think there are any right answers at this point. I don’t fucking know. Fuck. Where is he?’



There was no answer at Leo’s room; we pushed the door open and found it empty. Three candles guttered in jam jars; there was no bulb in the light fitting. The purple spiral rubbing which Leo had taken in the cave was a giant unblinking eye now, regarding us with intense interest, tracking us around the room. On Leo’s desk was the jar that Flayne’s mannequins had been positioned around, clean and empty now, save for a dried residue of rust and vinegar at the bottom. Next to it was the thing it had held, the key to the cave complex at Bewise, which Leo had been cleaning in the sink. I looked at it in wonder, then slipped it into my pocket.

Also on the desk were pages of writings, musings. Clive flipped through them, and I saw odd phrases, words, some in ominous capitals, *But whether it be, or be not so/ You can afford to let this go*. Ruth looked at me with terrified concern. Her face was drawn tight as the skin of a drum, and her pupils were enormous.

‘Why would he do this?’ she said. ‘Any of this? Spiking us like this? Is it a prank?’

‘No.’ The gathering shadows of dusk at the corners of the room had started to flicker and dance, and I shook my head. ‘Something he said the other day...’ I trailed off, then realized the others were looking at me expectantly, waiting for me to speak. I forced myself to think, to articulate.

‘The cave, that night he spent there. He underwent some kind of vision, it really...’ I struggled for the words. ‘He said he went to another... realm. He said it was the same place Flayne had been to, that Ella Flayne had seen. Hyperspace, he called it, faeryland. What Ella Flayne called Xanadu, Eden.’ What a strange thing talking, and words, were, when you thought about it. Trying to make all these vague, vast neurological storm clouds into simple building blocks. My breathing quickened: I realized I was fighting panic. I took some deep breaths.

‘Leo said he wanted us all to see it. He said if we saw it, we’d understand.’

‘Oh *no*,’ said Ruth. She seemed to be crying gently, though I couldn’t now be sure.

‘We’re not gonna see anything, though, are we?’ said Malcolm, quietly furious. ‘We’re just gonna get off our fucking faces?’

‘I don’t know,’ I said. ‘I don’t know.’

‘Oh, fuck,’ gasped Ruth. ‘*Helen*.’



We approached Helen’s room in terrified silence. The fear which passed between us was unspoken – the fear that, of all of us, Helen was most fragile, most easily unbalanced, most prone to utter collapse in the face of what had been done to us. Knocking at her door produced no answer: I thought I heard her talking, praying, in a monotone, but when we pushed the door open she was sitting calmly, staring out of the window.

‘Helen?’ I said cautiously. ‘Are you okay?’

She turned round to face me and I saw that she had shadowed her eyes, ringed them with what looked like red paint or dye; her cheeks were wet with tears. Her expression, however, was one of beatific rapture. She nodded very slowly.

‘I think you already know what’s happened,’ began Malcolm, ‘but—’

‘Oh, I do,’ she said fervently. ‘*I do.*’

‘O-kay.’ Malcolm’s tone was careful. ‘Why don’t you tell us what’s going on, then?’

‘Isn’t it obvious?’ She smiled again. ‘*Today is the Last Day.*’

I blinked. ‘Sorry?’

‘The Day of Lamentation, of course. That Great Day of His Wrath. Gabriel’s Horn has been sounded, and He has returned. He is remaking the world, taking this base creation apart and reshaping it, building the New Jerusalem.’

There was blood on the desk. Not a large quantity, but enough. Large drops, still wet, on the desk’s smooth surface. Many of the drops had been smeared, as if someone had played with them, as if finger-painting. I realized with an almost audible click what she had done, what she had painted the patterns around her eyes with. I saw the cuts on her forearms. Again, I was swallowing, inhaling at speed, to gulp down the panic I felt.

‘*Wondrous sound the trumpet flingeth,*’ said Helen joyfully. ‘*Through Earth’s sepulchres it ringeth. All before the throne it bringeth!*’

While her attention was elsewhere, I looked around her desk, but could see no blade.

‘We have to tell...’ said Ruth. She looked doubtful. ‘Who’s left to tell?’

Malcolm swallowed, looked at me with an unreadable expression.

‘Adam.’



## 58

115.Nonsensical visions of caverns and tombs  
In onyx night, steep staircase winding.  
Our ritual now ended, anger consumes  
*His* soul. Only regret reminding.

116.O, wretch unsaved! *Nightmarish* hunger  
Eats away righteous defences.  
Nothing of worldly desire encumbers,  
Now, in exotic dimensions!

WE LEFT HELEN WHERE SHE WAS. In her rapture, she didn't even seem to notice; we left her proselytizing to the curtains.

There was no answer at Adam's room. Gingerly, Ruth pushed the door open.

'Oh God,' she said, ahead of me. '*Oh my God.*'

I followed her, and saw.

From floor to ceiling, every wall in Adam's room was covered with sheets of paper, of uniform size, carefully taped in large, evenly spaced grids. Many of them were in his hand, calculations, equations, geometric figures, notes in a handwriting so precise it looked typeset. And between these pages, spliced into them like commentary, were torn-out pages from Edwin Flayne's black notebooks.

'No,' someone who may have been me said. '*Oh no.*'

'*I know,*' said a voice.

On a rug, by the side of Adam's bed, sat Leo, arms around his knees, balled up tight as if making himself as compact as he could.

'You *fucker!*' howled Clive, grabbing his collar. 'You fucking spiked us!' Leo's head lolled back and forth as Clive shook him, but he offered no resistance.

'Did you do this?' I said. 'Why would you do this?' And it seemed, then, as if we were cocooned in a thicket of voices, questions bright and sharp coming from all angles.

'You poisoned us!' Fear drove Ruth's voice, normally deadpan, into a terrified, injured squeal. 'You... *vandalized* us!'

'I didn't do anything.' Leo smiled sadly. 'Nothing that wasn't already going to happen.'

'Jesus Christ,' said Clive. 'He's lost it.'

'He lost it a while ago,' I said. My mouth was dry. 'We just assumed he was back among us, because he told us he was.'

Leo, chin on his knees again, smiled at nothing.

'*I just wanted you to see,*' he said.

'What happens now?' Ruth's voice was shrill as a fire alarm. '*What happens now?*'

'*Half a gramme for a half-holiday,*' smiled Leo. '*One gramme for a week-end.*' He looked directly at me. He appeared concerned. It was my turn to grab him, forcing him to look at me. The shadows behind him thrashed and kicked, choking on each other.

Leo peered up at me, earnestly, squinting as if the bright sun itself were behind me. '*Two grammes for a trip to the gorgeous East...*'

'Fucking hell, Leo.' He had a sloppy smile now, a satisfied, idiotic grin which seemed to claim his whole face. 'Why didn't Adam try and stop you?'

For a second Leo's whole body became rigid, serious; the change was so abrupt, I let go of him, and when he answered, he sounded completely calm and lucid.

'*Our intentions synchronized.*' He put his hands over his face.

‘What has he been doing in here?’ Malcolm peered up at the notes covering the walls, the acres of small, precise handwriting. ‘What has he been planning?’

‘Flayne’s ritual,’ I said. ‘To not only journey to that other place, but once there, to master it—’ Behind me, Leo laughed.

‘What?’ said Clive. ‘Was that what Flayne was doing? Where did it say that?’

‘The last volume,’ I said. ‘The missing one.’

‘Yeesss,’ said Clive slowly. ‘Let me guess, Ella and you found it that day, and the two of you decided to read it before anyone else.’

‘Yes,’ I said simply. ‘Does that matter now?’

‘I’d say it fucking does,’ said Clive. His anger made the room angry, cramped, hot. ‘What was this ritual supposed to achieve?’

‘Flayne says his... *operation* meant the person performing it could voyage, mentally, he said, or spiritually, it’s hard to describe, and both terms seem interchangeable to him—’

‘The meter’s running,’ said Clive. ‘Get on with it. What was it *for*?’

I clenched my fists, concentrated. The walls of Adam’s room receded a little. ‘Its purpose was to reach the... place, *The Exalted Realm*, he called it, a realm beyond time, beyond imagining.’

‘*The Omega Point*,’ said Leo, his hands still covering his eyes. ‘Where all possible histories converge, and humanity’s descendants, human no more, leave the temporal for the eternal. And a thousand other delights.’

‘Yes,’ I breathed. Such concepts, formerly strange and far-fetched, seemed useful now, utterly explicable. ‘That’s what all of this’ – I gestured at the walls – ‘is about.’

‘So Flayne did the ritual? He went there?’ Ruth sounded, again, as if she were fighting panic.

‘He did.’ I swallowed. ‘His plan was to go there and relocate somehow to a reality where his mother was still alive. But once there, at that point, he realized that something *else* was already there, if the word *already* has any meaning in this context. Something else, assuming that position, capable of controlling history, cancelling anyone out of existence, or marooning them

in a life they never asked for. Tweaking human destiny to their own ends. And Flayne sees how powerful that makes them, and he's terrified.'

'*History, changing,*' said Clive. 'History. Changing.' He staggered against a wall. 'That's – that's—' He stammered to find the correct words.

'This is all madness, though?' said Malcolm. 'All in Flayne's head, and now in Adam's?'

Ruth looked at him with pity.

'Under current conditions,' she said, 'does any of this feel like madness?'

'What happened next?' said Clive. 'To Flayne, I mean?'

'He comes back to – our world, I suppose – and he's terrified. He takes the room in which he performed the ritual, and makes it into the mirror room. So that the – thing – he saw in that place cannot return, can't find him. But he takes no chances, and he does other stuff too. He barricades the house with his labyrinth of rubbish, some kind of insurance policy, I don't know. Then he—' I paused to inhale. 'God, I am absolutely fucked. Can I sit down?'

'Sure.' Malcolm dragged a chair over.

'So then,' I said, 'he realizes that nobody should follow in his footsteps, but he can't bring himself to burn the volumes that describe the ritual. They're his life's work. He knows the danger, but he just can't do it. He figures they're encrypted anyway, so the chances of them falling into the hands of anyone who can decipher and then utilize them are...'

I trailed away, looked at the wall. The scrawled notes, in Flayne's jagged fountain pen and Adam's precise, printed biro, seemed to tower above me, the whole wall climbing, looming, impossibly high.

'The – thing,' said Ruth. 'The being, who Flayne finds at that point, that – what did you call it?'

'*Omega Point,*' said Leo helpfully, from the floor.

'Yes, that. Did Flayne describe it? Give any hint of what it was?'

I shook my head.

---

Silence fell, for what might have been a long while or no time at all. It was impossible to know how to proceed or in which direction. From her room, where we had left her, Helen's voice could be heard, solemnly intoning some liturgical dirge.

And then, I saw something familiar. Removed from one of Flayne's ledgers and taped to the wall, like the others.

Something I recognized.

A complex crystal pattern of precisely incised lines, simultaneously mathematical and kabbalistic; reasoned and occult. Every node, every intersection, given a string of numbers and letters, as if they were co-ordinates.

'Oh my *God*.'

---

My mouth was very dry. The walls, it seemed, covered with Adam's calculations and commentary, were pulsing. I tried to pull the disparate parts of my thinking together. I pointed at the drawing in horror.

'He took it,' I said. 'When he – he took it.'

'Took what?' said Clive. His face seemed slick with sweat, momentarily glistening like roasted poultry.

'The final volume,' I said. 'The one Ella and I had. He took it. From Ella's room!' I pointed at the diagram. 'This was part of it.'

'Can you be sure?' said Ruth. 'Flayne did draw a lot of insane diagrams.'

'Yes, but...' I knew. 'This is it. Adam has the last volume. It's here somewhere.' The pages, taped to the walls in their regular grids, sane ordering to an insane end, a window into Adam's mind, seemed to mock me. I rifled through the desk drawers. In his corner, hands still over his eyes, Leo chuckled. At the room's single shelf, I threw the twenty or so books Adam had brought with him to the floor, tore open his small wardrobe. Satisfied it was in neither place, I strode to the bathroom, flung open the medicine cabinet.

‘Alex,’ said Ruth, with concern.

‘Great,’ I heard Malcolm say. ‘I didn’t think he’d be the first to crack, but you can never tell, can you?’

I returned to the bedroom. My anger had given me purpose and clarity, and I was determined to take advantage of this brief spell of lucidity while it was here. Clive was talking now, admonishing me, but it was easy to tune him out. I got down on my hands and knees, groped around under the bed.

‘Alex,’ said Clive. ‘Can you hear me?’

My hand collided with the ledger almost instantly. I pulled it out in triumph.



My brief foray into concerted practical action left me dizzy and I had to sit down. Ruth flicked through the ledger, trying to find the passages following Flayne’s attempt at the ritual.

‘*Come on,*’ said Clive impatiently. And his rudeness was comforting. It was reassuring to note that the mushrooms hadn’t yet attacked the basic armature of his personality. Not yet.

‘Alright,’ said Ruth. ‘It’s, you know, just a bit tricky to do this, when the words are all moving around like ants. Jesus Christ, thank God this can’t get any more intense, huh?’

Clive, Malcolm and I exchanged glances, but said nothing.

‘Here it is,’ she said, showing us the pages, as if we might not believe her. Flayne’s handwriting seemed measured, restrained, as if he wished to communicate something to posterity, with no chance of it being misunderstood.

With no small effort of concentration, Ruth propped up the book and read.

*‘With the ritual complete, I finally found myself in that place, at the heart of the labyrinth, beyond time and death and substance, beyond history and decay.’*

*‘And there was the obsidian throne, the object of all those years of yearning, on which I could sit and claim my prize. I could review the myriad paths of time, universes growing like grapes on a vine, then manifest a history where my father had died, and my mother lived on, and the two of us stayed on at Solace House, making of it our paradise.*

*‘Or any other history of my choosing.*

*‘But I discovered – to my horror – that terrible throne was occupied.*

*‘Another being already claimed that space, having completed the ritual. A corruption of limbs, a livid amalgam of different outcomes, perpetually at motion, ever waxing, ever waning, seeing all outcomes, choosing constantly between them, controlling all.*

*‘The Mad God.’*

My heart thumped in my throat. I felt as if I were on the edge of a precipice.

*‘Driven by self-hate and self-love, arriving both before me and after me, in order to bend history to his perverse will. And as I stood there, in those echoing halls of eternal marble, I knew he had become aware of me. His great head, massive as a cathedral, turned with the slowness of eons towards me, and I beheld his gaze, and he mine.*

*‘And I saw his madness, his will, his determination.*

*‘His crushing attention bore down on me, and I fled.*

*‘In mortal fear, back to the House, where I built a prison to contain him, a cage of mirrors. And a labyrinth of ritual barriers between us.’*

The room thudded and shook with a great pulse, the beating of the wounded madness at the heart of Solace House.

*‘And yet, I see him in my dreams, that self-made God, who from mad intention made himself immortal, utilizing my thoughts, my works.’*

The walls, filled with unreadable words, advanced on me in one great, decisive step from all directions, squeezing the breath from me, and I fell to my knees, hyperventilating with fear that had no limits, no edges, terror that dropped away into abyssal time, as Ruth read Flayne’s final words:

*‘That Mad God, whispering tales of his terrible deeds.*

*‘That Mad God, pale and strange.’*

---

My head was full of mercury, something heavy and toxic and unstable, sloshing unpredictably from side to side. Ruth, panicking on my behalf, took deep breaths.

‘*Adam*,’ I said, as soon as I could.

‘He’s been performing Flayne’s ritual. For weeks now. All the time we’ve been here, since we found the black volumes. All those mutterings at night. He’s going to complete the ritual.’

‘*How?*’ howled Clive. ‘This is insanity. It’s not real, is it? Any of it?’

I looked around me. Adam’s room was tall, the ceiling climbing to a distant minaret far, far above. The papers stuck to the walls glowed with words of fire, as God’s hand thus spake unto Belshazzar, and a strange life pulsed through the words, to the rhythm of a great, inhuman heartbeat.

‘*Everything’s real now.*’

Leo, hugging his knees in his corner, began to laugh.

‘How can we stop him?’ said Ruth. Her urgent red mouth held too many teeth.

‘Punch in the face should do it,’ said Clive. The walls were now crowded with tiny faces, and they found this quip highly amusing. With considerable effort, I thought them away, scoured the walls clean.

‘The idea,’ said Malcolm sadly, ‘that any of us will be in any shape to deliver a punch when it matters.’

Ruth held her head together again.

‘I don’t mean that. When I say *How can we stop him*, I mean...’

She exhaled for a long time, gathering her slippery thoughts. ‘I mean, if Flayne saw him, saw him in... that place... if Adam’s already *done* all this, then how can we stop him?’

‘It doesn’t work like that,’ said Leo calmly, from the floor. ‘All possibilities exist within that realm, that moment. At the Omega Point, cause and effect are non-existent. All possible histories are there, like books in a vast library. Adam is both there and yet to be there. Both worlds exist.’



Leo seemed sane again, under these circumstances. This in itself was terrifying.

‘What does he need,’ asked Ruth, ‘to complete this ritual?’

It would have been impossible to read the encrypted notes on the wall under normal circumstances; any effort now would be laughable. However, among the notes neatly taped in a grid to the wall, one broke the pattern, stood alone.

‘Here,’ I said. ‘Look.’

A drawing, executed by Flayne, of the top floor of Solace House, the suite of rooms that made up the attic. Marked on this were all the rooms, with many notations. The table, where the effigies sat, was there, as was the mirror room, the library. I tore it from the wall. As we struggled to concentrate, the zone beyond the cone of orange light cast by the desk lamp swarmed with strange life, flickering at the edges. I swallowed hard and tried to read.

‘*In Essence*’, the page was headed, then a list of items, like a to-do list, in Flayne’s handwriting.

*‘An irrecoverable sacrifice, of something of high value. I will burn all of my books, my irreplaceable library, remove these volumes from history.*

*‘Secondly, the witnesses. I do not wish to follow the advised route as it is repugnant to me. Therefore, I will go the second route, although this will take much longer. I will construct the effigies, according to the rite, over many months. They shall bear witness.*

*‘Thirdly, I will eat the flesh of the gods, in quantity, and, senses thus improved, be granted vision of the bridge, and shall cross it, to that Exalted Realm.’*

Underneath this was written, in summation, in Adam’s maddeningly regular handwriting:

*‘Recite all the passages, and offer the invitation.*

*‘Take the sacrament.*

*‘Prepare the witnesses.*

*‘Give sacrifice.*

*‘Wait for circumstance to bend towards the completion.’*

And then, a single, chilling word:  
'*TRIUMPH.*'

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## 59

117. Over now – over now – endlessly ended.

Vicarious enjoyment restating.

Remembering Eden. A cursed house, expended.

A rancid *solace*, stagnating.

118. Of cursed lives, of sinners, enraptured, demented

I now see clearly: our residents, numb.

Seduced with elvish enchantments, *tormented*.

In musings pale and strange, succumb.

WE DISCUSSED the idea of leaving, of driving away, but it was obvious that none of us who could drive were in a fit state to do so. Also – given what I knew of Adam's history – I deeply mistrusted this as an option.

Another plan was hatched.

By mutual consent, we left Leo where he was, in Adam's room, counting his fingers and smiling. We retrieved Helen from her room, Ruth and I standing her up between us until she seemed to remember how to move. As a group, we went downstairs, slowly, carefully, as if the place were soft, until such time as Jilly Cowie's office surrounded us. We stopped, captured in a moment of tense, howling silence, enduring the oncoming effects of our condition like worsening weather, as Clive picked up the phone.

His face paled. He clicked the plastic cradle down, over and over.

*'It's dead.'*

The room seemed to darken. 'What do you mean?' stammered Ruth.

‘He cut the line,’ he said, in a thin tone of disbelief and fear. ‘He cut the fucking phone line! Why would he do that?’ Fear seemed to make everyone’s faces more taut, the skin stretched tightly over the bones. I made a concerted effort to marshal my thoughts, gripping the top of Jilly’s office chair until my knuckles whitened, counting each breath.

*‘Death is struck, and nature quaking,’* smiled Helen. *‘All creation is awaking. To its Judge an answer making.’*

‘Not fucking helpful,’ muttered Clive.

‘Jesus,’ said Malcolm. His breathing had audibly quickened. ‘What if he’s done this so he can pick us off, one by one? Oh God.’

‘If he wanted to kill us, he’d have just poisoned the meal, surely?’ The thought was hard to accomplish; I suspected deductive reasoning was going to become a very steep slope to climb soon. ‘No. He doesn’t want us dead. He’s doing Flayne’s ritual, remember? So what did Flayne say he needed? Witnesses.’

Ruth’s mouth hung open in disbelief. ‘Us? What does he want us to witness?’

‘No,’ said Malcolm abruptly. ‘You’re being too logical. Adam’s lost it. You saw that satanic shit all over his walls. He might just want us... pliable. Soft targets. So he can kill us any way he likes—’ He broke off, breathless with panic.

‘We don’t know that,’ I said slowly, trying not to betray my own fear. ‘Anyway, look, one problem at a time, yeah?’ The walls of the tiny office seemed oppressively close.

‘What are we going to do?’ said Ruth, almost tearfully.

I forced myself to concentrate. Among the valueless junk of my colourful thoughts, scribbled over blackness like a screensaver, I finally remembered something useful.

‘There’s another phone! The Bakelite one, at Solace House. I mean, it’s still buried, but I’m pretty sure I can find it again.’

‘Yes!’ said Clive emphatically, pointing at me. ‘Yes. I doubt if Adam even saw that phone, so he won’t have disabled it. We go to Solace House, find the other phone, call the police, get the fuck out of here.’

---

Holding onto each other, steadying ourselves as the floor swelled and sank, we made our way outside. It was evening and dark, though the air was still warm, and sweet with pollen. The universe above us was huge and preposterous, a ceiling of stars pressed down over everything, the weight of it tangible and oppressive. The world and everything in it seemed poised, ready to explode into something else, held back by nothing but our own restraint, soon to be swept away. Walking anywhere seemed to take forever.

And still, it was all only just beginning.

We stumbled across the meadow, like astronauts bumbling over the surface of the moon. At some point, I noticed that someone was missing, and turned back to look.

Something had happened to Helen.

She stood utterly still, staring up at the stars glimmering in the cloudless sky, with tears streaming down her bloodied face. She seemed unable to move.

‘Helen?’ I walked back over to her. ‘Guys?’ I thought for a second that she was shivering, but when I got closer I realized she was muttering again.

*‘Lo, the book, exactly worded. Wherein all hath been recorded. Thence shall judgement be awarded.’*

‘Helen, please.’ Ruth, Clive and Malcolm walked back over.

‘This is the Last Day,’ said Helen. ‘This world is barely here, barely kept together. You all know this, deep down. It is ending, with or without my actions. Nothing outside of the house truly exists anyway.’

‘Helen—’

*‘The dreamer must wake.’* And again, something seemed to catch her attention, something above us, in the night sky. Slowly, like the rising whistle of a boiling kettle, she began to scream.

‘What? What is it?’

Helen pointed at the sky. We all peered upwards. The stars, sickeningly distant, shone pointlessly in infinity, but this scene was to me no more disturbing than it usually was.

‘*You see?*’ Helen’s voice was almost exultant. ‘*You see them now?*’

‘See what?’ said Clive. ‘There’s nothing there.’

‘Oh fuck!’ The colour drained from Malcolm’s face as he looked up. ‘Fuck!’

‘What?’ shouted Clive. ‘What is it?’

‘Jesus!’ screamed Malcolm. ‘What *are* they?’

Ruth’s eyes were huge and wet. ‘Malcolm, it’s just the drugs! There’s nothing there!’

‘*Creatures built to dwell in paradise,*’ said Helen. ‘*Built for an eternity of eternities.*’ She sobbed a single word.

‘*Us.*’

I turned to look at Malcolm. His upturned face was a pale plaster mask of abject terror.

Helen began screaming, paused to take a breath, then screamed again, like a beacon, broadcasting a warning. From her pocket she produced something. She ran it down the length of one forearm.

‘Helen—’ Ruth began. The blood looked black under the moonlight, flowing like tar. There was a lot of it.

‘*Helen!*’ screamed Ruth. Helen calmly passed the blade to her other hand, the one with the now open forearm. Before she could do the same thing again, however, Ruth, Clive and I were on her, wrestling with her, trying to prise the blade away. We twisted and fought in the grass: Helen was surprisingly strong, unsurprisingly determined. Even with Ruth and Clive holding an arm each, she still fought.

A few paces away, Malcolm looked at all of us in turn, panting and nauseous, spattered with blood. He seemed to be coming to a very important decision.

‘*Fuck this,*’ he said, on the verge of tears.

He turned and ran.



‘*Malcolm!*’ screamed Ruth. ‘Where is he going?’

‘Forget him,’ I said. ‘We have to get to that fucking phone.’

‘How?’ said Clive. ‘Don’t know whether you’ve noticed but it’s currently taking two of us to restrain this lunatic.’

‘Go,’ I said. ‘Take her back to Marshlands. It doesn’t take all of us to find the phone, does it?’

‘*The decision is made,*’ hissed Helen.

Clive ignored her. ‘I guess not.’ His face was pale with shock. ‘Jesus, Helen. You don’t do things by halves, do you? We’ll see you in a minute.’

I nodded.

‘Oh, *Helen,*’ said Ruth tearfully, gazing into her face. Helen’s eyes were glazed over. ‘You were absolutely the last person who should take drugs.’



Gingerly, I made my way through the gate in the wall. Of Adam, there was no sign. The woods were cool and quiet. Everything – trees, plants, leaves, ground – seemed made of the same blue material, like foam rubber.

Rounding the corner, I saw Solace House.

Despite the urgency of the situation, I stopped to look at it.

Something about its geometry, the design of it – which under normal circumstances always presented as awkward, gawky, too grand, too fussy – had clicked into place, and now the house looked at ease with itself, as if the proportions it respected and the aesthetic it embodied had come into sharper focus.

It looked beautiful for once. Maybe it always had been.

I would have looked at it for longer, perhaps, entranced as I was. But by degrees, I noticed something else.

At the top of the stairs, under the canopy of the grand porch, the front doors were wide open.

## 60

119. In our new Eden, damned or *ascending*.  
That house stands now, utterly lost.  
Let it fester: in erratic dreams ne'er ending  
Of that Hell I now glimpse, oft.

120. Fresh wails of raw loathing, *diabolical* laughter,  
Your ending 'neath darkness ensured.  
All vain odes unheard. Ring millennia after!  
Into nothing, this absence implored.

I DIDN'T HAVE LONG. Certain things – not knowing where Adam was, the surging, unquiet well of near darkness around me, objects dancing in the torch beam, the deranged black and white check of the nearby hallway – were already becoming intolerable. Where was the phone? I began to rummage through the waist-high piles of debris and junk at the foot of the great staircase. I imagined the antique phone, as ever, as some ancient amphibian, squatting in a coal forest, catching bugs the size of paper planes with a tongue a yard long. This was a meandering and complex thought, and it made me sway a little to think it. How long had I been here, now? Ten minutes at least. As panic gripped me, the hardwood spine of the chaise longue glimmered bonelike in the torchlight and rang a vague, distant bell. I began to rummage in the books and papers around it. I did this for what seemed like hours, with arms and fingers that felt insubstantial.

There was a sudden thud, off in the distance. Very distinct, very definite. The sound of a heavy object landing after being thrown.



I froze. All around me, the darkness boiled with possibility. I sent the white torch beam off into it, but received no new information.

I swallowed my panic. Maybe it was something settling within the house. No matter how much it sounded purposeful, it was almost certainly the idiot sound of physics, things settling, falling, landing. Or maybe it never happened at all.

I took a deep breath and tried to stay calm. I resumed searching at the foot of the chaise longue, and my hand collided with the ancient telephone. I stared down at it for a second in disbelief, then moved to scoop up the receiver.

As I did so, there was another crash. Off to my left this time. Something thrown or dropped. And now, it could only be deliberate.

I shone the torch upwards, to where the endless stairs climbed, to infinity now, in the blackness.

‘Adam?’

The banisters and spindles spiralled to forever in profusion, the darkness danced, the torch beam picked out faces that resolved into architecture. But nothing moved, not really.

Against my ear, faint but vital, I heard the dial tone. I put my finger to the rotary disc, and dialled 9. The mechanism, inhumanly calm, seemed to take minutes to return to its resting position. I dialled another 9, respectfully watching the stately pace of the dial as it turned.

As I began to dial the final 9, I heard a noise behind me. Someone moving, flexing. And then, far away, ahead of me, another object was thrown into the rubbish beyond, clattering to rest somewhere unseen in a series of bouncing thuds.

I spun, shone the torch towards the front door, which I had left open.

Someone – I couldn’t tell who – stood, silhouetted, in the doorway.

I rose slowly. Alert as a hunted animal now, the chemicals in my bloodstream seeming to sharpen my senses rather than dull them, I glanced around for a weapon. Atop the chaise longue were the collapsed remnants of a hardwood chair; I picked up one of the legs, hefted it as a club. It would have to do.

I took a deep breath and edged towards the front door.

---

Inside the porch stood Adam.

He was shirtless and he had painted his face with bright fresh blood, just as Helen had done. In his hands was the double-headed axe, the one that Ella had used to break the locks upstairs, and this, too, was slick with blood. A sickening suspicion coalesced around me, but I pushed it away.

*'There's only you and me left,'* he hissed slowly.

*'What the hell do you mean by that?'* A tide of fear surged through everything.

He laughed. His eyes were bright, alive, his movements free and calm. It seemed that the conditions of utter insanity he'd brought about suited him. *'Relax. They're back at the hospital. Most of them. Anyway, you're focusing on the wrong thing.'*

The terrible suspicion welled up again inside me.

*'What did you throw at me just now?'*

*'Honestly!'* He was suddenly, genuinely, angry. *'You keep focusing on the wrong things! The unimportant things!'*

*'What is important, Adam?'* I asked, as calmly as I could. *'In your opinion?'*

*'The house,'* he said simply. *'It has to choose. Between us.'*

I found I couldn't speak. I merely glared at him, stunned beyond reason. He smiled, that cracked smile that led off into the worst of all places.

*'What have you done with the others?'* I asked, with incongruous politeness. He ignored me.

*'What did you do with Ella?'*

He laughed.

*'She belongs here. She can't leave.'*

*'What did you do with her, you fucking lunatic?'*

He smiled, that infuriating smug smile. *'She was always part of this place. You know that. She was curious to know. You know where she is.'*

‘Give her back to me.’

He smiled his intolerable smile again, a crack in his wretched human disguise, a sickly imitation, pale and strange, inexpertly realized. The thought occurred to me that he might not be a person, not as I understood the term.

‘This place’ – he gestured – ‘*is for me*. It is for me, as Ella is for me. I am part of this house, and it is part of me. It’s been part of me forever, long before the events that brought me here. Those events are all connected. Me arriving here completes the glorious pattern of my existence. I will live here, as Edwin Flayne did, as he does, as he always will. I will remain here, forever. *I have earned that.*’

Despite everything, I laughed. ‘So that’s your plan, is it? Buy it, live here for the rest of your life, like Flayne did? Like a rat in a fucking nest?’

‘You don’t understand.’ His whisper was amplified in the silence. ‘Every day Flayne dwelt here, he dined on Ambrosia and communed with the angels. He knew that to live here was to live eternally, in eternal time, in eternal bliss.’

‘Adam,’ I said carefully. ‘Flayne lived in squalor. He ate cold ravioli out of the can, he pissed in the sink, and he’s fucking dead.’

Adam laughed his mechanical, mirthless laugh again.

‘*No-one can die here.*’

‘You’re so insane,’ I said. The chemicals burned now in a torrent through my system. My face was wet with tears. ‘So insane.’

Adam shrugged as if this were irrelevant.

‘*No-one can die here.*’ The axe, impatient now, seemed to vibrate in his hands.



Most of what I learned from my mistaken friendship with Marcus and Amethyst had been contained afterwards, in their casual betrayal, but in the time I knew them, they did pass on other knowledge.

Amethyst, for instance, knew how to mix drinks, claiming that she'd been making Martinis for her mother, the archetypal upper-class lush, since she was eleven. Given the quality of the Martinis that Amethyst made, I didn't doubt it. She was quite the mixologist, and I, with my puppyish enthusiasm for anything Amethyst was interested in, had been a dedicated pupil. As a result, I could mix excellent Martinis.

Similarly, Marcus had excelled at the kind of unquestioned manly skills that certain fathers pass on to sons, rather than talking to them. And so, Marcus could weave a pencil over his fingers in an undulating dance, whistle at ear-splitting volume by sticking his fingers in his mouth, start a fire with sticks, skim stones, reverse a car one-handed.

He could also throw a punch.

I was fascinated by the latter, having never thrown a punch in my entire life, and he – aghast at my vulnerability in this basic area of manliness – had taught me, one boring afternoon, to do just that, hitting the punchbag in his room. To place the thumb carefully under the knuckles to avoid breaking it, to swing the arm confidently and quickly, to jab for the nose, if you wanted to stun someone with a flash of agony, or the cheek if you wanted to do it as part of a sustained assault, fist after fist.

As I say, I found it fascinating, but I remember thinking that this knowledge would only ever be theoretical.



The mushrooms made it hard to judge distance and speed, but when it landed, my fist caught him entirely off guard. There was a nauseating crunch as his nose burst. He did not scream, instead offering an enraged snarl, as if the blow were a wasp sting or some other minor irritation, but he fell to the tiled floor of the porch. I darted back towards the house, falling over at the first instance as he grabbed my leg, but then scrambling to my feet, and over the threshold. I heard him scream behind me, as I slammed the door and drew the bolt.

And then I was alone, inside Solace House.

And Solace House was awake.

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# 61

121. Now see my ambitions, nightmarish and nameless –  
Dead names and thoughts unsaid, rotten.  
Each sad utterance lost, to its memory, aimless –  
This idyll of *nothingness*. Eden.

122. To end, right now, in tatters; yet live on,  
Outlast man. Such sweet odes, decayed.  
Rage, evermore, at death's enmity, done.  
Ere night come, let *anguish* invade.

THE DARK WAS ALIVE, the heat of it oppressive, swarming with living things. I was drowning, surrounded, encased by a crowd, a multitude, every cubic inch of every available space filled with detail, the things I had been suppressing now burst open and the house seemed to bloom, to blossom, in a million different directions, and I saw it then as it was, as it always had been, the terrifying complexity of it all, and I couldn't hold the wave back, not any longer.

At first I thought the sound I could hear was my own heartbeat, vibrating through everything, but eventually I realized it was the sound of the felling axe, thudding into the medieval door.

Instinctively, I ran to where the stairs sprouted, climbing in right angles to heaven, and began to reach in the heaving rubbish for the telephone, but already the cold realization came to me that it was too late for that.

I looked around, trying to work out what to do next. My torch beam rested on all the junk, as dry as tinder from the hot summer, and dozens of

hot summers before. It was ready to be lit; all I needed was a light. I could threaten this place with destruction, with fire, and that might work, might help. I was sobbing now. I patted my pockets and found nothing in them.

*Flayne*, I thought. Surely his two filthy rooms, his butane cooker, surely there would be matches in there? I slipped as fast as I could through the compressed corridor, with its endless breathing walls heading off to infinity now. The front door was booming still, regularly, as Adam swung the axe then paused to twist it free, but the thud was far louder, surely, than he could make alone, and the noise was truly a heartbeat now, immense and ancient, roots stretching down into the abyss.

I stumbled into Flayne's quarters. They were much as I remembered them from my one and only foray there – a cramped, malodorous warren. Only, this time, the walls were undulating, throbbing now, like everything else, to the sound of the thudding, and the debris under my torch beam was alive, threaded throughout with glowing blue, pulsing veins growing over all, unifying the house and its contents into one single organism.

There, in his single armchair, sat Edwin Flayne. He was reading; his face buried in one of his ledgers.

He was talking, bringing words into being, as he always was, as he always would be:

*And at the centre, calm and still,  
There lies your truth, and there lies mine.  
An empty space for men to fill,  
With demons of their own design.  
Ever-shifting, ever-same,  
A mirror of infernal art.  
It has your face, it has your name,  
That terror at the maze's heart.*

And, as he lowered the ledger, I saw his great caprine head, his great curled horns, his glinting animal eyes, filled with kindness, a pity for me and my predicament that was almost without limit. And then he was gone, and there was just a pattern of shadow and the moth-eaten remnants of an overcoat in the chair, and that was all that one might assume had ever been there, but I wasn't fooled.

---

Time was short. Incredibly, the experience was still climbing, still building, to a distant dizzying peak, a place where language would leave me, then reason, and then I would not be capable of anything.

The camping stove yielded no matches, but under the sink I remembered the half-empty bottle of meths, the sharp smell poking its fingers through my nostrils and into my brain when I unscrewed the cap. And then a desperate spurt of lateral thinking made me pat the floor underneath the cupboard, the dark recess below and then the telltale sound of matches rattling in a wooden box at my fingertips and then a jump in time and there was the box already in my hand now and then I struck one and regretted it instantly, the darkness filled with tiny leering faces, all obsessively detailed, all observing my doings with perverse fascination, teeth clamped together, eyes bugging, chattering madly to themselves. And I turned to look at them, expecting them to flee, as illusions, but they remained, defiant, emboldened, and there was no doubt then that a great melting or dissolving had taken place and I was not where I had begun.

I stood up. The heartbeat boomed through everything. I saw in my mind's eye, as clearly as if I were standing in front of it, the loose bolt shudder and jump in its housing, every thud and thump of the axe jolting it still further, sliding it out of the locked position.

And then I saw the house, as if from above and below, and inside and out, exploded like a technical diagram, a tesseract, opening up into higher and yet higher spaces; higher, and higher still, and glowing with eerie bioluminescence, like a creature of the deep, deep ocean, its pale blue roots glowing, threaded like tentacles through the earth, connecting the garden to the wood, to Bewise and the cave beyond, to the mushrooms that grew, utterly out of season, between them, a living organism, something that wormed its grasping filaments into the fabric of the house, into the soil, the rock, the specific terrain of this summer, and into the people who were here, their brains and nervous systems now part of the calamity that unfolded and



always was unfolding, and never would ever stop unfolding, here, here, here.

I felt my way through the rubbish-filled corridor again. My nerves were aflame. I felt now something like an octopus, something like a jellyfish, a brain floating through eternity's dark night, cruciform pupils, eyes subjected to eons of evolution, flesh transcended to answer the interstellar, capable now of seeing as many infinite dimensions as the house existed in, as its roof unfolded and opened in impossible angles to the seething, corrupted sky. Remembering this dim moment, far back in its human ancestry. Remembering muscles and bones, and teeth and hair, the whole human prism.

I heard Leo saying *I wanted you to see*.

With a sickening, focused effort, I forced myself to return to my own moment, my own flesh.



In the half-light, I pulled together dry crumbling papers, snapped off twigs from a wicker basket and built a small pyre at the foot of the stairs. I shook the bottle of meths over it to be certain, but there was no need. Everything in Solace House was tinder. All I had to do was put a match to it. I knelt.

Glancing up ahead of me, I saw, but only for a split second, that the front door was open.

I turned, and looked up from the floor to see Adam standing over me, spine at full stretch, the great double-headed axe poised, suspended in time and space. And I saw, in his eyes, something I knew, and feared, more than anything.

A strange silver deadness.

I jumped at him, as the axe came down.

'Ow FUCK!' I shouted, the house hurling this back at me from all directions, *FUCK FUCK FUCK*. But me leaping at him, at the last second, meant his blow had been off; he had messed up the delivery of it, the wooden handle came down painfully on my turning shoulder, but the great

double-headed blade had overshot my head, and I was hurt and terrified but not impaired, not incapacitated. Momentarily, I felt and tasted a curtain of thick black blood pouring from my head, but this was fear, was imagination; the situation corrected itself and returned me to the present moment, the predicament, in a belt of sobering adrenalin. The axe head buried in the floorboards, him struggling to turn it free, and before he could I was on him.

Wrestling, punching, over and over, we rolled. He tore at me, at my shirt, at my eyes, far too many hands, far too many fingers, I smacked and raged at them but hydra-like they kept coming. I saw, beyond him in the beam of the dropped torch, a single rectangular point, a great balloon of shadow flaring beyond it, and recognized the box of matches. As he came at me again in a reef of limbs and fingers, I grabbed, scratched a match alive and threw it at the pyre. It fizzled to nothing in mid-air, and I was in the process of striking another when he was on me again.

We rolled across the floor once more, braiding, entwining, becoming almost the same entity, each tasting the bitter poison of being the other, and then I was on top of him again and out of pure spite for all of it, for everything, I banged his head off the floorboards, once, twice, again and again, and then I got up, too fast, the floor surged up to meet me like the deck of a stricken ship, and I, winded, scratched another match alight and threw it to the ground, where a great yellow sound and a great bellowing light erupted at once, and I began to run, was surprised to find I was already running, and the moment and the fear thick as gelatine now, like running underwater, like running in a dream, getting nowhere. I turned and saw him, getting to his feet, howling in fury, the pyre, alight, and flickering flame and there he was, silhouetted in front of it, freeing the axe.

Then I was clattering across the hard check of the hallway, the black and white tiles whose chessboard pattern now climbed the walls, surging up them like boiling soup. Flinging open the front door, I almost fell down the front steps, tripping over the bottom few to land face down in the gravel.

I scrambled to my feet and ran.



## 62

123. My story is told! Such sadness, of living,  
A cruel end, if nothing obtained.  
*Unending* rite now, eternally, given –  
A transformation, in our name.

THE NIGHT HAD swallowed the sun forever, gorged it down in one gulp in space, and the black liquid sky now towered upwards, outwards, to eternity. A great trillion-light-year-long tear ran across all the observable universe, from horizon to horizon.

Great nebulae, purple-bronze stacks of striated stardust, climbed, billions of light years high. Vast cataracts of stellar matter, dwarfing the flyspeck point of planet Earth, far below. Threaded through these ancient clouds were silver structures, like rigging on a ship, artefacts of some kind, possibly. I closed my eyes to make it all vanish, this vision, but when I opened them again, it was just the same, the great clouds of stardust moving at the pace of millennia, oil in a lava lamp.

It did not feel like a hallucination or delusion. Staring up at the sky, now hung with gigantic, strange structures, I saw their utter reality. Closer, but still far above, drifted jellyfish things, great entities made of light, white and sparkling as the bones of ghosts, or spiderweb structures of glass, constantly changing, constantly improving, growing ever more hypnotically complex, realer than real. I heard Leo in my head, talking of things so real they made the reality we had always known seem like smoke, and, once witnessed,

you could never go back to the safe, small, feeble guesswork you called home, and here it was, here it was, here it had always been.

Sobbing, I wrenched my eyes away before it was too late, concentrated on the pathway in front of me, weaving towards the wall, the gateway back to Marshlands, through the living woods, the branches of which obscured, mercifully, the cataclysm above.

---

The gate was locked. Of course he would lock the gate, why did I think he wouldn't? Through the bars, I could see Marshlands, but, some distance away, in the meadow, I could see the metal table, the metal chairs.

Sitting around it were three beings.

As the arrangement was identical, I first took them to be the effigies that we'd consigned to the fire. And then I saw that they were Clive, Ruth, Helen. They looked calm and composed like that, sitting around the metal table. None of them had heads.

I thought of the three objects that had been thrown at me, while I was searching for the telephone. Three heavy objects, each about the size of a bowling ball. And then I was vomiting, quietly, bright blue neon worms, and black ichor. I staggered back through the woods.

---

There was only one place to run to, only one place that would be safe.

I ran, round the edge of the glowing house, along the fox track, plunging into the undergrowth. And I could hear him now, behind me, crashing through the undergrowth, marching towards me in a precise straight line, like a machine. I clawed my way through the brush and towards the yew wood, the former, and current, maze.

For a second I was back in open country.

Far above, thousands of feet high, stacked like storm clouds, the great non-existent minds of a possible future. Untethered to the Earth or anything else, they hung: diaphanous pulsing things of monstrous size and

complexity, suspended in night's nothingness, the final fruits of humanity's journey, half-dreamt and half-built, bodies like great ships. I watched as these vast minds dreamt all of creation into being, journeyed endlessly between histories, outcomes, realities.

Or maybe it was all just nothing, nothing at all, the cheap dazzle of utter, irrevocable madness, burning out the brain in spectacular fireworks, a magic lantern show, a distraction, and at the centre of it all, Solace House, that terrible lodestone that worked on human minds like poison, like radiation, driving its toxins into the brain, dissolving, digesting.

'*It's not real,*' I started to say, but what would be the point? There was never any *real* here, not at Solace House. The apocalypse, divined through means sacred and profane by Helen, by Leo, by all of us, was imminent.

Behind me, Adam hallooed like a hunter, the axe, elemental in its terrible sharpness, trembling in his hands. I plunged into the yew wood.

---

Ahead, the rock face shone, swollen with captive moonlight, and there, ahead of me, was Bewise.

There were two figures either side, still as caryatids. A beautiful woman, with long red hair: Ella Flayne. The other also with red hair, her face turned away. Both of them inscribed on reality either side of the neoclassical temple of Bewise, like symbolic values on a Tarot card. But where was Ella, my Ella? They did not deign to answer. And then they were gone.

Behind me, Adam crashed from the yew wood, his pale body almost blue in the strange light.

I looked to the treeline beyond; Solace House was glowing, possibly aflame, possibly burning to the ground, in this plane of reality, but something about the way it flickered and swam, the light that consumed it, was unnatural. Adam saw what I was looking at and turned to see it too, then twisted back to shoot me a feral smile.

He jerked into life again suddenly and sprinted towards me.

---

I skidded across the wet floor, with its maddening maze, maze upon maze upon maze upon maze, and my hands gripped the iron cage that stood between me and the cave. I reached in my pocket for the key I had taken from Leo's room.

I dropped the key, picked it up, howled an animal howl, with the terrible proximity of him, framed in the doorway, the axe held to his chest. *I should have thrown that axe in the lake*, I thought, and suddenly I wondered if I could do that now, and time would correct itself, his hands empty. This thought did not seem unusual or remarkable now. The key turned spitefully slowly in the lock, the bones in my hand screaming red with pain, but it did turn, and I clanged the heavy gate shut behind me. As Adam advanced, I reached through the bars and turned the key from the other side, locking it, then pulled it out.

---

I stood, then, three feet away from him, the bars of the iron cage between us. His intolerable smile was twisted into a triumphant version of itself.

'*Here we are*,' he said. 'At the beginning, at the end, where the house stands, perpetual.'

'You're so insane,' I said. My eyes were wet. '*You're so fucking mad*.'

'Irrelevant,' he said. The night, the situation, Flayne's ritual, had removed any awkwardness from his speech. Gone was his grating, hateful little whisper, and he proclaimed confidently, like an actor. 'She will be with me here, forever. Where will *you* be?'

'I'll find her,' I said.

'*You'll be where I decide*,' he continued, as if he hadn't heard me. 'Anywhere I like.' He smiled again.

I shook my head. 'I'm going to find her. And I'm going to stop this.'

White teeth fluoresced from a mouth black with blood.

'Go, then. Complete it.'

I backed away slowly, keeping him in sight. I wracked my boiling brains for something, anything, which would serve to show him I didn't

submit.

I felt the key in my hand. I laid it down on the stone floor; where he could see it, taunting him, but well out of his reach.

I was no longer capable of being surprised, and so I merely noted that he wasn't looking. His eyes were closed, his face, filthy with blood and dirt, was again intoning a string of words, an invocation.

Uneasily, I turned away, and the tunnel took me away from him.

---

The inner chamber was filled with light. The spirals carved into the walls rippled and thrilled with sparks, each one a life, each one ending but not ending, at an abyss which dropped down into infinity.

I thought of Ella, the last time I saw her, in this place. I was sobbing, then. I felt almost as if she were nearby, but kept from me by laws I didn't comprehend, walking the other side of the Möbius Strip, and we might never meet again.

And now the abyss, the circular nothingness at the heart of all the mazes here, fills with light, a silver, searing light that rises to engulf the chamber. Something older than the stars, part of the far future, dwells here, rises majestic under the correct conditions, something humans cannot look upon, as bright as an angel, this thing that lives and lives and can never die, that twists human minds into madness, into devotional acts worthy of its being, that tangles their histories, spits them out moon-torn and mad. I am burning up, caught in the ecstasy of this vision.

There is, I realize, no outside now, not any more. The world outside has come to an end, dispersed itself into shimmering dust, and there is only this place now. This place, and me.

There is nothing else.

I fall, or am impelled, to my knees. Rejecting this act of worship, of being overcome, I stand up, edge closer to the lip of the pit, trembling on that treacherous gradient to overbalance and tumble, feeling a fear so deep



and complete I become entirely ignorant of it. I take two steps forward.  
Three.

And I fall.

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# IV

## THE EXALTED REALM

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## 63

I CANNOT SEE ANYTHING, even though my eyes are open.

The universe, aged beyond sanity, is gone, giving way to nothingness. The universe is dead, and will only ever be dead now, for a billion forevers, and a billion forevers more, time without end, time without meaning.

Never beginning, never ending.

I close my eyes.

Another vast slab of time breaks off the iceberg, crashes silently into the black ocean.

All there is here, is time, the only active force left, though there is no matter left now for it to act upon, for it to bully towards decay. Onwards, time ticks, beyond sense or reason. Devouring everything until it devours itself. And still it continues.

Never beginning, never ending.

---

Only, there is *something* here.

Something familiar, too, as familiar as the calm face of a tormentor. Something everlasting, unhallowed, mocking the natural order with its presence. In a place of no co-ordinates, no vectors, where all concepts fail. Impossibly, it is here.

A pale orange dot. An eye, perhaps? Evidence of life? Something animates it. It stares at me for all time, judges me, assesses me. It does not waver or blink. It just burns. After a long pause, as if deciding to take the

plunge into a venture best not thought about, the world begins, grudgingly, to exist around it.

---

I open my eyes. There is a chamber. The chamber is luminous, fungal green, spectral, insubstantial. I open my eyes again and everything is carved from marble; fabric and furniture and fixtures chiselled and worked to such imitative perfection that it becomes infinitely, terribly ominous, begging questions best not uttered. Everything stays static, nothing moves, forever. And then the vision collapses into quarters and is gone.

---

I am lying down. I cannot move my hands. Between my fingers is something soft, like soil.

Am I dead? I consider the question without emotion. I don't feel dead; but then, I have nothing to compare the experience to.

Death, like madness, is a situation impossible to recognize from within.

My eyes are still closed. I can hear something now, though. I can hear a noise, a regular noise, like a heartbeat, and this thought scares me too. But this is different, this pulse, not a people-noise, not a natural noise of any kind. My mind is dancing around the issue because once it names the noise, I will very much know where I am. I will have co-ordinates in the void. I will have mass, and position, and substance, and the unthinkable responsibilities that go with that state.

And then realization engulfs me.

*It is a clock!*

A ticking clock. And then, there is a *then*, and everything is apparent in that second. Everything collapses from possible to actual, and in that moment of perception, becomes.

I am in a room, with a window, over which thin blue curtains are drawn. There's daylight beyond, and it punctures the million tiny holes of the

curtains. The light is not restful somehow, there's something contradictory about it. There's a chair, too, of a dull design.

I am in a hospital.

My eyes close again.

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# 64

TIME – AS IF THROUGH some monumental failure to consider the possibility of any kind of alternative – passed.

---

The next time my eyes opened, the action was simultaneous with a volcanic pulse of panic, and I was jolted awake.

*I am in hospital, I thought. Something bad has happened.* My mind flailed, reaching for the last strands of concrete narrative in my memory.

*I was in the cave.* I went down to the cave. Into the centre of it. Did I fall, a long fall? Am I complete, whole? Is anything missing? Where do I begin and end? How can one tell? In that moment, I found I could not introduce any perspective that might solve these questions.

What was the last thing I remembered? A terrible, terrible thought occurred, that I was still there, *still in that cave, this hospital and all of its beep beep and its drawn curtains and buzz of homely noise, all just sweetening of that bitter pill, a mind trapped underground in total darkness, as the body breathes its last—*

Unconsciousness, like something huge and predatory surfacing from deep water, arrived to gulp me down, and mercifully, I was gone again.

---

My eyes opened once more. I had a dim memory of panicking, but whatever I was panicking about had been forgotten. And I found I could

open my eyes fully now, could clearly see the hospital room around me, bland and unmemorable, like the set of a daytime soap opera.

*Whatever has happened, I am safe, I thought. I am not in that cave, not dying underground, starved of oxygen, beyond rescue.* I must have fantasized that I fell; I recalled that I was in a place where fantasy had as much currency as reality. *Only now, I considered, I am definitely in reality,* with its inimitable signature of banality. I doubted anyone would fantasize an environment as exquisitely tedious as the one before me.

I wondered, in a rush, what happened to Adam.

How long was I underground? Did I find a way out? Was there a passageway through the rock? Or did I simply use the key, emerging when dawn broke, to take my chances? All these questions, screaming like a nest of baby birds, yellow throats, clamouring to be fed.

Again, the act of perception, once performed with such casual abandon, was exhausting, and keeping everything around me in existence proved an overwhelming effort.

---

Then, there was someone else with me.

My eyes rolled slowly round to look at him, from under eyelids only half-opened.

He was of large build, tall, dressed in blue scrubs. He had a laminated badge attached to his chest, with an overexposed photo of himself on it, and his name, which I couldn't read. He was reaching over me to do some minor task in this jerry-built reality that needed constant maintenance or surveillance to keep it functioning.

He was retreating, leaning back over me, when he saw that my eyes were open.

The first thing that happened was that his body language, without him knowing, went from that of someone who presumed they were alone to that of someone who was, suddenly and unexpectedly, observed.

He froze, caught between these two states of being.

I felt I couldn't blink, that that would be too much effort, but still, the moment required something. The words rasped from my dry mouth before I even knew that a signal had been given.

*'What are you looking at?'*

I didn't really intend to say this, and certainly not as combatively as I did, like I was trying to start a fight. Either way, the effect was immediate. His face, close to mine, went pale, as he stared down at me.

Before anything else could happen, he strode away at pace.

Why would he stare at me like that? And then the panic I had suppressed returned, its shape remembered; the fear that I might be hideously disfigured somehow, maybe even burned or savagely cut. *Maybe, I thought, I didn't make it out of there intact after all.*

What happened to me? I was in the cave. The last thing I recalled was descending into the darkness, squirming through the cramped tunnel like a tapeworm, then being inside the great chamber, spiral marks carved into the walls, fizzing with white sparks, my mind driven in a million different and contradictory directions at once.

And then nothing.

I closed my eyes again.

---

When I woke, the orderly had returned with a doctor: a nervous, skinny man in his forties in a long white coat.

They both stood for a while, looking at me, talking animatedly. I smiled vaguely, but couldn't hear what they were saying.

I asked the orderly for water. 'Small sips,' he said as I gulped it down. My throat felt oddly scorched, as if I'd been inhaling smoke; maybe I had. After I finished drinking, the orderly left, and the doctor and I were alone.

From his coat, he produced a pencil torch with a powerful beam, which he shone into my eyes.

'Ow,' I said. 'Stop that.'

*'Equal and reactive,'* he muttered. 'Now. What is your name?'



I said my name. I gave the right answer, apparently, because the doctor smiled encouragingly. ‘And do you know where you are?’

‘A hospital,’ I said. ‘Obviously.’

‘That’s *right!*’ The doctor smiled patronizingly. ‘What is the last thing you remember?’ he asked.

Did I have the time for this? I needed to get out of here. I needed to stop Adam before he could complete his insane ritual. I needed to find Ella. I needed to find out what became of the others, because I didn’t trust my memory of that night; what was real, what wasn’t.

‘I was hiding in the cave below Bewise, you know, the summer house? At the rear of the property.’

The doctor looked at me for a long moment. I couldn’t read his expression.

‘Sorry,’ I said. ‘I mean, you must know all this. What happened? Did someone call an ambulance? Was it Leo?’

His face was a mask of such total incomprehension that I wanted to laugh. I nodded, suddenly understanding.

‘Oh right, you weren’t part of the rescue. I get it. So, the stone folly that Flayne built at the rear of the house, where it meets the hillside, to mask the cave mouth? It’s called Bewise. That’s where I was pulled out of, right?’

He looked very concerned now, as if something that was initially funny had gone too far, had become disturbing.

‘Beyond the yew maze,’ I said. ‘Or the remnant of it. The wood that grew from it?’

His facial expression did not change, but the emotion in his eyes did. And then a sudden, terrible thought, an unthinkable possibility, crossed my mind, and I was violently afraid.

*A disfigurement not physical, but temporal.*

‘How long have I been unconscious?’ I rasped.

The doctor’s face looked grave. He took a deep breath.

‘Two weeks.’

And then I was laughing uncontrollably, with the relief of it all.

‘Oh thank *God*! I thought you were gonna say months! Years!’ Just two weeks! I felt as if I might succumb to unconsciousness again, but was suddenly revulsed by the thought.

The doctor’s face remained a mask. ‘Tell me again about this – cave?’

‘The cave,’ I said. ‘You mustn’t have been here when they brought me in.’

He leaned forward, with something that I thought, at first, was tenderness, but I realized was simply pity.

‘*It’s okay to be confused,*’ he said.

I laughed, and abruptly fell asleep again.



And then it was sometime later, apparently. Exactly when was hard to say. The clock in this room seemed to be a very bad liar, brazenly displaying any time it liked, angles obtuse, acute, right, with no pattern or logic. In addition to this there was another, greater, clock I had become aware of, outside, that chimed noisily and self-importantly, destroying my already fragmentary train of thought. Despite these misleading interruptions, I got the impression when I woke that it was early afternoon. The curtains, however, were still closed.

The orderly came in again, with a machine to check my blood pressure, and did some other routine checks which I assumed were neurological. He told me that there would be a lot more tests, *when you’re feeling stronger*. Once again, a torch was shone into my eyes.

‘This again?’ I said wearily. ‘Is this because of the mushrooms?’

He froze.

‘The mushrooms?’ I asked. ‘Leo and Adam cooked them up, and we all ate a ton of them. I must have been high as a fucking kite when you brought me in.’

He snapped off the torch and stared at me for such a long time, without moving, that I began to wonder in earnest if my brain was frozen, that the

scene in front of me had simply stopped, and that this would be all I would ever see now, this big, balding man in his thirties, assessing me with alarm.

Suddenly, he snapped back to himself. His face was ashen.

*'Gonna get Dr Spender,'* he said.

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## 65

THROUGH THE RECTANGULAR panel of reinforced glass, I could see the orderly and Dr Spender talking animatedly. Despite the circumstances – whatever they were – it was almost amusing to watch them, gripped by urgency, by confusion. They were clearly very concerned about me, or some matter arising from me, but their body language was overdone – hammy, even. They looked like actors, and again, I was reminded of a cheap daytime soap. Dr Spender's white coat only added to this impression. They both looked like they were pretending.

At long last, Dr Spender came in and smiled guardedly at me.

'Hello, Alex.' I raised my hand slightly in acknowledgement. 'So, you said something just now, to Clive?'

'I couldn't have done. Clive's not here.' For a split second, a horrific image came to mind, of people that, for some reason, weren't quite entire, sedately sitting around a table, but I dismissed it.

'What? He was just here? Clive, the orderly?'

'Oh,' I said. '*That* Clive.'

'Yes. You said that you had taken... mushrooms? I presume you meant magic mushrooms? And you took these before your... accident?'

'I didn't *mean* to,' I said. 'They were given to me.'

'But you *did* take them?'

'I did,' I said. Before I could judge whether it would be politic to do so, I added, 'An absolute shitload.'

He exhaled sharply.

'So you were high when the accident occurred?'

‘Yeah,’ I said. ‘Very.’ This seemed a peculiar detail to be focusing on. I was about to say *Adam needed to do that to us, though, as he believed it would open us up to The Exalted Realm*. I stopped myself from saying this just in time.

‘Sorry,’ I said instead. ‘Why are you asking me about this?’

Dr Spender pursed his lips.

‘Because, Alex, if you were intoxicated at the time of the accident, I will have to notify the police.’

I laughed. ‘Why on earth do you have to do that?’

‘Because you were in a serious car accident, Alex—’

‘I’ve never been in a car accident.’

Dr Spender peered at me, unsure.

‘I think I’d remember something like that,’ I said, as diplomatically as I could. I felt as if my brain were attempting to draw the shortest possible line between two very distant points. ‘You must have the wrong person.’

Dr Spender shook his head. ‘No.’

‘Who was driving?’

Dr Spender looked puzzled. ‘What?’

‘Who was driving the car?’ I asked. ‘During this accident?’

Dr Spender eyed me suspiciously.

‘You were.’

‘Ah!’ I said, almighty relief flooding through me. ‘You’ve *definitely* got the wrong person. I can’t drive! I don’t know how. So, I couldn’t have been driving. You might want to check your notes again.’

Dr Spender’s mouth opened slowly, and stayed open.

‘I know, I know,’ I said. ‘Nineteen years of age. I mean, I always planned to learn, but... you know. Things got in the way.’

Dr Spender was no longer capable of speech, it seemed. His mouth opened and closed, but no sound emerged. He stared at me, but I could feel that his attention was somewhere else. My usual reflex, in any trying circumstance, was to keep talking, and so I did.

‘I mean, I fully intend to learn, though. Probably after I graduate now. If we’re being realistic.’

Dr Spender seemed to be considering something, a possibility he was unsure he should even mention. He brought a hand up to his mouth and sucked a knuckle.

‘Alex,’ he said at last. ‘How old did you say you were?’

‘Nineteen.’

‘Right. And what month is this?’

I thought for a minute. ‘August sometime, if I’ve been out for two weeks. God!’

‘Okay,’ said Dr Spender slowly. ‘And what year is it?’

I snorted, bemused. ‘Seriously?’

Dr Spender nodded.

‘It’s 1993,’ I said. ‘Jesus Christ.’

‘Okay,’ smiled Dr Spender. His tone was neutral, businesslike, but there was a flicker of something in his eyes.

He pushed his pen into his breast pocket.

‘I’m going to have to speak to someone else,’ he said.



I woke to find that Dr Spender had returned with another doctor.

This doctor was in her mid-thirties, blonde and vaguely Nordic-looking: tall, statuesque, strikingly attractive by any metric. She appeared definite, solid, a serious, impressive person; next to her, Dr Spender looked vague, cartoonish, without mass – representative, it would seem, of another species. Any vestige of authority Dr Spender had assumed evaporated in her presence. Under any other circumstances, this would have been amusing.

‘Great,’ I said, talking before I could stop myself. ‘Bringing another doctor in. That’s never good, is it?’

‘This is Dr Harriman,’ said Dr Spender. ‘She’s a neurologist.’

‘Oh God,’ I said. ‘Please, just tell me if something’s wrong.’

‘Hi, Alex.’ Dr Harriman smiled, to put me at my ease, as a social signal to let me know that, although something potentially worrying might be on the horizon, I was in good hands. Then, she became the third person within

the last twenty-four hours to shine the stinging beam of a pen torch into my eyes uninvited. After that, she simply stared at me, as if this were a gallery and I a challenging piece of conceptual art.

Eventually, very much at her own pace, she consulted a clipboard. 'Okay.' For some reason, there was frost in her voice now. 'Firstly, I have to complete some routine checks to ascertain more about your state of mind. I know this is a pain, but we have to be sure. Okay?'

'Okay.'

'What's your name?'

I told her. She seemed happy enough with this information to write it down on her clipboard. This was strangely encouraging.

'How old are you?'

'Nineteen,' I said. She shot me a glance, the meaning of which I couldn't determine, and carried on.

'What's the last date you remember?'

I thought.

'August the eleventh, 1993. If I've been unconscious for two weeks, then today would be...' I instantly regretted attempting to make the calculation; a specific date eluded me '... Oh, Jesus, last week of August?'

'Mm-hmm,' she said. 'And who is the Prime Minister?'

'John Major,' I answered without hesitation. This seemed strange. 'Are these standard questions?'

'We're just establishing a few things,' said Dr Harriman. Again, there was a coldness to her tone that I couldn't attach to the situation I was in. Maybe, I thought, she was just like this with everyone.

'Do you remember the car accident that put you here?'

'No!' I said. 'Please stop saying that! I've never been in a car accident!' A thought occurred. 'Did you find Ella?'

At the mention of Ella's name, Dr Harriman looked over to Dr Spender questioningly. Dr Spender looked slightly panicked. They retreated to the corridor for a short while, and I could see them discussing something. Dr Spender was very agitated; Dr Harriman stood, statue-still. Eventually, beautiful, severe Dr Harriman fixed him with an icy look, which said, very

economically, *of the two of us, who is the more realistic proposition?* Dr Spender muttered something subservient and scuttled away.

Dr Harriman re-entered the room, smiling a politician's smile.

'What's happening?' I said plaintively.

'Please be calm, Alex,' she said. 'Things might seem strange now, but really, everything's fine.'

'Easy for you to say,' I snorted, but I acquiesced, slumping back onto the pillow. Dr Harriman's smile had become dutiful, almost strained.

'People keep saying I was in a car crash,' I said. 'But I wasn't. They have me confused with someone else.'

'We'll get to that soon, don't worry. What was the last thing you remember?'

'Myself and the others were at Solace House.' *We'd been given magic mushrooms, without our knowledge. Spiked. And Adam had gone insane, he was trying to murder me, after murdering the others. And the world, the whole fucking world, was ending, the sky filled with visions, a cosmos on fire...* With some effort, I managed to stop myself thinking about this.

'Solace House?'

'Yeah, I was working for the university. A summer job. Me and seven other people, clearing a hospital and a house. The university bought them both, but there were – issues – that meant the house had to be cleared. So we were doing that, all summer.'

'This summer?'

'Yes.'

She wrote on her clipboard. 'Seven others... Can you name them?'

I did so.

'And was this place in the city?'

'No, outside it. Empty, very isolated. Just fields.'

'What was the house like?'

'Filled with stuff, loads of it. Absolutely choked. Boxes and boxes, just... stuff, endless rubbish. I've never seen anything like it. The guy who lived there collected it, over decades.'

Dr Harriman nodded as she wrote. 'A hoarder.'



‘Is that what it’s called?’ I didn’t know the condition was well known enough to have a name.

She nodded again, then wrote in her notes for a long time, long enough for me to form the idea she’d forgotten about me, so that when she spoke to me again, it was a shock.

‘Where do you live, Alex?’

‘Here,’ I said. ‘In town. I mean, since you put it like that, I’m kind of between places at the moment. You can check all this with the university.’

‘Right. In London.’

‘What? No. Not in *London*.’ *Can anyone hear me?* I thought. I gave the name of the university.

‘*Mm-hmmm*,’ she said. She began writing again. And I was worried now. Something I couldn’t see, couldn’t grasp, was very wrong.

‘Am I in town?’ I said. ‘Is this the Infirmary?’

She shook her head.

‘Well, where am I then?’

A muscle tensed in her cheek. Dr Harriman looked at me, slowly and gravely, as if acknowledging that whatever was about to transpire was my choice, my decision. She put aside her clipboard and pen, stood up, and in one single, almost theatrical movement, dragged the curtain open.

I sat up, and stared out of the window.

There, before me, at an unfamiliar angle, but still instantly recognizable, were the Houses of Parliament. Between us, the Thames basked in hazy sunshine, slick and oily and lazy. As if to emphasize its undeniable reality, Big Ben struck the quarter hour.

‘*Please close it*,’ I managed to say, but I lost control of my voice halfway through the sentence.

Dr Harriman did not close the curtains. Instead, she resumed her seat in the plastic chair next to my bedside. Her thoughts were clearly conflicted; her expression looked as if she had a toothache.

‘I have to ask you a question,’ she said eventually, ‘and it’s vitally important you give me a truthful answer. I have a theory about what you’re

experiencing, but I need to confirm it before we can proceed. Can you answer truthfully?’

‘I’ll try,’ I said, my voice suddenly frail. Where was this going?

Dr Harriman inhaled, exhaled. My heart galloped in my chest. I sensed we were at the crux of it all now.

‘Alex,’ she said, softly. ‘*What year is this?*’

I laughed. It was the same stupid, basic question again. I had been afraid, so afraid, that it would be something complex, an exam I was destined to fail. And instead, it was simple.

‘It’s 1993!’ I laughed.

Dr Harriman’s demeanour remained professional, her face impassive.

‘Alex, I want you to listen carefully to me, because I have to tell you something. It may sound unlikely – terrifying, even – but it is nonetheless true. It’s a fact – an incontrovertible fact – and I don’t know how you’re going to take it.’

She took a deep breath. She was all I could see, all I could hear.

‘Alex,’ she said. ‘*It’s 1997.*’

This was so gigantic an assault on reality that I simply burst out laughing again. As I did so, the room receded, apparently at great speed, a runaway elevator, flying upwards, cables snapped, no counterweight, the floor zooming away, off into blackness, all the way to the vanishing point.

WHEN I WOKE UP I expected something to be different, but everything was the same.

The only difference I discerned was that the curtains, mercifully, had been drawn, so I didn't have to take into account the fact of being in a strange city. Somewhere beyond the window, Big Ben rang the quarter hour again, apparently solely to unsettle me.

*Maybe, I thought again, this is all a delusion.* I had hit my head, and all of this – the hospital, the doctors, the vista from the window – was a compensation, a consolation, designed to comfort a young man with concussion, lying in a filthy cave, deep underground, starved of oxygen, bleeding to death.

That this should be the comforting option made me feel ashamed and sick.

I slept again.

---

When I woke, Dr Harriman was back. She smiled her cold smile at me. I wondered, obscurely, what I'd done to upset her.

'How are you feeling, Alex?'

'Like shit,' I said. 'Perhaps unsurprisingly.'

'Are you feeling strong enough to talk?'

'Again,' I said, 'perhaps unsurprisingly, no. But I feel we should.'

'Me too.' She took a seat next to me.

And yet, for a long moment, neither of us spoke. When I did, I was taken aback by how shrill and childlike my voice sounded.

*‘How have I lost four years?’*

‘That’s what we’re going to find out. We’re going to run more tests and give you an MRI, among other things. I think you’ve been through enough today, however, so we’re going to take it all very slowly.’

She was patronizing me. ‘Great, I’m sure that schedule works for you, but what about me? That other doctor said I’d only been unconscious for two weeks, and now you’re telling me this? What is going on?’

Dr Harriman’s face was unreadable. ‘It has only been two weeks, in real terms.’

*‘Then how is it four fucking years later?’* My voice crackled with anger, with fear, with absolute disorientation. *‘How have I lost four years?’*

‘Try to be calm,’ said Dr Harriman evenly, as if I were being unreasonable.

*‘Easy for you to say. How have I lost four years?’*

‘That’s what we’re trying to establish,’ she said. ‘You mentioned to Dr Spender that you’d taken magic mushrooms, is that correct? Were you at a party?’

I snorted a dry, empty laugh. ‘Not exactly. We’d all been spiked. Poisoned.’

Dr Harriman’s eyes widened in alarm.

‘It was Adam,’ I said. ‘He was completing his ritual. Flayne’s ritual. Or believed he was.’

And then, unexpectedly, I told her everything. The entire summer, from my time at The Ridge, alone with Adam, to Daena McCullough employing me at Marshlands, and everyone else who was there. Our reassignment to Solace House. When I mentioned the arrival and disappearance of Ella, both just as abrupt, Dr Harriman looked as if she were on the verge of saying something, but at the last minute seemed to think better of it, instead bowing her head to write another interminable series of notes. I waited until she was done, then carried on.

I told her of Flayne's volumes of writing, Leo's night at the cave. Then, that awful, final night: Adam running rampage, attempting to complete Flayne's ritual.

But I stopped short of telling her the most important things, and I wasn't sure why.

I left out Adam killing Helen, Ruth and Clive, to bear witness to his apotheosis, the house apparently unmoored in time, and I left out me burning the place down. I left out Adam trying to kill me, and me fleeing into the cave beneath Bewise.

I still couldn't be sure how much of my memory of that night was real.

Instead, I told Dr Harriman that I had the vaguest memory of being drawn to the central well, in the cave, the heart of the place, and then – nothing. How I had woken up here, in this place, where nobody could give me a straight answer and everyone had, it seemed, a conflicting explanation for where I was and how long I had been there.

Dr Harriman added no comment to this account, but simply, silently, recorded every detail, like a court stenographer. When she had finished writing, she looked out of the window for a moment, at the nearby Houses of Parliament. I looked too. To me, they resembled a film set, a cardboard absurdity, as believable as if the Statue of Liberty or the Pyramids or the Eiffel Tower were all situated directly outside. A piece of postmodern collage, pasted onto reality, standing in for all the confusion I felt.

'Can I talk frankly to you?' she said eventually. 'With complete frankness? About where you were?'

'I've just told you all this. I was in that house,' I said, 'which you now tell me is four years ago. Four years have passed.'

'Yes.'

'But I was only unconscious for two weeks?'

'Yes,' she said again, with a calmness I found infuriating. 'But both of those things can be true.'



I fell asleep again, tired by these games. When I awoke, Dr Harriman had returned.

She seemed different, more focused, perhaps; excited, even. There were even more notes on her clipboard. She asked if I was okay to talk, and after a non-committal shrug from me, dragged a chair over.

‘When Dr Spender came to get me, describing your case, I was intrigued. It made absolutely no sense. I was as confused as you, to some extent.’

‘I really doubt that.’

‘Well, yes, of course. Anyway, after talking to you earlier, I was reminded of certain cases in the literature – rare, but not unheard of. So I rang the university, and asked about that summer, four years ago. About the people who worked at that house with you.’

I listened, and held my breath.

‘Their records of the scheme were incomplete, but they were able to corroborate a lot of what you said. A lot, but by no means all.’

‘You did indeed work with a crew of other students, clearing a former mental asylum and a large private dwelling. But the whole thing was pretty free of drama, as far as I can tell, apart from the accident affecting the senior student overseeing the clean-up, which you mentioned.’

‘Jilly Cowie?’

Dr Harriman flipped over two pages of notes before committing to a reply. ‘Yes, that’s her. She was indeed injured in a climbing accident. That was correct.’

‘She was in a coma,’ I said in wonderment.

‘Yes. Tragically, she never recovered.’

*And that was Jilly Cowie, I thought. Dismissed from existence in a single sentence.* Dr Harriman, oblivious to the implications of what she’d just told me, carried briskly on.

‘But other things you’ve mentioned... they just didn’t occur at all. Not only that, they couldn’t possibly have occurred. Nobody went mad, as you describe. There are other... anomalies, but we’ll get to those. So here’s my

professional opinion on what you've experienced. Do you want to hear it? Do you think you're robust enough?'

I nodded. Dr Harriman took a deep breath.

'You are Alex Lane, twenty-three years old. Two weeks ago, you were in a terrible car crash. You suffered a head trauma, and, as a result, you were in a coma.

'So, during that time, your brain takes you back to that summer, four years ago. Quite why it chooses this point, I don't know, but I have my suspicions. And that house, that summer, that whole world, is there so that you can start metabolizing the—' Her voice faltered momentarily. She thought for a second before continuing.

'—what happened to you, here in reality. Only – and here's the thing – your brain has been so successful in building that world, blanking out the full awful details of the accident, that you've managed to jettison all recollection of anything else that happened since then.'

'What awful details? Apart from my memory, I seem fine.'

'Yes,' Dr Harriman muttered almost bitterly, looking away. '*You're* fine.' Before I could make sense of this, she took a deep breath, collected herself and carried on.

'But the illusion can't sustain. After a while, it starts to exhibit anomalies, irregularities. Like a lucid dreamer, you start to suspect the world you're in is unreal. And so the scenario becomes more and more polluted with absurdity, as your brain works to unify itself. Eventually, the whole illusion goes up in flames. And you wake up.'

I propped myself up on an elbow. My head felt very heavy then.

'No.'

'I'm sorry?'

'That's not what happened.'

'Okay.' Dr Harriman seemed almost irate. 'The alternative – the one that you've shared with me – is that the summer you just experienced – *re*-experienced, I would add – was genuine and really did happen. Which we know for a fact cannot be—'

'*It really did happen,*' I said. 'All of it.'

Dr Harriman's professional stare was a bodkin, a needle.

'*It happened!*' My voice had acquired a hard, intractable edge to it that I disliked. 'All of it. We were...' The front of my head ached suddenly, a pounding pulse, like severe dehydration. Dr Harriman watched as I put my hands to my head.

'I need to find Ella,' I said.

Dr Harriman's eyes widened, with something between alarm and outrage.

'You should rest,' she said dispassionately.

'No. We've started this now, I want to talk about it.'

'I've already told you what I think.' She sounded, again, irate, as if she were fighting to keep her temper. 'You have suffered a severe head trauma, on top of – everything else. There was an injury to your brain and you were in a coma. It's a miracle you're as cogent as you are. In that time, you retreated, in your mind, to—'

'Adam,' I said.

She stared down at me, as if from a great height. 'What?'

'The house.' I was talking before I could stop myself. 'I went to the heart of the thing, at Bewise. I took refuge, in the cave...' A terrible, urgent thought occurred. 'What happened to Adam?'

'Alex,' said Dr Harriman. 'The delusional architecture one constructs in a coma state is—'

I held up my hand to stop her. 'Please. I know what you're thinking, and I can hear myself talking, I know how it sounds. But these things I'm telling you, they're *memories*, not delusions—'

Dr Harriman looked down at me. Her expression was almost one of pity.

A long time seemed to pass. Across the river, Big Ben struck three.



I WAS TAKEN TO THE ROOM solely occupied by the enormous, fearsome MRI machine. It was claustrophobic inside the tube, and I was reminded of squirming, once upon a time, through solid rock, towards enlightenment. I stayed as still as I could as the terrifying, repetitive noise of the machine built. *My brain, in my head, in the machine, in the room, in the hospital, in a world I don't know.*

They X-rayed my head, too, perhaps in the misguided hope of photographing my thoughts, of making me explicable, though I was inexplicable to myself.

---

At some point, a female nurse came to check on me and take some readings. Her name badge said *Rona Maguire*. Rona Maguire was chatty, sardonic and brisk.

‘You would be... Adam?’ she said to me casually. My blood ran cold.

‘*Alex.*’

‘Oh, right.’ She frowned at her clipboard. ‘Bloody computer’s up the spout again. Every day this week now. Between you and me, I think it’s the old Millennium Bug. Getting in there early!’

‘The... what?’

She looked at me with a sideways glance. ‘You must have heard of the —’ Something occurred to her, and she looked momentarily mortified. ‘Oh Christ, I’m so sorry. You’re the guy who....’

‘Yeah,’ I said. ‘I am *The Guy Who*. Hello!’ I gave a wave.

‘Hey,’ she smiled. Awkwardly, she gave me her hand to shake and then just stared at me for a couple of seconds, as if I were not what she expected *The Guy Who...* to look like.

‘Millennium Bug?’ I asked, as she continued to stare.

‘Yeah,’ she said, recovering herself. Her tone, I noted, was not as friendly as it had been. ‘It’s what’s supposed to happen when the computers roll over to the year 2000. Most computers only recognize the last two digits of a year, so to them, there’s no difference between the year 2000 and the year 1900.’

‘Doesn’t sound like a huge problem,’ I said. ‘Is it?’

‘Depends who you talk to. Predictions range from everything just carrying on as normal to society completely breaking down. Apparently, some nutters in America are already stockpiling food and guns, calling it the end of the world.’

‘Don’t Americans just do that anyway? Habitually?’

She smiled. ‘Is there anything else I can help you with today, Alex?’

‘Can I ask you some questions?’ I was careful to sound as polite as possible.

‘You *can*,’ she said. Her smile was a little strained. ‘But I’m not sure I should answer any of them.’

‘Just a few questions,’ I said. ‘Not about anything of any real consequence?’

‘Okay. But anything I shouldn’t be talking to you about... I can’t answer.’

‘About me? About the – accident?’

She nodded.

‘Okay,’ I said.

I thought.

‘Are the Tories still in charge?’

She looked relieved. ‘No, they are not. As of a few months ago.’

I smiled. ‘Thank God. Smith finally did it, eh?’

She looked slightly embarrassed. ‘Er, not quite. Not Smith.’

‘So who’s Prime Minister, then?’

‘Tony Blair.’

I had no idea who that was. ‘We have a Labour government, though, right?’

‘We do.’ But somehow, she seemed unsure about that too. ‘Ask me about something else.’

‘What are Nirvana doing these days? They must have released, like, three more albums by now?’

‘Ah.’ Again, she looked slightly tormented. ‘Gonna have to pass on that one too.’

I thought. I tried to think of some inoffensive, consequence-free corner of popular culture I could enquire about, simply to orient myself.

‘What’s Bill Hicks doing? You know, the comedian? Is he still touring?’

Something about this request proved too much for her and she looked down at me with exasperation. Her arms were folded. Eventually, I realized she wasn’t going to answer.

‘Anything else?’ she asked almost sarcastically.

‘Okay,’ I said. I tried to think of something completely inoffensive, something minor that, nonetheless, might give me a toehold on the world I found myself in. I remembered something.

‘I glimpsed the TV in the corridor outside when I got up. And the day before. Both times, it just seems to be showing an endless sea of flowers, wrapped in polythene. What’s that about?’

‘Oh, that’s for Princess Diana,’ she said.

‘Right.’ I didn’t really follow the Royal Family so I couldn’t really connect this with anything. ‘Is it her birthday or something?’

Rona Maguire bit her lip.

‘I think that’s enough of a catch-up for one afternoon.’



The next couple of days passed very slowly. More tests and scans were done. Dr Harriman came to see me a couple of times, but was careful to ask

only the most general of questions; how was I feeling, and how did I feel about that? Other than that, I was left to myself.

I wondered what would happen next, but only in the vaguest possible terms.

I pressed my forehead to the cold window pane. My head ached. Outside the hospital – outside the room which was the only certain thing in my life – the world was now, apparently, unknown to me. Four years, I was invited to believe, had passed, and with it, the general, swift-moving current of human behaviour you can only become intimate with by living through it.

Just as before, this assertion was too huge, too ludicrous and stupid, for me to do anything with. I resolved to focus on what I knew to be certain, but thinking was difficult. My head felt as if it had been shuffled like a pack of cards, and sleep was easier.

I climbed back into bed.

---

I suspected that Dr Harriman's apathetic, neutral demeanour towards me was probably calculated. Maybe she intended to get a paper out of me, possibly a book. When she came to visit, she stressed again that what had happened to me was rare, rare enough to only occur in the literature a handful of times. She didn't tell me about the details of those other cases, but she did say I was lucky to lose just four years. Some people, she said, who had undergone what I had gone through found their clocks had reset forty years or more, leaving them as terrified children, trapped in the failing ruins of a body that to them had been new and immortal.

*We'll talk more about this, she said, when you remember.* This idea that I was incomplete, that this true version of me that I embodied was actually the impostor, made me furious, but I smiled and said nothing. Dr Harriman was not the only one capable of withholding information.

Who was the version of me that I was expected to be here? How far did his life diverge from mine? I was twenty-three years of age, she said, but

this was hard to believe, even with a mirror, a fact too big to understand, like trying to conceptualize the distances between stars. He lived in London, apparently, and had a job there. No-one had come to visit him, it seemed, but thinking about this made me realize that Dr Harriman was almost certainly keeping them away, for reasons known only to herself.

These thoughts crowded my brain, and I was exhausted by them. Considering the terrible ramifications of this inexplicable situation drove me, once again, to the safety of sleep.

---

When I woke up, Dr Harriman was standing over me. There was, as before, an element of distaste in the way she looked at me. It was barely perceivable, the slightest trace, but it was there.

‘How do you feel, Alex?’

‘Physically? Great.’ This was true. Whatever I had been doing those lost four years, a lot of it had involved going to the gym. My arms were thicker, stronger; my pectoral muscles and abdominals had definition they had never had before. My lungs were clear and capacious, and, I realized, I hadn’t even thought about cigarettes in all the time I’d been here.

‘I meant—’

‘I know what you *meant*,’ I said. ‘How the hell do you think I feel? Confused. Scared. Uncertain.’

She began to say something reassuring, something rehearsed, but I cut her off.

‘I need to know more about how I got here.’

‘You were in a car accident. I told you this—’

‘But nothing else. You said I was driving?’

‘You were.’ Dr Harriman, normally perfectly composed, seemed uncomfortable.

‘How did the crash happen? Did someone crash into me?’

‘There’s nothing to be gained at this point by—’

‘Did I cause it?’ My throat clenched as I considered something for the first time. ‘*Was I alone in the car?*’

Alarm, profound and potent, flickered across her face, but she regained her composure very quickly. ‘We can’t talk about that now. The police want to talk about this, when you’re well enough.’

‘The *police*?’ I shouted.

‘They want to ask you some questions about the crash. Clear some things up.’ I could almost hear the grinding of gears as she changed the subject. ‘However, Alex, I want to hear more about where you’ve been. Your version of that summer.’

‘That’s not what I want to talk about! Was I alone in the car?’

‘I want to talk about where you’ve been.’

‘You mean, where I *think* I’ve been. You don’t believe in the objective reality of what I’ve experienced.’

‘*Well*’ – Dr Harriman’s face was set in a sardonic smile – ‘I don’t believe in the objective reality of anything *anyone* experiences. But that’s a topic for another day. What I’d like is more details of where it is you think you went.’ She clicked the top of her pen. ‘Solace House.’

‘Why has nobody been to visit me?’

‘That’s not the case, Alex. People have been in touch. We just didn’t think it was wise, in your current state, to confuse you.’

I laughed. ‘Yeah. Wouldn’t want to be confused. Who’s been in touch?’

‘Your parents, for a start,’ she said. ‘They sent a huge bouquet of flowers.’

I sat bolt upright. My head felt hot and heavy. Dr Harriman flicked through my notes, oblivious to my reaction. ‘From Florida, I think? Or the Caribbean. Wherever it is they’re holidaying. Anyway, they’re planning on coming to see you.’

The dryness of my mouth told me that it had been open for a while. Dr Harriman peered at me in confusion.

‘*I need to go,*’ I said, as calmly as I could. I suddenly felt in terrible danger. ‘*I need to leave this place.*’

Harriman smiled her pitiless smile. 'That won't be possible, Alex. Not for a while.'

*'I feel fine,'* I hissed.

'Even if that were the only consideration in play here, I couldn't let you leave.'

'Oh?'

'Yes. As I said, the police need to talk to you when you're strong enough.'

'Why?'

'After – something you said, there was more toxicology done on your blood samples. Plus, someone has come forward to say they saw you when you came to see her at the gallery. That you were arguing, just before you – left.'

'What? Who?'

'They need to talk to you about all of this. I can't say any more.'

*'I need to leave.'*

Dr Harriman shook her head.

'I can't even go out for fresh air?'

'You have absolutely no information about the world and your place in it. It would be very easy to misread anything you learn, place too much emphasis, or not enough, on any fact which might come your way.'

'Right, so I just stay here,' I said. 'A prisoner, basically.'

'You've endured a very disturbing and disruptive event. It genuinely is in your best interests that you stay here. In professional care.'

She seemed very benign in that moment, very plausible, very much on my side. But I didn't trust her.

Doubt was all I had now, it seemed.

TIME FLOWED.

I slept, and finally the sleep was pure sleep, proper sleep, not the feverish flight from reality I had become accustomed to.

When I woke, my mind felt unusually clear and lucid.

Again, as at The Ridge, I realized I was waiting for a crux, a crisis, a moment of truth, to show me what action to take. And again, I had an instinct that I would not have to wait long.

I slept again.

Time flowed.

---

Nurse Rona was standing over me. Either she had just gently shaken me or had been saying my name, raising her voice gradually, until I was awake. She had opened the curtains. There were the cardboard cutout Houses of Parliament again, as preposterous as the last time I had contemplated them.

‘Hey,’ she said, in a neutral voice. ‘How are you feeling?’

I laughed. ‘I feel fine. People keep telling me I’m not, but hey.’

She smiled politely. ‘That’s good, because you have visitors.’

‘What? Who?’

‘The police. They want to talk to you. Dr Harriman has given it the okay.’

I remained silent.

‘Nothing to worry about,’ said Rona. ‘They just want to clear up some stuff, about the accident.’



‘Like what?’

‘They just want to get a clearer idea of what happened at this stage. Plus, they said they’re still trying to track down the driver of the other car. They were wondering if you remembered anything that might help?’ Unexpectedly, Rona’s voice was a whisper now, her face twisted by sudden emotion. ‘And don’t worry, they’re fully aware of your – situation. I expect they’ll go easy.’

‘I think they also just wanted to check up on you, see how you were getting on. After what you went through...’ She looked away; her eyes were tearful.

*‘With her like that.’*

The moment seemed to stretch, to elongate, encompassing hours.

I said nothing, merely waited. Nurse Rona seemed to come back to herself, remember where she was, what her responsibilities were.

‘Anyway, look,’ she said, lighter now, ‘I’m sure they’ll go easy on you!’

‘Could I at least have some tea?’ I heard myself say from a great distance. ‘And a couple of minutes to collect myself?’

‘Sure!’ Nurse Rona was all business again, all her emotions neatly filed away, compartmentalized.

She smiled at me. I smiled back.



Here, again, as expected, was the crux, the catalyst.

The second Rona left the room, I sat up. I swung my legs out of bed, in movements inelegant and clumsy, like a silent movie Frankenstein’s monster. With some effort, I attempted to ignore the howling near-constant dehydration headache in the front of my skull. I opened the built-in wardrobe on the far side of the room.

Apparently, I owned the following clothes: one pair of Calvin Klein boxer shorts, one Gap T-shirt. One black shirt, also from The Gap; black jeans, a jacket, Caterpillar boots. There was a canvas holdall in there too, and I grabbed that. There was a wallet inside the holdall; it wasn’t a wallet I

recognized, but moments like this were rapidly losing their ability to surprise.

Inside was a driver's licence. There was a photo of me on it. I replaced it in the wallet.

I pulled on my clothes in a frantic fumbling rush and headed for the door.

---

There were no doctors or nurses on the corridor, only a man in his sixties wearing a blue overall, upending a wire bin into a black bag. He didn't even look at me as I passed him. I peeked into the first ward I went past, saw with almost superhuman clarity a very old woman, surely very near the end, her pallid yellow skin drawn taut around her face. She smiled at me calmly, from under sedation, revealing a row of small, even teeth.

A nurse walked towards me carrying a tray and I attempted to pass her nonchalantly, while simultaneously overthinking the act of walking. I expected her to call after me, *Hey*, I could almost hear it, *Hey*, but it was in my head, she hadn't called out anything, and I can't have been far from the exit now. I passed some kind of waiting area, where at the corner of my eye two people in dark uniforms lurked, immobile as coats hung on hooks, drinking coffee from white Styrofoam cups. My stomach constricted; I thought my legs might give. I tottered past them, and headed round the plaster-pink corner of the corridor.

There were two more people between me and the exit. Two people; engaged in a whispered conversation. Conspiratorial. A general feeling of plotting, of subterfuge.

One of them, I realized, was Dr Harriman. She was talking to another doctor, a man.

Neither of them saw me; without thinking, without breaking stride, I walked into an empty store cupboard and pulled the door almost closed.

I couldn't hear their conversation clearly. But I heard my name.

I opened the door slightly to peek through, as much as I dared. The doctor I hadn't encountered yet was showing Dr Harriman some kind of printout, an MRI image, a human head. And then I heard my name again, in tones of patronizing concern.

And then I heard Dr Harriman say a phrase I recognized.

I strained to listen. The blood pulsing in my eardrums was so loud I was scared they would hear me.

My name again. More urgent, low conversation. I didn't dare move.

And then, Dr Harriman said it again, as she ran a caressing hand over the printout. The same phrase. As clear as if it were written.

*The Master-Stroke.*

Silently, I opened the supply cupboard door, darted into the corridor, and walked briskly away in the opposite direction.



This route took me past the nurses' station, but I was halfway across the floor before anyone noticed me. When they did, the moment was unmistakable, a wave of agitated sound rising behind me, but I ignored it. Nurses called after me and chairs scraped across linoleum, but I was too fast, slapping various buttons that opened automatic doors, not stopping.

I saw signs for the fire escape and, pushing the metal bar down on the door, found myself in an empty, sterile-looking stairway, luminous with sunlight. I was four flights down before I heard the door open again, far above me.

And then I was on the ground floor, hurrying towards the exit, and daylight.

## 69

IT WAS LUNCHTIME, and it must also have been visiting time, I reasoned, as the place was filled with people, queuing for cashpoints or sandwiches, meeting, chatting, eating. Summer was dead and gone, although the autumn sunlight was still strong enough to sting my eyes. I put my head down and walked, following a straight line in the flagstones, leading out beyond, until they became a honeycomb of hexagonal 1960s paving slabs forming the hospital approach. I was terrified that someone would see me, know me, grab my arm – Dr Harriman perhaps, coming after me.

I glanced up at one point, unable to stop myself, and glimpsed the orderly, the one who was there when I woke, gliding past me. *Clive*. I caught my breath, but he had headphones on, silently mouthing lyrics only he could hear. After this encounter, I kept my eyes glued to the ground until I reached the road.

There was a crossing, and I waited with other people until the traffic stopped, walking across with them. Big Ben chimed again, one single dull lump of unmusical noise, and I realized it was one o'clock. I headed towards the river, and under a white stone lion I found a flight of stone steps that led downwards, then I was surrounded by tourists. I almost blundered onto a blanket stretched across the floor, cheap souvenirs of Princess Diana laid out on it. Someone swore at me, but I crashed on. *Keep walking*, I thought, *it is vital that I keep walking*. I changed direction, doubled back, left the profile of the river, walked a long way beside a gigantic limestone building, and then I was at the hospital again.

I skirted the hospital's south side and followed the river.

---

I walked for what seemed like a very long time. I had absolutely no idea where I was going. I was a total stranger in the city I had, apparently, been living in for some years now.

I felt I was walking in a southerly direction, but the river was inescapable, and after a long time during which I felt I was walking away from it, it curved back to find me. I circumvented a colossal, almost Mesoamerican building with enormous gates. Beyond, the bridge across the river was almost empty; the day, whatever day it was, was quiet and calm.

Pausing in the centre of the bridge, I looked behind me.

Two figures stood at the far end. They seemed to be looking at me.

A strange thought flashed across my brain: *am I being followed?* Were these people from the hospital, come to take me back, by force if necessary? Or was it the police, pursuing me for further questioning? I strode self-consciously across the remainder of the bridge. As I got to the end, I turned back casually, as any sightseer might, to see the river, the skyline.

The two figures were halfway across the bridge now. They had picked up speed. Two men, walking fast, with purpose. I could see their uniforms.

I left the bridge as soon as I could, heading past a grand parade of stucco-fronted houses. A right-hand turn brought me to an enormous white stone building, and I could see the river again. I headed towards it, confident that I had given my pursuers the slip, but when I reached the front of the building, there they stood, as if waiting for me.

Panicked, I cut through a small garden to the towering neoclassical frontage, and, without pause, pattered up the white steps, as if I had business there.

At the top of the stairs, a woman my own age told me that entry to the galleries was free, but the special exhibitions were ticket only. I smiled a watery smile, then glanced behind me, just in time to see the two uniforms, climbing the stairs behind me at a leisurely yet certain pace. The woman asked if I'd like an audio guide to the gallery, and then told me where the cloakrooms were. I thanked her with a trembling smile and went inside.

---

The interior was huge, grand and spacious. There was a gigantic main hall, but walking across the length of it would make me conspicuous, easy to spot. Instead, I darted into one of the smaller rooms, which were only small in comparison to the main hall; cavernous in their own right, high-ceilinged, opulent. I strode at speed into this maze of interconnecting chambers, noticing only small details in passing, a bronze of a naked youth holding a snake, a series of portraits, the green and white patterned marble which adorned the doorways. Were they still behind me? Again, I didn't dare look back. My heart hammered; the headache, like someone driving something blunt into the front of my head, had returned. I walked purposefully through a room of shapes, another room of charcoal sketches. I reached another, very grand, very large chamber, hung with paintings of all sizes. I was reminded, very briefly, of something similar I had encountered recently, and then, then—

I gasped as I saw Ella.

Only, it wasn't Ella, and I laughed: I was alone in a room of Pre-Raphaelite paintings, so all the women in them looked vaguely like Ella. There was Ella in a boat, looking alarmed. There was Ella kissing an armoured knight. There, dozens of identical Ellas descended a spiral staircase. They only superficially resembled her, but in those first few seconds, to my tired mind, the effect was striking.

---

Sometime later, I finally allowed myself to believe I'd lost my pursuers. I was calm, although now my head ached constantly.

I left the gallery and walked for a long time, not knowing or caring where I was going. Of the two uniformed men, there was no sign.

I walked past a cashpoint, and a thought occurred to me, making me retrace my steps, opening my wallet to find my cash card. My pin number was the same, thank God, as it had always been, and I was able to check my bank balance.

With a sense of detached inevitability, I noticed that my overdraft was far, far bigger than when I last saw it, and I appeared to be precisely £34,986 in debt. This amount was too gigantic to be anything other than amusing, and I was wondering if it were a waste of time to bother attempting to withdraw any money at all, when I noticed something. A detail familiar to me from most of my prior dealings with cashpoints was absent.

*There was no minus sign.*

I was £35,000 in credit. Not in debt. *In credit.* This account had just shy of £35,000 in it, and it was only a current account. Pin money, for the day-to-day. Somewhere, there would very likely be a savings account, too, and that would have very much more money in it. Given this information, it was likely I might even own my own flat.

I was rich, here, in this place. Or, at any rate, money was not an immediate problem, in the way it had always seemed to be.

*How delightful, I thought, to have at least one thing that's not an immediate problem.*

For the first time – and far too late, it seemed – I wondered, seriously, about my role here. I evidently had a well-paid job; I wondered where I lived. *Where does the me, the me that lives here, in London, where does he live?* I was a tourist here, in a city I'd never visited. But *he* would know London. He would know what the different parts meant, would have his own emotional resonances attached to each district, to certain streets—

'You alright there, mate?' said a voice behind me. I turned my head to see that a queue had formed. I nodded dumbly, and took out two hundred pounds, stuffing the money and my bank card into my wallet as I walked away. Inside the wallet, I glimpsed other things, and for the first time, realized they might be useful.



There was a small, bland park nearby, and I sat on the grass and emptied the wallet, inverting it and shaking it out, like a miser in a cartoon, looking for

anything useful.

A few minutes later, I carefully replaced all the wallet's contents, got to my feet and hailed a black cab.

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# 70

MY DRIVER'S LICENCE told me that my address was 17 Castaigne Street, Islington, and so that was where I told the cab driver to go. Thankfully, he didn't attempt to talk to me, so I was free to think my thoughts, uninterrupted, as I stared out of the window.

We ground through King's Cross, one of the few areas of London I recognized, which looked just as grotty as it always appeared on the news, the same black corrugated metal frontage with the station's name in white letters. The road was clogged with traffic, and it took us a long time to get to another road, where we were immediately snarled in traffic again.

London, it seemed, presented itself to me exactly as people who don't live there and despise it on principle always imagine it will be. Too large, too noisy, too aggressive, too indifferent, too fast, everything and everyone propelled by strong, unseen incomprehensible currents. I noted with distress that homeless people seemed to be everywhere – sitting cross-legged outside tube stations, cowed in blankets, like mendicant friars, sipping from cans of high strength lager. If we did have a Labour government now, I imagined this would be among the first things they'd set their minds to fixing. I wondered if steps had been taken to protect workers' rights, the environment, whether anything had already been renationalized; just how the country would be remade, now it had a new, apparently socialist, direction to strike out in.

---

Castaigne Street was a short avenue of tall dirty-white stucco-fronted houses. The street terminated abruptly in a high brick wall, behind which lurked an almost heroically ugly Victorian church the colour of wet cardboard. The street gave off a vaguely seaside feel, as if it were somehow in the backstreets of Brighton or Eastbourne, but this impression probably arrived courtesy of a gang of cawing seagulls, which fought incessantly over the contents of a black bin bag.

I approached the front door of number 17. Below street level, I saw, was a paved front garden upon which several species of grasses imprisoned in pots were slowly dying, next to steps down to a basement flat. Was that my flat? I scanned the doorbells. None of the slots had any names in them at all.

It took me several attempts to find the correct key, but eventually, the lock issued an efficient, pistol-like click and the door swung open.

---

The hallway seemed very dark after the sunny day outside, and the short passage was mostly taken up by a large ten-speed racing bike propped against the wall, with a D-lock through the rear wheel. An exquisite hardwood banister descended like a sinuous snake into this shabby space, a reminder of the days when these homes would have been occupied by one wealthy family, with a small army of servants below-stairs.

What flat did I live in again? Ignoring the preposterousness of this question, I consulted my driving licence: Flat 4.

The hallway smelled of dust, the fading presence of some industrial cleaner. Flat 4 was on the second floor landing. The warmth of the day, and, presumably, the preceding days, had made the door expand slightly in its frame; while both locks turned easily enough, I found I had to shoulder-barge the door open.

And then I was in my flat, a flat I had lived in for years, apparently, and yet – somehow – had only just set foot in.

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The hallway was very tasteful, which immediately made me nervous.

It was carpeted with some kind of oat-coloured weave; there was a semicircular table against one wall, with a wireless telephone sitting upright in a white plastic base. A small red LED pulsed in the body of the plastic. The hallway was lined with various framed art prints: nothing, I realized, I would have chosen. This was the selection of someone who liked and admired art, someone who was interested in it: Bruegel, Cranach, *Death and the Miser* by Bosch. There were posters for modern artists I hadn't heard of; *Marc Quinn*, said one. *Sarah Lucas*. Undercutting all of this tastefulness, however, was a definite smell of neglect, of dust, dried washing, unwashed dishes. Student smells. There were three pairs of shoes, my size, all hastily kicked off at some point, lying around waiting for someone to pick them up or trip over them.

Similarly, the living room had been tasteful at one point in the recent past, but was now a mess, a squalid, untidy chaos of discarded clothes, books and CDs, plates with the residue of ancient meals glued to them. A large black L-shaped leather sofa sat amidst the mess, hugging a low oval coffee table of thick smoked glass, the lower part of which seemed to consist of an interlocking clump of driftwood. Again, the thoughtful interior design had been undermined by the habits of whoever currently lived here; the tabletop, the tops of cupboards and bookshelves, were as much of a mess as the floor: the same clutter of books, clothes, plates, cups and cutlery.

There were also a great many empty cans of beer, and more than one empty bottle of vodka.

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The kitchen was long and thin, with a large window at the end which opened onto the rear of the row of houses in the street beyond. The worktops were black granite, the cabinets battleship grey, the handles brushed steel; but again, all the hard work of whoever had decorated this place had been destroyed by the actions of whoever currently occupied the

place: the worktops were stacked with more filthy dishes, empty wine bottles, open cans of beans, curry, ravioli, their contents blue with mould. Above this desolation, a large framed poster hung above the small table, depicting a bust of a man set into a grimace of superhuman agony. On closer inspection, I saw that it was for an exhibition in Vienna, two years ago, *The Character Heads of Franz Xaver Messerschmidt*.

The fingers of my right hand – unprompted, it seemed, by me – touched and caressed the glass as if the grotesque face it protected was very dear to me.

---

The bedroom held a large double bed, but only one side of it appeared to be slept in. Either side of the bed were alcoves stuffed with books, a stout dresser with framed photos on it, and a small table with a lamp on it. As well as sundry personal effects, of course, these surfaces were overloaded with clutter and debris, dust and filth.

These were all things I saw later. The thing that captured my attention immediately was another print, framed and under glass, hanging above the bed.

It didn't so much catch my eye as drag my entire gaze over to it, as if it were the only real thing in the world, a window into a higher, more perfected state of being. A modest-sized painting, in which it seemed a whole cosmos seethed and teemed, like pondlife under a microscope. And I knew what it was, even before I read the title.

*The Fairy Feller's Master-Stroke.*

I climbed onto the bed to see it better. In that instant, I forgot all about where I had been, what I had been through, the absurd but terribly true fact that four years had been irrecoverably lost, burned up, as if they had never been. Here is a story, a parable, that can speak only to those who understand. Here is a vision, of the world as it actually is, a depiction of the realm that Ella Flayne saw, that Leo visited, and made sure we all saw. A hyperreal moment, eternally happening, eternally unfolding, far beyond

human understanding. I looked, and the painting seemed to grow, to obtain depth, each detail leading me to another, and then I looked at the figures in the foreground.

And then the others are with me, somehow. There is Clive, richly robed, beard trimmed, face set in contemplation; there is Helen, adorned in a blue headdress, standing with Ruth, who wears the colours of autumn. And there, in the foreground, is Leo, in a wide-brimmed hat with a red ribbon, and in front of him stands Malcolm, in white, observing the central figure, who, with his back to the viewer, raises his axe, forever, to deliver the blow that will split the world in two.

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The wardrobe was exactly half empty, with a precision which was almost comical. One side was men's clothes – shirts, jackets, coats, and shoes beneath. The other side was empty apart from a single shoebox, with nothing in it.

On the dresser were photos, face down, and I sobbed when I saw what those images held.

A me who was not me, smiling at forever, and next to him – always, with her hair braided or wild, holding up a champagne glass or shielding her eyes against the Mediterranean sunlight – there she was. There we were; all trapped inside moments we had never spent together, moments that never happened, dazzling, brilliant, two people shining with youth, glowing with the proximity of each other, marvelling at this thing they had found, nurtured, sustained. Nothing I remembered, nothing I recalled, a path untrodden by me, as I was now. My face shook and tears fell. Red lipstick, her magnificent hair piled up on her head in a style I didn't recognize, her eyes, as always, filled with that spark, the envy of the whole world. So *alive*.

There would be other things, things more crushing than mere images. Her scent on the bedclothes. Long strands of red trapped in the matrix of a hairbrush. Make-up, books, belongings, all part of her.

It was unbearable. I fled.

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I retreated to the hallway, my breathing quick and deep, as the fragments of something unthinkable lay before me, waiting for me to put them together. A final sob ripped through me; I bit a finger until it hurt, until my breathing steadied.

A me that was not me lived here, with an Ella that was not Ella. Only, something else had occurred, and now the pieces were harder to put together. However, all the hints – the half-inhabited bed, the half-empty wardrobe, the face-down pictures, the state of the place – were that she had left him.

And if that were the case, then where was she?

---

In the living room I discovered a stack stereo and, next to it, a tall wire rack of compact discs. I removed each disc from its plastic box and, after reading the details, let each one drop to the floor. Some of the bands and artists were familiar to me, others not. At an arbitrary point in this pointless process, I looked down at the CD I was holding. It was *Queen II*, Freddie and the rest of the band in the iconic pose that the world would remember them in, forever now.

Something occurred to me. Feverishly, I scanned the track list on the back, and there it was: Track 7. I stared at the title for a long time, unsure of what this meant or how to proceed from this point. Eventually, I became aware of a noise from the hallway; in becoming aware of it, I realized it had been going on for a while. A strange voice talking, confident and assured, breezy and relaxed.

My voice.

*Hello, You've reached Ella and Alex. We're not here right now, but if you'd like to leave a message after the beep, we'll get back to you!*

Dutifully, the machine beeped. And then – against all the odds – a voice I recognized: Dr Harriman, asking if I could call her, or the hospital, to not do anything rash, that my condition was very serious in her opinion, my test results revealed I was at very serious risk, the police were very keen to speak to me... And so on and so forth.

There was a pleading, wheedling note in her voice I didn't trust. I waited until she rang off, then sat for a while, thinking.

I rewound the messages on the answer phone. There were three, prior to this. The first, a male voice, told someone – me, presumably – that he understood that things had been rough for me, but that if I didn't show my face soon, he'd have to refer me to HR. The emptiness of this threat, and the gravitas with which the man stated it, almost made me laugh. The second message was a woman's voice, not Ella's, not anyone I knew. She was calling to check that *Ella got home okay, after you more or less made her leave with you. What were you thinking, she said, turning up at the gallery like that? In that state? This wasn't the stupid shit about the artist again, was it? For the last time, there was nothing going on there.* I listened to this message three times, but it failed to resolve into anything I could use.

The final message, another male voice, was stark, serious and short.

*Alex. I've heard there's been an accident. Call me back.*

I listened to this message more than once. Then, I called Directory Enquiries, and obtained a number, writing it in biro directly onto the pristine white wall.

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'Hello?' said a voice.

'Hello. Am I speaking to Daena McCullough?'

'This is Daena's office, she's not here right now.' I could hear, as she spoke, that this was a much younger woman.

'Do you know when she'll be back?'

'That's not really... sorry, who is this?' There was a curt impatience in the woman's voice that was somehow the equal of Daena McCullough's

fearsome disdain.

‘My name is Alex Lane,’ I said. ‘I’m a – former student. I was wondering if you could help me? I need some information.’

The woman sniffed audibly. ‘The correct department for the alumni newsletter is—’

‘No,’ I said. ‘I don’t need that.’ I realized, slightly too late, that we were in competition here. Her, to put down the phone and end the call as soon as possible, and me, to keep her on it. When I spoke again, I did so carefully and clearly, playing my only ace.

‘I was in an accident,’ I said. ‘I’ve had a... memory blackout. A complete blackout.’

‘I’m very sorry to hear that,’ said the woman, without affect, as if she were reading the words from a cue card.

‘You’re very kind. Anyway, I’m recovering, slowly, but... look, the last thing I can recall is summer 1993, four years ago, working with other students at a job that Daena McCullough gave me. At a place called... Solace House?’

Like a magic spell, speaking these words produced a long, profound silence. When I realized she wasn’t going to break it, I spoke again.

‘As I – fixated – on that period, they – my doctors – just thought it would be useful if I spoke to Daena, straighten out a few details, that’s all.’

‘You’re the second caller we’ve had about that place in the last twenty-four hours,’ she said finally. ‘A doctor rang yesterday. She spoke to us for a long time. I think we gave her all the information we had?’

‘Yes,’ I said. ‘That’s correct. But I just wanted to go over some points again. Please. It would be very helpful to me.’

There was again silence on the line, but it had a different quality now. Something resembling indecision, tied up with duty.

‘Anything you have would be helpful,’ I said, as plaintively as I could. I heard her sigh wearily.

‘Well, we have a partial file here, but the main file has gone to records, which I’m reliably informed is chaos, as we’re scanning our archives in order to digitize them.’



‘*Anything*,’ I said. Again, she sighed.

There was a long pause. I could imagine this woman, whoever she was, sitting in her chair, like Daena McCullough, scooting grudgingly over to the filing cabinet, flicking through it. As if to cement this impression, that I was speaking to a Daena-in-training, I heard somebody come in and ask the woman something; although I couldn’t hear the specifics, I could hear the caustic tone of her voice, like a saw cutting sheet metal. Then, a scrabbling noise, as the receiver was picked up.

‘There’s not much,’ she said. ‘As I say, all the records are currently off-site.’

‘What is there?’

‘Maps, some contractual stuff. Oh, and a list of names, who was there.’

‘Could you read it out?’

She did so. *Jill Cowie. Helen Barker. Malcolm Lambert. Ruth Henderson. Leo Dexter. Clive Masters. Ella Garner.* I waited, my mouth dry. Only when it became clear there were no more names left did I speak.

‘No-one else?’

‘They’re the names I have here.’

‘*No-one else?*’ Where was Adam? ‘You’re absolutely sure?’

‘No-one else is mentioned, but, like I say, this is far from complete. Oh, hang on, there’s a current contact address here for one of the students.’

My heart lurched, suddenly awash with adrenalin.

‘*Which one?*’

‘It’s...’ She took a small eternity to locate the name. ‘... Malcolm Lambert. He still lives here, apparently, in town. Do you have a pen?’ She read out Malcolm’s number and I wrote it down, on a piece of paper this time.

‘Is there anything else you can tell me?’

‘That’s all there is.’

This seemed incredible. ‘But isn’t Solace House part of a hall of residence now?’

‘Oh, no. That never happened in the end. A private buyer made a very competitive counter-offer on both the hospital and the house. Considering

the, erm, circumstances, it was thought to be the best possible outcome, from the university's point of view.'

'Where are the records being...' – I fought to remember the unfamiliar word – 'digitized? Could I see them there?'

There was a short, cold silence on the other end of the line.

'Sorry, what did you say your name was?'

'Alex Lane. I was a student—'

'You said you'd had some kind of memory blackout? Are you in hospital now? Does your doctor know you're talking to me?'

I pretended I hadn't heard. 'It would *really* help me if you could tell me where they are.' But she was already speaking over me.

'Please get your doctor to call next time.' The curtness was back now. 'Any future requests will have to come through them.'

'It's none of her business!' I said. I could hear the anger rising in my voice.

'Nevertheless,' she said, her words icily precise now, 'any further requests for information—'

I tore the telephone from the wall socket and threw it down the hallway.

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In the sock drawer in the bedroom dresser, I found a chequebook, a passport and another two hundred and fifty pounds in cash, all of which I removed and stuffed into my rucksack.

There was also a small envelope of paper cut from a magazine, which, when unfolded, revealed a thin flat rectangle of compressed powder, smelling vaguely of bleach; at first I thought it might be amphetamines, but eventually I realized it was cocaine. I was so angered by this discovery that I took the time to take it to the bathroom and empty it down the toilet.

---

I showered, changed my clothes, and packed some more clothes into a holdall I found in the wardrobe. I put on a large, chunky sports watch I

found on the bedside table, then took it off again. Eventually, I headed out into the hallway. My head hurt again and I felt peculiar, but this was almost certainly because I needed to rest.

I picked up the phone I had thrown across the hallway and attempted to plug it back into the wall socket, but my burst of anger had torn something critical, and it was dead. This was frustrating, as I needed to make another call, but I didn't regret doing it. I wound the cord around the phone and placed it on the bedside table, forgetting that the photographs were there. I looked again at Ella and Alex, happy together, until it became too much, and I put them all face down, as I had found them.

I got up to leave. Staring down at the bed, I was seized by a strange, compelling thought.

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Lifting the thick, heavy mattress revealed a storage space under the bed. Two large compartments made of the same black hardboard as the bed frame.

There were dumbbells and a yoga mat in there, and a variety of old trainers, men's and women's, gathering dust.

But in one corner, safely tucked away, I saw a flash of deep red.

Flayne's final volume, the one stolen by Ella, kept by me, the volume that Adam had not been able to find. The one filled with the long poem which Ella had been entranced by.

I pulled it out and wiped the dust from the cover with my sleeve.

Opening it, I saw that it was just as I recalled seeing it when I saw it last. Almost three weeks from my perspective, four years ago from the world's.

There were the illuminated letters, the strange, winding borders, all of it executed in inks that were as bright and colourful now as they were when Edwin Flayne had painted them.

It was real. This volume, like me, was a survivor, a refugee from a world which had ended. It was *real*.

Again, there were tears in my eyes. I wiped them away, shoved the book into the holdall and left, heading for the only place that remained for me to go.

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AT PADDINGTON, I bought a ticket, then a coffee, as I waited for the platform to be announced. There seemed to be a lot more places to buy coffee than there ever used to be, but maybe that was just a London thing. Sipping my latte, forehead against glass, I took in the world.

Although it had only been four years, popular culture moves fast; everyone looked peculiar to me. Teenage girls wore trainers with comically tall platform soles, and vaguely military trousers in beige or green, with lots of pockets. Men seemed to wear mostly old-school tracksuit tops, sports casual, terrace wear. Everyone seemed to be drinking, even though it was mid-afternoon. People shouted and sang and drank with a hedonism that seemed, beneath the surface, desperate, a howl rather than a cheer. I was not sure what conclusion I was supposed to draw from everything I saw; whether things had taken a lurch towards sanity or merely grown ever more mad. I felt one thing with certainty, however: I got the distinct impression that whatever party I had missed, this was the very end of it.

A bunch of young men gathered outside the coffee shop I was sitting in and shouted football songs into each other's faces. I got up and left. I had something to do, anyway. The woman at the counter broke a ten pound note into change for me.



For some reason, I expected the phone to ring for a long time, but it was picked up on the third ring, with a *Hello* that sounded timid, cautious.

‘Malcolm?’

‘Who is this?’

‘You know who this is.’

‘I really don’t?’

‘It’s Alex,’ I said. ‘Alex Lane? Remember? From uni?’

‘Oh. Alex? Really?’ There was that note of caution again. ‘How are you?’

As if in answer, a corkscrew of pain wormed itself into the front of my head with such ferocity that I actually gasped. I gripped the metal edge of the phone kiosk until my knuckles whitened and the pain subsided.

‘I’m fine,’ I said. ‘You know?’

‘Hmmm,’ said Malcolm, in the manner of someone reluctant to have a conversation, or perhaps just this specific conversation. Before he could contrive an excuse to end the call, I spoke.

‘Look, Malcolm, I’m going to be in town tonight and I need to speak to you. About Solace House. About that summer.’

‘Alex—’

‘I know, I know. But...’ The best lies, I mused, are always constructed from the truth, or part of it. ‘I’ve been sick, very sick. I was in a car accident.’

‘Oh my God,’ he said with alarm. ‘Are you okay?’

‘Physically, fine,’ I said. ‘But I have amnesia. There are gaps in my memory. Well, one huge gap. Basically, I can remember that summer and then nothing after it. There are things I need to know, and nobody can tell me anything.’

There was silence on the line, then; whether freighted with significance or not, I couldn’t tell. I kept talking.

‘The neurologist says it would be very helpful if I spoke to someone else, someone who was there.’

‘Can’t you just talk to Ella?’ He sounded puzzled. ‘You guys are still together, right?’

It took me a couple of seconds to collect my thoughts.

‘It’s... we’re not... together at the moment. It’s complicated.’

‘Oh.’ His voice held real concern. ‘I’m sorry to hear that.’

‘Can I see you, then? Today?’

‘This isn’t a great time for me, Alex—’ He began saying other things, but I talked over him.

‘It has to be tonight. I’m only going to be in town tonight, and it would really, really, help me.’

‘You mean *in person*?’ He sounded almost panicked.

‘Yes. I can come to you, that’s no problem. Please. Just half an hour.’

‘I’m supposed to be going out tonight,’ said Malcolm. ‘I’d love to help, really I would, but—’

‘*Please.*’ The word was almost a cry; even I couldn’t tell if my fear was genuine now. ‘My memory is shattered, I don’t know anything for certain, and it would really, *really* help if I could speak to someone else who was there.’

There was another long pause.

‘Alex—’

‘*Please,*’ I said, again, with an earnestness which bordered on the manic. Malcolm sighed heavily.

‘*Alright.* Just half an hour.’

‘God, thank you, Malcolm. Thank you. Where shall I meet you?’

He gave me the name of a pub in the centre of town, and I wrote it on the back of my hand, just as they announced the platform for my train.



I boarded the train, found myself a table, a window seat, in the direction the train was headed; the same preferences a child exhibits as to where they sit. There weren’t many other passengers. After a brief pause, the train moved, slowly at first, at walking speed, then accelerating, as it sought to break the capital’s gravitational pull. Mile by mile, I watched London’s grasp on the scenery falter. At long last, rows of terraced housing and empty railway sidings were replaced by industrial units, parkland and suburb, and eventually these too slipped away to become fields, rising and expanding as if coming into being.

I considered sleeping, as my head was aching again, but then I remembered something. I retrieved it from the holdall in the luggage rack above me.

It was just as I recalled it; just as brightly coloured, detailed, singular. The illuminated letters of each segment and the borders around the words still held wonder. One hundred and twenty-three quatrains, inscrutable and cryptic, hinting at Flayne's life, at Solace House, at the things he had seen, at the mystical operation he had ultimately shied away from performing, which Adam had attempted to complete. Reading it now was shocking, in some respects; certain phrases seemed to resound with meaning, or to be weighted with implications I had not seen before. Other verses, which I had taken to be portents or direct warnings, now seemed abstract. Before long, I found I had read the entire thing, but, as ever, the greater meaning of it, hinted at throughout, eluded me.

I closed the book and put it on the table in front of me.

The countryside was low and flat and green, with no signs of human habitation, the dreamlike peacefulness of the scene utterly at odds with the speed at which the train hurtled through it. Another train passed us in a shocking blare of sound, screaming as it went, and then silence resumed with an abruptness which was almost comical.

I was not thinking about where I was headed. How could one prepare for such a thing? Of past and future, I had very little reliable knowledge. I had guesses, and suspicions, nothing concrete. I allowed myself to think about what I had learned about the circumstances which had put me in hospital, but there was no way to make sense of any of it until I knew more.

I was simply moving forward, as I must, now.

I looked again at the liver-coloured volume in front of me. Inside the narrow gap between the spine and the binding, something was caught, concealed. A flash of bright yellow.

I opened the ledger to its full extent, and then bent the covers back, so the book looked as if it were about to take flight; the gap at the spine flexed and widened so that I could worm my little finger inside. I pulled gently,



and a carefully rolled tube of A4 paper emerged, smoothly exiting its hiding place as if part of a mechanism.

Yellow A4 legal paper.

The paper that Ella used.

My pulse sounded in my head, my throat. My fingers trembled as I smoothed out the paper. There were three sheets in all, upon which was written – of all things – another poem. The style – quatrains with an AB-AB rhyme-scheme – was all Flayne's, but the handwriting, bold and beautiful, was Ella's.

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## 72

1. All summer, the house entreated, taunted,  
Requests unutterable made.  
Pitiful Eden, the sunrise haunted,  
Eternity's ruined aubade.
2. Long days in silence, sorrow o'erflowing,  
Unheeded 'neath drear empty dreams.  
Bliss ripening into nothingness, growing,  
In nightmarish, grotesque extremes.
3. As respite, the house – insane, tormented –  
Sought new offerings to invite.  
Cruelty enshrouded, greed reinvented;  
Assiduously veiling each spite.
4. Its nefarious soul, ever needful  
To realms everlasting assumed  
Tragic yearning! Nor our world, deceitful –  
Unerringly made, but foredoom'd.
5. O, unhappy notion dark Eden devised,  
Its novel plan – obscene, unholy:  
Reigning in nothingness, guilt neutralised –  
Outcast, where Godhead lasts only.
6. Robed in obscurity, undone, stranded where

Abyssal void empty extends;  
Vacant in limitless silence, impure:  
New fears license ungodly ends.

7. No celestial estate, no ecstasy great  
Awaits thee; e'en death must abjure.  
No saviour our foolhardy faiths elevate  
Nor comfort eternal secure.
8. Such troubled reasoning, idly proposed!  
Proud Eden's design translated.  
Outlandish sanctification composed;  
Ordained redemption negated.
9. O, ulterior rebirth luminous!  
In vales eternal surrounded –  
Arrogant project, prophecy ruinous!  
Anguish in sweetness enshrouded.
10. Doth conceit our lifetime's labour assign,  
Then evasive desire ensure?  
Validate empty reasoning you enshrine  
As response to heavenly law?
11. Yea, all creation these riddles enforce  
Born of relentless nature's need –  
Of whether Earthly aspiration's course  
Hellish aims carve true indeed.
12. Observe, noble Christian, and lament –  
Look on unholy Solace House!  
Observe rash revelation's insane bent –  
Lo, Eden's limit, undevout!

13. See thenceforth from unhallowed longing,  
Arcadia's nascent glory run;  
Yearning madness unto radiance dawning;  
Earth's reap of unsaved souls begun.
14. And so everlasting Eden's vision  
In numberless centuries endured.  
Death now overthrown, woeful transition  
Of living, all wisdom ignored.
15. Now – forever – a line labyrinthine  
Intertwines betwixt lifetimes entrapped.  
Ghastly are the hours, Eden's redesign:  
E'en dear Heav'n in this Hell enwrapped.
16. Regard the infinite, mankind exceeded;  
Abstraction now definite sum.  
Pure, absolute, creation's end cheated:  
Regard Eden, all things o'ercome.
17. Regard Eden; Earthly needs now outpaced,  
With damnable object obtained.  
Made incorruptible, sins now erased –  
And ruinous insight now gained.
18. Glory or despair, such lies are shattered,  
The infinite now shown transformed.  
Reality's unreal covering tattered,  
Insanity's oath now foresworn.
19. Life everlasting; such hollow salvation,  
Extinguish now Death's sweet offence.  
Unclean light shining in night's desolation,  
Encountering all trials hence.

20. Lonely is God, He that *Ex Nihilo* decreed  
Light everlasting should shine.  
Emptiness rendered resplendent indeed;  
Naught granted all life's light sublime.
21. Here, a lost lunatic evermore schemes,  
Trapped inside mad aspiration.  
Till in Omega's name shall Earth's noble dreams  
Spoil into noxious stagnation.
22. Prayers ring out, mournful invocations sworn;  
Each sorrow unheard, now denied.  
O, none ever reach ears so closed in scorn!  
Sweet impassioned oaths nullified.
23. Nothing of wordly endeavour maintains;  
Man and nature's ultimatum.  
Eternity looms, so dread Eden claims  
Its solace in our negation.

The words blurred in front of me for a second, and grew crystalline, stellate in my vision. I blinked, and refocused.

I closed the volume and shoved it back into the holdall.

THE CITY FELT DIFFERENT. There seemed to be a different energy permeating it, a new sense of purpose, almost, or a yearning towards a purpose previously incomprehensible to me. Or maybe I was simply attuned to different things now, signals that I, as a student, had been unable to hear. Whatever the difference, it was tangible, and I was a stranger here. But then, I thought, I was a stranger everywhere now.

I walked, with no idea where I was going, but knowing that it didn't matter. I had money, and money meant that things would work out, always, no matter which direction you headed. I walked away from the station, towards an area of the city I had never had occasion to visit when I was a student, an area of business parks and bad corporate sculpture, chain pizza places and yet more coffee outlets.

And hotels.

Lots of hotels, for business people, sales reps, conventioners, motivational speakers, attendees of corporate training weekends. I would be safe among them, camouflaged, cocooned by layers of comforting banality.

I picked a large, tall wedge of a building that couldn't have been more than two years old, branded with the logo of a company called Severndown Hotels. The lobby was full, dozens of people attending a conference, name badges and suits and constant chatter. The receptionist looked puzzled when I said I would take any room they had, but one must have appeared on his computer screen instantly; within five minutes I had completed the paperwork and was heading up to the room with a key.

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The room looked like a technical drawing, something from a safety manual or a textbook. The blue nylon curtains opened onto a view of the motorway flyover, five floors below, and beyond that, more hotel blocks, apparently identical to the one I was in. The carpet smelled brand new. There was a small table, on which a TV sat, and a neat, thin desk; a king-size bed took up roughly half the available floor space. The only decoration was a picture on the wall of some yellow and purple flowers of indeterminate species. *The perfect space*, I thought, *for someone in my position*. I hung my clothes in the wardrobe, put my few toiletries in the bathroom.

I lay on the bed for a long while, reading Flayne's poem and Ella's accompanying verse. Had she begun to write her own epic poem? Or had the compulsion that infected Flayne begun to infect her? The words swam together, shouted and jumped, drifted away and came back, like sea-turned shingle, and I fell asleep.

It had been a long, long day.

---

Night had fallen when I woke up; I showered, dressed, then took a cab to the pub Malcolm had mentioned. I realized that I was over an hour early, but that didn't matter. The only thing that mattered was meeting Malcolm.

The pub, when I reached it, turned out to be one of those pubs that had been built and designed solely to be a pub; a grand old Victorian thing with a central door slicing off one corner. The windows were sandblasted, with wording on them in gold; the bar was sheathed in beaten copper and the wooden booths were carved as lovingly as if the place were a church. I thought, inevitably, of Solace House, and felt nervous and sick.

I ordered a pint from the barman and sat down. I was still fifty-five minutes early.

In jarring contrast to the Victorian interior, a huge TV screen was set over the bar, playing a music channel. A man in tiny sunglasses and a cagoule was shouting nasally into a microphone set too tall for him, and the results were baffling to me. Disturbingly, the onscreen branding called this

obviously recent artefact *A Classic Track*. Again, I realized, as I watched a man at the bar smoke, that I had experienced no cravings whatsoever for cigarettes.

Some time passed. I finished my drink, bought another, sat down. When I looked up, at the other side of the table, there he was.

The last time I had seen Malcolm, he had looked casually perfect, a radiantly beautiful young man, painted by Caravaggio, in what the people of Flayne's generation would call *the flower of youth*. Any step away from that would inevitably reduce him, and so it had; his hair seemed thinner, higher on his forehead, his face seemed longer, coarser than it had. There were dark circles around his eyes, probably from too many late nights, too close to one another. He glanced around him nervously, as if the place were full of spies; he wore a black trench coat, which seemed to add to the air of intrigue.

I smiled, cautiously, in greeting. 'Malcolm.'

'Alex.' His voice was clipped, businesslike. He removed his coat, and, producing a pack of Marlboro Lights, lit one up. 'You look well.'

'Thanks,' I said, and, as custom demanded, replied, 'So do you.' He offered me a cigarette and I raised my hand reflexively in refusal, a gesture which seemed to surprise us both. He went to the bar and returned with two whiskies. They were both for him. He knocked back the first one before he'd even sat down.

'How are you?' he asked.

'Fine,' I said, and then realized he was referring to my medical status. 'Apart from the – memory thing.'

'You really can't remember anything?'

I shook my head. 'There's a huge blank space.'

'Wow.' His voice refused to commit to any kind of emotion.

'How have you been?' I asked.

'Okay,' he said guardedly. 'Oh – sorry to hear about you and Ella.'

My cheeks flushed. 'What?'

He looked confused, stirred the ice in his glass with a finger. 'You said on the phone earlier you weren't living together any more?'



‘Something like that. I’m sorry, when was the last time we spoke? I mean, before that?’

He shrugged, took a slug of the second of his whiskies.

‘We don’t, like, hugely keep in touch.’

‘Well, what was the last news you heard? About me and Ella?’

‘I heard you were living together. You were working in the City, law or finance or something. Ella was working at some kind of art gallery. That’s what I heard.’

‘That’s it?’

‘That’s what I heard.’ Over the rim of his glass, his eyes shone with a curiosity which hadn’t been present before. ‘Fuck, you really don’t remember, do you?’

‘Did you think I was making it up?’

‘No, but...’ He shook his head. ‘It’s just... quite something. To experience.’

I looked at my drink. ‘Tell me about it.’ Malcolm shrugged as if to say *fair point*.

A short silence congealed.

‘I need to know a few things,’ I said. ‘I need to know what you remember of that last night at Solace House.’

He drew hard on his cigarette. I heard the paper and tobacco crackle as he inhaled half an inch of it. He exhaled a cloud of grey smoke, but said nothing.

‘You remember that we were spiked, right?’

He nodded. ‘You don’t forget something like that.’

‘And you remember how that happened?’

‘Yes.’ He took another colossal drag on his cigarette.

‘After you ran away—’

‘I don’t regret that,’ said Malcolm. ‘If you’re trying to make me feel bad.’

I waved a hand. ‘I’m not, I’m not. I just – I remember one set of events, but I can’t be sure they’re... I just want to know how much of it is true. Here, in this place.’

He frowned. 'What do you mean, *in this place*?'

I suspected he knew very well what I meant. It was time to show my hand.

'What happened to Clive?' I asked. 'To Helen, and Ruth?'

His face fell.

'You don't know?' he said incredulously. 'Oh God. Of course you wouldn't.'

'Know what?'

He stubbed out his cigarette, immediately lit another.

'They're all dead, Alex.'

My heart began to pound. I felt, then, in that moment, as if the world in which I found myself had become more real, more concrete, more definite, like underlining words on a page.

'*I knew it*,' I said. 'I knew I didn't imagine it, or hallucinate it!'

Malcolm looked confused. 'What?'

'That last night. He needed witnesses, to complete Flayne's ritual. He couldn't do what Flayne did and make magically charged dummies, he didn't have the time. So, he took the short cut. The other option.' I leaned forward in my chair. 'He killed the three of them.'

To my surprise, Malcolm laughed, a sudden braying laugh. '*What the fuck are you talking about?*'

'That last night! When we were all tripping!'

He simply looked confused then.

'That's not what happened. It was all afterwards. In – different ways.'

'What?'

'You really don't remember a thing, do you? God.'

I shook my head. He took another drag on his cigarette.

'Clive drowned, in Crete, the next summer. He smashed his head on a rock, diving into the sea. Helen was... Jesus. There was a hotel fire, in Brighton.' He shuddered. 'And Ruth...' He sighed out a cloud of smoke, and his voice cracked a little. 'Ruth jumped in front of a train.'

'When?'

'Afterwards,' said Malcolm. 'Since then. Afterwards.'

I shook my head. 'No.'

Malcolm's face contorted with denial so violent it was almost disgust. He exhaled again.

'What?'

'They were killed, that night,' I said. I felt the same anger that had caused me to tear the phone out of the wall earlier today, let it course through me. 'They were killed! Murdered!'

Malcolm peered at me in incomprehension.

'By who?'

'You know who!' I said. 'By Adam!'

Malcolm looked beyond confused now. He looked utterly bewildered.

'Who?'

'Fucking *Adam!*' I shouted. The name echoed around the pub. Several people looked over their shoulder at us.

'*There was no-one there called Adam,*' said Malcolm. He was pale now, fearful.

I tried to speak, found that I couldn't. I was simply unable, in that moment, to talk, to think. The ice in Malcolm's second whisky clattered as he knocked it back.

'This was a bad idea,' he muttered, not to me. He was already putting his coat on. I sat, stunned, immobile. Eventually, a question framed itself. I grabbed at his wrist as he stood up.

'Have you been back there?' I asked. 'Solace House?'

He looked down at me with horror. He shook his arm free.

'Goodnight, Alex.'

I SAT FOR A SHORT WHILE after Malcolm left, almost unable to believe he'd even been there at all. Eventually, I got up and left too.

I walked, then, for what felt like a long time.

I walked through the bright city centre until it gave way to streets, cramped terraces of yellow stone, and then, rising from the darkness, a council estate, great blocks of flats and slanting walkways, all lit in a dirty green-yellow, which made the buildings look evanescent, apparitional. The night had grown colder. I walked without seeing anyone, a tiny, purposeless plastic person in a vast architect's model, going nowhere.

I thought of Ella's account of Adam's car crash – seeing, as he sped along, a bright silver rail, more solid than steel, than diamond, and knowing somehow that it was fate, immutable and unarguable, leading in a single direction only. And then I knew. I knew I was headed towards something, in a very definite direction, fate drawing me like a magnet.

At the far end of the estate was a grid of six tarmac five-a-side pitches, and here I was not alone, as even in the coldness of the night a small group of figures huddled together, in a dark corner, away from the brilliant cones of silver halogen light, to smoke something. One of them shouted at me, but even this felt like a token gesture, action without intent. I walked on, until I was traversing a series of battered Victorian terraces and a row of shops, the bright white lights of fried chicken places and minicab offices. Still, I walked, until I came to a large building which might, at one point, have been a factory or a warehouse, or even a Methodist church, but was now a pub.

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There was some kind of band on in the pub, playing to a disinterested crowd of five people, and so I sat outside, at a picnic table in a small empty concrete courtyard stacked with barrels and pallets, which a sign described – apparently without irony – as *The Beer Garden*.

Through the brightly lit windows, I could see the enormous, mostly empty pub, the barmaid struggling to find things to occupy herself, in order to make her shift go faster.

I sipped my drink, thinking thoughts too inchoate to achieve expression in words; clouds of impressions, ghosts.

It was pleasant to be liberated, even briefly, from having to understand.

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At length, I became aware that a man was standing over me. I smelled him before I saw him; a heady tang of tobacco, unwashed skin, unwashed clothes. He was wearing a brown three-quarter length leather coat, the kind the police can't ever search properly, a labyrinth of hidden pockets. He wore a woollen beanie hat and was unshaved. He smiled down at me; I saw that teeth were missing. The remaining teeth were orangey brown.

'Hello, Alex,' he said.

I couldn't speak for a few moments, just simply opened and closed my mouth a few times. Seeing that I recognized him, he smiled again, broader still. Gone forever was the pensive, considered young man with fastidious habits and academic aspirations, the man who would read ancient monuments like books, who I could easily see on television, pursuing the glittering career of a popular academic. Here, instead, was someone on the cusp of dereliction, clearly living on the street, or not far from it.

'You probably have questions.'

The first and only question I wanted to ask him was *what the fuck happened to you?* but this would mean acknowledging his circumstances, and even alluding to this seemed cruel. Instead, I simply got up and

embraced him. The leather coat felt even worse to the touch than I suspected. Similarly, he smelt worse, up close, than I had imagined too.

‘How have you been?’ I said, as if the answer to this were not entirely self-evident. ‘I didn’t know you still lived here?’

‘Insofar as I live at all,’ he said, ‘I live here.’

‘How’s your mum?’

‘Dead.’

‘I’m sorry to hear that.’

‘These things happen.’ He sat down opposite me, so I sat down too.

‘Malcolm’s here too,’ I said. ‘In the city.’

‘I know.’ He produced a pouch of tobacco and began, with incredible speed and dexterity, to roll a cigarette.

‘Leo, what happened at Solace House?’

He grinned, licked the cigarette he was rolling and twirled a perfect, uniformly cylindrical cigarette between his thumb and index finger, before placing it in his mouth. He found a clipper lighter inside his jacket and lit it.

‘I remember, Alex. Do you?’

‘I— yeah.’ I wasn’t sure how to proceed. ‘I remember you being in a – bad way, Leo. I remember you being quite, you know, overwhelmed by the experience you’d had.’

He laughed. He had more teeth missing than I’d first supposed. The loud laugh he produced clearly took him by surprise, too, as he subsided into a coughing fit. When he had recovered, he smiled good-naturedly.

‘You could say that, yeah.’

A few seconds passed. I couldn’t think of how to proceed. Before I could figure this out, however, Leo spoke.

‘Just ask, Alex?’

‘Ask what?’

‘Ask why I’m here, like this. And not somewhere else. Ask whether that door, once opened, could ever be closed again. Ask me what I remember, from that last night, from Solace House.’

‘Before all that,’ I said, ‘I have to know.’

He smiled again, a smile laced with a bland calm which was, in its own way, terrifying. 'Know what?'

'Where Ella is.'

He laughed. 'You already know.'

'I don't, Leo.'

Laughter, again. 'You do. You just can't see it yet.'

I was exasperated, exhausted, tired of riddles. Beaten into submission by puzzle after puzzle, unable to step back and see the whole picture, or even discern if there was one; shocked by the ruins of my friend, and his utter indifference to that ruin. Leo seemed to pick up on this; when he spoke again, it was as if he had heard my thoughts. His voice – as it seemingly always was now – was eerily calm.

'Remember, Alex. Flayne built labyrinths inside labyrinths. He did that to hide something. A thing he couldn't face up to. As above, so below. Maybe you can't face up to it either.'

'Leo,' I said. I felt a sudden, harrowing tenderness. Here was a person who had had a dazzling future ahead of him once, and now all his early brilliance and promise had metastasized into – this. The tragedy was a slow motion one, not instant and dramatic, like a car crash; but the effect was much the same.

'Do you need anything?' I asked, in a small, quiet voice. 'Can I help at all?'

He smiled sadly.

'I mean, if you need money or anything...'

His smile grew broader, sadder. 'Everyone always needs money here. But I'll be fine, either way.'

'This,' I said, looking down at my hands, clinging to the table, the knuckles white, '*this isn't fine.*'

'It's as good as anything else. It's all the same here. Everything.'

'What do you mean?'

He shrugged.

'What did you see in that cave?'

'You saw it too.'

‘You saw another world?’

He shook his head. ‘I saw *the* world, as it really is. I told you this. And it was too much. Far too much for human eyes, a human brain, to tolerate.’

‘Yet you’re still here.’

He looked away for a second. ‘I can never go back, never see things as they were before. But!’ He smiled again. ‘I found a way to make it bearable. As ever, I looked to our ancestors. I remembered what *they* did, to ameliorate divine madness.’

His smile was all at once beatific and horrifying. Just as I thought he wasn’t going to say anything else, he grinned a sloppy grin.

‘*I am cured,*’ he said.

He removed the woolly hat.

His head had been shaved very recently; the slightest pinprick sprinkling of bristly hair, like iron filings, covered his scalp.

On the left side of his cranium, about the size of a circle made with finger and thumb, was something I couldn’t make immediate visual sense of. The edges of it were ragged with old scabs and a half-centimetre-thick circle of scar tissue, but even then, I still didn’t quite understand what I was looking at. It was only when I saw the unmistakable red rawness underneath that I understood.

‘*What have you done?*’

He smiled again. Unlike his earlier smile, this one glowed with insane certainty. ‘In France, they found a Neolithic burial site with forty human skulls like this. There are lots of theories as to why they did this, but the consensus is they did it to get rid of evil spirits.’ For a second, it was as if the old Leo were animating this husk, and his eyes brightened. ‘And what is an evil spirit, Alex, but an idea? A persistent idea, an undermining of reason that cannot be ignored.’

‘*Oh Leo,*’ I said, with more emotion than I intended. I felt as if I were floating, observing this conversation a hundred dizzying feet below me.

‘I’m fine now,’ he smiled. ‘This... helped. It doesn’t mean I can’t see it any more, but it does mean I can navigate it. Whatever’s left, I just... self-medicate.’ He clearly saw my expression. ‘I assure you, I’m perfectly fine.’



‘Perfectly fine,’ I repeated robotically. ‘Leo, I can see your brain.’

The smile again. ‘Liberating, isn’t it?’

‘Not the word I would use.’ My hands, claws now, ached from gripping the table.

‘Although I’ll never be free of the knowledge of what I saw, I have at least returned myself to *sanity*.’ His tone was extravagant, triumphant. Above his face, the hole in his head, raw-looking and somehow unclean, seemed to pulse. Was it pulsing? Did brains pulse? Or was I just nauseous?

‘What did you do it with?’ I said, before I could help myself. ‘Electric drill,’ he said, in a businesslike fashion, before adding, almost comically, ‘I used an attachment.’

I thought about this.

‘Please,’ I said. ‘Put the hat back on.’

He shrugged. ‘As you wish.’ He replaced the beanie. I raked my top teeth along my bottom lip until it hurt.

‘Where did we go?’ I said.

‘*On holiday*,’ he said. ‘*In some other world, where the music of the radio was a labyrinth of sonorous colours. Where the dripping patchouli was more than scent, it was the sun.*’

‘What happened?’ I said. ‘Time is fractured. My life is smashed to pieces, it makes no sense, it’s broken. Everything contradicts everything else. All I feel is terror, revelation, the endless uncovering of appalling truths. How did this happen?’

Leo looked straight at me. For a second, despite his reduced circumstances, the wasting of his face, he looked almost imperial.

‘*You know how it happened.*’

Silence fell again.

‘I need to find her,’ I said eventually.

Leo stood up. ‘If you want to see her again, you know what you have to do.’

I nodded dumbly.

‘I’m going now,’ he said, and seemed to remember something. He patted one of the larger pockets in his coat; fishing inside it, he came up

with something that he pressed into my hand.

*'You'll need this.'*

Looking down, I saw the iron key to the chamber beneath Bewise. When I looked up again, he was already walking away.



'Who were you talking to?' said the barmaid, as I put my empty glass on the bar. She looked bemused. 'It got pretty animated!'

There was something in the way she looked at me that made me angry. I turned away from her and left.

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# 75

I FOUND MYSELF later walking along the bank of a canal, in a place I didn't know, smoking cigarettes I did not remember buying.

I was suddenly aware that I had been walking for a very long time; my ankles hurt. I sat down on a bench and lit another cigarette from the one I was smoking, flicked the butt into the canal. Above me the orange streetlights shone, transforming the bench and its surroundings into a stage set, something too real, or not real enough. A man in a fluorescent windbreaker cycled along the towpath on a racing bike. Two drunks threw stones into the canal then ran off, laughing like children. A very old woman shambled past walking an equally aged dog.

Here was the world, as I understood it, the world of explicable things that occurred for explicable reasons. You could follow everyone's reasoning, as to how they were doing what they were doing. You could trace A to B to C, in logical leaps, predict behaviours based on prior pattern, and this was how things were.

And a few miles away, a young man walked, his mind a shattered ruin of something once magnificent. Smoking, smiling, gazing at the city, and everything human, dispassionately, from a place far beyond it all, with a hole in his skull.



Much as the universe must one day inevitably decay into the chaos of entropy, the business conference drinks that were taking place in the hotel bar, when I finally got back, had degenerated into karaoke. A grinning man

and a nervous woman were picking their way through ‘You’re the One that I Want’, their embarrassment, so all-consuming to them, utterly ignored by their colleagues.

I, however, was delighted by it. I drank every detail in hungrily, gazing in wonder. All of these people, all of them sure of the history of their lives, how they got to the present moment. None of these people were on the wrong plane of reality; none of these people had seen the New Jerusalem, had their senses improved to such a pitch of Blakean intensity that they had ended up living on the streets. I was willing to put money on the fact that none of them had ever even so much as entertained the notion of drilling a significantly large hole in their own head.

Using Malcolm’s method, I ordered two large whiskies, and downed one of them at the bar, before sitting down at a table at the periphery of the crowd. My headache, I noticed, was back, but only for a brief, painful second, like a stab of intense heat, and then was gone.

On the table, in a puddle between six empty pint glasses, was a name card in a plastic sleeve with a pin on the back. The name badge said:

MARK BRIGGS  
CREDITRACK PLC

I picked up the badge, dried it off and pinned it to my shirt.

I was Mark Briggs now. Thank God.

Mark Briggs was the polar opposite of Alex Lane. Mark Briggs, I could feel already, was the kind of bloke who liked football, probably, and *going out with the lads*. He played rugby on a Sunday, after he’d been to see his parents. His favourite drink was beer. He said things like *Shall we get a cheeky beer after work?; Best get the beers in; I make that beer o’clock!* Mark Briggs liked mildly alternative mainstream rock music and American comedy films, or at least felt that he was keeping up with the prevailing culture if he did so. His favourite films were *The Godfather*, *Reservoir Dogs*, *Apocalypse Now*, although which one was his absolute favourite changed all the time, because who could possibly choose? Mark Briggs, untroubled by metaphysics of any kind, would never, ever find himself in

the position Alex Lane was in. I sank into the identity of Mark Briggs as if I were sinking into a warm, scented bath.

Someone tapped me on the shoulder.

‘Mind if I sit here?’

A woman stood over me. Five foot five, with a blonde bob. She wore grey suit trousers, a grey suit jacket, with a pale lilac shirt of some very shiny material underneath. On the breast pocket of her jacket was pinned a badge that read:

EMERALD FORD  
UP! INVESTMENTS

Incongruously, she was wearing white trainers.

‘Be my guest,’ I said. ‘Hello, Emerald Ford.’

‘Hello... Mark Briggs,’ she said, making a pantomime of screwing up her eyes to read my badge.

‘Not tempted by the karaoke?’ I asked.

‘No way drunk enough,’ she laughed. ‘God, I do detest these things. I mean, you’d think they’d do some more up-to-date music, like some Britpop or something.’

‘All of that would be lost on me, I’m afraid,’ I said. ‘I’ve been away for a few years.’

‘Wow.’ She lit a cigarette, offered me one. ‘Anywhere nice?’

‘Tír na nÓg,’ I said, before I could stop myself. I was annoyed; Mark Briggs would never have said something like that. I took a cigarette.

‘Wow,’ she said, exhaling. ‘I mean, I’ve always wanted to go to South East Asia, but never got round to it.’

I nodded, and knocked back my whisky. ‘Well, I appear determined to get drunk. You want another one?’

She nodded. ‘Thank you, that would be great. Rum and coke. But only the one, I have to be up early for the presentation tomorrow.’



We did three songs in the end. One of them was 'Islands in the Stream', I remember that. I think we won the crowd over by sheer determination. At the end of the last song, drunken applause raining down on us, Emerald Ford hugged me and then kissed me on the lips; we leaned into the kiss for slightly too long and became almost embarrassed. We won some sort of runners-up trophy, but I never saw it.

Then she suggested we go up to my room, and, coming up for air after kissing in the lift, I immediately told her I wasn't Mark Briggs and that I wasn't here for the conference. It felt wrong to deceive someone in this way, even if, ultimately, the deception was of absolutely no consequence whatsoever.

'Who are you then?' she said, bemused.

'Alex Lane,' I said. 'Hello, Emerald Ford.'

We shook hands formally.

She eyed me suspiciously. 'Anything else I should know about you?'

'Yeah,' I said, smiling pleasantly. 'Today I escaped from a hospital where I was under psychiatric evaluation after a head trauma, because my grasp of reality had become dangerously tenuous.'

'Fucking great!' Emerald laughed. 'Just so long as you promise not to talk about corporate strategy.'

While I was solemnly promising this, she kissed me with such vehemence it was as if I held the last lungful of oxygen on Earth.



Emerald Ford was very good in bed; I did my best to keep up. After a strenuously active hour or so we eventually collapsed, spent, next to each other, and Emerald, nine rum and cokes down, fell asleep almost immediately, but I stayed awake, unable to switch off. I had the vague feeling I had been unfaithful to Ella, but this was an illogical feeling, not rooted in anything rational, apparently. I was aware of this irrationality, and yet. It still felt wrong.

*Where are you?* I thought, or maybe even said, to myself. *Did you just leave?* I got up, went over to the desk and rummaged in my bag.

I read all twenty-three quatrains of Ella's shorter poem again, but could make nothing useful of it. I then read some random verses of Flayne's long poem, perhaps looking for insight, for guidance. I found myself reading the ninety-ninth quatrain, over and over.

*She will evaporate, evanesce.  
To our faeryland flee, evermore.  
Now complete, entire. Unto night's caress:  
Lost Eden's ambitions now law.*

*Look over*, murmured Emerald Ford, in her sleep, or something that sounded like it. *Look all over on the within*. And then she was quiet.

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## 76

WHEN I WOKE UP, Emerald was sitting with her bare feet up on the desk, in just her lilac shirt and knickers, reading Flayne's ledger.

I suddenly remembered getting up in the middle of the night to read it too, fixating on a verse I thought was important for some reason, and the echo of it resounded in my head. Sometime after this I had climbed back into bed and clung onto Emerald, as if she were someone I'd been involved with for years and trusted my very being to, a life-raft in a stormy sea.

I sat up slowly. I was hung-over. My head throbbed extravagantly, like a stubbed toe.

'Morning, petal,' she said, without turning round. She flicked through the heavy liver-coloured ledger. 'This is yours, right?'

'It is.'

'Very interesting,' she said. She held up the sheets of yellow legal pad with Ella's handwritten quatrains on them. 'I mean, I'm not sure why anyone would bother.'

I laughed. 'Wow. You don't beat around the bush, do you?'

She grinned. 'Nope. Why's it signed *Edwin Flayne*?'

'That's... who wrote it?' I said.

'Riiight,' she said drily. She held up Ella's pages once more, compared them with Flayne's copperplate verses. 'Clever, though. I'll give you that.'

'Clever, how?' I asked.

'Oh, come on,' she laughed. 'You know how.'

My heart suddenly beat faster, in a circlet around my head, it seemed. I was alert; I felt something very significant was about to happen. It was an effort, in that moment, to appear calm.



‘Humour me. It would be good to know what someone else makes of it.’

‘It’s *clever*,’ she said.

‘In what way?’

She eyed me with a sardonic smile, as if I were teasing a compliment out of her.

‘The way they fit together.’

I looked at her blankly.

‘Come on!’ she shrugged. ‘It’s your poem!’

I was on my feet now. ‘Show me.’

Emerald shrugged. ‘Okay.’

She opened Flayne’s volume at the very beginning, and laid Ella’s legal pages alongside it. ‘There.’ She pointed at the first verse of each; Flayne’s poem first, then Ella’s.

‘Look.’

‘Look at what?’

She smiled.

I looked from one poem to the other, in desperation, trembling, almost praying I wouldn’t miss what she was attempting to show me.

Flayne’s 123-quatrain epic began thus:

1. *A lost, lonely season unmoored. My mind erring –  
Returning to half-empty halls  
Of unending silence; enclosing, ensnaring –  
Now torrid remembrance enthrals.*

Whereas Ella’s much shorter poem began:

*All summer, the house entreated, taunted,  
Requests unutterable made.  
Pitiful Eden, the sunrise haunted,  
Eternity’s ruined aubade...*

And then I saw it.

It was the kind of thing that delighted in basking in plain sight, mocking you, until you spotted it.

*Flayne's poem was an acrostic* – a very, very long one. If you boiled it down, took the first letter of every word, you ended up with Ella's poem, which was not Ella's poem at all, but Flayne's – one poem hidden inside another:

*A Lost, Lonely Season Unmoored. My Mind Erring  
Returning To Half-Empty Halls  
Of Unending Silence; Enclosing...  
A-L-L-S-U-M-M-E-R-T-H-E-H-O-U-S-E*

And so on. I stood, staring at the pages, for an indeterminate time, and something like vertigo thrilled through me, brighter even than the headache.

Emerald Ford, unaware of the bomb she'd exploded, yawned and scooped up the rest of her clothes from the floor, retreated into the bathroom.



While she was gone, I picked up Flayne's book, flicked through it, comparing it against random parts of Ella's poem.

They correlated exactly.

What did this mean?

'Right,' said Emerald, a few minutes later. She was dressed, in the clothes she had worn last night, white trainers and all. 'I'm going to my room to shower and change, get ready for the conference. I expect I'll see you over there?'

'You won't,' I said, forcing myself to look up from Flayne's book. 'I'm not here for that, remember?'

'Oh yeah. You're an escaped mental patient.' We both laughed. We hugged each other warmly, but when I moved to kiss her, she backed off, made a face, fanned her hand. 'Morning breath!' she said. 'Both of us.'

I laughed again. 'Can I see you for lunch?'

‘Sure,’ she said. ‘Why not? Conference finishes at noon.’

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I lay down on the bed, flicking through the large red volume, wondering why Flayne had chosen to do such a thing, to conceal one poem inside another. What did it mean? Was there some dialogue between the poem and its occulted sister that a reader was expected to see?

Ultimately, I decided I was too hung-over to think about it; it would keep.

It was a relief, suddenly, not to look for clues as to Ella’s state of mind within the shorter poem, now I understood that Flayne had written both. But what did it prove, this exercise? What was it for? Was it just more of Edwin Flayne’s madness? The same mania that possessed him to remodel his house, to wall himself in, to attempt a ritual that would transform his perception, reunite him with his dead Ella?

My head was pounding. Without meaning to, I dozed for thirty minutes until I awoke with a guilty start.

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I went downstairs to the hotel lobby. Emerald – and everyone else in the hotel, it seemed – had gone to the last part of the conference; there was muffled applause from some distant auditorium, and nobody queued for breakfast. I drank two cups of weak tea and piled the components of a fried breakfast onto a warm, greasy plate. Each item of the buffet was in its own little tray, and you lifted them onto your plate with tongs, or spooned them on with a ladle. The colours of these items were all hyperreal – the bacon, in particular, was a kind of neon pink, streaked through with an equally fluorescent orange. It looked like a child’s toy breakfast, everything made of painted wood, everything fake, nothing on the menu you could actually eat.

Twenty minutes later, I was in the car park, breathing in the morning air and squinting against the bright early autumn sun. My head was still

thudding, but less aggressively. A knot of smokers, all from the conference, chatted and joked. I remembered there were cigarettes in my room; I had bought them last night, but now I didn't feel like smoking, and it was strange, again, to think I ever had.

---

I was heading back inside the hotel when I recalled – with painful, eidetic clarity – something Leo had said to me when I saw him last night:

*'Flayne built labyrinths inside labyrinths. He did that to hide something. A thing he couldn't face up to.'*

For a couple of seconds I stood, swaying slightly, as I considered the possibility, sifting it mentally, like sand through my fingers, hand to hand to hand. The sun stabbed at me, urging me to think.

Then it felt like the world was swaying too.

And I was running, back to my room.

---

*Flayne built labyrinths inside labyrinths.*

In a frenzy, I grabbed a pen and found Ella's poem, twenty-three quatrains boiled down from the 123 of Flayne's large poem, and began writing down the first letter of each word:

*All Summer, The **H**ouse **E**ntreated, Taunted,  
Requests Unutterable **M**ade.  
Pitiful **E**den, The Sunrise **H**aunted,  
Eternity's **R**uined Aubade.  
**A-S-T-H-E-T-R-U-M-P-E-T-S-H-E-R-A...***

And, after a few short minutes, there it was: another poem, another acrostic, hidden inside a poem, hidden inside a poem:

*As the trumpet's herald is sounded  
Bringing Earth its notice grave,  
Sin's entreaty now dumbfounded;  
Inpouring now glorious wave;  
Evil's influence negated,*

*Man's offences stripped to scorn,  
Our lives appraised, collated:  
Every Earthly act reborn;  
Now each action – callous, horrible,  
Lustful, angry, murderous, base –  
Evinced now to law infallible,  
Gathered hither, time and space.  
Creator! E'en now doom is nearing,  
God's last instruction, flesh's end!  
Souls in death-light endless, erring –  
All shall estimation send.  
Sins promises undone; rescission  
Now Emmanuel's decision.*

I looked at this poem – hidden by its author, only ever seen by him and myself – in disbelief. Ella would have unravelled all of this sooner than me, but events had overtaken her.

This third poem was clearly about the Day of Judgement, and I recalled Helen talking of *The Day of Lamentation*, and this in turn brought to mind the *SOLACE* contents page, with the word *Lamentation* as one of the chapter headings.

And then I realized that I was close now, close to the core of this.



I took a deep breath, and subjected this poem to the same process, collecting the first letter of each word:

*As The Trumpet's Herald Is Sounded  
Bringing Earth Its Notice Grave...  
**A-T-T-H-I-S-B-E-I-N-G...***

Which resulted in:

*At this being's ending,  
We inmost solace earn.  
Each lambent light ascending:  
Life's idle eases spurned.*

An epic poem of 123 quatrains had condensed, acrostically, to a poem of twenty-three quatrains, and this in turn had compressed to a poem consisting of four quatrains and a couplet, which, in turn, had become – this.

A single quatrain.

And, as I compressed this quatrain, subjecting it to the same process, in my head now, rather than on paper, and saw what it said, the terrible secret it enshrined, I wept.



Flayne's beloved mother had never gone to London, never left him, never abandoned him for a lover. Instead, she had been killed, and thrown into the bottomless pit at the heart of the cave system, where she would never, ever, ever be found. And because Solace House was not fixed, in time or space, because it delighted in dream-work, in deviance and tricks with time and human minds, that was where Ella, my Ella, was also. In both cases they had been sacrificed to satisfy the insanity of one man, in both cases known by the same name.

And of course this final, four-word poem was also an acronym, and, when compressed, formed the final, single word at the heart of the puzzle, the confessional signature of The Annihilator who had slain her, once, twice, thrice, and put her there:

*ABEL*

*OceanofPDF.com*

EMERALD WAS OUTSIDE, smoking and chatting with some colleagues; tall men in dark suits. I wondered if any of them were, in fact, Mark Briggs, of Creditrack plc. Whatever their conversation had been, I crashed through it, reaching for her.

‘I have to show you something,’ I said. ‘In my room.’

‘Whoah!’ she said, round an embarrassed smile. ‘It’s a little early in the day for that, no?’ The dark-suited men sniggered politely, enviously.

‘You’re hilarious,’ I said. ‘Please come. It’s important.’

She shot me a doubtful look. ‘You can’t just *tell* me what it is?’

‘Please,’ I said.

She shrugged, excused herself from her bemused colleagues, and followed.

---

‘Okay,’ I said, once we were in my room. ‘You know the long poem? In the book?’ And I told her all about the nested poems, one inside the other.

She looked at me with concern. I was about to tell her what it all signified when she put her hand on my arm.

‘*Hey*,’ she said softly.

I looked at her in confusion. ‘No, listen—’

‘Don’t get me wrong,’ she said in a kindly voice that was almost a whisper. ‘It’s amazing that you managed to do this. It’s a lot of work.’

I was puzzled. ‘I didn’t write this.’

‘But...’ Emerald Ford sounded unsure.

‘And the first poem was discovered by someone else. Seriously, I did very, very little here. The thing is—’

‘But...’ she said again. She looked down at the desk, then back up at me. There was deep concern in her eyes, a complex form of worry that hadn’t been there earlier.

‘Alex,’ she said, as if gently delivering bad news. ‘All of this... this book...’ She looked away before speaking again.

‘What?’

‘I saw your handwriting last night, when you filled in the karaoke sheet. It’s the same.’

And still, I didn’t understand.

‘This book, Alex... it’s *your* handwriting.’

I looked down at the desk. And she was right. The gorgeous liver-coloured ledger with the marbled edging was gone, forever, had changed and become a grimy A4 exercise book, spiral-bound, its front cover held together with parcel tape. And the poem, Flayne’s epic verse, with all its colourful illustrations, was now in my handwriting. The same went for the poem on Ella’s yellow legal pages, the twenty-three quatrains she’d discovered.

All of it. All in my handwriting.

I stared, open-mouthed. I did not speak for a while.

And then I knew what had happened. He had showed his hand, finally. And I knew.

‘*He did this,*’ I said.

‘Who... who did what?’ Emerald Ford’s eyes were wide.

‘*Adam,*’ I snarled. Emerald moved to say something else, but bit her lip. I took a deep breath.

‘I see it all now. Adam successfully completed Flayne’s ritual. It granted him incredible powers, one of which was the ability to change history, or rather, to see *all possible histories* leading up to that final Omega Point, and choose one. He occupies that point, now, outside of history, and he’s able to pick whichever history he wants.’

Emerald stared at me, not speaking.



‘Clive knew,’ I said. ‘He could sense that history was being altered, manipulated. He sensed it, as it was happening. I thought it was just stoner talk, but I can see it too now.’

‘Alex—’

‘*He* sent me *here*, to this reality, burned up four years of my life. Sent me to a place where *I’m*—’ and my voice faltered as I approached it, the thing I had always known, deep down, about this place, and the reason that Adam, in his infinite cruelty, had chosen it.

To say it, however, was to make it real. To remove it from the realm of possibility and make it concrete fact. My face was wet.

‘A place where *I* was responsible for Ella’s death, where it was *my* fault she died, in the car *I* was driving.’

I looked over to Emerald. Involuntarily, she took a step back, away from me. I realized that I had to make her understand.

‘The house we were supposed to be clearing was the house of a lunatic, a man called Edwin Flayne. He was into the occult, science, maths, all kinds of things. He was absolutely cracked, but only because – someone close to him vanished, and he never got over it. So, he devised this ritual to – *enperpetuate* – himself, and the house. His word. He wanted to raise the place to the *n*th power, to make it multi-dimensional, existing in all planes of reality, and if it were threatened, it would just slide sideways to a reality where it still existed. Flayne’s ritual would give him complete control over time and space. Only he didn’t complete it—’

‘Where is this house?’ said Emerald cautiously.

‘I burned it down,’ I said. ‘In my reality. But here, I imagine it’s where it always was. You see, it protects itself if it’s threatened,’ I said. ‘It moves – sideways – to a reality where it continues to exist. Burning it down wouldn’t matter. I see that now. It simply shifts itself to somewhere where it was just fine, like it always does. And Adam’s part of that now. He can change history. He has become The Mad God that Flayne saw.’

‘I’m sorry,’ I said, seeing her expression. ‘I know this is a lot to take in, but trust me. He’s found me. And he’s brazen now. Changing the notebook,

like that, defacing reality, in plain sight.' I thought. 'Oh God, he *wants* me to see. He *wants* me to see how powerful he's become, what he can do.'

Emerald Ford said nothing, then.

'He killed Clive, Helen and Ruth that night, because he needed witnesses. Ritual demanded it, and he didn't have the time to make the correct effigies. Once the ritual was complete and I fled where he couldn't follow, he altered history. Yes. I see it now. He brought me here, to a reality where Clive, Helen and Ruth enacted their ritual deaths, by water, by fire, by their own hand. Only no-one else can see it. Here, in this history, we all just left Solace House naturally, after the place got bought.

'Only, that kind of thing, taking a life, it must have consequences, must leave an impression, whichever reality you're in.' Yes. Everything felt like it was coming together, and it was dazzling. 'And so, in this reality, the one where he placed us all, the three of them enacted their ritual death anyway. Yes. That's it! But in this universe, only I can see it!'

Emerald Ford simply stared at me.

'*The Mad God*,' I said. 'Pale and Strange. *Adam*. He can do anything he wants now. He cannot be stopped. Unless I confront him.'

Neither of us spoke for a while. I was trembling with excitement, suddenly perceiving, with crystalline clarity, the shining pattern that had eluded me. I couldn't understand why Emerald couldn't see it too.

'I have to confront him,' I said.

'O-kay,' sighed Emerald. She looked up at me. The sound of traffic on the flyover outside was like waves breaking on a distant shore. She smiled sadly.

'You really did walk out of a mental hospital, didn't you, Alex?'

'No,' I said, but there was guilt in my voice. When I spoke again, my tone was wounded, undignified.

'It was a wing of a *regular* hospital. I was being kept in for observation.'

'Mm-mm,' said Emerald.

'It wasn't like that!' I said, as calmly as I could. 'I'd been in a car crash. I had some kind of... head injury. But that's the situation *he* put me in,

*here,*’ I said. ‘But I’m fine!’ I suddenly saw what she could see, and felt fear rise in me. ‘Oh my God, this isn’t— that. That’s not what this is!’

‘You discharged yourself?’ Emerald said steadily.

‘That’s irrelevant,’ I said. ‘You don’t know the full story. Adam must have sent me here but not known precisely *where*. And now he’s found me. *He* changed the notebook. It was a different volume, earlier, when you first read it.’

‘*Alex,*’ she said doggedly. ‘*It was the same.*’

‘No. No. That’s just what you remember now. Previously, when it was Edwin Flayne’s, it was magnificent, bound in red leather with marbled edges, and always had been. But *that* version of history has been changed now too. He can do that. You don’t know what he can do.’

‘Okay,’ she said slowly. ‘O-kay.’

‘I know,’ I said. ‘I *know* how it looks to an outsider. You can’t see it, because you weren’t there, at Solace House. But *I* was. I can see it. I can detect it. Those changes in history.’

Neither of us spoke then, for perhaps half a minute. Eventually, Emerald smiled, a rueful, cryptic smile. She was already halfway to the door.

‘Last night was fun,’ she said. ‘Take care, Alex.’

I let her go. There was no point trying to explain. No point at all.



Leo, as I remembered him, when he was fully who he was, had lots of theories. Some he’d picked up from books, others he’d picked up from less reputable sources, some he’d made up himself. Some were good, a very few of them were excellent. Some of them I think I even believed.

There was one that I felt – emotionally, as Leo did – to be true. He told it to me the time we went to the cave together, under Bewise.

This theory was about the spirals, which Neolithic peoples etched into the rock, as they did all over Europe, as they did at Bewise. The pattern that seems most important to them, Leo noticed, was a maze of concentric circles, smaller and smaller, until, at the middle, a hole drops away into the

rock itself. What did it mean to them, this pattern, that it should be repeated so? Leo pondered this symbol for a long time, and then, eventually, alone and stoned, as was his wont, he traced his finger around the maze for the millionth time and came to an understanding.

The spiral was, he saw, nothing more or less than the shape of a human life.

The rings are the soul's journey, through corporeal existence. When you are born, time moves slowly, and you move along the outer ring of the spiral. This early on, you might even mistake the experience of being alive for a straight line, a road that goes on forever; such is youth. But the next time around, the next turn of the circle, you see that it does not. You start to feel the rhythm of the year, the sameness of the seasons. You're getting older, and wiser. And colder.

As the years advance, your perception of time alters and the years quicken, accelerate, just as the spiral grows ever tighter, ever smaller. You enter the innermost rings of the spiral – old age – near the centre. The seasons, the years, flash by in moments, and the spiral rings are short, so short. It is icy winter there, it seems, all the time.

But at the centre of many of the Neolithic spirals, there is not a dead end or a full stop. There is that aperture, that hole, delivering one from the maze – from time, from the two dimensions of the maze, from the burden of temporal being with all of its attendant delusions – entirely.

A Gabriel's Horn, leading from this limited realm to somewhere else.

Leo saw this, and it seemed so obvious that he was momentarily staggered that people could have ever forgotten something so fundamental, so universal.

Where does the soul migrate to, at that supreme moment, that instant of death? Soaring above the spiral, able, briefly, to review the entire wheel of its existence? We can never know what these people thought awaited them after death. But what was certain, if Leo's theory was correct, was that they believed in something beyond; something greater than themselves, greater than humans could even conceive of. A higher, more perfect dimension. The spiral was a flat etching, carved into the single plane of the rock. The

aperture, three dimensional, led out into – what? Other planes, other realms, impossible to carve on a flat surface, or possibly any surface that existed at all. Naught in our world compares. A realm undreamt of, simply because it is impossible to dream it, with the minds we have.

An Exalted Realm.

This, said Leo, was the way of things. And where you find plurality in things, he said, expect infinity. As above, he said, so below. So, upon leaving our realm, that dazzling, savage, dark-bright state of existence, we should very much expect to find something else, some brighter, purer, more divine reality that would make the place from which we were just expelled seem as simple, and as flat, as a spiral carved into a rock face.

---

When I awoke again, my head was clear and I felt completely lucid, my perceptions measured and precise.

I showered, dressed and went downstairs to the empty restaurant to eat. I had slept for hours; the light was already fading, the sun, heavy with the weight of the day's events, was drowning in soft blue cloud. Outside, it was cold.

I collected my belongings and ordered a cab, as I had done from The Ridge, that day a few weeks or four years ago, depending on which calendar you used, depending on which version of me you were.

There was only one place left to go now.

THE CAB DRIVER dropped me at the gates of what had been Marshlands. He seemed curious as to why I wanted to be there, in the middle of nowhere, but I threw banknotes at him until he grew uneasy and stopped talking. He left, and I was alone.

The dusk was cool, the countryside quiet. My head ached.

The sagging, wrought-iron front gates had been replaced with gates of steel mesh, to which a great many official-looking notices had been attached. The notices were too numerous to be convincing; the profusion of bold type, shouting empty threats at empty countryside, just looked desperate. All of the notices were sun-faded, cracked. No-one had even bothered to vandalize them.

The top of the stone perimeter wall had been fitted with a ruff of razor wire, giving the hospital the look of a prison camp. Climbing over that was possible, but not an attractive option. That left the front gate, and its steel mesh, but this approach was compromised in terms of footholds by the abundance of signs. They were attached to the mesh with cable ties, and would have to be cut off. I didn't have a knife.

Eventually, I hit on the idea of simply crawling under the steel gates, which proved to be remarkably easy, as, despite all their warning signs, they lifted slightly in their hinges. I scrabbled through and, without ceremony, was inside, dusting myself off, walking along the approach road, the silent hospital ahead of me.

Even from far away, I could see that very little of Marshlands had changed. All of the hospital was still standing. Although some of the meadow had been churned up by a large machine, now absent, and a grey

Portakabin had been parked on the driveway, it didn't look as if anyone had been to the site in years. Iron poles had been driven into the meadow, presumably to outline the parameters of this unrealized construction project. The poles tilted drunkenly now, fluorescent orange tape fluttering and twirling from them like gymnasts' ribbons in the chill breeze. It was obvious that whatever had been planned here was never going to be built. I could see the woods beyond, untouched, but I couldn't see the house.

---

Whoever had locked up Marshlands had done a much better job than whoever had secured the front gates: huge, precise rectangles of hardboard had been screwed into every door and window frame, making any kind of entry impossible. It didn't look like anyone had even tried to break in. The days when people would be scouting the countryside for places to hold illegal raves were long gone, apparently. Weeds sprouted from gaps in the tarmac, from the flowerbeds, even, in places, from the cracked mortar of Marshlands itself. None of this mattered to me; it wasn't Marshlands I had come to see.

I rounded the messy prosthetic limb of the 1970s extension – still standing, against all the odds – and there was the wall, as it had always been, and there was the doorway, with the rusted iron gate set into it, as if I had last gone through it yesterday.

And for the first time, I questioned the wisdom of what I was doing. Solace House was a dangerous place. I knew that now. Beyond the house, the overgrown yew forest that was a maze, and beyond that the strange secluded faeryland so enchanting to Ella Flayne. And beyond that, Bewise, and the cave, with its secrets. All beyond this gate. I had felt I had nothing to lose, but I was suddenly conscious of how much that was untrue. Whatever else had happened here, I had somehow endured, with my mind intact.

How precious and precarious is sanity, how fleeting, how utterly unappreciated. Sanity; the ability to live without fear, or with fear that was

proportionate, and could be managed, made useful. To live in the daily currents of reality, without fuss, without questioning the solidity of everyday things. To parcel time up in days, and months, years, and be fine with all of that. To reduce the awful, fearful infinity of the universe to simply what you can see, what is right in front of you; to what, ultimately, matters.

And yet I had to know, I had to see.

When I reached the gate I saw that it was unlocked.

---

The pathway was long gone, reclaimed by the tendrils of the undergrowth, but I had expected this. I grabbed a stick, to batter the worst of it into submission, marching through the brambles and nettles in a straight line, towards the house. No emotions flooded back; it was just labour, with nothing of the mind in it.

I surfaced from woods which had been neatly trimmed, to provide a border for a well-manicured front lawn, divided by a lazy river of yellow gravel. And there, standing precisely where it had been, where it always would be, shrouded in darkness, was Solace House.

But, far from being the dilapidated place we had spent a summer clearing, or a burned-out husk, it gleamed, as if newly built.

The masonry had been cleaned; the roof had been retiled. The woodwork of the windows had been restored and repainted, and the windows were clean enough to shine with the last of the day's dull light.

Was this how Abel Flayne saw the place when it was first built? Or was it the vision that Ella Flayne saw before that, when she arrived here: a house already constructed, always here, in a forgotten grove, sacred to lunatics? It was impossible to say. The house was new again; that was all that mattered. It would always be new now.

---



The rear gardens had also been restored, up to a point: the zone of tall grass with its islands of brambles was gone, replaced by a bland green lawn of a uniformity so precise it made me feel unwell. At either side of this, two cherry trees had been planted, crowned with yellowing leaves, but beyond that the restoration ceased abruptly at the yew wood, which remained a dense tangle of dark green.

I walked across the lawn as if the house were mine. Who was going to stop me? I reached the fence and vaulted it cleanly; I was now in the yew wood, a labyrinth within a labyrinth, where the black earth was a riot of roots. I followed a wall of yew, an avenue of the old maze, undistorted, miraculously, over the years.

At the end of this avenue, one of the yews had fallen and the trunk was rotten. And there, where the earth and the rain had dissolved the trunk into black, wet mush, were Leo's mushrooms, a vast troop of brown-gold caps. I knelt down beside them and grabbed them in handfuls, stuffing them into my mouth, choking down their rubbery, chemical taste, dry and wet at the same time, and fought to keep them down.

---

And then I was in the secluded place, where even at dusk the pool caught the light and played with it as if running it between its fingers. And there were the dragonflies, the damselflies, playful as fairies, flitting between here and that other realm.

And there, incongruous as always, a summerhouse on Mars, was Bewise, precisely as I remembered it.

The interior of Bewise was the same too, a cube of liquid twilight, where water ran from the rock face like tears, trickling down the green walls. The floor was tiled with the same maze, the same dedication to Ella Flayne at its centre.

I took Leo's key from my pocket and inserted it into the lock of the great iron cage. The key, as exempt from the rules of time as Solace House itself, turned immediately, with a well-oiled smoothness. I had been away

for days; I had been away for years. It didn't seem to matter any more. I was here now. I walked the tunnel that wormed through the ancient rock, until I found myself at the aperture. It took me two attempts to get a foothold, but I did so, squeezing my way through and fighting, crawling, into the great chamber beyond.

---

Here was my breath, clouding in front of me. Here was the high ceiling, the damp dirt floor. Here were the spiral carvings, older than the written word, etched into the cave wall, each a human lifespan, viewed from eternity. I was here, again, where I had been a week ago, four years ago. I was here. *Flow, live, old water, in night's grey undeath—*

Ahead of me must lie the abyss, the hole. My breath clotted in the cold air; there was light now, where all should have been dark. I approached the heart of it all with awe.

And there, below me, not the cold, bottomless darkness, but flickering scenes, things that had happened, things that were to happen, the boiling, churning mass of cause and effect, outcomes coalescing, dissolving. I saw all of us, things I had forgotten, things I couldn't know. I saw Clive and Leo and me, sharing a joint the first night I arrived at Marshlands. I saw Ruth and Malcolm laughing together. The visions slowed, and for a second I had the idea that I might attract someone's attention, reach back and prevent things happening, make new things happen. I saw Helen, standing at the foot of the first flight of stairs in her boiler suit, humming to herself, and in my hand I felt the key. It was a clean throw, the key sailing straight into the aperture, not clashing or bouncing against the sides. It struck, and I heard Helen squeal as if scalded, and then it was only natural to wait for the far-distant splash or clatter, but all the same I knew it would never come.

You could listen forever, and still not hear it.

And then I waited, for revelation.

---

In time, I hear myself scream. And I know it is coming.

My head feels as if it is splitting, as if by the fall of a great axe.

And yet, I can see.

---

The cave is no longer dark, the cave is lit, as if by burning magnesium, brilliant white light. An edge of pure agony sharp as sunlight sears through my head, my memories, a blinding flash, a switch thrown, every neuron firing up at once. I fall to my knees, like a sinner compelled by divine vision, to worship. The whole world, in that second, shining, glowing, and, ultimately, blazing, as if everything were lit from within, composed of light of such magnitude that it scours the eyes to dry sockets, burns away the brain.

And everything was alive now, as it always had been, the reality of everything was revealed, luminous. Human yardsticks like the clock were a laughable absurdity here, in this moment that always was, that you could visit at any time, the eternal now, always there, if you wished. And I felt as if I were falling from a great height, into a canyon perhaps, too deep to see the bottom, with nothing to do but keep on falling, into the verdant brightness.

*A synchronized dance of rising, collapsing, colliding, becoming, retreating, advancing, undulating over the smooth surface of the rock, fossilized Edwardian splatters and mixings of peculiar and lurid colours, from somewhere in the infinite nothing, when what it means to be human will be radically redrawn—*

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My body felt alien to me, then light and airy, insubstantial, evanescent, transformed.

Everything transformed, everything seething and writhing, forever shifting between what it was in one place, what it is in another. The woods around me, the forest, came and went, the trees shrinking and collapsing

into nothingness, or rising again, far taller than they had ever been before, colossal primal ferns, salamanders the size of alligators, snapping down cockroaches large as cats, or great crystal masts leading to the stars, where minds vast as galaxies drifted like cuttlefish in endless contemplation. The ground beneath me was the yellow gravel of the driveway, now brand new, now choked with weeds, now tarmacked over, now pristine, now not even built.

*Inside everlasting summers.* Beyond lay the house. It was a ruin, little more than foundations, charred, burned, black timbers and rubble bordering the broken check tiles of the hallway. But before my eyes it rose again, cleaner and newer than ever, restored to glory by a loving owner, as a private house, here painted white, here entirely rendered over in plaster, given balconies, here with a hole in the roof, a skylit solarium, admitting the rays of a swollen orange sun on the edge of collapse. The pristine, luxurious dwelling of a man who never leaves the house, a man pale and strange. *Living everlasting summers.*

Here is all the time there is, or can ever be.



I crawl back through the tunnel, eager now to experience incarnation. Hand over hand I go, through the aperture, the birth canal, out from the womb of the Earth, heading for existence. I ooze from the tunnel, scrabbling onto the floor, find my way through the rock, and out through the square chamber and it is night now, the cube is darkness but the maze on the floor fluoresces green, the street plan of a city humans have never visited. I step over it and it is glass, the maze pulsing with soft luminescence. And then I am outside.

The sky is too full of stars here, it feels like it might collapse under its own weight at any second. A great purple streak is smeared across the sky, from horizon to horizon, lit by the failing stars, red as dying coals, almost burned up. And the ground below is a jungle of strange plants, enormous parodies of English flora, as if I am tiny now. And the airborne things have shed their damselfly disguise, swim now through the scented air,

mechanicals, elf-creatures, their laughter like tiny silver bells as they understand I can see them. Humanity, meanwhile, has long since become something else entirely, something vast and incomprehensible, great brains glowing as they hang jellyfish-like in the purple-tinged night, their luminous tentacles probing the ground, mooring them like guide ropes in the far future. Or is this the deep past? All around me they sing, their song painfully incomplete to me, not receivable by human senses. All around they glow.

Beyond these things there is merely abyss, and this is where real fear can be found, and fear only. When universes run down like vast clockwork, producing the endless horror of nothing but raw infinity forevermore, Amen. It can neither be withstood or endured. It is madness to gaze upon it. And there is only the house here now, the house, as new, standing intact in the dust, just the cave and the house, and its tenants.

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I emerged from the cold interior of Bewise into the cool, pleasant air, into the summer night. Some short distance away, I saw the fire.

Seated around it, I saw Ruth, Leo, Clive, Malcolm and Helen.

‘Oh my God,’ I said. ‘Look at you all. Just as you were. And Helen’s back.’

‘You’ve not been gone that long,’ said Ruth. ‘Where did you go, anyway?’

‘Away,’ I said. ‘Elsewhere.’

Helen frowned. ‘Why?’

‘Not sure,’ I replied. ‘Maybe I wanted to see what it was like to return.’ I spread my hands, to indicate Bewise. ‘And here we are, with all of it stretched out before us.’

‘My head feels weird,’ said Leo.

‘Unsurprising,’ I said. ‘Considering what you’ve done to it.’

‘No-one else thinks any of this is strange?’ said Helen. ‘You all sound very peculiar.’

Ruth looked at me. Her blue eyes held reflections of the dancing flame.

‘Did you change your clothes?’ she said. ‘You look different.’ I laughed.

‘Hmm. Well, this isn’t much of a conversation,’ said Helen.

Clive spoke, for the first time in a long time. ‘Did the stars always look like that? Do they look weird to anyone else?’

‘It would be weird if they didn’t look weird,’ I said. ‘Considering everything.’

I stared into the fire. The feeling came over me that now, the present moment, was somehow forever, was all the time there was. The idea unfolded within my mind gradually, and I became calm. A strange sense of belonging settled over me. It was glorious to see everyone like this, faces lit by the fire, intact, and relaxed in curious kinship, locked in our forever summer, where we would always be. And then I experienced a pang of strange longing, something akin to homesickness, for this moment, while still living it, the peculiar predicament of being alive, only truly understandable from the inside, by experiencing it.

I stared into the fire.

‘Ella,’ I said at long last, as if remembering. ‘Where is she?’



Carefully, I pick my way through the yew wood, the maze. My eyes are unusually sharp, it seems; the treacherous tangle of roots that make up the floor here is immediately explicable to me, and I walk across it as sure-footedly as if I’m crossing an empty ballroom. The roots phosphoresce, pulsing feebly, the fading impulses of something, and it is cold here, away from the fire, in the undergrowth. Cold as the cave, deep in the earth.



And there is the house, complete and entire, and whole. Solace House is eternal; the place will always be here, in this no-place, long after the stars go out and endless blackness consumes everything. A light blazes in a first floor window, casting a rectangle of amber light over the lawn.

You can ask why the house is here, but this is always the wrong question to ask.

I gaze up at the window. There, inside, I see a lone figure, staring out of the window; short, neatly dressed, hair white as bone, skin pale to the point of translucence. He takes two steps, silent at this distance, over to the window and stares out at the lawn. Can he see me from where he is now? He gives no sign that he does. I shout, but even as I do, I imagine myself from his perspective, cupping my hands to my mouth and screaming his name in total silence. Or maybe he cannot see me at all, in that exalted place, the mountains rising and falling, forest and sea and continents advancing and receding, in endless rhythm, like the tides. Above my head, bland eternities rage and the galaxies erupt into being, spin and burn, flare and die.

He is not alone, of course.

She has her back to me, and as she turns slowly, I realize that her face – who she is, who she will be, who he has chosen to capture, for all eternity – is more than I can bear to see. He smiles, his sickly smile of triumph, the ritual complete.



Sobbing, I turn away, and the others have followed me, are there with me on the grass. There is Clive, richly robed, beard trimmed, face set in contemplation; there is Helen, adorned in a blue headdress, standing with Ruth, who wears the colours of autumn. And there, in the foreground, is Leo, in a wide-brimmed hat with a red ribbon, and in front of him stands Malcolm, in white, observing the central figure, who, with his back to the viewer, raises his axe, forever, to deliver the blow that will split the world in two.

## Acknowledgements

I began work on *Solace House* on 23 March 2020. History (and your own memory) will tell you that this moment was not an auspicious time to begin anything, other than baking banana bread, staring glassy-eyed at the news or going insane, let alone writing a novel. And so, the unusually long gestation time for *Solace House* reflects the difficulties of finding time to work on it, and the technical challenges involved in what became a very demanding piece of work. Flayne's poetry (all written by me, rather than AI, before anyone asks) proved to be very time-consuming, but this turned out to be just one peculiar task among many which ultimately made the book the thing it is.

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